

**User Guide | INTERNAL – Authorized for SAP Partners**
User Assistance at SAP
Document Version: Updated continuously – 2026-03-16

# SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication

## Basics for style, wording, UI text, Links, multimedia, and legal aspects
## Target group: user assistance developers and translators

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# 1 About the SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication

Technical communication is more than documentation. The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* focuses on user assistance and people-centric communication. Learn about target groups, information needs, user interface texts, accessibility, translation, multimedia, and legal aspects. The nitty gritty part outlines wording, punctuation, and cross-references. The guidelines cover English and German.

**Information classification: internal** (see SAP Global Information Classification and Handling Standard)

> ⓘ Note
>
> Want to know more about user assistance? Try this: User Assistance Overview

## Is This Style Guide for You?

Anyone, from any line of business, who wants to communicate in a professional and effective way, can use the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* in their daily work. Admittedly, it's **primarily for user assistance developers and translators**. But also if you are a developer or work in the areas of user experience, product support or global communication, you'll find a wealth of useful tips.

Here's some role-specific information:

| Your Role | How Does the Style Guide Relate to You? |
|---|---|
| User assistance developers (including editors and architects) and translators | This style guide is an SAP-wide standard. It's the basic reference work for user assistance.<br><br>If you're new or are from an acquired or partner company, it helps you find your way around. For more information about partner user assistance, see Development Partner Enablement for User Assistance. |
| Translation coordinators | This style guide defines the quality prerequisites for the source text. You can use it as a basis for setting up translation-specific standards for the target languages. The external translation agencies can access this style guide on the virtual translation portal (VTP). |
| Training authors | This style guide is a general reference work. |
| User experience colleagues | You can use this style guide to align user experience standards with user assistance and translation standards. This typically concerns embedded help, formulation patterns for user interface elements and messages, capitalization of user interface texts (sentence style or title case?), variables or placeholders, space restrictions, and punctuation. |

| Your Role | How Does the Style Guide Relate to You? |
|---|---|
| Developers | You're most likely to encounter this style guide in the form of a best-practices document created by your user assistance developers or translators. But this is for you: Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] (short link: `https://url.sap/uadevchecklist`) |
| Marketing and communication colleagues | Use this style guide when you need to present technical information. |

## What Does This Style Guide Cover? How Strict Is It?

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* applies SAP-wide. It's the central one in the area of user assistance. Consider it an **80% baseline**. Feel free to define additional, more specific, or even different standards for your product area or software type.

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* has guidelines and examples for **English and German**, the source languages at SAP:

- **Legal** aspects in a nutshell
- **Target groups and their information needs**, and how to come up with product-specific user assistance deliverables
- **User interface texts**, including common user interface elements, messages, tooltips, and how to refer to the user interface in text
- **Style and wording** principles, such as terminology, people-centric language, accessibility, product and approved names, abbreviations, numbers
- **Structuring** principles, such as cross-references, lists, tables, notes, and cautions
- **Multimedia** elements, such as videos, graphics, or screenshots
- **Language**, grammar, and punctuation
- **Translation** aspects, just search for **`translation`**

**Out of scope:** This style guide is tool agnostic. It can't replace the various tool guides, which outline formatting options, workflows, and so on.

## Stable Links to This Style Guide? Where Is the Latest Version?

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is published on the central *Standards and Guidelines Overview* page. It's continuously updated.

**Helpful short links** (you have to be in the SAP corporate network):

- https://url.sap/sng-page – *Standards and Guidelines Overview* page
- https://url.sap/sgtc – the latest HTML version of the style guide
- https://url.sap/sgtc-pdf – the latest PDF version of the style guide

### What About Other Style Guides? Overview Page?

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is not the only one at SAP. The different types of user assistance out there require their own style guides – just think of the different software types, target groups, user interface technologies. And then there are also the brand guidelines, user interface guidelines, or guidelines for projects or initiatives.

**Helpful short links** (you have to be in the SAP network):

- https://url.sap/sng-page – *Standards and Guidelines Overview* page
- https://url.sap/ua-infrastructure-guide – *UA Infrastructure User Guide* for the IXIA CCMS, User Assistance Content Platform, and related tools such as SAP Companion (also linked on the *Standards and Guidelines Overview* page)
- https://url.sap/uacommunity – *User Assistance* community, your one-stop shop for all things user assistance, such as training courses, service catalog, info forum, news, events, or questions and discussions

**Translation:** Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) provides a set of language-specific style guides for product translation. For more information, see Product Style Guides.

### Contacts and Feedback

Daria Schuster and Doug Savage (User Assistance Content, Services, and Infrastructure, also known as central user assistance group)

Feedback channel: Ask the Editors

### Related Information

SAP Brand
SAP Fiori Design Guidelines
SAP Product Standards

## 1.1 Busy? New? Clueless? Try the Top 10

Style guides may not be your favorite read. Nevertheless, here are the top 10 standards for you. Help make our customers' lives easier. Help provide clear and meaningful information. Help reduce translation costs.

> ⓘ Note
>
> Just in case: Don't really know what user assistance is? Here's a presentation: User Assistance Overview (short link: `https://url.sap/uaoverview`)

## Top 10 Standards for Text and Translation Quality

**(1)** Whatever you do, do it **consistently**. Align with others. Define standards, and adapt them if there's a good reason. “I don't care” doesn't count.

**(2)** Write your texts in **U.S. English**. It is the corporate business language at SAP.

**(3)** Define **terminology** with subject matter experts early on, preferably in the specification phase. Enter the terms in SAPterm. Spread the words.

**(4)** Participate in developing a user-friendly and **self-explanatory user interface**. Clear formulations, consistent terminology, and correct language are essential for this.

**(5)** Write texts that **add value**: Consider the target group and their work situation. Do not describe the obvious or what everybody can see on the user interface.

**(6)** Write in a **people-centric and friendly tone**. Address the user directly with “you”. Rewrite overlong sentences or endless noun clusters. To make the text easy to scan, use lists, tables, graphics, or subheadings.

**(7)** Work in the **official user assistance infrastructure**: IXIA CCMS and User Assistance Content Platform. You get document versioning, status management, translation integration, and lots of other nice things.

**(8)** Get your texts reviewed. It's vital for translation into up to 50 target languages. There's **language, developmental and copy editing**. And content reviews by subject matter experts don't hurt either.

**(9)** Ensure that user interface texts are **translatable**:

- No cryptic, manual abbreviations. Reword the text instead. Alternatively, remove or adapt text length restrictions. This will help other languages, which need more space than English.
- No hard-coded texts. Externalize text strings.
- Get rid of hard-coded texts, space issues, and truncated texts early on. Use the **User Interface Text Space Calculator**. Simulate screens with **pseudotranslation (2Q)**.

**(10)** Use **variables** only for values, technical names, or other text that is not translated. Number or otherwise identify the variables in the message and elsewhere. Reason: Different languages have different word order and grammar.

✔ Remove device `<variable 1 (number, ID, ...)>` from group `<variable 2 (number, ID, ...)>`.

✘ Do you want to `<variable 1 (verb)>` `<variable 2 (noun)>`? [Note: Concatenations with translatable words do not work in other languages.]

## Want a Printable Handout for Workshops or Other Internal Events?

Here's the link: https://url.sap/uatop10-textquality

Feel free to use it in workshops with developers. There is one thing you need to know: The handout is intended for print, which you can tell from the crop marks in the PDF. When you send it to one of the SAP in-house print shops, tell them that the paper format is **`10,5 cm x 21 cm`** (**`4.72 in x 8.85 in`**) and the paper weight **`200 gr`**. If there's no print shop or your cost center won't pay, recycle the text and put it into a presentation. Enrich it with your own examples.

## 1.2 What's New 2025

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is continuously updated. And guess what, here are the style guide changes for 2025.

Table 1:

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2025-01 | Editorial | **Happy new year to all readers of the** *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication***!**<br><br>From Daria, Doug, and Dwight, and all the editors of the Ask the Editors community | |
| 2025-04 | Updated | **Legal Aspects: Information classification updated**<br><br>The information classification *Confidential* is no longer available for usage on SAP Help Portal due to its high potential legal risk. The labels to appear on documents can be *Public* or *Internal*. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50]<br><br>Blog post on document security in user assistance |
| 2025-05 | Enhanced | **Software and AI**<br><br>The topic Software Objects and Entities [page 193] has been enhanced with information on how to refer to artificial intelligence (AI). | SAP AI brand guidelines:https://url.sap/brand-ai |

## 1.3 What's Old – Changes from Previous Years

### 1.3.1 Change History 2024

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is continuously updated. And guess what, here are the style guide changes for 2024.

Table 2:

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2024-12 | Editorial | **Hello and goodbye**<br><br>Daria Schuster is the new owner of the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication*, together with Doug Savage. Andrea says goodbye and will embark on new adventures or non-adventures (couch potatoe). | |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2024-10 | Deleted | **Translate or Not Translate** and **German: Häufige Anglizismen bei der Übersetzung**<br><br>Both topics were removed from the *Appendix* and deleted. The topics now appear in the *SAP Translation Style Guide for German Product Translation*, which is published by Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) on Language-Specific Product Style Guides. | |
| 2024-10 | Updated | *Legal Aspects* **chapter updated**<br><br>The changes reflect the refactoring of the Product Standard for User Assistance and the user assistance task, which is part of the *Cloud Qualities* project. The task has become less important. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50]<br><br>Product Standard News |
| 2024-08 | Deleted | **Chatbots**<br><br>The *Chatbots* topic was removed from the *Communicating with Your Audience* chapter because it's obsolete. Its main purpose was to connect you with the relevant training courses, which were sunsetted some time ago. | |
| 2024-08 | Deleted | **Translation Reading List**<br><br>The *Translation Reading List* topic was removed from the *Appendix* and deleted. The topic will appear in the *SAP Translation Style Guide for German Product Translation*, which is published by Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) on Language-Specific Product Style Guides. | |
| 2024-07 | Updated | **SAP Support: "incident" is now "support case"**<br><br>The formulation pattern has been updated accordingly. The terminology change was decided in August 2023. We only found out now. | Formulation Patterns for Message Texts [page 140]<br><br>SAP Note *What is the difference between "incident" and "case"? Why is there a terminology change?* 3067028 |
| 2024-04 | Enhanced | **Term Changes: Making a Decision**<br><br>It's not always easy to decide on terminology changes in terms of effort, benefit, and implications. The SAPterm colleagues have created a decision help, which is now linked in the *Terminology and SAPterm* topic. | Terminology and SAPterm [page 74]<br><br>Direct link: Term Changes: Making a Decision |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2024-01 | Editorial | **Happy new year to all readers of the** *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication***!**<br><br>From Andrea, Doug, Dwight, Jon, and all the editors of the Ask the Editors community | |

## 1.3.2 Change History 2023

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is continuously updated. And guess what, here are the style guide changes for 2023.

Table 3:

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2023-11 | Editorial | **"IXIASOFT CCMS" now "IXIA CCMS"**<br><br>The product name has changed. | |
| 2023-11 | Editorial | **The new** *SAP Brand* **site**<br><br>The new *SAP Brand* site has been launched with the following URL: https://brand.sap.com. The previous site was called "SAP Brand Tools" (`https://sapbrandtools.com`). We're in contact with the colleagues from the *Brand and Awareness Marketing* team (previously. "Brand Voice").<br><br>In the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication*, we've faithfully reviewed and adapted the relevant topics, mainly the ones for tone and voice as well as for product names and other approved names.<br><br>The main changes are:<br>• URLs have been updated.<br>• "Brand Voice" and "SAP Brand Tools" have mainly been replaced with "*SAP Brand* site".<br>• The CIAO principle (clear, insightful, approachable, optimistic) is no longer in the writing section on the *SAP Brand* site. But the brand colleagues have assured us that it still holds true, and so it remains in the style guide. | SAP brand site at https://brand.sap.com: Identity Overview, How We Write, and Writing Style Overview |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2023-04 | Editorial | **Tools from Language Experience Lab (LXLab)**<br>*More information* links updated for the following tools: User Interface Text Space Calculator, Pseudotranslation (2Q), and Translation Object Detective (1Q) | Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] |
| 2023-03 | Enhanced | **Referring to third-party products on the user interface**<br>In import/export dialogs, you have to name the file format, such as "Microsoft Excel (*.xlsx)" or "Comma-Separated Values (*.csv)", which users later select. It's ok to do so, you can't do otherwise. | Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62] |
| 2023-02 | Enhanced | **Product sunset updated**<br>The product sunset process contains the *Remove User Assistance* task. This task now reflects the new archiving process for user assistance, as outlined in the *UA Infrastructure User Guide*. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP*<br>Direct link: Remove User Assistance task |
| 2023-01 | Editorial | **Happy new year to all readers of the** *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication***!**<br>From Andrea, Doug, Dwight, Jon, and all the editors of the Ask the Editors community | |

## 1.3.3 Change History 2022

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is continuously updated. And guess what, here are the style guide changes for 2022.

Table 4:

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2022-12 | Editorial | **SAP Jam goes SAP Work Zone**<br>Lots of URLs to be replaced. But that's done. There are redirects but who knows whether they will be there for eternity. | |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2022-12 | Enhanced | **Social Media Strategy Worksheet for User Assistance**<br>The *Social Media* topic was a bit outdated, some broken links, some outdated SAP Jam groups. Anyway, now we point you to the single-source of truth called *Social Media Strategy Worksheet for User Assistance*. Thank you, Laura, for helping with reanimating the topic. | Social Media [page 107] |
| 2022-12 | Editorial | **Gerund in topic titles**<br>The gerund is and remains the standard formulation pattern for titles of task topics. The guidelines and examples are now clearer. | Titles and Headings [page 202] |
| 2022-09 | New | **What to do if SAP sells off a product to a third party?**<br>We now have a best practices document for offboarding user assistance. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP*<br>Direct link: Offboarding User Assistance in English and Relevant Languages |
| 2022-05 | Editorial | **"Web Assistant" replaced with "SAP Companion"**<br>We've already implemented this product name change, in parallel with the internal rollout in the UA Info Forum on May 10. The new product name will externally go live with the new release at the end of June. | |
| 2022-03 | Enhanced | **Inclusive Design**<br>Links to Inclusive Design added. | Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98] and Accessibility [page 103] |
| 2022-02 | Enhanced | **Formulation Patterns in SAP Fiori**<br>Message texts are sometimes not that easy to write. For your inspiration we added links to the relevant sections in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*. | Formulation Patterns for Message Texts [page 140] under *Basics* |
| 2022-02 | Enhanced | **Before you cross-refer to SAP Notes**<br>Check whether you need to fill gaps in the user assistance or describe some typical cases. SAP Notes (category *Consulting* or *FAQ*) are often created as a response to customer requests "We need to know how `<this>` works, it's not in the documentation." | Cross-References and Hyperlinks [page 240] |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2022-01 | Editorial | **Happy new year to all readers of the** *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication***!**<br><br>From Andrea, Doug, and all the editors of the Ask the Editors community | |

## 1.3.4 Change History 2021

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is continuously updated. And guess what, here are the style guide changes for 2021.

Table 5:

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2021-10 | Enhanced | **Authorization messages as part of a secure authorization concept**<br><br>When you use the formulation pattern "not authorized for" in messages, be aware of requirement *Secure Authorization Concept (SEC-248)* in the Product Standard for Security. | Formulation Patterns for Message Texts [page 140] under *Authorization Problems* |
| 2021-09 | Editorial | **SAP Corporate Portal goes SAP One**<br><br>SAP Corporate Portal will be sunsetted at the end of 2021. We're replacing various links and hope to complete this in September or at least in October 2021. | Done. Ok, it's November 9. But not too bad, considering the efforts for tracking down the new link targets in SAP One or elsewhere. Looking forward to updating the SAP Jam links whenever it shall be. |
| 2021-04 | New | **Limitations and restrictions**<br><br>What to do when you're tasked with describing limitations and restrictions? As a general rule, user assistance is usually not the right place. Have a look at the guidelines. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *Limitations* |
| 2021-04 | New | **Geographic names**<br><br>Geographic names (countries, regions, cities, mountains, and so on) are proper names. They sometimes have equivalents (translated forms) in other languages and sometimes not. How can you deal with this in the source text and in translation? We now have some guidelines. | Geographic Names [page 221] |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2021-03 | Enhanced | **Suspended hyphens are now allowed**<br>A suspended hyphen looks like this "short- and long-term memory" (it's the first hyphen). And now it's ok to use it. We even checked the *Chicago Manual of Style*. Maybe the old rule against using suspended hyphens was from the stone ages when the various predecessor documents of the *SAP Stye Guide for Technical Communication* were created way back then. | English: Hyphenation [page 277] |
| 2021-01 | Enhanced | **Product Standard for User Assistance**<br>The product standard went live in January 2021. Hooray! It complements the user assistance task in Sirius. So we've updated *Legal Aspects: User Assistance* accordingly and explain how task and product standard relate. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP*<br>Direct link: Product Standard for User Assistance |
| 2021-01 | Editorial | **Happy new year to all readers of the** *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication***!**<br>From Andrea, Doug, and all the editors of the Ask the Editors community | |

## 1.3.5 Change History 2020

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is continuously updated. And guess what, here are the style guide changes for 2020.

Table 6:

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2020-07 | *Enhanced* | **Inclusive Language**<br>SAP is taking a stand against racism to drive change inside and outside of our organization to ensure that equality becomes a reality. Terminology is one part of that.<br>We'll update the *Bias-Free Language and Communication* topic as the *Inclusive Language* project progresses. We've added a note in the topic and link to the project page. | Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98]<br>Direct link: Inclusive Language Project |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2020-06 | *Changed* | **SAP information classification updated**<br><br>The SAP Global Security team changed the *SAP Global Information Classification and Handling Standard* in February and April 2020. A user assistance spin on these classifications is necessary because SAP Help Portal is external facing. Now that the changes have been reflected in the IXIA CCMS, we have also updated the *Legal Aspects* topic accordingly. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *Information Classification (SAP-Wide Policy)*<br><br>Direct link: Important Updates to Information Classification by SAP Global Security |
| 2020-05 | *New* | **Product sunset and out of mainstream maintenance**<br><br>Same, same but different. We've tried to explain the differences and how that relates to your work as user assistance developers. Most important: Do not delete content in the IXIA CCMS and on SAP Help Portal. And as life (at least at SAP) is complicated, we've added links to background information. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP* |
| 2020-03 | *Enhanced* | **Variants of the user assistance task in Sirius**<br><br>Link to user assistance task description for pilot deliveries added. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP* |
| 2020-02 | *Enhanced* | **Partner user assistance**<br><br>In the list of user assistance tasks in Sirius, there's now also a link to the new task for partner user assistance and the accompanying overview page. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP*<br><br>Direct link: Development Partner Enablement for User Assistance |
| 2020-01 | *Editorial* | **Happy new year to all** *SAP Style Guide* **readers!**<br><br>From Andrea, Doug, and all the editors of the Ask the Editors community | |

## 1.3.6 Change History 2019

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is continuously updated. And guess what, here are the style guide changes for 2019.

Table 7:

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2019-12 | *Enhanced* | **Controlled vocabulary: Preferred verbs for task topic titles**<br>The editors have compiled a list of verbs to be used in the titles of task topics and they are still extending this list. These verbs are based on the common user action that are defined in the Product Standard for User Experience Consistency. | Terminology and SAPterm [page 74], Titles and Headings [page 202]<br>Direct link: Controlled Vocabulary in the *Ask the Editors* community |
| 2019-11 | *Enhanced* | **English: Title case for normal, everyday words?**<br>You may be tempted to use title case for normal, everyday words because these words are somehow special. The answer is: Don't do it. In English, title case is reserved for titles, headings, names, and proper nouns. Find out more by reading the guidelines and examples. | English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199] |
| 2019-11 | *New* | **Chatbots**<br>Just like with graphics, videos, or social media, we've added a brief topic with the most basic guidelines for chatbots. You'll also find a link that gets you to the detailed guidelines in their full beauty in the *Chatbots@UA – Play and Learn* community. And exceptionally (because you will need a hands-on introduction), we've also included a link to the relevant chatbot courses. | *Chatbots* |
| 2019-08 | *Changed* | **Referring to third-party software**<br>The existing guidelines had become a bit unwieldy and out of touch with reality. So we updated them with the colleagues from the Product Standard for Licensing. | Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62] |
| 2019-07 | *Enhanced* | **Prereleasing documentation and disclaimers**<br>Some products prerelease documentation on SAP Help Portal with a disclaimer, which is a conscious risk decision. The thing is that a disclaimer won't get you out of the legal obligation to provide features according to the legal department.<br>Also, nothing to do with disclaimers, just a small thing: The guidelines for applying SAP's information classification now have their own section. They used to appear under *Basics*. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *Release Types and Delivery Channels* and *Information Classification (SAP-Wide Policy)* |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2019-06 | Tt *Editorial* | **"SAP Language Services (SLS)" renamed**<br><br>The department is now internally called "Language Experience Lab (LX Lab)". And externally it's "Globalization Services – LX". The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* was adapted accordingly. | Announcement: Unit name change from SAP Language Services (SLS) to Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) |
| 2019-05 | *Enhanced* | **`https://` versus `http://`**<br><br>Hyperlinks need to be reliable and trustworthy. So we added a short note saying that external URLs need to start with `https://`. And if there's only `http://`, think twice. | Cross-References and Hyperlinks from a Legal Perspective [page 58] |
| 2019-04 | Tt *Editorial* | **SAP language strategy**<br><br>The country and language strategy got updated by Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) and the link changed. It's absolutely worth reading because it gives you (and product owners) the reasoning behind translation scope decisions (for example, recommended languages, user interface is translated into more languages than documentation). | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP*<br><br>Direct link: Requirement SAP Language Strategy (GLOB-188) in the Product Standard for Globalization |
| 2019-02 | *Enhanced* | **Product Standard for User Experience Consistency**<br><br>The product standard went live on January 1, 2019. It addresses SAP-wide design aspects like theming and visual appearance, terminology (for common actions on the user interface), typography, icon usage, and the placement and order of actions. The user interface chapter links to the product standard. | User Interface: User Assistance Meets User Experience [page 108]<br><br>Direct link: Product Standard for User Experience Consistency |
| 2019-01 | Tt *Editorial* | **Happy new year to all** ***SAP Style Guide*** **readers!**<br><br>From Andrea, Doug, and all the editors of the Ask the Editors community | |

## 1.3.7 Change History 2018

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is continuously updated. And guess what, here are the style guide changes for 2018.

Table 8:

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2018-11 | *Enhanced* | **`NOTR` – the non-ABAP text type for no translation**<br>Developers classify non-ABAP texts (the ones in property files) with text types such as `XFLD` for field label. We've added the text type `NOTR` for no translation and explain when to use it.<br>**⚠ Caution**<br>`NOTR` is not intended for "well, I don't think this text needs translation." Developer may use it only for technical text strings that are inherently untranslatable such as `https GET` or `E029S6MMckcNCO2iv4bomEAVlD8=`. | Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] under *Context Information for Translators* |
| 2018-11 | *Changed* | **Input hints (or prompts) don't get an ending period (.)**<br>Aligned with the User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps. | Common User Interface Elements [page 119]<br>Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157] under *Punctuation Marks* |
| 2018-11 | *Enhanced* | **The term "technical support"**<br>Please note that "technical support" is just an example of a technical target group. You don't have to write "technical support" each and everywhere. It's absolutely fine if you use something that works better for the user. For example, you could go for "company's internal support team" if you only want the user to contact someone in their company instead of contacting SAP. | Formulation Patterns for Message Texts [page 140] under *Technical or Business Errors* and *Technical Target Group Needs to Take Over* |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2018-10 | *Changed* | **“figure” sounds somewhat ancient, let's use “graphic”**<br>“Figure” is a term from print times when they had a figures list in the appendix of books or printable PDFs. It was a convenient umbrella term for graphics, tables, and whatever forms of diagrams. Today “figure” sounds a bit stilted. So let's go for using the term “graphic” when referring to graphics in text.<br>By the way, the *Graphics* topic was generally revised. For example, it now explains in more detail when to use the `alt` text with graphics. | Graphics [page 260] |
| 2018-10 | *Enhanced* | **When to publish documentation with which access rights on SAP Help Portal**<br>Ever wondered whether you'll need to publish documentation at the release-to-customer date or at general availability? And what about beta deliveries? The answers lie in the Sirius tool. We've compiled some basic guidelines for the typical cases, which will also enable you to handle the more exotic delivery types. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *Release Types and Delivery Channels* |
| 2018-10 | *New* | **How to translate hotkeys**<br>We've compiled a few things that are good to know, especially how to deal with hotkeys in translation. Hotkeys are keyboard combinations. At design time, they look like this: “&Save” and sometimes “_Save” | Keyboard Keys and Key Combinations (Hotkeys) [page 153] |
| 2018-08 | *New* | **The term “country” and its political dimension**<br>It is often safer to use formulations like “country or region”, especially in combination with politically controversial territory names. This applies to user interface texts and documentation. | Terminology and SAPterm [page 74]<br>Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] |
| 2018-08 | *New* | **Overview of user assistance process added**<br>In the *Legal Aspects: User Assistance* topic you'll now find a nice overview of the user assistance process. It's actually a link to a presentation with lots of background information. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *Related Links*<br>Direct link: *What and where the heck is the user assistance process?* (https://url.sap/uaprocess_overview) |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2018-08 | *New* | **Variants of the user assistance task in Sirius**<br>The *Legal Aspects: User Assistance* topic now mentions and explains variants of the corporate task *User Assistance in English and Relevant Languages*. For example, there is a variant for user assistance in incubation channel deliveries. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP* |
| 2018-08 | *New* | **Feature scope description**<br>Good news – a best practices document for feature scope descriptions is available. It's linked in the legal aspects section and of course also on the *Standards and Guidelines Overview* page. | *Best Practices for Feature Scope Descriptions* (https://url.sap/uafsd) in the *UA Legal Network* community<br>Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP*<br>*Standards and Guidelines Overview* page (https://url.sap/sng_page) |
| 2018-05 | *Enhanced* | **Feature scope description**<br>Added a few helpful aspects, such as make it a self-contained PDF and no outgoing links. Also, graphic slightly adapted. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *User Assistance at SAP* |
| 2018-04 | *Changed* | **SAP global information classification changed**<br>The classification "customer", that we were supposed to use on front pages, is gone (March 28, 2018). The current classifications are "Confidential", "Public", and "Internal", which also have to go along with appropriate access control (for example, authorizations on SAP Help Portal).<br>**Rule of thumb:** For external content, it's now either "Public" (even Auntie Emma is allowed to read it) or "Confidential" (if it contains information you need to guard). | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] under *Basics*<br>Direct link: SAP Global Information Classification and Handling Standard and Update on Information Classification for User Assistance |
| 2018-03 | *Enhanced* | **Cross-reference formulation patterns**<br>The generic pattern "For more information, see `<target>`" is still used. We've just added a few variants and examples for your inspiration. All this is not exhaustive because the exact cross-reference formuation depends very much on the context and overall text flow. | Cross-References and Hyperlinks [page 240] |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2018-02 | *New* | **Country/Region-Specific Terminology and Foreign-Language Terms**<br><br>Country/region-specific terminology is a tricky area. This starts with deciding whether to use a foreign-language term in English (source language) or not. But help is near, we've put together best practices for terminology research, questions to ask, and examples.<br><br>A big thank you to the user assistance colleagues in the *Globalization Services* unit for their research and examples. | Terminology and SAPterm [page 74] under *Country/Region-Specific Terminology (Including Foreign-Language Terms)* |
| 2018-02 | *Enhanced* | **"We recommend" versus "SAP recommends"**<br><br>Due to popular demand, we've added "we/SAP recommends" examples to the *"We" Versus "SAP"* guidelines. It all comes down to this: Is "SAP recommends" really a recommendation or are you trying to make something mandatory sound nice? In either case, think about rephrasing. | "We" Versus "SAP" [page 88] |
| 2018-02 | *Enhanced* | **Different types of notes – restriction and remember added**<br><br>Admittedly, the guidelines for dealing with restricton and remember were a bit hidden. But now they're in the table where the other types of notes are explained. And guess what, now even with examples. | Notes, Tips, Cautions, and the Like [page 255] |
| 2018-01 | *Enhanced* | **User interface: when to use spaces before and after a slash (/)**<br><br>No, English punctuation rules haven't changed. But on the user interface things can be different with field labels. For example, if there's one field label that precedes two separate fields. Just think of an address form with adjacent fields for ZIP code and city. The field label that precedes them would read: *ZIP Code / City*<br><br>Also added a link to a very comprehensive chapter about punctuation on the user interface in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*. | Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157]<br><br>Direct link: User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps |
| 2018-01 | *Editorial* | **Happy new year to all** *SAP Style Guide* **readers!**<br><br>From Andrea, Doug, and all the editors of the Ask the Editors community | |

## 1.3.8 Change History 2017

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is continuously updated. And guess what, here are the style guide changes for 2017.

Table 9:

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2017-12 | *Enhanced* | **Intercultural aspects of user experience in** *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*<br><br>The *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines* complement very well what we have in the *Bias-Free Communication and Language* topic. So we now link to this.<br><br>Here's how they summarize things: "designing technology that considers many different cultures, languages, and economic standings while ensuring usability and user experience across intercultural boundaries" You'll find lots of examples of local working methods, environments, and symbols. | Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98]<br><br>Direct link: Intercultural Aspects of User Experience |
| 2017-11 | *Enhanced* | *Numbers* **topics now with links to** *Formatting Data Overview* **in the** *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*<br><br>Even if you don't have an SAP Fiori app, the formatting data overview will help your developers (and you) with dates, numbers, time, and units of measurements on the user interface. For example, when to display long numbers in full and when to use a short form, such as 1T, 1B, 1M, or 1K? And they also provide country/region-specific guidance (for example, "1T" in the United States versus "1 Bio." in Germany). | Numbers [page 208] and in all subordinate topics<br><br>Direct link: Formatting Data Overview |
| 2017-10 | Tt *Editorial* | **Title of user assistance task adapted**<br><br>The title of the user assistance task in Sirius is now "User Assistance in English and Relevant Languages". This title was adapted everywhere in the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication*.<br><br>The title used to be "User Assistance in All Relevant Languages". This made people **wrongly** think that the user assistance task is not relevant if their delivery is English only. | |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2017-10 | *Enhanced* | **Variables in user interface text – video and examples added**<br><br>The video has been included in the developer checklist. It visualizes the existing guidelines and examples. So it's a good complement to the guideline text.<br><br>Also, there are now examples that contrast English word order and grammar with languages that rely on inflectional endings. These examples make it tangible for developers why they must not use variables for translatable words – unless they prefer to be flooded with translation queries.<br><br>And here's a big thank you for the Concur colleagues who provided the examples. | Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] under *Variables in Messages and Other User Interface Text* |
| 2017-09 | *Enhanced* | **No need to use "then" in conditional sentences "if"**<br><br>In most cases, sentences work fine without "then". Therefore, we added this guideline. Previously there was no mention of using "then" or not. You could only guess that it's not required by looking at the example sentence. | Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles [page 176] under *Logical Sequence* |
| 2017-08 | *Enhanced* | **Developer checklist –** *Truncated Text, Length Restrictions, and Abbreviations* **section restructured**<br><br>Content was restructured in a more natural way. Section now also mentions the translation object detective (language 1Q), which helps you find the technical name and object type of a user interface text. Otherwise you won't get this text corrected. | Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] |
| 2017-08 | *Changed* | **No need to number tables and graphics any longer**<br><br>Up to now there was the odd standard "Preferably use automated numbering." It's a relict from olden print times when you couldn't search in documents and therefore had to resort to a manually created index in an appendix.<br><br>In the here and now, there's no added value numbering tables and graphics. If needs be, the IXIA CCMS has a parameter for automatic numbering. The new standard "do not number tables and graphics" is aligned with the DITA publishing team and the DITA usage expert group. | Tables [page 251] under *Table Introductions (Including Titles)*<br><br>Graphics [page 260] under *Graphic Introductions (Including Titles)* |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2017-08 | *Enhanced* | **When to use the future tense?**<br><br>Additional examples and explanations added. | Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles [page 176] under *Simple and Easy to Understand*<br><br>Discussion in the *Ask the Editors* community: When is it acceptable to use the future tense? |
| 2017-07 | *Enhanced* | **Developer checklist enhanced**<br><br>• Note on language editing added under *Basics*, why it is important and which options there are (in GitHub etc. or as translation step)<br>• Feedback for *Variables in Messages and Other User Interface Text* incorporated, variables for translatable words are now explicitly classified as *Never ever!* (apparently the previous text was too wishy-washy), another example added | Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] |
| 2017-07 | *Enhanced* | **Link to** *User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps* **added**<br><br>These guidelines are part of the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*, that is, of the *User Assistance* chapter under *Services and Resources*.<br><br>About the SAP Fiori user interface text guidelines: They build on the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication*, and cover only specific conventions for SAP Fiori applications. The guidelines are based on points that have arisen during SAP Fiori app development and in app design reviews. They cover things such as abbreviations, application names, punctuation, word choice (in particular, standard verbs and nouns to be used on the user interface, such as "Send" versus "Submit"), and floorplans and elements (for example, buttons, messages, object pages, or wizards).. | Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111] under *Formulation Patterns for Standard User Actions*<br><br>Direct link: User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2017-07 | *Enhanced* | **Link to** *User Interface Text Checklist for SAP Fiori Apps* **added**<br><br>This checklist is part of the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*, that is, of the *User Assistance* chapter under *Services and Resources*.<br><br>About the SAP Fiori checklist: The checklist was compiled on the basis of feedback from SAP Fiori app review sessions during design gates. It covers terminology, style and formattting, messages, and specific user interface elements or patterns. | User Interface: User Assistance Meets User Experience [page 108] under *Basic Quality Criteria for User Interface Texts*<br><br>Direct link: User Interface Text Checklist for SAP Fiori Apps (in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*) |
| 2017-07 | *Editorial* | **Links to the** *DITA CMS User Guide* **replaced with links to the new** *UA Infrastructure User Guide*<br><br>Note that actually only the title of the guide is new. The *UA Infrastructure User Guide* consists of the former *DITA CMS User Guide* and the *User Assistance Content Platform Guide for Doc Leads*. Both guides were merged and restructured from a process and role perspective. Great work!<br><br>By the way, here's the short link to the new guide: https://url.sap/ua-infrastructure-guide | Announcement in the *User Assistance Infrastructure* community: Merge of DITA CMS User Guide and UA Content Platform Guide for Doc Leads – one guide for all |
| 2017-06 | *Editorial* | **Link to** *Offering Types* **community updated**<br><br>On this community you find information about the different release types, such as *Standard* or *Beta*. The community used to be a subgroup of the *Program and Release Management* community on SAP Jam, but is now a community of its own. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50]<br><br>Direct link: Offering Types |
| 2017-05 | *Enhanced* | **Singular "they" and "their"**<br><br>This construction is gaining in use, especially in spoken language. Brand Voice decided in favor of it. We recommend using as a last ditch formulation option because there are usually other ways of phrasing things, such as "you" or plural "they". Also, singular "they" is an unusual construction for people without first-language proficiency in English. | Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98] under *Gender and Gender-Inclusive Language*<br><br>English: Grammar Issues of Frequent Debate [page 283]<br><br>Discussion in the *Ask the Editors* community: Is it ok to use "they" as a gender-neutral singular? |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2017-05 | *Editorial* | **A few editorial changes**<br><br>Examples: repairing the broken link to theon-premise installation guide (T066) template, adding a link to the *Multimedia Production in User Assistance* community in the *Graphics* topic, or replacing the term "column title" with "column heading"<br><br>And: Thank you for providing feedback! Much appreciated. | |
| 2017-02 | *Enhanced* | **Video about the User Interface Text Space Calculator**<br><br>In the developer checklist, there's now a video about the User Interface Text Space Calculator and more information where you can find the app. | Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] under *Readable User Interface Text* |
| 2017-01 | *Editorial* | **"Information developer" now "user assistance developer"**<br><br>As of January 2017, our basic HR job title is now "user assistance developer". The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* has been adapted accordingly. All occurrences of "information developer/development" have been replaced with "user assistance developer" or "user assistance". | Everywhere in the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication*<br><br>Info Forum, January 10, 2017: User Assistance Job Titles and Profiles |
| 2017-01 | *Changed* | **Non-ABAP text types updated**<br><br>Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) has simplified the non-ABAP text types. The text types table now tells developers which text types to use and which not because they're obsolete.<br><br>Summary:<br>• `XMSG` is now the only text type for messages. Obsolete: `YMSG` and `XLOG`<br>• `XTIT` is now the only text type for titles. Obsolete: `XCOL`, `XGRP`, and `XTBS`<br>• `XSEL` is now the only text type for values in a dropdown list. Obsolete: `XLST` | Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] |
| 2017-01 | *New* | **Overview table with allowed cross-references**<br><br>Is it allowed to cross-refer or even link to SAP-owned sites such as SAP Community or to non-SAP content? What about the link disclaimer? We've added an overview table that gives you basic guidance. The table is based on a presentation in the Legal Network for User Assistance. | Cross-References and Hyperlinks from a Legal Perspective [page 58] |

| Date | Type of Change | What's New | More Information |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2017-01 | Tt *Editorial* | **Happy new year to all** *SAP Style Guide* **readers!**<br>It may be a bit late (I'm writing this on January 9). So maybe let's say all the best for 2017! Yours, Andrea, Doug, and all the editors of the Ask the Editors community | |

## 1.3.9 Change History 2016

The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* is updated continuously. And guess what, here's where you can read about style guide changes in 2016.

### December 2016

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| **Added: How to fake links** | Should you ever need to fake links, use https://www.example.com as the underlying URL.<br>More information: Examples – Names, Other Data, and How to Introduce Them [page 223] |
| **Added for German: Last-ditch abbreviation examples of German compounds on the user interface** | In ABAP legacy systems, there's an abbreviation pattern for German compounds, which relies on CamelCase and omitting vowels, as in "MindBstMng." for "Mindestbestellmenge". We're **not** promoting this pattern. The main rule is always "do not abbreviate".<br>More information: Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111] |
| **Added: In-a-nutshell versions of important SAPterm standards** | We now explain when a context description and a definition are mandatory in SAPterm. There's also an English and a German example definition. And there's a reminder to label country/region-specific terms as such (*Valid in Country/Region* field). As before, there's a link to the full range of SAPterm standards. Also, a link to the brand translation guidelines was added.<br>More information: Terminology and SAPterm [page 74] |

### November 2016

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| **Changed: *Message Process Consulting* service to be discontinued** | The service will be discontinued as of January 2017. Therefore, the link to the service in the *User Assistance Services* catalog was removed from the *Message Texts and Content Pattern* topic. |

## October 2016

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| **Added: What is a complete sentence? What about the ending period?** | A complete sentences has a subject (who does something?) and a verb, and it unsurprisingly gets an ending period. But is "Enter your user ID." a complete sentence? Well, yes, it is. The subject is just hidden in the imperative verb.<br><br>More information: Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157] and Periods [page 304] |
| **Changed: Term "help" replaced with "core user assistance"** | "Help" is a generic, everyday term with an unspecific meaning. In the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication*, we also used it with the specific meaning "legally required minimum of user assistance, which is provided with the software". To avoid confusion, we've switched to "core user assistance" for the specific meaning. This also nicely contrasts with "additional user assistance", which enriches the user experience. SAPterm and SAPedia have also been updated accordingly.<br><br>More information: Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] |
| **New: Short link for the developer checklist** | Here's the new short link: https://url.sap/uadevchecklist<br><br>What is the developer checklist? It's an **SAP-wide collection of dos and don'ts for developers**, such as "no hard-coded text" or "use variables only for untranslatable items such as IDs". As a user assistance developer or translator, you can use this checklist as a basis for reviews, your own product-specific developer checklists, or for developer workshops. Pick what works for you, and enrich it with additional dos and don'ts and examples from your product area or software type.<br><br>Just in case – **only the short link is new**. The topic *Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages* has been part of the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* since the style guide was rolled out in July 2015. |

## September 2016

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| **Nothing major** | Just the odd editorial edit. |

## August 2016

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| **Added: Why not to use emoticons and emojis on the user interface and in user assistance** | Emoticons and emojis are culture specific. You can't really tell whether they're appropriate or whether and how to translate them. Neither do they comply with the CIAO principle (clear, insightful, approachable, optimistic) of Brand Voice. Therefore, hands off.<br><br>More information: People-Centric Language and Communication [page 83] |

**Added:** Translatability requirements are now in the developer checklist

Should you ever need to prove that hard-coded text is a big no no or similar things, then have a look at the developer checklist. We've now included the translatability requirements from the Product Standard for Globalization.

More information: Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] (under *Basics*)

**Updated:** When and how to refer to open-source software

Never ever publish the list of open-source software that's used in your product in guides or other user assistance. SAP treats such information as confidential. The *Open Source Legal Notices (OSLN)* are intended only for customers and are published **only in the SAP Software Download Center** (as rolled out by the Product Standard for Licensing on July 27, 2016). No need to worry – your product owner is responsible for this.

The previous version of this rule mentioned "the README file that is delivered along with the software or the [...] user assistance" and" insert a note [...] into your documentation after the *Legal Notice*". This is now obsolete.

More information: Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62]

**Deleted:** Topic *Additional Resources (Reference Works and the Like)*

Topic deleted for reasons of redundancy. This topic very much repeated what's on the *Standards and Guidelines Overview* page (https://url.sap/sng_page) and in the *User Assistance* community (https://url.sap/uacommunity).

## July 2016

**Added:** When to use "we" and "SAP"

Sometimes it is hard to decide whether to use "we" or "SAP". Unsurprisingly, there are no hard and fast rules for this. But lucky you, we've been able to come up with guiding principles and examples. If you want to know the in-a-nutshell version, it's this: "We" is personal whereas "SAP" is neutral. Think about what you want to convey in a particular context.

More information: "We" Versus "SAP" [page 88]

**Added for English:** When to use title case for approved names that contain lowercase

In titles, headings, and anywhere else title case is required, follow the title case rules. For example, a topic title could be "Installing and Configuring the SAP HANA Cloud Connector". But in body text you'd use of course sentence style as in "The SAP HANA cloud connector ensures ..."

More information: SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183]

## June 2016

**Added for German:** When to exceptionally use an article with an approved name

The simple reason for breaking the rule "approved names without articles" is German grammar. If a formulation sounds odd or even ungrammatical, then

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| | it's ok to use an article. For example, compare “Mit SAP Sports One können Sie ...” to “Mit dem SAP Support Portal können Sie ...”.<br><br>More information: SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183] |
| **Added: Why the x mark can be a confusing symbol in table columns** | In some countries or regions, the x mark means “correct”. In others, it means exactly the opposite. To be on the safe side, use descriptive words, such as “Yes” or “Correct”.<br><br>More information: Tables [page 251] |

## May 2016

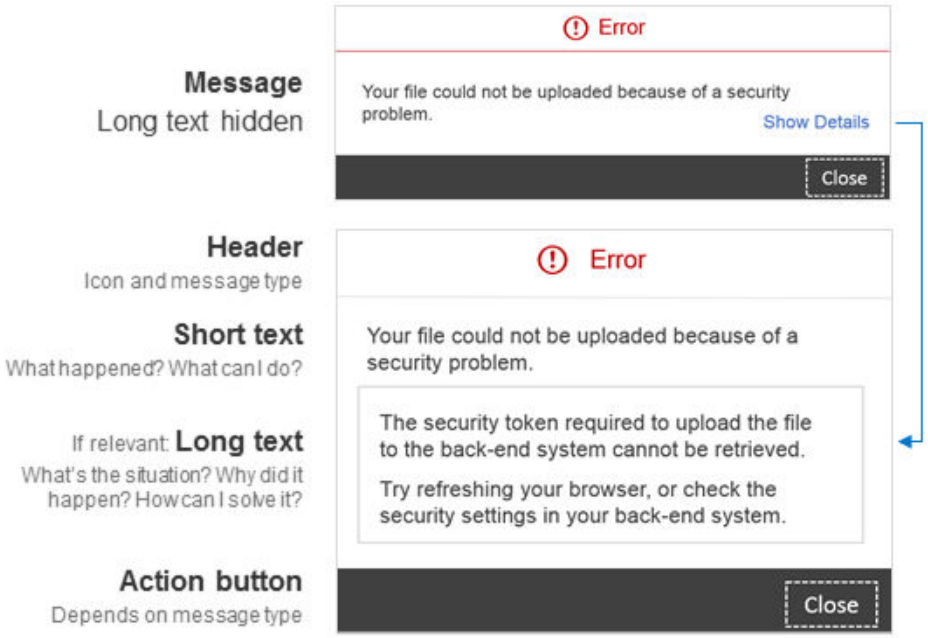
| | |
|---|---|
| **Nothing major** | Just the odd editorial edit. |

## April 2016

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| **Updated: Links to the Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) Web site for external translation agencies** | The Web site is now on SAP Support Portal (https://translation.sap.com). The Web site on SAP Service Marketplace (`https://service.sap.com/translation`) will be shut down.<br><br>More information: Support Portal Migration |
| **Added: Link to overview of the different release types** | In the *Program and Release Management* community, there's a really helpful overview of the different release types, such as standard, beta, pilot. The *Legal Aspects* topic now has a link to this overview. Here's the direct link: Offering Types<br><br>More information: Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] |

## March 2016

| | |
|---|---|
| **Enhanced: Graphic with message elements added** | It's an example of an SAP Fiori message box (message header, short text, long text, and action button). The graphic complements the table with the message elements and the guiding questions. |




More information: Message Texts and Content Pattern [page 135]

## February 2016

**Enhanced:** Feature scope description explained in more detail

Ever wondered about the feature scope description and why separate it from user assistance? Now there's the notorious car example that explains it. In a nutshell, the feature scope description corresponds to your contract with a car dealer. And user assistance corresponds to the car manual, which explains how to use all features of a car, even the ones that you didn't select. The thing is that you are only entitled to the features in the contract. In other words, user assistance is not the legally binding description of the software – if you have a separate feature scope description.

More information: Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] (*User Assistance at SAP* section)

**Updated:** Links to *Graphics* wiki replaced with links to the *Multimedia Production for User Assistance* community

The *Graphics* wiki is to be retired. All the information goes to the multimedia community. Rollout to follow in the March Info Forum.

More information: Multimedia and Graphics: Overview [page 259] and Graphics [page 260]

### January 2016

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|---|---|
| **Changed: Less strict guidance on clipped words such as "phone" or "sync"** | It used to be "do not use clipped forms". Maybe this was a bit strict. The thing is that clipped forms such as "phone" or "sync" become part of everyday speech over time. So the new rule is: Use clipped forms with care and consider what's natural for the target group.<br><br>More information: Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles [page 176] (under *Simple and Easy to Understand*) |

## 1.3.10 Change History 2015

The *General S&G Update* project was completed in July 2015. Now it's time for continuous improvement of the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication*.

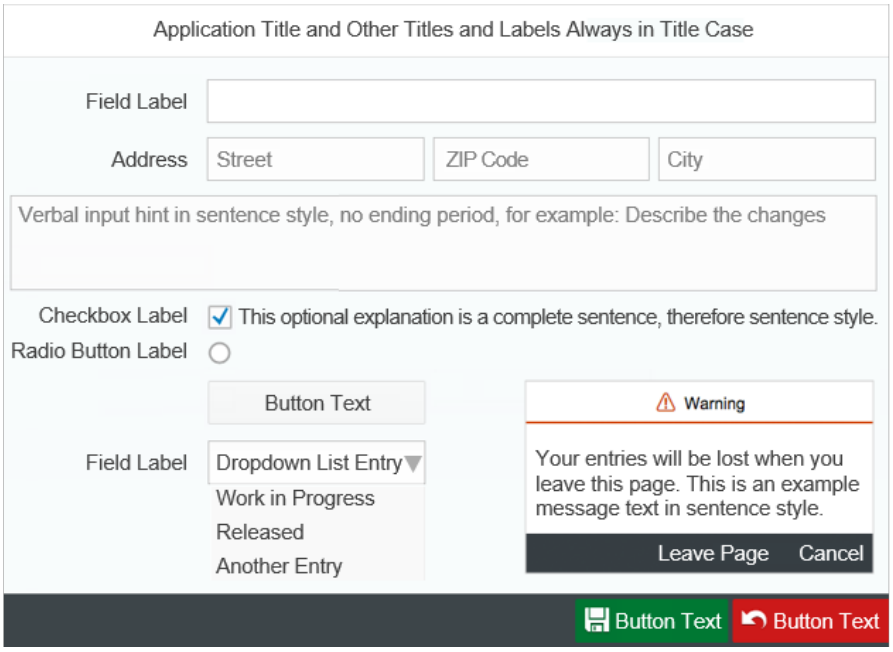
### December 2015

| | |
|---|---|
| **Changed: Term "product documentation" replaced with "user assistance"** | This is actually a change of concept, not just a terminology change. Wherever possible, "product documentation" has been replaced with "user assistance". The term "product documentation" was kept in names, titles, and contrasting contexts.<br><br>More information: Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] |
| **Ongoing: Editorial changes** | Nothing noteworthy. An additional example here, a reformulation there. |

## November 2015

**New: Screen mockup with user interface elements in title case and sentence style**

The new graphic will make it – hopefully – easier to remember when to use title case and sentence style for on the user interface:




More information: Common User Interface Elements [page 119] and Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160]

**Changed: Sections in topics are now collapsible**

Maybe you've thought that some topics are rather long in this style guide. That's why the sections in each topic are now collapsed when you open a topic. So you can scan the content more easily.

**Changed: Links to the Legal KM Network and the Legal Framework updated in various topics**

Both links pointed to wiki pages, which won't be updated any longer. Note that the "Legal KM Network" is now called "Legal Network for User Assistance" and follows a community-based approach. Rollout to follow in the December Info Forum.

Therefore, if you have bookmarked the outdated links to the Legal KM Network and the Legal FAQ, proceed as follows:

✘ Legal KM Network and Legal FAQ – remove these outdated links from your bookmarks

✔ Legal Network for User Assistance – bookmark this link to the new community (contacts from your product area, FAQ, and more)

## October 2015

| | |
|---|---|
| **New:** Delta from *Translation Style Guide for German: Product Documentation* incorporated | If you don't know whether to translate paths and folders, placeholders in code examples, and so on, have a look at the new topic *Translate into the Target Language or Keep the English Source Text*. If you translate from English into German, try the new topic on anglicisms in German and how to avoid them. |

## September 2015

| | |
|---|---|
| **Renamed and enhanced:** *Visuals: Layout, Graphics, and the Like* is now *Multimedia and Graphics: Overview* | No need to worry, the guidelines haven't changed. In the topic, we've simply added a link to the new multimedia community in SAP Jam, called *Multimedia Production for User Assistance* in SAP Jam. This is also the reason why the title was changed to *Multimedia and Graphics: Overview*.<br><br>The new multimedia community helps you find the appropriate media types for your user assistance deliverables. It covers different types of videos, demos and tutorials, and graphics (static and interactive). For each media type, you'll find templates, style guides, tool support, and contact persons. In addition, you can request a production service and book training courses.<br><br>More information: Multimedia and Graphics: Overview [page 259] (in this style guide) |
| **New:** Translatability aspects and conversational transitions added to *People-Centric Language and Communication* | You often hear that you can't translate people-centric language. There are certainly limits and these are now explained. To help you make information sound more like natural language, a section on conversational transitions such as "Take a look" and "Here's how" was added. To counterbalance this, there's now also a reminder that conversational doesn't mean chatty. It's always important to be direct and concise. Last but not least, a big thank you to the people-centric ambassadors because the guidelines and examples are from their course material.<br><br>More information: People-Centric Language and Communication [page 83] and Conversational Tone and Casual Phrasing [page 90] |
| **Terminology change:** "User Interface Text Space Calculator" instead of "User Interface Text Space Matrix" | The User Interface Text Space Matrix is now called "User Interface Text Space Calculator". In this style guide, the new name is already used. The terminology change was decided by Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) and Brand Voice. The calculator was rolled out by Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) in the September 2015 Info Forum.<br><br>More information: Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] |

## August 2015

**New: More information about the different types of tooltips and about the text length**

A rose is a rose is a rose, but a tooltip is not a tooltip is not a tooltip. Tooltips depend very much on the development environment and user interface technology. So find out what kind of tooltip is technically used on your user interface. How does it relate to other types of embedded help? For example, in SAP GUI you need to decide whether to provide the information in a tooltip or rather in the field help. This brings up the question of how long tooltips are supposed to be. The philosophical answer is as short as possible, especially if your tooltip type disappears after a few seconds. If you want a very general rule, then let's say 5–10 words.

More information: Tooltips (Mouseovers) [page 150]

**New: List of common units of measurement added**

In addition, there are now links to *SI Brochure: International Systems of Units (SI)* (English and German version) provided by the Bureau International des Poids et Mesures and the *Common Conversion Factors* provided by the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST). This is just in case you need to look up things.

More information: Units of Measurement and Scientific Symbols [page 213]

**New for German: "Sie" as the default form of address**

In a way, "Sie" as the default form of address is obvious. Now this is also mentioned in the style guide, plus a few rare exceptions such as "Du" used in apps for sports team communication. Note that all exceptions need to be based on industry research.

More information: Addressing the User Directly [page 86]

**New: Developer checklist now with implications of wrong language usage**

Why? Translation tools and memories work only if a text with source language English really contains English text.

More information: Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160]

**New: "Make your messages sound friendly and instructive." added to the message formulation patterns**

You can create a friendly and instructive tone even with little things such as using articles and complete sentences. A telegraphic style tends to make messages sound abrupt although in particular cases it can be an efficient means of communication. Examples are provided.

More information: Formulation Patterns for Message Texts [page 140]

**New: *Video* topic now with link to a video community for user assistance**

The new *Multimedia Production in User Assistance* community in SAP Jam has a subgroup for videos in user assistance. You'll find templates, style guides, and contacts for different types of videos, such as how-to, or what's new. You can also book trainings or create a production request.

More information: Videos [page 264]

## July 2015

| | |
|---|---|
| **New: “in the community” and “in the wiki” added to prepositions overview** | More information: Prepositions to Be Used with Common Computer Terms [page 227] |
| **Terminology change: “target language” instead of “follow-on language”** | The change was requested by Language Experience Lab (LX Lab). |
| **New: Developer checklist now with link to the User Interface Text Space Matrix in Bridge** | The User Interface Text Space Matrix is now available in Bridge (go to https://bridge.mo.sap.corp). The matrix calculates the minimum text length and space that are required in the source to make screens work in other languages. Nobody wants truncated user interface texts, right? So the table with the recommended length for user interface texts was removed from the developer checklist and a link to the User Interface Text Space Matrix was inserted. Please note that for the time being the matrix is a beta version. If you have questions, contact Language Experience Lab (LX Lab).<br><br>More information: Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] |
| **New: Input hints (also known as “hint text”, “placeholder text”, “input prompt”)** | Here are the guidelines in a nutshell:<br>• Use sentence style.<br>• End complete sentences with a period (.).<br>• Do not use ellipsis (...).<br>• If a field has a self-descriptive field label, do not add an input hint.<br><br>More information: Common User Interface Elements [page 119] |

## 1.3.11 Change History 2014/2015 (General S&G Update Project)

Here's the delta between the new *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* (November 2014 onwards) and its predecessor, the *General Standards and Guidelines for Writing at SAP* (2.0, December 2007). All changes are based on research and decisions by the *General S&G Update* project (April 2014 – July 2015).

### Overall Changes

| **Keyword or** *Topic Title* | **Change Description** | **More Information** |
|---|---|---|
| New document title – goodbye *General S&G* | The *General Standards and Guidelines for Writing at SAP* are now called *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication*.<br><br>Why? As user assistance developers and translators, we deal not only with text, but also with other media types, such as videos and graphics. So basically it's all about communication. Also, the term "technical communication" is a standard industry term. | Familiarize with the updated style guide. |
| Rollout and publication – no big bang but main chapter by main chapter | **Which style guide version is the binding one?**<br><br>With the July Info Forum, the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* replace the *General Standards and Guidelines for Writing at SAP* (2.0, December 2007).<br><br>**When and how was the new style guide rolled out?**<br><br>The new *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* was rolled out main chapter by main chapter in subsequent Info Forums from November 2014 to July 2015.<br><br>**Where is the new style guide published?**<br><br>The new style guide is published on the central *Standards and Guidelines (S&G) Overview* page. | Info Forum Agendas and Materials. Search for **`General S&G Update Project`**.<br><br>General S&G 2014 Update Project |
| How to deal with legacy content or inconsistencies? | As is custom, new and updated standards apply only to new content and to existing content that needs to be updated. Do not adapt your content for the mere sake of consistency.<br><br>However, changes in the standards may turn out to be disruptive for your existing content. For example, if age-old back-end messages appear together with new messages on a new front end, style, tone, or punctuation are likely to be different. There is no one-solution-fits-all approach for this. You will have to weigh different aspects and implications against each other. For example, will the user notice the difference at all? Will it affect text comprehensibility? | In the case of disruptive changes, discuss the issues with the user assistance architects in your area. |

| **Keyword or** *Topic Title* | **Change Description** | **More Information** |
|---|---|---|
| Table of contents reworked (but recognizably) | The table of contents has been updated, adapted, and restructured. Some topics, such as *People-Centric Language*, are new. Others, such as *Lists* or *Typographic Conventions and Formatting*, have been condensed or are discontinued.<br><br>But no need to be afraid. You'll recognize things and find your way through the new style guide.<br><br>Here are the **new main chapters**:<br>• *About This Style Guide* – **released** (rolled out Info Forum November 2014)<br>• *Busy? New? Clueless? Try the Top 10* – **released** (rolled out Info Forum November 2014)<br>• *Legal Aspects: User Assistance and Product Documentation* – work in progress<br>• *Communicating with Your Audience: What Do Your Target Groups Need?* – **released** (rolled out Info Forum January 2015)<br>• *Style and Word Choice: Practical Issues* – **released** (rolled out Info Forum March 2015)<br>• *Structure and Text Organization: Basic Elements* – **released** (rolled out Info Forum April 2015)<br>• *Visuals: Layout, Graphics, and Video* – **released** (rolled out Info Forum May 2015)<br>• *The Mechanics: Language, Grammar, and Punctuation* – **released** (rolled out Info Forum November 2014)<br>• *User Interface: User Assistance Meets Usability* – **released** (rolled out Info Forum July 2015)<br>• *Appendix* – work in progress | Have a look at the table of contents, its main chapters, and their subtopics. |
| Discontinued: *Typographic Conventions and Formatting* topics | The new style guide is tool agnostic and therefore does not cover formatting. The different formatting standards for the various authoring tools would never be up to date anyway. Please refer to the user guide of your authoring tool instead. | Refer to the formatting topics in the user guide for your authoring tool. |

## Legal Aspects

Interim version for the time being (rollout postponed). Change description: July 15, 2015

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Legal Aspects* and subtopics | Revised and updated as required.<br>**Note**<br>The *Legal Aspects* main chapter will remain work in progress to a certain extent. This is related to the ongoing transition from product documentation to the more holistic concept of user assistance. | Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] |
| *Cross-References and Hyperlinks from a Legal Perspective* | Revised and updated as required. | Cross-References and Hyperlinks from a Legal Perspective [page 58] |
| *Copyright, Legal Notice, and Trademarks* | Revised and updated as required. | Copyright, Trademarks, and Other Legal Notices [page 60] |
| *Third-Party – How to Refer to It* | Revised and updated as required. | Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62] |

## Communicating with Your Audience: What Do Your Target Groups Need?

Released (rolled out in Info Forum January 2015). Change description: January 15, 2015

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Communicating with Your Audience: What Do Your Target Groups Need?* | New topic. Determine who you're writing for and what they need. This topic includes a list of the SAP-wide key target groups, a description of each group's unique information needs, and recommendations for how to address those needs. The key target groups are decision maker, IT consultant/implementer, IT administrator, super user, professional user, casual user, developer.<br>**Just in case:** You might be wondering where to find the bottom-line standards and principles (for example, present tense, simple words and sentence structure, active voice, "you", abbreviations). They are not gone. They are in the *Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles* main chapter. | Communicating with Your Audience: Who Are Your Target Groups? [page 65] |
| *From Information Needs to User Assistance Deliverables* | New topic. Determine your key deliverables by assessing the information needs of your audience. This topic provides a list of possible deliverables and the target groups who will be most interested in using them. | From Information Needs to User Assistance Deliverables [page 68] |

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Terminology and SAPterm* | No major changes. Topic and examples have been revised and updated as required.<br><br>The updated topic summarizes general standards for terminology work, such as "define terminology early on" or "enter your terminology in SAPterm according to the entry conventions". It also addresses the issue of country/region-specific terms and process aspects.<br><br>The previous style guide version contained the topic *Terminology Entries in SAPterm*. This previous topic is discontinued because you can find the latest version of the SAPterm standards (terms, definitions, other entry conventions) on the central terminology home page. The updated topic links to the SAPterm standards. | Terminology and SAPterm [page 74] |
| *Brand Voice: Tone of Voice and Writing Style* | New topic. It's an in-a-nutshell version of tone of voice and writing style on SAP Brand Tools (the CIAO principle: clear, insightful, approachable, and optimistic). These principles form the basis for everything you'll find on people-centric language and communication in this style guide. | Tone of Voice and Writing Style (SAP Brand) [page 81] |
| *People-Centric Language and Communication* and subtopics | New topics. Provides clear guidelines for how to adopt a more personable and conversational tone in your writing. Includes recommendations on addressing the user, using contractions, using casual phrases, and being polite. | People-Centric Language and Communication [page 83] |
| *Bias-Free Language and Communication* | No major changes. Topic and examples have been revised and updated as required. | Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98] |
| *Accessibility* | Topic and examples have been revised and updated as required. This includes guidelines for using the term "accessible" and related formulation patterns (based on project findings from 2012). You'll also find a link to the new *Standards and Guidelines for Accessibility Documentation*. | Accessibility [page 103] |
| *Social Media* | New topic. Provides and links to guidelines for how and what to communicate through social media. Note that social media content cannot replace the core assistance, which is provided with the software. | Social Media [page 107] |

## User Interface: User Assistance Meets Usability

Released (rolled out in Info Forum July 2015). Change description: July 7, 2015

| **Keyword or** *Topic Title* | **Change Description** | **More Information** |
|---|---|---|
| *User Interface: User Assistance Meets Usability* and subtopics | Major update. Topics and examples have been revised, updated, and enhanced.<br><br>Good software is all about a simple, elegant, supportive, and user-adapted experience. As a user assistance developer or translator, you are the expert for terminology, comprehensibility, tone of voice, consistency, and of course linguistic correctness. Your expertise will decisively improve the user experience.<br><br>So get involved in user experience activities early on. Work together with the user experience designers. Embed important information on the user interface.<br><br>You'll also get recommendations for applying new standards to legacy software from SAP or acquired companies. In a nutshell: Be pragmatic. There is no one-solution-fits-all approach.<br><br>Main change: Consider all user interface standards as default standards. Consider defining more specific rules for your product area or software type. In times of about 30 different user interface technologies at SAP, hard and fast rules are history. You're the expert, you know best. | User Interface: User Assistance Meets User Experience [page 108] |
| *Text on the User Interface – The Basics* | New topic. Lots of background information and principles.<br><br>A meaningful user interface provides users with relevant information in good language quality. So don't hide information in guides. Ask for language editing. Ask your developers to run pseudotranslation checks and detect hard-coded or truncated texts. Get involved in defining formulation patterns for user interface elements. For example, are you going to use *Create* or *New* on your screens? You'll also get recommendations for dealing with front-end/back-end inconsistencies and with abbreviations and space restrictions. | Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111] |

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level* and *Common User Interface Elements* | Major update. Topics and examples have been revised, updated, and enhanced.<br><br>Main change: Get away from detailed click-level formulations. This is nearly always stating the obvious and it doesn't work for multidevice applications. Instead, try indirect, device-neutral formulations. Instead of standard formulations for field labels, buttons, and other common user interface elements, you will now find formulation patterns for your inspiration. They cover patterns for the text that appears on the screen itself and patterns for referring to these elements in text. However, consider defining more specific standards for your own product area or software type.<br><br>**Example**<br><br>✗ Enter a product name in the *Search* field, and choose *Search*. Then add the product to your shopping cart by choosing *Add to Cart*.<br><br>✓ Add products to your shopping cart.<br><br>New: There are guidelines for dealing with incorrect user interface texts, especially when you need to refer to them in text. First try to fix major defects such as incorrect terminology or incomprehensible wording on the user interface. If this can't be done in time, quote the incorrect text as-is and add the issue to the backlog for the next release. | Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116] and Common User Interface Elements [page 119] |
| *Message Texts and Content Pattern* and *Formulation Patterns for Message Texts* | Major update. Topics and examples have been revised, updated, and enhanced.<br><br>Main change: Complete sentences get an ending period (.). Instead of standard formulations, you will now find formulation patterns for your inspiration. However, consider more specific defining standards for your own product area or software type.<br><br>New: A content pattern explains the different elements of a message, such as message identifier, message short text, message long text (diagnosis, cause, solution), or action buttons. | Message Texts and Content Pattern [page 135] and Formulation Patterns for Message Texts [page 140] |
| *Tooltips (Mouseover)* | New topic. Tooltips appear on mouseover in desktop applications. They briefly explain fields, buttons, GUI icons, and other user interface elements. Tooltips also help make screens more accessible. But then not all tooltips are alike. There's not even a universal terminology for them, and their use depends on the development environment. | Tooltips (Mouseovers) [page 150] |

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Keyboard Keys and Key Combinations* | Topic and examples have been revised and updated as required. | Keyboard Keys and Key Combinations (Hotkeys) [page 153] |
| *Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface* | New topic. In times of different user interface technologies and screen designs, there are even specifics for punctuation marks and special characters. For example, when to use ellipsis (...) or why punctuation marks must not be hard-coded. | Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157] |
| *Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in all Languages* | New topic. This checklist outlines what developer can do to ensure that all users get meaningful screens in their language. User assistance developers or translators can use the checklist for reviews or as a basis for a product-specific checklist. The checklist is based on various *Developer Dos and Don'ts* presentations, wikis, and so on from different product areas and Language Experience Lab (LX Lab). | Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160] |

## Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles

Released (rolled out in Info Forum March 2015). Change description: March 10, 2015

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles* and subtopics | No major changes. Topics and examples have been revised and updated as required.<br><br>This new main chapter provides you with bottom-line standards and principles such as comprehensibility, conciseness, and the all-time classic active and passive voice. You'll also find guidelines for dealing with approved names (incl. what to do if there is none) as well as for capitalization, titles and headings, abbreviations, numbers, names for using in examples, why not to use "(s)" plurals, and so on. The main chapter is based on the main chapters *Style and Related Topics* and *Terminology and Word Choice* from the previous version. | Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles [page 176] |

| **Keyword or** *Topic Title* | **Change Description** | **More Information** |
|---|---|---|
| Stable topics from the previous version | This main chapter contains topics that haven't changed much since the previous version:<br>• *SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names* – revised and updated as required<br>• *Software Objects and Entities (No Approved Names)* – previously called *Descriptors, Titles, and Technical Names*<br>• *English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case)* – section on capitalization of user interface elements is now part of *Common User Interface Elements*<br>• *Titles and Headings* – "English titles with plural nouns, German titles with singular nouns" is now "Use plural or singular nouns in titles as appropriate."<br>• *Abbreviations* – the general direction is now "Less is more. But no abbreviation is best, especially on the user interface."<br>• *Numbers* – revised and updated as required, especially the thousand separators in German; new section on millions and billions; general alignment with Brand Voice, for example, "spell out numbers one through nine", which is a rule with many many exceptions<br>• *Prepositions to Be Used with Common Computer Terms* – section on user interface and related terms is now part of *Common User Interface Elements*<br>• *Names and Other Data for Using in Examples* – revised and updated as required<br>• *Special Characters – How to Refer to Them* – "braces" are now referred to as "curly brackets" and "brackets" as "square brackets" for the sake of clarity | |
| *Releases, Support Packages, and the Like* | New topic. If you need to refer to support package stacks or feature package stacks, use the formulation pattern "SAP Invented Product 2.1 SPS 4" for **body text**. Note that there are contexts, such as data entry in PPMS or folder sorting, that require a leading zero (0). The formulation patterns are aligned with the central release management group. | Releases, Support Packages, and Other Versioning Information [page 189] |
| *English: No Plurals with "(s)" or "/s"* | New topic. In English it is tempting to use plural forms such as "contract(s)" or "order/s". But this doesn't work in other languages. So how can you avoid the tempting""(s)" and "/s" and make life easier for translators? | English: No Plurals with "(s)" or "/s" [page 229] |

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Files and Folders – How to Refer to Them* | New topic. As the title suggests, it's mainly about how to refer to file types. And here's the standard in a nutshell:<br><br>Refer to a file type either with a generic descriptive term such as "text file" or with the acronym-like abbreviation in uppercase such as "the ZIP file". Descriptive terms for file names usually have a broader meaning than the acronym-like abbreviations. Check how specific you need to be.<br><br>Don't feel obliged to rewrite your texts if you've adhered to a different convention so far – as long as you've done so consistently. | Files and Folders – How to Refer to Them [page 231] |

## Structuring: Topics, Links, Lists, Tables, and More

Released (rolled out in Info Forum April 2015). Change description: April 14, 2015

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Structuring: Topics, Links, Lists, Tables, and More* and subtopics | Topic and examples have been revised and updated as required. You'll now find checklists for meaningful navigation structures (DITA: maps) and topics. In the previous version, the topic was called *Basic Principles of Structuring* and was part of the *Style and Related Topics* main chapter.<br><br>The theme of all topics in this new main chapter is that information is easier to scan and understand when it is structured. This applies to topics and block elements such as lists, tables, or cross-references but also to topics arranged in a navigation structure. | Structuring: Topics, Links, Lists, Tables, and More [page 237] |
| *Cross-References and Hyperlinks* | Topic and examples have been revised and updated as required. You'll recognize things. The main difference is that the standards are rather best practices and things to consider instead of hard and fast rules. For example, instead of standard formulations you'll find formulation patterns for typical cases, which you can adapt to your situation.<br><br>In a nutshell, the topic covers this: Have a linking strategy for your product area or software type. Don't clutter your text with cross-references. Prefer end-of-topic cross-references to inline cross-references. Apply the formulation patterns for inline cross-references and for cross-references to external link targets. | Cross-References and Hyperlinks [page 240] |
| *Lists* | No major changes. Topic and examples have been revised and updated as required. | Lists [page 246] |

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Tables* | No major changes. Topic and examples have been revised and updated as required.<br><br>The only notable change is: Empty cells are fine. Screen readers know how to interpret empty cells. Previously you had to add "Not relevant" or a similar formulation. | Tables [page 251] |
| *Notes, Tips, Cautions, and the Like* | No major changes. The topic, however, reflects the current DITA usage at SAP. So it's not really tool agnostic.<br><br>New aspect: Safety-related information is addressed from an ISO and ANSI standards perspective. The thing is that in industry 4.0 the worlds of software and manufacturing will move closer together. In the appendix, there's a comparison of various international standards, such as ISO 26514 and ANSI 535.6. | Notes, Tips, Cautions, and the Like [page 255] and Cautions and Warnings in ISO and Other International Standards [page 320] |

## Visuals: Layout, Graphics, and the Like

Released (rolled out in Info Forum May 2015). Change description: May 5, 2015

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Visuals: Layout, Graphics , and the Like* and subtopics | New topic and main chapter. The various visual aspects are decided at **different levels**. For example, there is SAP Brand Tools, where colors, fonts, and so on are defined SAP wide. In the area of user assistance, there are a specifications for PDF and HTML design and there are specific standards for graphics, screenshots, and videos. | Multimedia and Graphics: Overview [page 259] |
| *Graphics* | No major changes. Topic has been revised and updated as required. The *Graphics* topic summarizes the graphics standards in the *Graphics* wiki and focuses on how to connect graphics and text.<br><br>In 2011, the *Graphics* main chapter in the previous style guide was superseded by the *Graphics* wiki. The wiki has all the standards for tools, graphic templates, graphic types, colors, fonts, pictograms, Technical Architecture Modeling (TAM), and so on. | Graphics [page 260] |
| *Screenshots* | No major changes. Topic has been revised and updated as required. It now reflects *Screenshots – Things to Consider* in the *Graphics* wiki. | Screenshots [page 262] |

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Videos* | New topic. Note that the video medium is in the process of being established in user assistance. So this topic is rather generic and refers you to an SAP Jam community with up-to-date information.<br><br>In a nutshell: Videos can make it much easier for your audience to grasp the information. You can demonstrate what you want to convey. However, this very benefit is a drawback for users with disabilities. So you have to consider accessibility requirements, for example, by providing subtitles. | Videos [page 264] |

## The Mechanics: Language, Grammar, and Punctuation

Released (rolled out in Info Forum November 2014). Change description: November 4, 2014

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *Corporate Language (U.S. English) and Source Languages (English, German)* | New topic. As the title suggests, it explains how U.S. English as corporate language at SAP relates to the English and German as source languages. This is actually nothing new. It just wasn't explained anywhere before. | Corporate Language (U.S. English) and Source Languages (English, German) [page 267] |
| *English: U.S. English, Global English, and Some Grammar* and subtopics | No major changes. Topics and examples have been revised and updated as required.<br><br>The main chapter *American English* in the previous version is now called *U.S. English, Global English, and Some Grammar*. This is to reflect that most of the content deals with English in general and not with American English in particular.<br><br>The following topics are new:<br><br>• *Global English: How to Write Clear, Translatable Texts for a Global Audience* provides guidance for grammar and wording issues that are tricky for peple without first-language proficiency in English and also for translation.<br>• *Grammar Issues of Frequent Debate* deals with issues such as dangling modifiers, split infinitives, or the position of prepositions in relative clauses.<br><br>Discontinued: *Simple Past Versus Present Perfect* because feedback has revealed that it is considered confusing and not helpful. | English: U.S. English, Global English, and Some Grammar [page 269] |

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| *German: Deutsche Rechtschreibung und Wortwahl* (German spelling and wording) and subtopics | No major changes. Topics and examples have been revised and updated as required.<br><br>In *German: Komposita mit englischen Wörtern (nicht im Rechtschreibduden)*, you'll now also find spelling and punctuation standards for names other than approved names (softwarenahe Eigennamen; for example, "die Accounting Engine") and for compounds with elements from programming languages (for example, "IF-Schleife").<br><br>The Rechtschreibduden has been online for some years. As it is always up to date, feel free to look up words online: https://www.duden.de | German: Deutsche Rechtschreibung und Wortwahl [page 286] |
| *Punctuation* and subtopics | No major changes. Topics and examples have been revised and updated as required.<br><br>The topic *Using Spaces* from the discontinued main chapter *Typographic Conventions and Formatting* is continued and has therefore been moved to this main chapter.<br><br>Terminology change for the sake of clarity:<br>• { } = "curly brackets" instead of "braces"<br>• [ ] = "square brackets" instead of "brackets" | Punctuation [page 301] |

## Appendix

Released (rolled out as part of the relevant main chapters). Change description: July 7, 2015

| Keyword or *Topic Title* | Change Description | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| Various | *Accessibility Aspects for Output Formats and Tools*, *Cautions and Warnings in ISO and Other International Standards* | Appendix [page 319] |

# 2 Legal Aspects: User Assistance

Legal aspects are a complex matter, more than a style guide can cover. So here are the very basics about user assistance (previously known as “product documentation”) and the legal concept of documentation.

## Basics

**If you have questions about legal issues, contact the Legal Network for User Assistance.**

For more information, see the Legal Network for User Assistance community (each and everything) and the Product Standard for User Assistance (the very basics).

**Ensure that customers get sufficient information to install/deploy, configure, and use the software and a feature scope description. Don't describe things that the software can't do.**

That's it in a nutshell. Unfortunately, things are a bit more complicated. When trying to comply with legal requirements, you will encounter similar terms and concepts, in particular “documentation”, “product documentation”, and “user assistance”. This can get confusing. Let's take a closer look.

## “Documentation” as a Legal Concept

Forget user assistance and software for a moment. In a legal context, “documentation” serves the following purposes: (1) customer enablement in terms of usage instructions, (2) complete and simultaneous delivery with the product, and (3) product description in terms of functions and features

**What does the law say?**

By law, “documentation” is an **integral part of any product**, in terms of “product completeness (free of defects)”. That is, SAP is legally required to provide documentation **with** the software, which is SAP's product. Documentation needs to **enable the customer** to use the software, including installation and configuration (German BGB §434 (2): insufficient assembly instructions). So documentation needs to be complete and correct.

In laws and jurisdiction, which is mainly from around 1990 to 2000, the term “documentation” has the connotation “printed/printable documents”. This is because print was the then-current medium for providing information.

**What do the International Financial Reporting Standards (IFRS) say?**

IFRS requires **complete and simultaneous delivery of all parts of the software**, including documentation. Deferred or incomplete delivery constitutes a breach of contract and entitles customers to claim complete delivery of all documentation, defer payment, claim damages, or even terminate their agreement with SAP.

**What do SAP's General Terms and Conditions (GTC) say?**

The GTCs are part of the agreements between SAP and a customer (see SAP's Terms and Conditions). "**Documentation**" is positioned as follows:

- It means "technical and functional documentation", which is not explained further.
- It describes the "**functional qualities**" (feature scope) of the software. That is, SAP guarantees that the functions and features are provided as described in the documentation.
- It is made **available with the software**. For on-premise software, this means physical shipment on disc or other data media or electronic delivery via SAP Software Download Center.

**Therefore, describe only functions and features that are actually available in the software.**

> ⚠ Caution
>
> If the documentation describes **functions or features that are not available in the software**, this could result in SAP having to provide the missing functions and in **deferral of payment of related SAP software license revenues**.

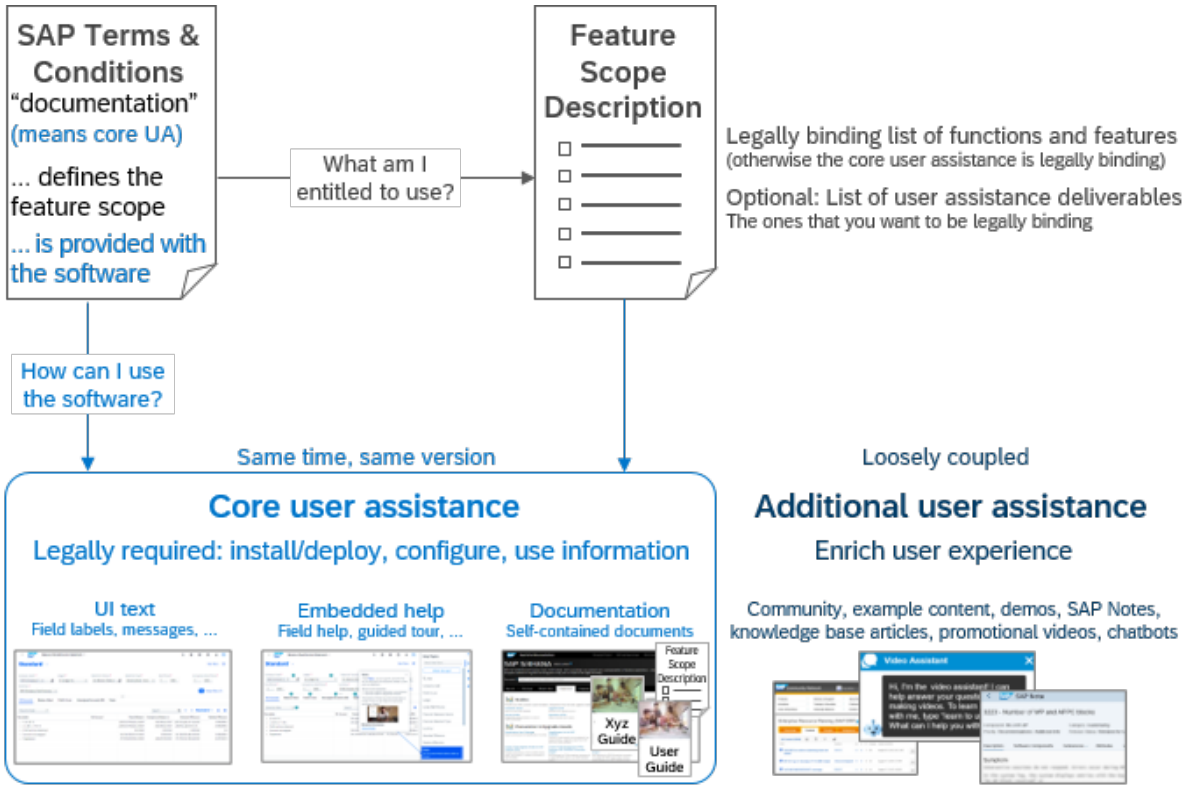
By the way, describing functions and features does not mean stating the obvious. If a screen is intuitive and has embedded help, there is no need to repeat in a click-level description with a numbered list what the user does on the screen.

## "User Assistance" at SAP

"Documentation" is a legal concept. At SAP, the corresponding concepts in a software context are "core user assistance" (the legally required minimum provided with the software) and "feature scope description" (the mere functions and features). It all comes down to the question: Which information deliverables do you provide with SAP software?

So how do user assistance and the feature scope description relate to SAP's Terms and Conditions? You may wonder why this is important to understand. The reason is that SAP's Terms and Conditions are a document

from the legal sphere. They use only the term “the documentation” but never mention “user assistance”. Have a look at the following graphic and the questions and answers:




**What is “user assistance”?**

User assistance enables **the customer to install/deploy, configure, and use the software** and enriches the user experience. It is flexible and innovative, especially with output formats and multimedia. It covers user interface texts (for example, field labels, messages), embedded help (for example, mouseovers, guided tours, how-to videos), and separate, self-contained deliverables (for example, user guide, administrator guide, or even things such as community blogs).

**Is there a legal minimum of user assistance?**

Yes, there is. At SAP, it's called “**core user assistance**”. Core user assistance (“install/deploy, configure, and use”) is simultaneously provided with the software. What does this mean? UI texts and embedded help appear on the user interface, and documentation is provided on SAP Help Portal (for on-premise also in SAP Software Download Center). All this relates to the legal concept of “documentation” in terms of product completeness and complete and simultaneous delivery with the software. Core user assistance is **legally required**.

To enrich the user experience, you or others can provide **additional, supporting user assistance**, such as community content, blogs, best practices, example content, or demos. In a broader sense, SAP Notes or knowledge base articles also belong here. These deliverables typically have their **own publishing cycle**, which is loosely connected to the product delivery cycle. Their content is more of a dynamic or short-lived nature.

> **Note**
>
> Multimedia content has to be usable for everybody. In terms of accessibility, this is in particular about text alternatives for non-text content, audio and video control, and no flickering or flashing content. For more information, see the Product Standard for Accessibility.

**What exactly are the user assistance deliverables for your type of SAP software?**

Unsurprisingly, there is no SAP-wide set of tangible deliverables and output formats along the lines of "always provide an installation guide in PDF". There are just too many different types of software.

The only thing you can do is to derive the deliverables for your type of software from the SAP-wide target groups (users, administrators, consultants/implementers, developers) and their information needs (for example, terminology, security, administration, user interface). For more information, see Communicating with Your Audience: Who Are Your Target Groups? [page 65], From Information Needs to User Assistance Deliverables [page 68], and Product Standard for User Assistance.

**Is there an SAP-wide procedure for defining and creating user assistance deliverables? What about the language strategy?**

Yes, there is. In Sirius, there's the Product Standard for User Assistance. The requirements User Assistance (Including Translation) Provided with the Software (UA-010) and Only Existing Features Described (UA-030) have the obligation level *Corporate*. They are relevant for the release decision and are listed in the corporate requirement Revenue Recognition According to IFRS. UA-010 links to the planning aid for user assistance and to the requirement SAP Language Strategy (GLOB-188), which belongs to the Product Standard for Globalization.

**Who's involved?** The product manager is accountable for fulfilling the product standard. They work together with the user assistance lead and translation coordinator from Language Experience Lab (LX Lab). Together with the user assistance developers and the translators, they are responsible for getting the work done.

**What is the "feature scope description"? What's the benefit?**

The feature scope description is a mandatory document, as per requirement Only Existing Features Described (UA-030). It lists all the functions and features of an SAP product from a **high-level, purchase-decision perspective** (nothing to do with features in your backlog). It forms the basis of the contract and SAP's legal obligations to the customer and is therefore **legally binding**.

Create the feature scope description as a **self-contained document** on SAP Help Portal. Ensure that it does not have outgoing links. Do not make it a subset of guides or other documentation. For more information, see Feature Scope Description Overview.

> **Note**
>
> Without a feature scope description, all your core user assistance (legally required) automatically counts as a legally binding description of the software. It's clever to separate these things.

The feature scope description **can** also list which core user assistance deliverables are legally binding. That is, the feature scope description is legally binding per se

but the product manager might want to position certain user assistance deliverables (typically guides) as legally binding in terms of "documents x, y, z also define the product scope". On the other hand, this means you have mandatory user assistance deliverables, to which you are bound for eternity.

**What is product sunset? What is out of mainstream maintenance?**

"Product sunset" and "out of mainstream maintenance" are not the same. "Product sunset" refers to the whole product with all its versions whereas "out of mainstream maintenance" is a status that refers to a specific product version. For more information, see the internal SAP Release Strategy and Management and SAP Maintenance Strategy on the public SAP Support Portal.

Let's proceed to "out of mainstream maintenance". Even if a product version is out of mainstream maintenance, there are still customers who use this version and who need access to the documentation. Same goes for the product support colleagues. What you need to ensure is that the product version is classified as *Out of Mainstream Maintenance* on SAP Help Portal. For more information, see the UA Infrastructure User Guide and search for **`out of mainstream maintenance`**.

Now to "product sunset". It's a complex process. The good thing is that you don't need to do anything before the sunset project lead contacts you or your product manager. At the end-of-life phase in the product sunset process, the sunset project team has verified that there are no paying customers for any product version of the product. Now it is time that all traces of the product (including user assistance) disappear from the public. Internally, however, SAP needs to keep (archive) user assistance for 10 years after product sunset. This is a legal requirement. For more information, see the Remove User Assistance task and the Product Sunset process.

**What to do with user assistance if SAP sells off a product to a third party (offboarding)?**

Every offboarding project is different. Many details will be covered in the handover contract. For user assistance a best-practice document is available: Offboarding User Assistance in English and Relevant Languages

## Release Types and Delivery Channels

**Familiarize yourself with the different release types (for example, standard or pilot) and with Sirius.**

In the *Global Release Strategy* community, each release type is explained along the categories of use case, usage right, pricing, contract template (for example, test and evaluation agreement), revenue recognition, availability, country/region coverage, release type, validation, Product Availability Matrix (PAM), Product and Production Management System (PPMS), product standard compliance, and so on. For more information, see Product Release Types and Other Offerings in the *Global Release Strategy* community.

This is really worth reading because the names of the release types appear in Sirius (remember https://url.sap/sirius?). Each delivery has delivery attributes, one of them being the release type.

**Adhere to SAP's official delivery**

The official delivery processes and channels are defined in the **shipment matrix**. This ensures that customers get exactly what they have licensed according to their

**processes and channels.**

contract and that SAP can track who received a complete or a partial delivery. Also, SAP is safeguarded from severe risks such as loss of IP rights, violation of third-party licensing, or non-permissible revenue recognition. For more information, see SAP Delivery Channels and the corporate requirement Controlled Software Production and Approved Shipment Channels.

So much for the general background. But it won't help you decide **when to publish documentation with which access rights on SAP Help Portal**. The decisive aspect is whether access to the software is restricted to specific customers or not:

- Find out the release type in Sirius. And if it's one of the more exotic types (they'll usually say something like "this is not standard"), expect some peculiarities and discuss them with the product manager.
- If it's a **standard release**, publish the documentation with **unrestricted access** on SAP Help Portal at release to customer (RtC – also known as "RtH (release to hosting)"). No need to wait until general availability (GA) because the software is for productive usage and is already on the price list.
  **Exception:** Unrestricted access does of course not apply to sensitive content (for example, a security guide), which you need to guard and therefore restrict to customers and partners. For more information, see the *Information Classification (SAP-Wide Policy)* section.
- For the **other release types** (for example, pilot, incubation, or beta), **restricted access** applies. So ensure that **only** the customers involved have access to the documentation. It does not necessarily have to be on SAP Help Portal but it makes sense if you can already foresee that it's going to become a standard release one day. For more information, see Documentation on SAP Help Portal (UA-070) and (again) Product Release Types and Other Offerings in the *Global Release Strategy* community.
  **A short note on beta:** In addition to restricted beta, there can also be a **public beta** (ask your product manager). That is, the software with the beta features is available for all customers. For example, in the SAP Business Technology Platform cockpit, beta services are labeled as beta and customers can choose to use them non-productively. This is also reflected in the documentation on SAP Help Portal, which is available for all customers and where the beta content is also labeled (for example, the root topic of beta service documentation for SAP Business Technology Platform has "(Beta)" in the topic title). For public beta there's also a disclaimer in the footer of SAP Help Portal, which has a section on beta and other experimental features (see Disclaimer). If you need more specific disclaimers, contact the Legal Network for User Assistance. For more information, see 2019-02-12_InfoForum_Beta_Shipments_UA.pptx.

**Do not give interim or preview versions of the feature scope description and other user assistance to external parties.**

Interim and preview versions may be incomplete or may describe functions that won't be included in the software delivery. This could result in SAP having to provide the missing functions.

There are products that prerelease documentation on SAP Help Portal to customers and partners (but never to the general public) with a disclaimer along the lines of "All product features and delivery dates represent product development expectations only and are not a delivery commitment. These features may not be delivered in the indicated time frame or at all." This means they are consciously taking the risk of having

to provide the features. The Legal Network for User Assistance can help you write such a disclaimer. But let's be clear about this: Whatever disclaimer you use, it won't get you out of the legal obligation. This is why the legal department does not advocate prereleasing documentation, not even with a disclaimer.

**Exception:** Different rules and procedures may apply to pilot releases, custom development project releases, and activities as part of the Customer Engagement Initiative (CEI). In each case, non-disclosure agreements and other contractual agreements with the external party are mandatory.

## Limitations

**As a general rule, do not describe limitations in user assistance.**

This is because SAP does not want to divulge limitations to the public, especially not to competitors.

**Together with the product manager, assess the nature of the limitation and then decide where to describe it.**

The main distinction is between severe, IFRS-relevant issues (customers can't use the software in the communicated scope = stop of delivery) and temporary issues plus workaround (created in the limitations tool and communicated to customers via release restriction notes). For more information, see the IFRS Compliance / Limitations task in Sirius.

If the so-called limitation (or restriction) is different from what's described in the *IFRS Compliance / Limitations* task, then it's not a true limitation and chances are that you can describe it in user assistance. For example, if there's a trial version for an existing cloud product, it is fully ok to use headings such as "Reduced Scope" or "Restriction". But do not use the term "limitation", just to avoid confusion. Another way out of the limitation question is that you provide a positive list instead of a negative list. A good example is a list of supported Web browsers instead of the ones your software does not support.

## Information Classification (SAP-Wide Policy)

**Classify and publish separate, self-contained user assistance deliverables (typically guides) according to SAP's information classification.**

The labels to appear on documents are "Public" or "Internal". The information classification is part of SAP's security policy. For more information, see SAP Global Information Classification and Handling Standard.

Now how does this apply to user assistance deliverables? As a general rule, don't think about whom the user assistance deliverable is meant for, but rather **what** is in it. Think solely about content. Also, consult other stakeholders, such as the product manager.

| SAP Information Classification | When to Use |
|---|---|
| *Public* | This is the classification most commonly applied on SAP Help Portal. There are no reservations about making the content available outside SAP. The content does not need to be protected as it will not harm SAP in any way. |
| *Internal* | *Internal* is pretty obvious. It's **only** for SAP-internal use, such as the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* or the *UA Infrastructure User Guide*. |
| *Internal – Authorized for Customers and Partners* | This classification grants access to **all** SAP employees and **all** SAP customers and partners, but excludes the general public. Therefore, set the access rights on SAP Help Portal accordingly.<br><br>Moderate or some damage could occur to SAP's financial, competitive, or legal position if unauthorized disclosure, compromise, or destruction occurs. You use this classification for documentation that contains sensitive information. |
| *Internal – Authorized for Customers* or *Internal – Authorized for Partners* | See *Internal – Authorized for Customers and Partners*. The only difference is that you – for whatever reasons – may want or need to either exclude SAP partners or exclude SAP customers. |

> **Note**
>
> The SAP information classification *Confidential* is no longer available for usage on SAP Help Portal due to its high potential legal risk.
>
> This classification grants access **only to specific** SAP employees, customers, or partners. The content needs to be protected for legal, regulatory, or contractual reasons.

## Intellectual Property

**Protect SAP's intellectual property.**

The more proprietary information is made available to the public, the easier it is for others to make unauthorized use of it. Before including proprietary information such as code in user assistance, consider carefully whether this information is required by the target group. In case of doubt, contact the representative for your product area in the Legal Network for User Assistance.

**Do not include quotations or other information from third-party sources in user assistance.**

This can have legal implications. Quotations (for example, when the CEO of another company comments on SAP software) have no place in user assistance anyway. They are used in marketing and communications texts. For more information about third-party software, see Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62].

### Related Information

Terminology and SAPterm [page 74]
Country/Region-Specifics (Product Standard for Globalization)
SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183]
Overview: What/Where the Heck Is the User Assistance and Translation Process?

## 2.1 Cross-References and Hyperlinks from a Legal Perspective

There's so much information to cross-refer and link to. What are the legal dos and don'ts for hyperlinks in user assistance? When do you need a link disclaimer and where do you get it?

### Basics

> **Note**
>
> The guidelines cover the following scenario:
>
> - The cross-references and hyperlinks go from core user assistance (legal minimum provided with the software) either to other SAP-owned sites such as SAP Community at https://www.sap.com or to non-SAP sites. For more information, see Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50].
> - The user assistance is written in the official user assistance infrastructure (IXIASOFT CCMS and User Assistance Content Platform), where content-specific link disclaimers are in place.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Cross-refer or link to information only if users need it to get their work done.** | Don't just link to information because it might be useful or somehow interesting. Ask yourself: What would happen if I do not set the link? |
| **Be cautious with third-party software.** | Cross-refer or link to third-party including open-source software **only if** they are **officially required** for SAP software. For more information, see Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62]. |
| **Cross-refer or link to reliable, trustworthy, and stable information.** | **Reliable** means: It's not the personal opinion of John or Jane Doe from St. Elsewhere. It's something official, quality checks have been performed, the content is monitored by the software manufacturer. For example, this could be Google's API documentation, an IBM database forum hosted by IBM, or the Product Availability Matrix (PAM) by SAP.<br><br>**Trustworthy means:** It's not a malicious Web site. The underlying URL needs to start with `https://`. `http://` is not trustworthy. To prevent hackers from creating a link to a malicious Web site that begins with `help.sap.com/?` |

`redirect`, SAP Help Portal must ensure that it only redirects to SAP-approved domains. You may need to get your link target into the allowlist. For more information, see the UA Infrastructure User Guide and search for **`External links - Help Portal Allowlist`**.

**Stable** means: You can safely assume the hyperlink to be technically stable over time. For example, you link to a top domain or use a quick link such as `https://www.example.com/support`, which hides a long URL. Do not fall for deep links with long URLs. If you want to point users to something more specific, consider using a formulation such as "and search for `<search term>`".

## Allowed Cross-References and Link Targets

Familiarize yourself with the basic legal guidelines for cross-references with and without hyperlinks.

| Source of Cross-Reference | Target of Cross-Reference | Legal Perspective on Target |
|---|---|---|
| Core user assistance (in particular separate, self-contained documents)<br><br>This is where the cross-reference formulation appears. It may or may not contain a hyperlink. | SAP content | ✔ Cross-references allowed within core user assistance, for example, from an installation guide to a user guide or to application help<br><br>✔ Cross-references allowed (prerequisite: link disclaimer in place) to all SAP-owned sites such as SAP Community or SAP Notes or to SAP tools such as Quick Sizer<br><br>✘ No cross-references allowed to SAP books, which are actually non-SAP content because they are published by Galileo, or SAP training material |
| | Not SAP | ✔ Cross-references allowed (prerequisite: link disclaimer in place) to standards (for example, published on OASIS), to organizations or authorities such as the German Federal Ministry of Health, or to third-party, open-source, and partner documentation (but see Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62])<br><br>✘ No cross-references allowed elsewhere |

**If you have cross-references between products that require different licenses, make this dependency clear.**

Use the formulation pattern that applies to your language:

| English: Formulation Pattern | German: Formulation Pattern |
|---|---|
| This `<function, feature, ...>` is available only if you've licensed `<product> <version>`. | Diese `<Funktion, Feature, ...>` ist nur verfügbar, wenn Sie auch `<Product> <Version>` lizensiert haben. |

### Link Disclaimer and Link Classification

**External hyperlinks must be accompanied by the official legal disclaimer.**

You don't insert the link disclaimer as text in your topic. It's a background function in the IXIA CCMS. Whenever you create a link with a complete URL, it's processed according to the link classification algorithm. In the final output, external links have specific icons (one for SAP-owned sites and one for third-party sites), and users get to read the link disclaimer text (https://help.sap.com/disclaimer) before they can proceed to the real link target.

For more information, see the UA Infrastructure User Guide and search for **`Linking in the IXIA CCMS`** or **`External Links (Link Classification)`**.

### Related Information

Cross-References and Hyperlinks [page 240]
Legal Network for User Assistance

## 2.2 Copyright, Trademarks, and Other Legal Notices

You have to ensure that software, user assistance, and whatever you provide to customers do **not infringe the rights** of third parties and, in particular, intellectual property rights.

### User Assistance, especially Self-Contained Documents

**Self-contained documents, such as guides, must contain copyright and trademark information and**

All **deliverables that can be accessed independently of the software** (for example, SAP Library, PDF guides, or Eclipse plug-ins) must contain these legal texts. Texts that are integrated in the software (for example, tooltips, messages, or other user interface texts, ABAP system documentation) do not require

the *Important Disclaimers on Legal Aspects*.

these legal texts or links to them. It would actually be really odd if these legal texts were linked from say a tooltip. Also, on the user interface there's always somewhere a link to copyright and trademark information, for example, in the footer of a Web application or in a *Help* or *About* menu.

**Where to find the latest versions of these legal texts**

- **IXIA CCMS:** These legal texts are reusable topics and are automatically included. The topics are centrally updated on a regular basis and are translated into up to 50 target languages. If you need a specific copyright or other legal texts, contact a power user. For more information, see the UA Infrastructure User Guide and search for **`rendering settings for legal content`**.
- **Offline templates:** If you are exceptionally using an offline template, make sure that it contains the latest version of the legal texts. If the template contains outdated versions of the legal texts, ask the template owner to update the template. Alternatively, update the legal texts in your offline document yourself. The copyright and trademark information is available at https://www.sap.com/about/legal/copyright.html. The *Important Disclaimers on Legal Aspects* are available at https://help.sap.com/docs/disclaimer.

**Do not use the trademark symbols (™ or ®), neither in body text nor on title pages.**

In user assistance, the trademarks are covered in the central *Copyright* topic, which is automatically added to documents created in the IXIA CCMS. Even without the trademark symbols, always use correct product and other approved names. Also verify that you are entitled to use or refer to third-party materials.

## Marketing and Communication Materials

**If you create communications materials, texts, or presentations in an offline template, make sure that you are using the SAP corporate template, including the latest legal texts.**

The SAP corporate templates are available on the SAP Brand site under *Templates and Guidelines*.

**Use trademarks as outlined in the Guidelines for Using Trademarks.**

This document explains the correct use of trademarks and provides a list of current SAP trademarks. For more information, see Trademarks and Legal on the SAP Brand site.

## Related Information

Intellectual Property (Copyright, Trademarks, Anti-Piracy)
Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62]
SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183]
Legal Network for User Assistance

## 2.3 Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It

Third-party software covers commercial, free, and open-source software. Sometimes you can't avoid referring to it. But when and how can you do so?

### Basics

**As a general rule, do not provide information about third-party software in user assistance.**

If you make inappropriate references to third-party software (including user assistance), SAP can be held liable. Just by mentioning a third-party product, you can create the impression that this product is part of the SAP software or that SAP recommends this product. Recommending third-party software is not allowed in the interest of fair competition.

In particular:

- Do not describe problems relating to third-party software.
- Do not give instructions for modifying third-party software.
- Do not describe functions or settings in third-party software.

**Exception:** On the user interface, different conventions may apply. This is typically the case in import/export dialogs where the user can select the file format, such as “Microsoft Excel (*.xlsx)” or “Comma-Separated Values (*.csv)”. You and your developers are on the safe side with using the official SAP Fiori (SAPUI5) controls. They come with predefined text for the file format options. The controls undergo a review process where sometimes even the legal department gets consulted about the wording.

**Check whether it is sufficient to use a generic term that describes the type of software.**

Example

| ✔ English: Generic Term | ✔ German: Generic Term | ✘ Specific Third-Party Software |
|---|---|---|
| a word processing program | Textverarbeitungsprogramm | Microsoft Word |
| a spreadsheet application | Tabellenkalkulationsprogramm | Microsoft Excel |
| a slide presentation program | Präsentationsprogramm | Microsoft Powerpoint |
| a PDF editing program | PDF-Editierprogramm | Adobe Acrobat |

| ✔ English: Generic Term | ✔ German: Generic Term | ✘ Specific Third-Party Software |
|---|---|---|
| accessibility software, [more specific:] screen reader | Software für Barrierefreiheit, [more specific:] Bildschirmausleseprogramm | JAWS |

## Exception: Referring to Specific Third-Party Software

**Refer to specific third-party software only if it is officially affiliated with SAP software and if there's a good reason.**

Let's have a closer look:

- Apply the third-party company's naming and usage guidelines. In particular, write product names exactly as the company does.
- "Officially affiliated" means that there's a license and distribution agreement for the third-party software. Alternatively, the third-party company is in a strategic partnership with SAP and there are agreements for certain software offerings. For example, there's a strategic partnership with major cloud providers, such as Amazon (for Amazon Web Services Cloud), Google (for Google Cloud Platform), or Microsoft (for Microsoft Azure).
- "Good reason" means, for example, that you need to mention the third-party product as a prerequisite or as an integration option. It could also be that you need to describe settings or activities that ensure SAP software runs as intended. There's no need to mention third-party software that's embedded in SAP software.
- As for "describe settings or activities that ensure SAP software runs as intended", make a distinction between what needs to be done on the SAP side and on the third-party side. This is exactly where the information needs to go.
  That is, the recommended approach for describing settings or activities in the third-party product is that these are provided in the user assistance (typically documentation) of the third-party company. For example, have a look at SAP on AWS Technical Documentation or SAP on Google Cloud Platform Documentation.
  If this is not possible (for example, you can't find your user assistance counterpart at the third-party company), you can describe the third-party settings or activities in your user assistance. Just ensure:
  - This is mentioned in the risk assessment of the SAP product (contact the product owner). The risk is that SAP can be held liable for providing such information. For more information, see the Risk Assessment task in the Sirius tool.
  - On SAP Help Portal, the relevant documentation can be accessed only by partners and customers, but not by the general public. Also, the documentation needs the information classification *Internal – Authorized for Customers and Partners*.

For more information, see the corporate requirement Licensing of Open-Source and Third-party Software and the Product Standard for Licensing. If you have questions, contact Global Licensing.

## Open-Source Specifics

| | |
|---|---|
| **In any case, do not list the open-source software for your product in documentation or other user assistance.** | **Background:** SAP is legally obliged to publish *Open-Source Legal Notices (OSLN)* for free and open-source software that is provided in or with SAP software to customers and partners. SAP treats this information as confidential and publishes these legal notices only in the SAP Software Download Center (SWDC). That is, open-source legal notices are intended only for customers who have licensed the associated SAP software. For more information, see PPMS and Open-Source Legal Notices (OSLN). |
| **If you can't avoid referring to open-source software or you need to describe settings or activities, check that the open-source product appears in the Open Source Legal Notice (OSLN) for your product version.** | Ask your product owner. If you have questions, contact Global Licensing. And remember that the guidelines for referring to third-party software also apply to open-source software.<br><br>It is ok to refer to open source projects as long as they're managed by SAP. Once a project is transferred to a foundation or other third-party, you'll have to rework the relevant user assistance. This can be unwieldy. So it's better to handle such software and its user assistance from the start as if it were not managed by SAP. |

## Related Information

Copyright, Trademarks, and Other Legal Notices [page 60]
Legal Network for User Assistance

# 3 Communicating with Your Audience: Who Are Your Target Groups?

You need to understand who you are creating user assistance for. Decision makers, consultants/implementers, administrators, developers, and users – they all have their own unique needs, abilities, and challenges. This can influence everything from style, tone, and word choice to output formats that you choose for presenting the information.

## Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| **Familiarize yourself with the SAP-wide, generic target groups (personas).** | Whatever personas, roles, or user types have been described for the software (the worst case being that there's no such information), take a look at the SAP-wide, generic target groups. They will help you understand the basic differences of what is often referred to as “the customer” or “the user”. |
| **Determine the overall audience and use cases for the software.** | Specifications often include this kind of information. There may even be detailed descriptions of specific personas or roles (at the level of accountant, sales clerk, traveler) or a series of use cases or user stories. These provide a sense of what the audience will be trying to achieve with the software. Make use of existing resources as much as possible because that's your starting point for everything else. In lieu of descriptions, set up a meeting with your product team or other subject matter experts to find out about the audience. |

## Generic Target Groups

Different audiences have different information needs. Here's a list of the SAP-wide, generic target groups and some things you might want to consider for each one.

| Target Group | Considerations |
| --- | --- |
| **Decision maker**<br><br>**Tasks:** Assess the software to make sure that it will meet the company's needs. Needs the facts – not just marketing spin – before signing on the dotted line.<br><br>**Goal**: Purchase the right solution for the company, and ensure stakeholders back this decision. | Decision makers need information about functions and features, integration, or implementation. Make sure you provide comprehensive overviews and clear use cases. Think task-based organization and workflows.<br><br>User forums and communities can also be useful for this target group. Decision makers appreciate opportunities to interact with their fellow customers, to get a practical sense of how the software works.<br><br>Use people-centric language, but nothing too informal. |
| **IT consultant / implementer**<br><br>**Task:** Makes a coherent and secure landscape out of multiple SAP software offerings. Thrives on tackling the big issues: integration, security, configuration, business processes.<br><br>**Goal**: Implement SAP solutions that fully support customer requirements. | Consultants and implementers want clear and comprehensive information. Make sure you provide big-picture workflows, architecture details, and potential integration issues. Consultants need to know everything, from the big picture down to the configuration issues. Once up to speed, consultants tend to prefer expert-level information.<br><br>Don't use overly conversational language with consultants. They don't need a new best friend. They need the information required to get the job done right.<br><br>Consultants are unlikely to use videos. They already know a lot and want to fill in the blanks in their knowledge. So they'll want something comprehensive and searchable. |
| **IT administrator**<br><br>**Task:** Oversees a skilled IT team maintaining a hybrid SAP on-premise/cloud solution. Deals with installation, upgrades, system troubleshooting.<br><br>**Goal**: Support the ongoing operations and evolution of the SAP implementation. | IT administrators need detailed information that is easy to locate. They need comprehensive information at first, but once they've got the hang of it, they prefer quick checklists instead of guides and videos for daily maintenance work.<br><br>IT administrators are keen on knowledge-sharing and collaborative content development (for example, documenting a workaround for fellow IT admins and posting it on a forum). |
| **Super user**<br><br>**Task:** Bridges the IT/Business divide as the users' go-to person. Helps plan system evolution. Adapts software configuration and user interfaces to fit business processes. Troubleshoots and educates about usage.<br><br>**Goal**: Evolve software to add business value. Ensure that colleagues can work efficiently. | Super users need practical task-based information to help them configure and customize solutions that will work for their end users. They need clear use cases and workflows, and they need to know how to customize SAP solutions to fit the needs of their company's users.<br><br>Super users often serve as intermediaries between business users and technical experts, so they tend to be comfortable with both business and technical terminology. |

| Target Group | Considerations |
| --- | --- |
| **Professional user**<br><br>**Task:** Depends on software to get the work done. Interested in features and best practices.<br><br>**Goal**: Work efficiently. | Professional users need to be aware of new functionality and best practices that can help improve daily productivity.<br><br>When professional users need help, they need it quickly, so they want an intuitive user interface with embedded help. They also tend to appreciate forums for discussion with SAP experts and fellow users. So watch out what's happening there.<br><br>Professional users need information to be easy to search and navigate. They appreciate a personable tone. |
| **Casual user**<br><br>**Task:** Uses software or performs a particular task only occasionally. May not feel comfortable with the software or the task.<br><br>**Goal**: Work efficiently. Be guided by an intuitive user interface. Enjoy the software or at least feel comfortable with it. | Do you even need documentation? Casual users want information at their fingertips.<br><br>Focus on making the user interface intuitive. Go for embedded help. Consider using videos.<br><br>Don't be afraid to lighten up and be a little more conversational. |
| **Developer**<br><br>**Task:** Interested in technical topics. Solid knowledge of programming languages. Experienced in programming and development projects. Expert in the technical or business area. Uses and contributes to community content.<br><br>**Goal**: Develop and enhance software. | Developers are hands-on learners, so they want quick access to the precise information they need in the moment. This means user assistance that is easy to find, easy to navigate. In other words: Embedded help!<br><br>Developers also tend to use interactive forms of learning such as discussion forums and social media. So watch what's happening there.<br><br>Provide plenty of useful code samples and use cases, because developers learn by doing. |

## Related Information

From Information Needs to User Assistance Deliverables [page 68]
People-Centric Language and Communication [page 83]

# 3.1 From Information Needs to User Assistance Deliverables

The target groups of your software have different information needs. How can you cover these needs? There is no SAP-wide set of predefined user assistance deliverables. But what all deliverables have in common is that they are derived from a set of information needs. Let's take a look.

## Basics

**To get from information needs to tangible deliverables, make covering "install/deploy, configure, and use the software" your overall information goal.**

This fuzzy goal gets more tangible if you think in terms of information needs, such as terminology, user interface texts, application help, getting started, what's new, or installation and technical implementation/integration. Now combine these information needs with the SAP-wide generic target groups (end users, administrators, consultants/implementers, developers), and you will be able to derive your user assistance deliverables, especially the legally required ones. For more information, see Communicating with Your Audience: Who Are Your Target Groups? [page 65] and Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50].

In other words: Your final deliverables depend on the information needs, the target groups, and the type of software, including the user interface technology. You will also have to decide on suitable output formats such as text or video and on channels such as on the user interface or in a separate help center. All this can be a very iterative process with many stakeholders (product team, tool groups, customers, and so on) and lots of testing, reviewing, and also legal considerations. If you're new, ask your user assistance manager or architect for support.

**Embed as much information as possible on the user interface.**

Go for embedded help. Do not hide information in guides. For more information, see Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111].

Think of user assistance as a kind of continuum. It goes like this: Improve the user interface and all permanent text. That's it? Good. If not, try embedded help. That's it? Good. If not, try self-contained documents.




**UI texts**
Field labels, messages, button text, dropdown lists, and other permanent text

**Embedded help**
Field help, guided tour, getting-started video, and so on

**Documentation**
Security / administration / user guide and other self-contained documents

**To plan your deliverables or get an overview, start with the planning**

The planning aid is part of the Product Standard for User Assistance, that is, requirement User Assistance (Including Translation) Provided with the Software (UA-010). It helps you and the product owner mirror information needs and target groups against your deliverables. Are there gaps? Superfluous or outdated

aid (https://url.sap/uatask-planningaid).

information? Note that no information need or target group is mandatory. Either they apply or they don't. You know best. You can use the planning aid for all types of software (on premise, cloud, mobile, multidevice, and so on). It's especially helpful if it's a new type of software or an acquired company.

## Information Needs, Most Likely Target Groups, and Some Deliverable Examples

The planning aid is very concise. Here's a bit more about the information needs and the target groups:

| Information Need | Most Likely Target Groups | Examples |
|---|---|---|
| **Terminology and definitions**<br><br>Consistent terminology is key for user experience and translation into up to 50 target languages. Agree on central terms, at least. Create definitions in SAPterm if you can't assume the target group to know the meaning of terms. Make these definitions available to the target group, as appropriate for the type of software and user interface design.<br><br>More information: Terminology and SAPterm [page 74], Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111], and Standards and Guidelines Overview | **Everybody** because terminology is the mandatory basis for efficient communication.<br><br>Also relevant for internal target groups, such as user assistance developers and translators. | Your very own software! Implement consistent terminology on the user interface and elsewhere, based on your SAPterm entries. |
| **User interface texts (and embedded help)**<br><br>All types of texts that appear directly on the user interface. These texts directly shape the user experience. They range from simple labels and titles to – this is called "embedded help" – explanatory text such as mouseovers or permanent on-screen explanations. Embedded help doesn't have to be text. It could also be a video or a wizard. User interface texts are sometimes also referred to as "primary help".<br><br>More information: Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111], Common User Interface Elements [page 119], and Standards and Guidelines Overview | End users (super user, professional user, casual user), the ones who get their work done with the software.<br><br>Don't forget: Developers, IT administrators, or IT consultants/implementers can also be in end-user roles if there is specific software for them. | Menu item texts, dialog box titles, application titles, field labels, radio buttons, check boxes, push buttons, and – if required – their explanations (for example, as mouseovers)<br><br>Messages (errors, warnings, information) and – if required – their explanations (for example, diagnosis, solution)<br><br>Screen-area explanations (for example, explanatory text below the steps in guided activities) |

| Information Need | Most Likely Target Groups | Examples |
|---|---|---|
| **Application help**<br><br>Whatever answers "What does the software do for me?" and "How can I use it?" Application help can take many forms.<br><br>For complex software, application help often consists of context-sensitive links to topics and their subtopics in a separate help structure, but it could also be a separate user guide. With less complex software or apps, application help and embedded help somehow merge. Application help doesn't have to be text. It could also be a video.<br><br>More information: Standards and Guidelines Overview | End users (super user, professional user, casual user), the ones who get their work done with the software.<br><br>Don't forget: Developers, IT administrators, or IT consultants/implementers can also be in end-user roles if there is specific software for them. | User guide, context-sensitive help structure with topics, SAP Library (for traditional SAP software), FAQ, quick guide, secondary help |
| **Getting started**<br><br>Whatever helps familiarize the different target groups with basic features, functions, settings, or navigation patterns. Make it crisp and short. Wherever and however you provide this information, preferably use the title "Getting Started". It doesn't have to be text. It could also be a video.<br><br>More information: Tbd | End users (super user, professional user, casual user), the ones who get their work done with the software.<br><br>Don't forget: Developers, IT administrators, or IT consultants/implementers can also be in end-user roles if there is specific software for them. | *Getting Started* as embedded help on the user interface, *Getting Started* chapter in a guide |
| **Accessibility**<br><br>Whatever helps users with disabilities use the software and whatever helps administrators set up the software accordingly. Typical topics are features and settings in SAP software that support users with disabilities, keyboard shortcuts, and recommendations on accessibility alternatives (for example, subtitles in videos).<br><br>More information: Accessibility [page 103], Product Standard for Accessibility, Standards and Guidelines for Accessibility Documentation, and Standards and Guidelines Overview | End users (professional user, casual user), who rely on accessibility features, tools, and settings to get their work done with the software.<br><br>IT administrators (and maybe super users), who are responsible for providing accessibility functions and features centrally. | Depends very much on the software type and user interface technology used. Discuss with a user assistance architect or an accessibility expert. |
| **Feature scope description**<br><br>Whatever describes the mere functions and features of a particular release from a "What did I buy? What is licensed?" perspective.<br><br>More information: Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50] (section on *User Assistance at SAP*) | Decision makers<br><br>Don't forget: Developers, IT administrators, or IT consultants/implementers can also be in decision-making roles. | Feature scope description, product description, functions and features, solution description guide, About (in an app), product specification (for external use) |

| Information Need | Most Likely Target Groups | Examples |
|---|---|---|
| **What's new**<br><br>Short description of new features or changes since the previous release. It may make sense to provide such information as a separate deliverable for each target group. It doesn't have to be text. It could also be a video.<br><br>Social media: Do not communicate what's new information on social media before the software has been officially released to the public. If you do, this could result in SAP having to provide the missing functions and in deferral of payment of related SAP software license revenues.<br><br>More information: Standards and Guidelines Overview | End users (super user, professional user, casual user), the ones who get their work done with the software.<br><br>Don't forget: Developers, IT administrators, or IT consultants/implementers can also be in end-user roles if there is specific software for them.<br><br>Decision Makers (functional delta) | Release notes (for traditional SAP software), delta information |
| **Installation and technical implementation/integration**<br><br>Technical implementation information is typically about the installation process and tools. It can be as simple as an *Install* button for an app. It can be as complex as a master guide plus multiple installation guides.<br><br>In an **installation guide**, typical topics include the installation process (planning, preparation, installation, post-installation), combinations of operating systems and databases, system landscape, hardware and software requirements for the installation hosts, installation tools, starting and stopping, troubleshooting, or log files. In a **master guide**, typical topics are software component matrix (installable units required/optional for scenario x), a minimal/typical system landscape, an overall or scenario-specific implementation sequence (planning, preparation, execution, and follow-up) with cross-references to the separate installation descriptions of the installable units (for example, separate installation guides), or cross-component configuration.<br><br>If the software or installable unit has an installation tool (for example, an installer or a wizard), provide the installation information in this environment. If there is more to say or if there is no installation tool, provide the installation information in an installation guide or as part of another document and focus on what is not automated by the tool (for example, manual steps).<br><br>More information: Product Standard for Software Lifecycle and Standards and Guidelines Overview | IT consultants/implementers, IT administrators | **Simple:** *Install* button of an app, installation note for add-ons<br><br>**Typical:** installation guide, installation chapter in an administration guide<br><br>**Complex:** master guide with links to the related installation guides<br><br>Templates for on-premise software: T066 and T065 |

| Information Need | Most Likely Target Groups | Examples |
|---|---|---|
| **Upgrade**<br><br>Whatever helps the different target groups upgrade the software. It's very similar to installation information.<br><br>More information: Product Standard for Software Lifecycle and Standards and Guidelines Overview | IT consultants/implementers, IT administrators | Very similar to installation information. Just replace "installation" with "upgrade".<br><br>Templates for on-premise software: T090 and T067 |
| **Configuration**<br><br>Whatever helps the different target groups adapt the software to the business needs. It may make sense to provide such information as a separate deliverable for each target group. Typical business needs are, for example, the definition of currencies, accounting schemes, cost centers, prices, master data, shop centers. However, this depends very much on the type of software.<br><br>If the software has a configuration tool, provide the configuration information in this environment. If there's more to say or there is no configuration tool, provide configuration information in a configuration guide or as part of another document and focus on what is not automated by the tool (for example, manual steps).<br><br>Upgrade: Consider whether you need to provide information from an upgrade perspective. If so, you might need to distinguish between configuration information for new functions and for changed or enhanced functions. For example, configuration activities in ABAP systems can be classified as new or changed in the IMG tool.<br><br>More information: Standards and Guidelines Overview | IT administrators, IT consultants/implementers<br><br>Don't forget: Super users may also be involved in configuration activities. | Configuration guide, IMG (for traditional SAP software), Customizing, Scoping and Finetuning (wizard) |
| **Operations**<br><br>Whatever helps administrators operate the scenarios and components of the software. Typical topics are technical system landscape, technical runtime scenarios, high availability, starting and stopping, user management, backup and recovery, periodic tasks, load balancing, monitoring, logging and tracing, data consistency, software maintenance, quality and test management, or troubleshooting.<br><br>More information: Product Standard for Operations and Support with requirement Operations Information (O&S 1-1) and Standards and Guidelines Overview | IT administrators | Operations guide, chapter in administrator guide |

| Information Need | Most Likely Target Groups | Examples |
| --- | --- | --- |
| **Security**<br><br>Whatever helps the different target groups securely set up, configure, run, and use the software. It may make sense to provide such information as a separate deliverable for each target group. Typical topics are delivered default users, authorization concept, delivered/required roles, critical authorization combinations, secure network setup, data protection/privacy, or (for software containing development environments or SDKs) a secure programming guide.<br><br>Vulnerability information: Provide this type of information only in SAP Notes. This is not public information. You can refer to the SAP Notes in the security documentation.<br><br>More information: Product Standard for Security with requirement Security Information (SEC-247) and Standards and Guidelines Overview | Developers, IT administrators, IT consultants/implementers<br><br>Don't forget: End users (super user, professional user) may also be interested in security information snippets (for example, is a secure protocol used?). | Security guide, chapter in a user/administration/configuration guide, section in an FAQ |
| **Troubleshooting**<br><br>Whatever helps the different target groups solve typical problems or user errors. It may make sense to provide such information as a separate deliverable for each target group. Consider whether it makes sense to embed or link to the information on the user interface.<br><br>**Note**<br><br>An extensive amount of troubleshooting information (for example, a guide) should make you wary. Why is there so much troubleshooting needed at all? Can the software or error messages be improved?<br><br>Even though troubleshooting is primarily the task of product support, why not team up with a colleague in product support? Find out what information from the product support materials you can incorporate into user assistance or bring to the attention of the product owner. | End users (super user, professional user, casual user), developers, IT administrators, IT consultants/implementers | Troubleshooting topics in a guide, section in an FAQ<br><br>If the user interface technology technically only allows message short texts: error message table in an appendix or even an error message guide that lists the message identifiers and suggests workarounds for each error |
| **Extensibility (for example, APIs)**<br><br>Whatever external developers need to develop enhancements to the standard software. Prerequisite: Programming interfaces are released for external use.<br><br>More information: Standards and Guidelines Overview and User Assistance Services | Developers | JavaDocs, extensibility guide, BAdI documentation, SOA service documentation |

| Information Need | Most Likely Target Groups | Examples |
| --- | --- | --- |
| **Content information (shipped with development environments)**<br>Information about software objects, sample data, templates, and so on that are developed with tools, frameworks, or developer studios and that are shipped and maintained by SAP.<br>More information: Standards and Guidelines Overview | Developers, IT consultants/implementers | Analytics content documentation, portal content documentation, pharmaceutical regulations, scenario/process information in SAP Solution Manager (business scenarios, business processes, implementable steps, or similar) |

## Related Information

Multimedia and Graphics: Overview [page 259]

# 3.2 Terminology and SAPterm

Terminology is key for user acceptance and customer satisfaction. By defining, using, and promoting consistent terminology, you are laying the foundation for effective communication. Here's a summary of terminology principles, including where to find SAPterm, the SAP terminology database.

> ⓘ Note
>
> There is SAP-wide terminology that you must adhere to. Here are the relevant components in SAPterm:
>
> - *SAP Corporation* (`SAP*`) containing components such as *Inclusive Language* (`SAP-INCLUSIVE`), *Controlled Vocabulary* (`SAP-UA-CV`), or *User Experience Consistency* (`SAP-UXC`)
> - *Brand Voice* (`BV-BRAND-VOICE`) containing the product and other approved names, which are replicated from the *Approved Names* repository on the *SAP Brand* site
>
> The Product Standard for User Assistance has a corresponding requirement: Product Terminology (UA-050)

## Basics

| | |
| --- | --- |
| **Speak the language of your target group.** | Research terminology with subject matter experts. Review with all stakeholders. Do not invent your own terms. Do not use SAP or other jargon. |

**Define terminology in U.S. English and German.**

This is very important for language consistency on the user interface and in all other types of user assistance. English and German are the source languages at SAP. They are also the target languages for in-house translation.

**Define terminology early on, preferably in the specification and design phase. Tell your product team.**

Make sure that everybody (including developers, user experience designers, product owners) uses consistent terminology. For example, hand out terminology lists, or show your product team how to look up terminology in SAPterm.

Why is this important? Terminology is a key factor for the user experience. Communication depends on terminology. One word, one meaning. Everything else means confusion. Adapting and cleaning up inconsistent terminology on the user interface and in all other types of user assistance is a lengthy and expensive process.

**Translation:** Consistent terminology is a key factor in minimizing internal and external translation costs. SAP software is translated into up to 50 target languages

**Be aware that terminology work is an ongoing process.**

Terminology is dynamic and evolves over time. Start with central terms and their definitions. Expect more terminology work to come up in the course of the development cycle.

**Research the implications of a major terminology change. Involve your translators as early as possible.**

Also involve Language Experience Lab (LX Lab) for the target languages. Changing central terms usually requires a terminology change project. Terms have to be agreed on, they have to be entered in SAPterm, on the user interface, and in all other types of user assistance – in all source and target languages. For more information, see Term Changes: Making a Decision. In addition, you will need to plan the rollout of the terminology changes to internal stakeholders, such as training, and possibly also to customers.

## Tools: SAPterm

**Enter terminology and definitions in SAPterm.**

SAPterm is the SAP terminology database and covers the source languages U.S. English and German and about 50 target languages. It contains terms, definitions, rejected terms (including spellings), context (a chunk of text that contains the term), and source information. For more information, see Terminology Standards for SAPterm.

Here's an example of a good definition:

> ### Example
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **English: cost center** An organizational unit within a controlling area that represents a defined location of cost incurrence. [Note: Use a nominal phrase. Begin with a definite or indefinite article.]
>
> End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German: Kostenstelle** Organisatorische Einheit innerhalb eines Kostenrechnungskreises, die einen eindeutig abgegrenzten Ort der Kostenentstehung darstellt. [Note: Use a nominal phrase. No article.]

End of 'Localization': German

**How to access SAPterm?**

To create and change terminology, use the SAP GUI on your desktop and connect to the STM system. There's also read-only Web access, for example, https://www.sapterm.com (public). For more information, see SAPterm Access.

When you need to change terminology or formulations on the user interface, use the SAP Language Search tool. For more information and direct access, see the SAP Language Search Tool community.

**Translation: Also check the product-specific translation glossary or the translated user interface, whichever has been provided to you by Language Experience Lab (LX Lab).**

In some software offerings, the translations of frequently used words on the user interface may deviate from the standard terminology in SAPterm. For example, in SAP BusinessObjects English "save" translates into German "speichern" instead of the standard translation "sichern". In most cases, this variant translation is already available as a variant in SAPterm with the relevant attributes (for example, component at term level or country/region). If not, enter it.

## Consistent Terminology

**Use terms consistently. No synonyms!**

Do **not** use the same term with different meanings. Do **not** use different terms for the same meaning. This adds consistency to our user assistance. Users like consistency. This is also a critical step toward machine translation quality.

But don't forget the context: You may need to use different terms for different target groups or in different contexts. For example, with regard to a user interface framework (technical context), the term "control" is used to refer to the individual technical elements whereas from a user perspective these controls are perceived and labeled as "tabs", "menus", and so on.

Example

| Context or Target Group | ✔ Appropriate Term | ✘ Inappropriate Synonym |
|---|---|---|
| Utilities industry | point of delivery | metering code, metering point, meter point administration number |

| Context or Target Group | ✔ Appropriate Term | ✘ Inappropriate Synonym |
|---|---|---|
| Reinsurance | treaty | contract |
| User perspective | screen<br>checkbox | dynpro<br>flag |
| Technical perspective | dynpro [Context: refers to the technical system object in the ABAP workbench tools]<br>flag, field, parameter, ... | screen<br>checkbox |

**Apply the controlled vocabulary for SAP-wide, product-neutral terms.**

The controlled vocabulary won't limit how you express yourself. It just means that, for example, if you're writing about how to create something, you prefer the verb “create” instead of its many synonyms, like “make”, “build”, “define”, or “generate”. Again, it's all about consistency.

The controlled vocabulary currently covers **preferred verbs to be used in the task topic titles**. For more information including the list of verbs, see Controlled Vocabulary in the *Ask the Editors* community. The controlled vocabulary is also available in the `SAP-UA-CV` component in SAPterm.

These verbs for task topic titles are based on the terms for common actions on the user interface that are defined in the Product Standard for User Experience Consistency. For more information, see Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111].

Also, use the terminology defined by the SAP-wide *Inclusive Language* working group. For more information, see Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98].

**When referring to SAP software offerings (products, services, or other), use approved names only.**

If your product team needs to submit naming requests, be aware that these requests generally take 3-5 weeks to process effectively. For more information, see SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183]. The approved names are also replicated to the `BV-BRAND-VOICE` component in SAPterm.

**Translation:** For approved names, use the brand translation guidelines. These guidelines contain language-specific translation instructions and examples of the most common naming patterns at SAP. For more information, see Brand Translation Guidelines.

## The Term “Country” and Its Geopolitical Dimension

**Do not use the term “country”. Instead, use “country/region” or**

This is because of geopolitics. By doing this, you protect SAP from legal or other consequences, such as product bans or the shutdown of Web sites. For

**“country or region”, or rephrase completely.**

more information, see Country/Region-Specific Guidance in the Product Standard for Globalization and the related requirement Country and Region Handling (GLOB-192).

> **Note**
>
> In such cases of political or other sensitivities, it is not the user assistance developer or the translator who makes rewording and clean-up decisions. There needs to be guidance from high-level decision makers, such as the legal department or marketing. Please keep discussions internal and confidential.

Enter the relevant terms in SAPterm. Write a usage comment that explains your product-specific way of dealing with existing and future occurrences of the term “country” and its compounds.

> **Example**
>
> ✔ Country/Region [Note: This is a field label, therefore title case.]
>
> ✔ Country/Region Code [Note: This is a field label example with a compound.]
>
> ✔ Local Version [Note: This is a field label. This example shows that “country” can also be replaced with something else.]
>
> ✔ Country/Region | Region | City [or:] Country/Region | Subdivision | City [Note: These are column titles. “Country/Region” used to be “Country”. The question now is what to do with “region”: Keep, change to “subdivision”, or to something else? The term “subdivision” is used in the ISO standard *Codes for the Representation of Names of Countries and Their Subdivisions* (ISO 3166). Your decision depends on the context. Align with the Product Standard for Globalization.]
>
> ✘ Country Version
>
> ✔ Specify your country/region. [or:] Select a country/region and language. [or:] Select the relevant countries/regions. [Note: These examples appear in message texts and refer to the *Country/Region* field.]
>
> ✔ ... in compliance with all applicable laws, including local laws of the country or region in which you reside ...

## Country/Region-Specific Terminology (Including Foreign-Language Terms)

**Enter country/region-specific terms in SAPterm and classify them as such.**

For more information, see Terminology Standards for SAPterm. But first you need to do some terminology research.

**Find out whether there's an established English term or equivalent phrase for the country/region-specific phenomenon (concept). If not, use the foreign-language term**

Country/region-specific terminology is a tricky area. This starts with deciding whether to use a foreign-language term in English (source language) or not. Here are some ideas for your **terminology research**:

- Talk to terminology and localization experts. Keep these decisive questions in mind:
  - Is the phenomenon (concept) only known in a specific country or region? If so, languages not spoken there are not likely to have a term for it.
  - Do people tend to use the foreign-language term in English because they feel anything else is not adequate?
  - Do people tend to say "Oh, `<foreign-language term>` is a special kind of `<English term>` in `<country or region>`." and then explain the specifics?
- Try the term database of the European Union.
- Swap the language on multilingual Web sites.
- Check glossaries on government or other official Web sites (search for **`glossary`**, **`terminology`**, **`dictionary`**, and so on)
  For example, the Turkish Ministry of Foreign Affairs offers extensive terminology lists in Turkish, English, French, and Arabic: Terminology for Foreign Affairs

Example

| Country/ Region | Country/ Region-Specific Term/ Concept | ✔ Term Used in English Texts | Comment |
|---|---|---|---|
| Chile | impuesto de timbres y estampillas | stamp tax | There's an equivalent English term. In other words, it's a translation. It can be translated because "stamp tax" is a concept also known in English-speaking countries and regions. |
| Turkey | Çevre Komi-syonu | Committee on Environ-ment | "Committee on Environment" appears (written in title case) in the terminology lists provided by the Turkish Ministry of Foreign Affairs. |
| Japan | 礼金 (trans-literation: re-ikin) | reikin | The concept of "reikin" (literally "grati-tude money") is specific to Japan. It's a mandatory, non-refundable fee that a tenant pays to the landlord. |
| India and Pakistan | चालान (trans-literation: cālān) | challan | "Challan" is a term generally used in India and Pakistan as a receipt for payment or delivery. Borrowed from Hindi. |

| Country/ Region | Country/ Region-Specific Term/ Concept | ✔ Term Used in English Texts | Comment |
|---|---|---|---|
| United States | social security | social security | There are also country/region-specific terms in English. |
| United Kingdom | national insurance | national insurance | |

**Capitalize the foreign-language term according to the usage of the country or region.**

Here are a few other guidelines:

- Do **not** set off the foreign-language term from body text with formatting (italics or tags).
  **Translation:** This is to ensure that translators won't have to remove formatting in their target language, where the term is obviously not a foreign-language term. This also saves them from getting warnings about missing formatting. Same goes for machine translation.
- Briefly explain the foreign-language term, as appropriate for text flow and preceding text. If it's a foreign institution, use its official English name (as given by the institution) in the explanation. If there's no official English name, look for an established translation and write it in title case. Otherwise explain what the institution does in your own words.
- If there's an acronym and it's more common than the full form, use the acronym. But don't forget to give the full form in the language of the country or region.

### Example

✔ Shukko is a type of personnel exchange in Japan in which employees are lent or borrowed between group and related companies.

✔ Every person and corporation is assigned a tax number by the DIAN (Dirección de Impuestos y Aduanas Nacionales, the National Directorate of Taxes and Customs in Colombia). This number is known as the NIT (Número de Identificación Tributaria). [Note: The abbreviation“NIT” is more common than the full form. The full form is written in title case (see this FAQ page of the DIAN: Aspectos Generales Registro Único Tributario).]

✔ Each hospital is identified by a FINESS number, which locates it in a department or region. FINESS is the Fichier National des Etablissements Sanitaires et Sociaux (National Directory of Health and Social Establishments in France). [Note: “FINESS” is more common. The full form is written in title case (see FINESS Web site and the glossary on ASIP Santé).]

### Related Information

Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98]
Geographic Names [page 221]
Corporate Language (U.S. English) and Source Languages (English, German) [page 267]
English: U.S. English, Global English, and Some Grammar [page 269]
German: Deutsche Rechtschreibung und Wortwahl [page 286]

## 3.3 Tone of Voice and Writing Style (SAP Brand)

The SAP brand guidelines help make SAP software memorable. They are the foundation for tone of voice and writing style in user assistance.

> ⓘ Note
>
> For a detailed version of this, see How We Write and Writing Style Overview on the *SAP Brand* site at https://brand.sap.com.

### Basics

**Speak and write in a positive and encouraging voice.**

Here are some more adjectives: relaxed, conversational, friendly, trusted, familiar, helpful, natural-sounding. Imagine a respected coach who has already experienced what the audience is about to go through, and is showing how it's done while giving tips and all the benefits of experience.

**Make it sound like a conversation, human to human.**

To drive this conversational style, follow these principles:

- **Be brief. Be bright. Be gone:** Shorter text is at the heart of all communication, with the ultimate goal of simplification. Explain a complex situation in the clearest way possible. Details and nuance still matter, but in a way that makes practical sense.
- **Incorporate contractions:** With contractions you can achieve natural, human tonality.
- **Do not use clichés:** Text can be clear, informal, and catchy without using colloquialisms or platitudes. Make it sound human while also sounding professional – and keep our text easy to localize.
- **Watch out for word salad:** There are buzz phrases or collections of words that are "correct" but say nothing specific or useful. Once certain phrases become trendy, they often lose meaning and context. Turn these phrases into text that specifically addresses the topic.

**Remember the CIAO principle: clear, insightful, approachable, and optimistic**

The CIAO principle is still valid even though it's no longer featured on the *SAP brand* site. Here's what it means:

- **Clear:** Speak in a concise and comprehensible language that is understandable to all audiences.
- **Insightful:** Be an insightful problem solver, sharing knowledge enthusiastically and focusing on the benefits SAP can provide to customers.
- **Approachable:** Speak authentically as humans to humans so that customers can get to know SAP and have an amazing experience with the SAP brand.
- **Optimistic:** Speak with confidence about the real-world impact, inspiring customers with a positive attitude.

## Writing Style

**Keep your communication clear, precise, and easy to read.**

Communication is all about making connections with your audience, regardless of language, location, or channel.

How to ensure this:

- Use simple, comprehensible wording and sentences. No SAP-internal jargon.
- Eliminate or reduce acronyms and abbreviations.
- Do not use capitalization for emphasis or importance.
- Avoid awkward, overly long sentences, or tortuous constructions.
- Use active voice instead of passive voice.
- Use parallel constructions where appropriate.
- Use offering names exactly as given in the *Approved Names* repository.

### Example

✔ To achieve success in today's climate, businesses must find ways to increase agility and speed up problem solving.

✘ The pace of change that characterizes the global business environment continues to exert pressure on companies to increase business agility and solve problems faster in order to maintain competitive edge.

✔ What's new? What can we sell in Q4? How can we sell it? These were the questions addressed at the recent retail boot camp.

✘ The half-day session focused on questions such as “what is new?”, “what can be sold in Q4?”, and “how can you sell it?”.

### SAP's Global Policies

**Comply with the SAP Communications Policy.**

This policy is one of SAP's corporate policies and guidelines. In a nutshell, it covers communication principles such as: Identify yourself as an SAP employee in external communication. Differentiate your personal opinion from information that you are conveying as part of your job function. Do not communicate on behalf of SAP. There are employees who are expressly authorized to do so. Comply with the communication guidelines on the *SAP Brand* site. Be polite, honest, and respectful, do not cite sources or people without permission. In cases of uncertainty contact the relevant corporate parties, such as Global Compliance, Global Legal, or Global HR.

For more information, see Marketing/Communications Policies and Guidelines.

### Related Information

SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183]
Photography – Diversity and Inclusion (on the SAP Brand site)

## 3.4 People-Centric Language and Communication

The people-centric approach involves creating content that is tailored specifically to the needs of your target group. Familiarize yourself with its principles. Discuss with others what it means for your product area or software type.

### Basics

**Think about what the people-centric approach means for you.**

Based on the people-centric principles, develop a style and tone of voice that works for your product area or software type and its target groups or personas.

**What is the people-centric approach?**

The people-centric approach is a renewed focus on creating content for your audience's unique perspective. The people-centric approach is all about understanding the target group perspective and tailoring your content to that perspective at all levels. This ranges from information architecture and output format down to tone of voice and the words that you choose at sentence level.

Adopting the people-centric approach does not mean that you need to completely change how you write. You may already be using a people-centric approach. It's a new take on the

well-known usability tradition of putting the user at the center. You all know what target group orientation is, and you know user stories and the persona-based approach.

**What the people-centric approach is not**

The people-centric approach is **not** a license to write **bad English**. SAP is still a business software company. So casual language means business casual. People-centric language is also **not** a new **one-solution-fits-all writing style** with a myriad of conversational standard formulations. An overly standardized approach would contradict the purpose of the people-centric approach.

For example, for an experienced target group of IT consultants, you don't need to soften the tone with conversational things such as "This feature will make your life easier. Just try it out." But this kind of conversational formulation might work well for an app description targeted at end users. For consultants, accountants, and other more senior target groups, the people-centric approach suggests the good old writing principles of avoiding nominalizations, using familiar words, and so on.

## Conversational Tone

**When is a conversational tone appropriate?**

It is always important to use language that is appropriate for your target group. This doesn't mean that you should always write in a conversational tone. Think about the language you're using and whether it's appropriate for the situation. For example, an error message about a software crash should not sound cheerful. On the other hand, cloud applications and social media allow for more opportunities for conversational language. For more information, see Conversational Tone and Casual Phrasing [page 90].

A conversational tone is particularly suitable in these cases:

- End-user personas
- Business-to-consumer products or services
- On-device or other Web-based applications
- Conversational output formats such as video or social media

## Emoticons and Emojis

**Do not use emoticons and emojis on the user interface, in user assistance, or other official SAP materials.**

As with all symbols and images, emoticons and emojis are culture specific. You can't really tell whether an emoticon or emoji is appropriate at all, has an unwanted meaning, or needs to be replaced or even omitted. Apart from technical restrictions (code pages, browser support), it will get you into a lot of localization research. Therefore, hands off.

Also, emoticons and emojis come from the sphere of personal or private communication in emails, forums, or messenger apps. They add this chatty, ultracasual, jargon-like tone to your communication. This is not what SAP wants to

convey on the user interface and in user assistance. In other words, emoticons and emojis do not comply with the tone-of-voice principles on the *SAP Brand* site

## SAP Brand

**How does the people-centric approach relate to the SAP tone of voice in communication?**

The people-centric approach is not alone in the SAP world. It mirrors and enhances the tone-of-voice principles on the *SAP Brand* site. For more information, see Tone of Voice and Writing Style (SAP Brand) [page 81].

## Translation and Translatability

**What are the limits of people-centric language in the source language?**

You often hear that you can't translate people-centric language. Well, word for word doesn't work of course. But translating is never a word-for-word process. Translators look at the meaning of the whole text and translate in a way that fits language, culture, country, or region.

As a user assistance developer, you can help translators by using clear, comprehensible terminology and sticking to the brand profile. Do **not** use **jargon, colloquialisms, or dialect**. They are difficult, if not impossible to understand for others, especially for people without first-language proficiency in English.

**Translation:** If you're sensing that formulations in your type of software are shading into localization, involve the translators early on and align. Keep in mind that localized content is difficult and costly to translate. Translators need more context and background information, which will slow down the translation process. If you don't support the translators, users will have a bad user experience with the software and user assistance. Again, to be on the safe side, find the right balance for people-centric language and prefer a neutral formulation option if in doubt.

> Example
>
> [Note: This example is from an email app. The text appears in the *Trash* folder when it's empty. The German version is not a direct translation but a localized one. It matches the German style of people-centric language that fits language and culture.]
>
> **English:** Empty. Looks like someone finally took out the trash.
>
> **Localized translation for German:** Keine E-Mails im Papierkorb. Gute Arbeit! Sieht sauber aus hier. [Note: If you don't know German, here's the English equivalent: No emails in the *Trash* folder. Good work! Looks tidy here.]

✔ **Ideas for neutral formulations:** Empty [or less abrupt:] No emails in your *Trash* folder [or:] We didn't find anything to show here.

**What if an equivalent conversational tone, which is suitable for business software, does not exist in a target language?**

Translate it into a tone that best suits the target language. For languages where an equivalent conversational tone exists, translate it to the spirit of the source text. Have a look at SAP's brand profile, which is available for a number of different languages and cultures on the *SAP Brand* site. In any case, also follow the principles of people-centric language: clear terminology and formulations, no jargon, or other non-standard language. And get back to the user assistance developers and product owners.

### Related Information

English: How to Write Clear, Translatable Texts for a Global Audience [page 270]

## 3.4.1 Addressing the User Directly

Keep the focus on your audience by addressing the user with “you” and other techniques. This helps you create a more conversational tone and ensures that you are putting the user at the center of the narrative.

### Basics

**Use the target group perspective.**

Present functionality from the target group perspective instead of the software perspective. This often involves taking a task-based approach to the content. Don't describe the feature. Describe what the target group can do with the feature. For more information, see Communicating with Your Audience: Who Are Your Target Groups? [page 65].

✤ Example

✔ Find people by searching for their user name, first name, last name, or email address.

✘ The search tool can search by user name, first, last, and email.

✔ You have new messages.

✘ There are new entries.

**Address your target group directly with “you”.**

Simulate a conversation. Don't call them “the user” or “the administrator”. Say “you” like you would in normal conversation. Similarly, you can often use “your” instead of a generic article such as “the”. Don't overdo it, though.

Just to be on the safe side: You can of course use the third person when you need to explain what different people or roles do. For example, when you explain to an administrator how to create and configure users, you'll obviously address the administrator with “you” but refer to the user with “the user”.

> Example
>
> ✔ You can upload your data file. [or:] Upload your data file.
>
> ✘ The user can upload the data file. [Note: If the text is targeted at the user, it's “you”. If you're telling your target group what users can do, then “the user” is fine.]
>
> ✔ Your password must be 8 characters long.
>
> ✘ One's password must be 8 characters long.

Only valid for 'Localization': German

## German: “Sie” oder “du”?

**Address your target group with “Sie”.**

“Sie” is the default form of address for German. Similarly, all advertising, branding, or marketing communication uses “Sie”.

**Exception:** “du” is likely to work in use cases such as an internal SAP application speaking directly at employees, a special app for sports team communication, or a youth campaign. Before deciding on “du”, do some research. What is the use case for “du”? What is the industry practice?

End of 'Localization': German

## Related Information

Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles [page 176]

## 3.4.2 “We” Versus “SAP”

There are no hard and fast rules for using “we” and “SAP”. It depends on context, text type, and the product-specific tone of voice.

### Basics

**As a general rule, “we” is personal and is often used in apps or cloud software whereas “SAP” is neutral and has a certain connotation of “official”.**

The decisive factor is of course the context. For example, is it a message or are you describing a system landscape? Is the overall tone of voice for your type of software more casual or personal? And so on. By the way, you can also switch between “we” and “SAP” (or the product name) in a text but this depends on the text flow. Alternatively, consider rephrasing and omitting “we” and “SAP” altogether.

> Example
>
> ✔ We could not find the resource you're trying to access. It might be misspelled or currently unavailable. Please check the URL or try again later. [Note: This is a message example. “We” makes the message sound personal.]
>
> ✔ The resource you're trying to access is not available. It might be misspelled or currently unavailable. Please check the URL or try again later. [Note: This message formulation sounds more detached.]
>
> ✘ SAP [or:] SAP Sports One could not find ... [Note: This sounds really odd in a message.]
>
> ✔ SAP Cloud for Travel and Expense is a highly efficient travel management application built for the cloud. As a company, you can control your travel policies, budgets, and expenses. As a traveler, you can easily claim your expenses and quickly get your money back.
>
> ✘ SAP Cloud for Travel and Expense is a highly efficient travel management application built for the cloud. We enable you as a company to ... We support you as a traveler to ... [Note: “We” doesn't really work here. It's a question of focus. In this context it is not important who enables whom but rather what companies and travelers can do. Also, the use of “we” keeps piling up, which is rather self-centered.]
>
> ✔ We recommend that you set up the development landscape as shown in the following graphic: [Note: This sentence appears in a topic called *Recommended Configuration of Runtime Systems*, surrounded by topics like *Maximum Configuration of Runtime Systems* or *Minimum Configuration Using the Developer Studio*. As “recommended” and “maximum” already contrast nicely, there's no need to make things sound official with “SAP recommends”.]

**???** SAP recommends that you set up the development landscape as shown in the following graphic: [Note: “SAP” makes it sound definitely more official and less like a recommendation. So maybe rephrase the sentence. Make the intended meaning comply with wording.]

✔ Ensure that your development landscape complies with the following architecture principles: [Note: This could be one way of rewording “SAP recommends”.]

**When using “we”, make sure that “we” refers to SAP or SAP software.**

Otherwise, mention the agent or product. This is particularly important when writing about third parties. For more information, see Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62].

## “We” and “Not” (Especially in Recommendations)

**Be careful with combining “we” and “not”. Stress what you advocate, rather than what not.**

Example

✔ We recommend using hot water.

✘ We do not recommend using cold water.

✘ It is not recommended to use cold water.

**If you can't avoid mentioning the negative case, try at least contrasting things.**

Example

✔ We recommend eating fruit. Avoid eating dairy products. [Note: Instead of “avoid”, you could also try “do not” but this is really strict. Depends on what you want to convey.]

✔ This document focuses on ... For information about the HP Vertica database processes, see ...

✘ We do not document the specific HP Vertica database processes that are required. For complete and up-to-date explanations and processes, consult ... [Note: Here it is better to omit “we”. “We” makes it personal, but in a negative formulation this gets the wrong spin (unnecessary focus on “we”).]

## Related Information

SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183]

## 3.4.3 Conversational Tone and Casual Phrasing

Some phrases are more conversational-sounding than others. So where do you need to draw a line? Don't forget that you're writing for a global audience and your text will be translated into up to 50 target languages. Let's have a look at casual phrasing and its implications.

### Basics

**Find out what degree of casual phrasing is appropriate.**

There are different types of target groups with different expectations and information needs in different situations.

**Make it sound like a natural speaking voice. Don't exaggerate, though.**

People are more attentive to something that sounds natural and more likely to understand what you are saying. But sometimes the mechanics or formality of writing it down gets you stuck. When that happens, read your content aloud and adapt it. Start with the most important aspect. Replace company or technical jargon with words that are meaningful to the other person.

> Example
>
> ✔ You have switched to a new system address. Have you checked the address? If you're sure it's safe, go to app settings and activate it.
>
> ✘ The new back-end service has been written to the app settings and requires now a manual activation.
>
> ✔ For security reasons, we had to end your server connection. Please contact your IT department.
>
> ✘ The connection to the server could not be secured. It might be that the server has been configured wrongly or that someone is tampering with your data.
>
> ✔ You're trying to switch to a system address that is not from SAP. We don't allow this because it just isn't safe.
>
> ✘ You try to switch to a new service which does not come from SAP. This is not allowed.

**Do not get into a wordy, chatty style or jargon.**

Conversational doesn't mean chatty. It's always important to be direct and concise. In the beginning, you might be tempted to use many words to achieve a conversational tone when, really, the user might just want the information.

**Translation:** Shorter, more direct sentences are easier (and much cheaper) to translate.

> **Example**
>
> ✔ Choose a database. [Note: This formulation gets to the point in less than half the words. And it's also easier to translate.]
>
> ✘ You'll need to track down the right database.
>
> ✔ Once you've made your bookings, your trip data is sent to the travel application. After a few seconds, your trip appears in your list of documents.
>
> ✘ Okay, so now you've finished booking your trip. Anyway, once you're done, all the trip data you've entered is sent to the application. Then you'll just need to wait a little bit, and your trip will show up in your list of documents.

## Natural Information Flow Instead of Formal Writing Conventions

**Use conversational transitions. Guide with questions.**

> **Example**
>
> ✔ Here's how [or:] Take a look [or:] You'll see
>
> ✔ Learn more [or:] See what's new [or:] Explore more options
>
> ✔ What's next? [or:] What do you want to do now? [or:] Stuck? Let's troubleshoot

**Use excitement sparingly.**

Don't shout at people. Don't talk down to them. Be careful about using exclamation points (!). They can be viewed as shouting or as danger. This is not a party. Have an adult conversation, not a teenage one. View yourself as the mentor wanting to assist the user.

## Some Simple Word Substitutions

**For your inspiration, have a look at some examples of phrasing choices that you can make.**

You can often make your work sound more people-centric by making some simple word substitutions. The following table is not a list of standard formulations. You must ultimately decide what is appropriate for your target group.

| Word Choice | Original | People-Centric Approach |
|---|---|---|
| “as follows” | Proceed as follows | Here's what you do: |
| “issue” | If this issue persists, ... | If this happens again, ... |

| Word Choice | Original | People-Centric Approach |
|---|---|---|
| “advantage” versus “best thing” | The advantage of using access tokens is that once users are authenticated, they can go from page to page without having to sign in each time. | The best thing about using access tokens is that once users are authenticated, they can go from page to page without having to sign in each time. |
| “be more efficient” versus “work better”. | ... so that your system is more efficient. | ... so that your system works better. |
| “obtain” versus “get” | By simply updating the dictionary to calculate the cost instead of obtaining it directly from the database, your users never know the difference. | By simply updating the dictionary to calculate the cost instead of getting it directly from the database, your users never know the difference. |
| “occur” versus “happen” | This formula divides the record number by 2. If the remainder is something other than 0 (which will occur for every odd numbered record), ... | This formula divides the record number by 2. If the remainder is something other than 0 (which will happen for every odd numbered record), ... |

## Related Information

Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles [page 176]
English: How to Write Clear, Translatable Texts for a Global Audience [page 270]
Tone of Voice and Writing Style (SAP Brand) [page 81]

## 3.4.4 English: Contractions

Adding contractions is one of the easiest ways to make your content sound more conversational, an important aspect of the people-centric approach.

### Basics

**Use common contractions, in moderation.**

You often use contractions when you speak. Using contractions can make your writing sound more natural. Trust your own instincts and test your content by reading it out loud. If you'd use a contraction when speaking, you can use it in your texts. If in doubt, then write it out in full.

If you're stuck, consult colleagues. If you do not have first-language proficiency in English, ask a language editor or a native speaker.

**Exception:** Do not use contractions when you need to emphasize something important. For example, a warning message sounds more serious if you say “Do not” instead of “Don't”.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ When you sign in to the system, you don't need to provide your account information.
>
> ✘ When you sign in to the system, you do not need to provide your account information. [Note: This traditional style sounds robotic compared to the version with contractions.]
>
> ✔ Do not manually edit the INI file. [Note: This is an example of when you shouldn't use contractions. This is a serious warning that could stop the software from working properly. Warnings sound more serious without contractions.]

**Do not use unusual contractions.**

Compound contractions such as “couldn't've”are unusual and confusing. Contractions such as “the user'll” are rarely used in spoken language and look even more unusual in written text.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✘ You wouldn't've configured the security settings during installation. [Note: This is a confusing compound contraction.]
>
> ✘ The user'll need to configure the profile. [Note: This is an informal contraction.]

## Common Contractions

| Contraction | ✔Example | Comments |
|---|---|---|
| aren't | They aren't available. | “Aren't” sounds more casual than “are not”. |
| can't | In the context menu of the page, choose *Delete*. Note that you can't do this if only one page exists. | “Can't” sounds more casual than “cannot”.<br>**Exception:** Use “cannot” when you need to warn users about serious consequences.<br>Spelling: “cannot”, never “can not”<br>Note: “cannot” may sound sterner than “can't”. This depends on the context. Compare “You cannot/can't do that.” (not allowed) to “You cannot/can't open the file.” (impossible in the given circumstances). “Cannot” also seems to be used more often in passive sentences. |
| doesn't | This document doesn't address single sign-on authentication issues. | “Doesn't” is generally friendlier than “does not”. |
| don't | You don't need special permissions to access the folder.<br>To avoid potential loss of data, do not use multiple CMCs in a clustered environment. | “Don't” sounds more casual than “do not”.<br>**Exception:** Use “do not” when you need to warn users about serious consequences. |
| hasn't | If your report hasn't been saved, ... | “Hasn't” is generally friendlier than “has not”. |
| isn't | Reports with saved data are useful for dealing with data that isn't continually updated. | “Isn't” sounds more natural than “is not”.<br>**Exception:** Use the long form “is not” when you want to emphasize something. |
| it's | After your report is processed, it's stored in the default folder. | “It's” sounds more natural than “it is”.<br>Note: Be careful to avoid the common “its” (possessive pronoun) versus “it's” error. |
| that's | You can now edit the file that's displayed in the text editor. | You can use “that's”, but it shows up rarely. In the example shown here, you would be more likely to say “You can now edit the file in the text editor.” |
| they'll | Normally, database fields will be placed [better: are placed] in the *Detail* section of the report. Under certain circumstances, they'll be placed [better: are placed] in other sections. | You can use “they'll”, but you don't need it in most cases. The word “will” is overused and can often be deleted. In this example, it would be better to say “they are placed”. |

| Contraction | ✔Example | Comments |
|---|---|---|
| they're | They're not displayed. | You can use “they're ”, but the long form “they are” often reads better. Try both and use the one that sounds better to your ears. |
| wasn't | The report wasn't saved. | “Wasn't” is generally friendlier than “was not”. Same goes for “weren't” |
| won't | If you don't select the *Allow Context Menus* checkbox, users won't be able to [better: can't access] access this feature. | “Won't” sounds more casual and less bossy than “will not”.<br>Note: Watch out for unnecessary use of “will”. In this example, you could be more direct and say “users can't access this feature”. |
| you'll | You'll notice that the details are now hidden. | You can use “you'll”, but it is often unnecessary. For example, in this case, you could say “The details are now hidden.” |
| you're | The advantage of using this format is that you're free to create your own XML format. | “You're” sounds more natural than “you are”. |
| you've | By hiding the *Details* section of this report, you've created a summary report that's easy for users to navigate. | “You've” sounds more natural than “you have”. |

## 3.4.5 Politeness

Being polite is part of maintaining a personable people-centric style. Be polite, especially when the situation demands it.

### Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| **Be respectful.** | When you use a conversational tone, make sure it's polite conversation. Don't criticize. Don't be negative. Use humor carefully, because it can often be misinterpreted. |
| **Be wary of using “please”, “sorry”, or other apologetic formulations.** | The problem with apologetic formulations is that they quickly lose their meaning. Of course, it really depends on how annoyed you think the user might be in the situation. But, for the most part, reserve “please”, “sorry”, and the like for times when the software messes up through no fault of the user. |

## “Please”

**Say “please” when appropriate. Don't overdo it though.**

If you use “please” too often, it becomes a meaningless filler word. It can also make text sound unnatural if repeated too often. Here's a little test that may help you decide on “please”: Imagine the situation in which the user is and then write or say the text with and without “please”. Which formulation sounds better? If there's no or next to no difference, omit “please”. Don't worry too much about it. There are no hard and fast rules.

- Say “please” when the user is asked to do something inconvenient or beyond their expectations.
  For example, if a step in the middle of a guided procedure requires the user to go read another section and perform a completely different action before proceeding to the next step, then you are asking the user to do something annoying. It might be a good time to say “please”. It also might be a good time to talk to the product owner about changing the interaction design.
- Say “please” if the situation is already troubling for the user.
  For example, if you're writing an error message, the user is probably already annoyed that they are receiving an error, so it could be appropriate to say “please”.

**Do not say “please” just because you're asking the user to do something.**

Cross-references and step-by-step instructions do not require “please”. They are not polite requests, they are simply instructions.

### Example

✔ The network connection was lost. Please enter your password again.

✔ The application has failed. Please restart the application. [Note: This is an example of using “please” in an error message. The instruction is simple (restarting the application) but the level of annoyance may be high. Time to say “please”.]

✔ For more information, see Database Tables.

✘ For more information, please see Database Tables.

✔ Follow these steps:

1. Open the subaccount to which you'd like to add members.
2. Select the *Administrator* checkbox.
3. Enter the user IDs you have received from your application provider and confirm.
4. Notify your application provider that the users now have the necessary permissions to access the subaccount.

✘ Please follow these steps:

1. Please open the subaccount to which you'd like to add members.
2. Please select the *Administrator* checkbox.
3. Please enter the user IDs you have received from your application provider and confirm.

4. Please notify your application provider that the users now have the necessary permissions to access the subaccount.

## Apologizing

| | |
|---|---|
| **If you apologize, use the passive voice when possible.** | Sometimes it feels right to apologize when something bad happens, but try not to blame the user or the software. You can use the passive voice to remove blame from statements of apology. |
| **As with "please", use "sorry" or similar phrases consciously.** | For example, if the situation is troubling for the user or something unexpected has happened that the user is not responsible for, consider using "sorry" or similar phrases. Less is often more. Discuss it with others. |

Example

✔ The request uses incorrect syntax and can't be processed properly. [Note: This version doesn't blame the user for poor syntax.]

✘ The request can't be processed because you used the wrong syntax. [Note: This example blames the user.]

✔ Sorry, the server has failed. Your request can't be processed at this time. Please try again. [Note: An example of apologizing without blaming the software.]

✘ Sorry, the application caused a massive server failure and your request can't be processed at this time. [Note: This example makes it sound like the software isn't very good.]

✔ It looks like the file couldn't be imported because its name was changed. Try importing it again with the original file name.

✘ Could not import file. Try again later.

## Related Information

Tone of Voice and Writing Style (SAP Brand) [page 81]
Message Texts and Content Pattern [page 135]
Formulation Patterns for Message Texts [page 140]

## 3.5 Bias-Free Language and Communication

Bias-free communication does not stereotype or discriminate against people with regard to culture, gender, ethnicity, language, and similar categories. It's about treating everybody in a fair and respectful way. Now how can you ensure this? Here are some general principles.

### Basics

**Communicate in a way that is free of stereotypes and discrimination and that is sensitive to people's identities.**

Bias-free communication relates to various dimensions of a person's identity such as culture, nationality, ethnicity, age, economic background, religion, gender, sexual orientation, or disabilities. Exemplify diversity in society. For more information, see Accessibility [page 103] and Inclusive Design.

**Be careful with metaphors and idioms.**

Metaphors and idioms depend on culture and language. They can make texts difficult to translate.

### Culture

**Use culturally neutral terms. Do not make references to specific religions or holidays.**

> Example
>
> ✔ first name, last name, holiday bonus, religious tax
>
> ✘ Christian name, surname, Christmas bonus, church tax

**Be careful with symbols and images.**

Symbols and images may not be immediately recognized or they may even have an unwanted meaning. For example, a mailbox (as a symbol for mail) or an electrical outlet (as a symbol for power) look different in different countries or regions. Or the other way round: An x mark is often used to convey negation or disagreement. But in some countries or regions, people use it in some contexts (for example, checklists) to mean “correct” or “done”.

The use of emoticons and emojis is also culture specific. You can't really tell whether they are appropriate. Therefore, hands off! For more information, see People-Centric Language and Communication [page 83].

**Be careful with colors.**

Colors may have different meanings in different cultures. For example, in the United States black is commonly associated with death and mourning whereas in China white is associated with these concepts.

## Inclusive Language

> **Note**
>
> SAP is taking a stand against racism to drive change inside and outside of our organization to ensure that equality becomes a reality. Terminology is one part of that. The SAP-wide *Inclusive Language* working group started in July 2020 and is still ongoing. The *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* (the topic you're reading) will be enhanced as the project progresses.

**Replace inappropriate terms as outlined in the Guidelines for Inclusive Language.**

The finalized terms are also available in SAPterm component `SAP-INCLUSIVE`. Inclusive language and the corresponding SAPterm component are mentioned in the Product Standard for User Assistance. For more information, see requirement Product Terminology (UA-050).

The terminology guidelines currently focus on replacing words and phrases containing "black/white" and "master/slave". They also list terms that are acceptable to use (and why), such as "scrum master", "master data", or "white paper". Over time the terminology workstream will also cover other words and phrases and their inclusive replacements.

**Always consider the underlying meaning and context in which the terms are used.**

Inclusive terms are not one-to-one replacements. The context is important, and there might be clearer ways to say the same thing.

> **Example**
>
> ✖ You can add unwanted visitors to the blacklist.
>
> ✔ You can add unwanted visitors to the blocklist. [Note: This is the one-to-one replacement. Not bad, but there might be clearer ways to say it.]
>
> ✔ You can block unwanted visitors. [Note: This is the rephrased version. It's clearer and shorter. Have a try with your text. Be inventive.]

**If you have a question, just drop it on the forum: Ask a Question**

Questions are being monitored by the terminology workstream, which consists of user assistance developers from different product areas.

## Gender and Gender-Inclusive Language

**Communicate in a gender-inclusive style.**

Mention people of all genders in equal numbers and in comparable job roles. Use gender-inclusive terminology, for example, "chairperson" instead of "chairman".

**Make sure that your text sounds natural. Do not stretch a language to the limits of grammar and comprehensibility.**

Writing in a gender-inclusive style has different challenges for different languages. There are languages that have grammaticalized gender in

nouns, pronouns, noun/adjective agreement, (pro)noun/verb agreement, and so on.

For example, in English it is easier to write in a gender-inclusive style because English does not have grammatical gender. Articles are gender neutral (English “the” but German “der, die, das”). Nouns seldom mark gender overtly (English “the user” but German “der Benutzer ” and “die Benutzerin”). To avoid the gender-marked third person singular pronouns “he, she; his, her; him, her”, the gender-inclusive form “they (with plural verb); their; them” has been gaining in use in English. In German, however, there's no such equivalent. There's still only “er, sie, (es); sein, ihr, (sein); ihm, ihr, (ihm); ihn, sie, (es) ” and the related relative pronouns “der, die, (das)” (with case-specific forms).

**Consider these options for referring to people in a gender-inclusive way.**

Not all options will work equally well for your context. So pick the one that fits best:

| Option | Example |
|---|---|
| Use **gender-inclusive nouns**. | ✔ chairperson, business executive, workforce, person days, working hours<br><br>✘ chairman/chairwoman, businessman/businesswoman, manpower, man days, man hours |
| Address the user directly with an imperative form or **with “you”**. | ✔ Change your password. [Note: Could also be “... the password”.]<br><br>✔ After six months, you need to change your password. [Note: Could also be “... the password”.] |
| Use the **third person in the plural** (“they”, “their”, “them”). | ✔ Users must enter a password. After six months, they need to change the password. |

| Option | Example |
| --- | --- |
| **English:** If you can't avoid the third person singular, use singular "they" ("their", "them") or rewrite. For more information, see English: Grammar Issues of Frequent Debate [page 283].<br><br>Do not use "he/she", "he or she", only "he", or only "she". | ✔ The user must enter a password. After six months, they need to change the password.<br><br>✔ The user must enter a password. After six months, the password needs to be changed.<br><br>✘ The user must enter a password. After six months, he needs to change his password.<br><br>✔ Each participant contributed in their preferred language.<br><br>✔ When the chairperson published the report, they immediately got feedback.<br><br>✔ When the chairperson published the report, there was immediate feedback.<br><br>✘ When the chairperson published the report, he or she immediately got feedback. |
| **German:** If a gender-inclusive noun does not exist or you can't avoid the third person singular, resort to using the masculine form of the noun or the pronoun ("er", "sein", "ihm", "ihn"). Consider this to be a last-ditch recommendation. On the user interface, the male form (for example, "Benutzer") is the current default for field labels, column titles, and so on. But there's often a good alternative (for example, "Verantwortlich" instead of "Verantwortlicher"). | |

**German: Do not use word formation patterns such as "die Aufgabe eines/r Entwicklers/-in", "BenutzerIn", "Benutzer*in", or "die SoftwareentwickelInden".**

The whole area of gender-inclusive writing ("geschlechtergerechte Schreibung") is very much language and society change in progress. This is especially tricky for German, which is a language with grammatical gender. In the current phase of this change process, there are lots of variants around (for example, gender asterisk/underscore/colon, present participle, neutral words). In addition to binary word forms such as "Entwickler/in, EntwicklerIn", there are also nonbinary ones such as "Entwickler*in, Entwickler:in, Entwickler_in". But there is no official linguistic standard. For the meantime, you can consult the Duden companion *Richtig Gendern*, or find some inspiration at https://geschicktgendern.de or at https://www.genderleicht.de.

The **Rat for deutsche Rechtschreibung** (Council for German Orthography) decided in March 2021 to continue watching the ongoing process. For more information, see Rat für deutsche Rechtschreibung and search for **`gendergerecht`**. They haven't promoted a particular variant to a standard. Beyond the mere spelling conventions, this language change also raises the question of how to deal with compounds (for example, "Bürgermeisterkandidat" or "benutzerfreundlich"). It also

brings grammatical gaps in the area of articles and pronouns (for example, German does not have singular “they” for “er/sie”, with “es” not being an option). Also, words like “Kunde” (customer) do not necessarily refer to human beings, they can also refer to companies. That is, a simple search and replace as in “Kunde → Kund:in” does not work. And there is the eternal question about inflectional endings.

At SAP (in the development area including user assistance), the additional challenge is the mass of text. There's millions of text in 50+ languages. These texts exist over decades (in various product versions) and are extensively technically reused. The texts appear as short texts on the user interface (for example, as field labels) and in longer texts (for example, embedded help, documentation, or messages). There needs to be text coherence between user interface and these longer texts. You can't adapt one without adapting the other. There are lots of other aspects to consider. Long story short: Implementing this language change is nothing trivial.

All these aspects also apply to communication texts (for example, marketing, sales, corporate communication). Now these texts have a rather short lifetime as opposed to user assistance. This is where SAP could start with gender-inclusive language. SAP can define SAP standards (for example, decide on the gender colon in German as in “Benutzer:in”) and then easily switch to a different variant if the Rechtschreibrat decides differently. In communication texts, it's also easier to rewrite gendered words (for example, use the plural or “die Person, die ...”). On a user interface, however, you need a brief form in the singular.

## Related Information

English: How to Write Clear, Translatable Texts for a Global Audience [page 270]
People-Centric Language and Communication [page 83]
Tone of Voice and Writing Style (SAP Brand) [page 81]
Photography – Diversity and Inclusion (on the SAP Brand site)
Intercultural Aspects of User Experience (SAP Fiori Design Guidelines)
Gender Inclusivity in SAP Software: Why It’s a Rubik’s Cube

# 3.6 Accessibility

Accessibility is about equal participation for everybody, including and especially people with disabilities. Software, user interface, and user assistance need to be as accessible as possible. Accessibility also affects how you communicate. This ranges from wording to accessibility documentation about features and settings.

## Basics

**Familiarize yourself with the Product Standard for Accessibility.**

You don't have to know it by heart. But it's definitely helpful to have a look at its accessibility requirements that relate to user assistance. There is an extensive accessibility wiki that covers the product standard, personas, status documents, guidelines for various UI technologies, and accessibility tools. For more information, see the Product Standard for Accessibility (also Accessibility Personas) and Accessibility Aspects for Output Formats and Tools [page 319].

**Familiarize yourself with inclusive design.**

Inclusive Design is a human-centered approach that considers the widest range of human diversity with respect to ability, language, culture, gender, age, and other forms of human variance. For more information, see Inclusive Design, which complements the Product Standard for Accessibility and Accessibility in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*. In addition, see also the UA Infrastructure User Guide and search for **`Making Content Usable for Everyone (Accessibility To Dos)`**.

**For a general background, have a look at the *Facts and Regulations Around Accessibility* page.**

For example, did you know that accessibility is a principle in the *UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities*? There are also country/region-specific laws and regulations, such as the *Employment Equality Framework Directive 2000/78/EC* or Section 508 of the *United States Federal Rehabilitation Act*. For more information, see Facts and Regulations Around Accessibility.

**Do not use formulations that are discriminatory.**

For example, do not refer to people by their disabilities. For more information, see also Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98].

> Example
>
> ✔ 15% of the world's population are people with disabilities. Some of them use wheelchairs.
>
> ✘ 15% of the world's population are handicapped. Some of them are bound to a wheelchair.
>
> ✔ 15% of the world's population live with a disability.
>
> ✘ 15% of the world's population suffer from a disability.

With verbs such as “see” or “click”, the discriminatory impact depends on the context. For example, in cross-references, such as “For more information, see ...”,

the verb “see” has the wider meaning of “refer to”. It does not denote visual perception. The verb “click” could be construed as discriminatory. But as long as there is information about alternative navigation modes (for example, in your accessibility documentation), you can use “click”. These examples were discussed with the colleagues from the Product Standard for Accessibility, and they are fine with it. However, note that “click” does not work with multidevice applications. For more information about “click” as opposed to device-neutral “choose”, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116].

**Remember some basic accessibility principles for providing information.**

Text is the format that's best from an accessibility perspective. Text is easy to process for assistive technologies, such as screen readers. Structure the text with headings and format them as headings. Introduce lists, tables, and graphics with an introductory sentence. Use column or row headings for tables. When using icons, graphics, video, or audio, always provide a text alternative (a textual description, subtitles, an audio description, or a transcript). For more information, see Lists [page 246], Tables [page 251], and Multimedia and Graphics: Overview [page 259].

**Logical sequence: Describe what before how.**

Think about the way assistive technologies like screen readers present information to users. Describing an action first helps users understand the consequences of an action before they perform it. For more information on logical sequence, see Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles [page 176].

## How to Address Users with Disabilities

**Focus on the need, not on the disability.**

First, this is about **not** equating people with disabilities. Second, users want to know what to do if they have a disability or a special need. It's not important why they have this need.

For example, visual-only output (speech to text, subtitles) is obviously important for people with hearing loss or impairments. But the same need for visual-only output arises if you're not fluent in a foreign language or if a speaker has a strong local accent. Other examples are the need for a screen reader, for a screen magnifier, for text resizing, for color adjustments, for high-contrast themes, for keyboard-only navigation, or for speech input. For more information about the different needs and types of users, see User Groups.

> Example
>
> ✔ If you use a screen reader, ...
>
> ✔ Users who work with a screen reader ...
>
> ✔ Need screen content as speech output?
>
> ✔ You can change the application colors to your individual needs.
>
> ✔ You can navigate using speech input.

## Accessibility Status and How to Use Terms Such as “accessible”

**Do not use the term “accessible” to state that the software is accessible or not.**

The term “accessible” implies 100% accessibility, which can hardly be reached. If you referred to the software or parts of it as being accessible, customers would be entitled to claim missing features or recompensation. Therefore, do **not** make statements about the accessibility status in user assistance.

The **official way** to communicate the accessibility status is by means of product-specific, legally binding **accessibility status documents**. Based on test results, these documents describe the accessibility compliance in detail and are handed out to customers on request. The process is coordinated by the Accessibility Competence Center (ACC). For more information, see Accessibility Status Documents.

> **Note**
>
> In SAPterm the term “accessible” (German: “barrierefrei”) has a legal restriction with the note “Do not use this term!”.

**Use the formulation patterns that apply to your language.**

For more information, see Guidelines to Document Accessibility for End Users.

| English: Formulation Pattern | German: Formulation Pattern | Comment |
|---|---|---|
| usability improvements | Verbesserungen der Bedienbarkeit | Do not use “accessibility improvements”. |
| For accessibility according to the respective SAP Accessibility Status Document for `<Product Name.>`, use `<...>` instead of `<...>`.<br><br>For accessibility according to the respective SAP Accessibility Status Document of `<Product Name.>`, make the following settings `<where>` under `<path>`: | Um Barrierefreiheit gemäß dem entsprechenden SAP-Statusdokument zur Barrierefreiheit für `<Produktname>` zu nutzen, verwenden Sie `<...>` anstelle von `<...>`.<br><br>Um Barrierefreiheit gemäß dem entsprechenden SAP-Statusdokument zur Barrierefreiheit für `<Produktname>` zu nutzen, machen Sie `<wo>` unter `<Pfad>` folgende Einstellungen: | If the software or a specific function has an alternative version with improved accessibility and the IT consultant/implementer or IT administrator can choose between them when configuring the software, mention the alternative version explicitly. |

| English: Formulation Pattern | German: Formulation Pattern | Comment |
|---|---|---|
| `<...>` accessibility mode<br><br>✔ keyboard accessibility mode<br><br>✔ In the accessibility mode, users are supported with more text information for screen readers and additional keyboard navigation options or hotkeys. | Barrierefreiheitsmodus für `<...>`<br><br>✔ Barrierefreiheitsmodus für die Tastatur<br><br>✔ Im Barrierefreiheitsmodus werden Benutzer mit zusätzlichen Textinformationen für Bildschirmauslesprogramme und Navigationsmöglichkeiten über Tastatur oder Aktionstasten unterstützt. | Do not use "accessibility mode" on its own. Instead, make clear which function or feature is supported. Add a modifier phrase or a description. This is to avoid the impression that switching to accessibility mode makes the software 100% accessible. |
| Accessibility in `<Product Name>` | Barrierefreiheit in `<Produktname>` | Use this formulation pattern for topic titles. |

**Do not use the term "accessible" even when you mean "available".**

The term "accessible" can be ambiguous. Saying that the software is "accessible" can mean that users with disabilities can use it, but it could also mean that everybody has access to the software, regardless of security restrictions, or that the software is available.

> Example
>
> ✔ The system is available.
>
> ✘ The system is accessible.

## Accessibility Documentation

**Provide accessibility documentation for the software.**

Accessibility documentation covers accessibility features and settings (client, server), keyboard shortcuts, and alternatives for users with disabilities. It ensures that these users can use the software and the user interface. For more information and templates, see the Standards and Guidelines for Accessibility Documentation.

**Familiarize yourself with the personas for accessibility documentation.**

The personas are, for example, users with a hearing or visual impairment or users who rely on speech input or keyboard. However, do not mention these personas or their names in your documentation. The personas are just intended to help you understand the situation of users with disabilities. For more information, see Personas for Accessibility Documentation.

### Related Information

From Information Needs to User Assistance Deliverables [page 68]
Videos [page 264]
Photography – Diversity and Inclusion (on the SAP Brand site)

## 3.7 Social Media

SAP encourages the proper use of social media and provides standards to help you successfully participate. Engage with your target groups in a two-way conversation. But note: Social media content cannot replace the core user assistance.

### Basics

**Remember that social media can only serve as an addition to the core user assistance, which is provided with the software.**

In particular, do **not** communicate information about new functions and features on social media **before** the software (including the core user assistance) has been officially released to the public. For more information, see Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50].

**Familiarize yourself with the social media guidelines.**

For more information, see:

- Social Governance Center of Excellence community
- Social Media on the *SAP Brand* site
- Social Media Strategy Worksheet for User Assistance

# 4 User Interface: User Assistance Meets User Experience

Good software is all about a simple, elegant, supportive, and user-adapted experience. As a user assistance developer or translator, you are the expert for terminology, comprehensibility, tone of voice, consistency, and of course linguistic correctness. Your expertise will decisively improve the user experience.

## Basics

**Familiarize yourself with the SAP product standards that are relevant for the user interface.**

You don't need to know all product standards and all their requirements. Some requirements apply directly to you as a user assistance developer, others are just helpful background. Here are the relevant product standards:

- Product Standard for User Assistance
- Product Standard for User Experience Consistency including the SAP Fiori Design Guidelines
- Product Standard for Accessibility including Inclusive Design
- Product Standard for Globalization

**Get involved in user experience activities early on.**

For example, participate in site visits or usability tests, or get involved in developing user stories, user profiles, or prototypes. Have a look at the methods and best practices in the user experience communities. And so on.

**Get involved in all user-interface-text discussions with developers and user experience designers.**

Why? Because you're the one with the text and language expertise. And because getting user interface texts right early on saves everybody time and money (don't forget that there are up to 50 target languages). That's fewer queries from translators to developers, fewer customer tickets for SAP, and more customer satisfaction.

**What can you do?** Think and act in the spirit of "user interface first" and "contextual guidance". Embed important information on the user interface. Test the user interface. Participate in user interface reviews. Hand out terminology lists, or set up a terminology session for your product team. Hand out product-specific or tool-specific dos and don'ts for developers, or invite to a dos and don'ts workshop. Team up with translation. If the user interface can't be improved in time for your release, solve the easy issues first and add the difficult ones to the backlog of the next release.

## Basic Quality Criteria for User Interface Texts

**Follow the content and formal criteria.**

Need help with applying the criteria? Have a look at the service catalog. For example, book an editing service or a user interface review. For more information, see User Assistance Services. Now here are the quality criteria in a nutshell – and remember it always depends on target group and task:

| Content Criteria | Formal Criteria |
|---|---|
| ✔ Relevant information embedded on the user interface (don't hide it in guides) | ✔ Correct spelling, grammar, and punctuation (spell checker! language editing!) |
| ✔ Concise and meaningful texts, no stating the obvious | ✔ No abbreviations or truncated text |
| ✔ Consistent and user-friendly terminology (target group specific, no synonyms) | ✔ Consistent capitalization (for example, sentence style for messages, title case for titles and labels) |
| ✔ Easy-to-understand, friendly formulations (people-centric language) | ✔ Active formulations and "you" |
| ✔ Correct product names and other approved names (for example, on welcome screens) | ✔ Formulation patterns (for example, parallel formulations or verbal versus nominal) |

For more information, see User Interface Text Checklist for SAP Fiori Apps in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*.

## User Experience and Usability

**Familiarize yourself with the Product Standard for User Experience Consistency.**

This product standard ensures a familiar and consistent user experience across SAP products and technologies. It addresses design aspects like theming and visual appearance, terminology (for common actions on the user interface), typography, icon usage, and the placement and order of actions. These aspects are highly important for a user to work efficiently and effectively. For more information, see the Product Standard for User Experience Consistency.

**Think and act usability in your daily work.**

An important element in user experience is usability. Usability is about enabling users to work effectively, efficiently, and satisfactorily with the software (as outlined in the ISO standard *Ergonomics of human-system interaction – Part 110: Dialogue principles* (ISO 9241-110)). The following usability aspects are closely related to user assistance:

- **Consistency:** Consistent means that the same things look, feel, and behave the same within a given context. For example, fields, buttons, and the like are labeled consistently.

- **User expectations:** For example, users expect terminology that they are familiar with. They also expect functional elements, such as a *Save* button, to be placed and labeled consistently, and they expect numbers, dates, or currencies in the format of their country and language.
- **Efficient information retrieval:** Screens are easy to scan if there are underlying structural patterns. For example, the search screens of your software type follow the same layout and interaction pattern. Headings and labels are concise and unique. Important content is highlighted. Even if the text size or screen resolution is adjusted, the structural patterns still shine through.
- **Self-descriptiveness:** The primary mechanism to guide users is the user interface itself. The screen and interaction design needs to be intuitive. Field labels, button texts, menu items, headings, and screen titles need to be precise and informative.
- **System feedback and error tolerance:** The software provides feedback whenever possible or needed, for example, by displaying appropriate messages, by highlighting appropriate fields, by navigating automatically to errors, or by displaying progress bars. If users can't complete a task, they get information about how to fix the problem.

## Legacy Software and Acquired Companies

**Background:** SAP's software portfolio comprises legacy software that has been around for many years and is still supported, as well as a wide variety of software from multiple acquisitions. The default standards included in this style guide cannot address all circumstances and types of user experience and user interfaces.

**As a general rule, apply the standards in this style guide only to new content and to existing content that needs to be updated.**

This may lead to inconsistencies. There is no one-solution-fits-all approach for this. You will have to weigh different aspects and implications against each other.

**When dealing with inconsistencies, weigh aspects such as user experience, consistency, and translation against each other.**

Here are some things to think about and discuss with other stakeholders, especially user experience designers:

- What kind of inconsistencies will there be? Will users notice at all? How disruptive are the inconsistencies in terms of user experience and comprehensibility?
- What will the new standards and the resulting inconsistencies imply for user assistance developers and translators?
- Will the benefits outweigh the inconsistencies?
- Would it be an option to apply the new standards only to new screens?
- Is there a more specific user interface guideline for your software type? Have its standards been applied correctly and consistently so far? If not, consider switching to this style guide (the one you're reading now). If your existing user interface guideline is going to change, harmonize it with this style guide as far as possible.

### Related Information

Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160]

## 4.1 Text on the User Interface – The Basics

Users want concise and meaningful text on the user interface. What are the things to watch out for? It's all about embedded information, consistent terminology and formulations, and good language quality. But it gets tricky when front-end and back-end terminology clash or when there are space restrictions.

### Basics

**Familiarize yourself with the SAP Fiori Design Guidelines.**

You don't need to know the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines* by heart. But they provide helpful background knowledge, and they have a section called User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps.

**Ensure that user interface texts undergo language editing (copy editing).**

Not every developer or user assistance developer has first-language proficiency in the source language English. Linguistic correctness, however, is a prerequisite for customer satisfaction and efficient translation processes.

**Translation:** Language editing of the source is vital for translation into up to 50 target languages.

**Test and improve the user interface early on – in all your target languages.**

A perfect user interface in English is not automatically perfect in other languages. Text may be hard-coded (directly embedded in the source code and therefore not translated) or cryptically truncated. You'll only notice when you sign in with another language. Screens may even get incomprehensible. All this means a bad user experience.

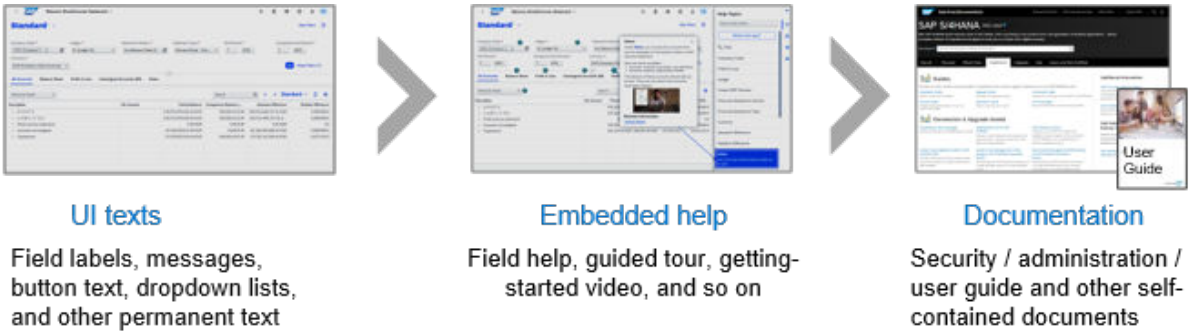
**Translation:** Hard-coded texts are not translated because they are not detected by translation tools. Texts are truncated because most languages need more space than English.

**What can you do?**

- Together with your developers, go through the **developer checklist**. For more information, see Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160].
- Already in the **mockup phase**, you can work on user interface texts. For example, if a screen mockup has the field label “Method” (instead of the longer “Payment Method”), ask your colleagues whether the user would know what to do. Ask your translators if they see any issues with the term.
- When **tangible screens** are in place, run **pseudotranslation checks**. Pseudo-translation (language 2Q) helps you **detect truncated texts, space issues,**

**and hard-coded texts** by simulating translated screens. Recommend the User Interface Text Space Calculator to your developers. For more information, see Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160].

## Embedded Help




**Do not hide information, which helps users get their tasks done, in self-contained documents.**

An intuitive user interface with embedded help makes a lot of procedural descriptions or reference documentation superfluous. For example, the solution part of a message belongs in the message itself, not in a separate user guide. Lengthy procedural descriptions can be turned into a wizard or partially reemerge as permanent on-screen explanations. Field or button explanations are best provided nearby on-screen, for example, as tooltips (mouseovers).

> **Note**
>
> This does not mean that you must or can store all information on the user interface. It would get a bit crowded indeed. Complex concepts for expert target groups, such as developers or consultants, are usually best explained in separate, self-contained documents, such as guides.
>
> Remember: User assistance is about providing the right information in the right place and format at the right time, as appropriate for target group and usage situation.

## Terminology on the User Interface

**Use terminology that is natural to your target group and their work situation.**

If the software addresses casual users without specialist knowledge, use everyday terms. This applies to employee apps or any application that might also be used by a non-expert. If the software addresses professional users or experts, use standard business terms or – for developers and other technical target groups – technical terms.

Find out as much as you can about the target group. Contact and ask customers. User stories are also a good source of information. The terminology used by your developers does not necessarily reflect the user perspective. For more information, see Terminology and SAPterm [page 74].

**For common user actions, use the terminology defined in the Product Standard for User Experience Consistency.**

It's about the naming conventions for user actions like “Add” versus “New” or “Send” versus “Submit”, which are used across all applications and lines of business. For more information (especially which terms to use), see the requirement Terminology for Common UI Actions (UXC-015). This requirement is closely connected to the User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*. The corresponding SAPterm component is SAP-UXC.

By the way, it doesn't hurt to get involved in defining formulation patterns for user interface elements that are specific to your product area or software type.

**When you need to change terminology or formulations on the user interface, use the SAP Language Search tool.**

For more information and direct access, see the SAP Language Search Tool community.

## Capitalization (Uppercase, Lowercase) of User Interface Elements

**Ensure that user interface texts of the same type use consistent capitalization (uppercase, lowercase).**

This is not only about title case and sentence style in English. Irrespective of the language, you may need to define whether the very first letter of field labels, screen titles, predefined entries, and so on is written in uppercase or lowercase. Establish conventions for your product area or software type. Check the user interface by using a test system.

Only valid for 'Localization': English

**English:** For more information about English capitalization, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199] and Common User Interface Elements [page 119].

End of 'Localization': English

**Do not write entire words in uppercase (all caps).**

Text in all caps is not easy to read. It's discouraged by the standard *Systems and software engineering – Engineering and management of websites for systems, software, and services information* (ISO IEC IEEE 23026).

**Translation:** Text in all caps usually indicates that these texts are technical names and must not be translated.

## Abbreviations and Space Restrictions on the User Interface

**As a general rule, do not abbreviate user interface texts. In particular, do not use on-the-fly abbreviations.**

There is a general trend of not having abbreviations at all. This, however, depends on the development environment and user interface technology. In some environments, the user interface texts are automatically truncated with an ellipsis (...) and the complete text string is shown in a tooltip (mouseover) or appears when the screen or user interface element is resized. In other environments, texts are cut off and you need to rephrase or even manually abbreviate the texts to make them fit. For more information about how to avoid abbreviations and truncations, see Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160].

**Exception:** Industry-standard abbreviations and acronyms are fine, as are established dictionary abbreviations. To be on the safe side, check with the target group.

**If it's a multidevice application, test whether titles and labels have sufficient space on all user interfaces (desktop, tablet, mobile).**

On mobile screens, space is scarce. A text that is fine on a desktop screen might be severely truncated on a mobile screen. So the challenge is to find the shortest meaningful text unless there is a technical solution for text length alternatives.

**If you can't avoid abbreviations, make sure that each abbreviation is as easy as possible to understand and translate.**

Abbreviate a word or a phrase the same way each time it appears on the user interface. Similarly, do not use the same abbreviation for two different text strings. Do not abbreviate more than necessary. Consult the dictionary for any existing official abbreviations for the words you are shortening (for example, “pmt” for “payment” or “min.” for “minimum”).

As a last-ditch abbreviation strategy, cut off the end of the word and place a period (.) at the end (for example, “Paym.”). Just in case, if you keep the final character, do not use a period at the end (for example, “Paymt”). In ABAP legacy systems, it is common practice to omit vowels, primarily those in unstressed syllables, as in “Paymnt”. However, this often just looks like a typo. So watch out.

For more information about abbreviations in general, see Abbreviations [page 205].

**Exception:** In certain contexts, different conventions may apply, for example, the abbreviations listed in the Global Technical Name Catalog, which are mainly used for core data services (CDS) views. Note that the last-ditch abbreviation strategies come from the dated SAP R/3 Text Guidelines, which applied to SAP GUI screens (see SAP Reference Lists). This doesn't mean that they are wrong or forbidden. It's just that they may be superseded by different conventions.

Only valid for 'Localization': German

**German:** Here are some last-ditch examples of abbreviated German compounds. This pattern is typical for ABAP legacy systems. The abbreviations are not intuitive because of CamelCase (German:

Binnenmajuskel) and omitted vowels. So again, avoid abbreviations. Ok, now to the examples: “Wareneingangsdatum” can be abbreviated to “Wareneingangsdat.”, to “WareneingDatum”, to “WarEingDat.”, or to “WE-Datum”. Similarly, “Mindestbestellmenge” could appear as “MindBestellmenge”, “MindBstllmenge”, or “MindBstMng.”

End of 'Localization': German

**Translation:** Enter the abbreviation in SAPterm. Otherwise it cannot be translated. Do not use single letter abbreviations. They don't work with double-byte languages.

## Front-End and Back-End Issues, Such as Terminology or Punctuation

**Be prepared for inconsistencies. Weigh consistency against user expectations.**

If new, specific front-end applications are developed for an existing, generic back end, there are usually consistency issues with terminology, style or tone of voice, or punctuation. There is no ideal solution. The most important goal is to ensure comprehensibility and avoid confusion. The crucial questions are: Will users notice the issue? Will it affect their work? So inconsistencies in punctuation and style are more permissible than terminology issues.

**If a back-end term differs from the standard business term, find out what would be the natural choice for the front-end users.**

The standard business term is likely to be the natural choice for the front end, especially for new users, who have never worked in the back end. Even if existing users know the back-end term, this is not an exclusive criterion against using the standard business term on the front end. Ask yourself: What is the natural choice? Alternatively, what is comprehensible for the majority of users?

**If texts are drawn from the back end, think about how you can ensure consistency on the front end.**

Natural terminology is one thing. Back-end texts appearing on the front end (typically messages and field labels) are another. What can you do? Make your product team aware of the issue. It's not your problem, it's a central issue for everybody. Team up with translators and user experience designers. Mention that the terminology clash will also result in customer tickets. And this means additional work for everybody.

Find out which technical options your user interface technology (front-end development environment) provides. Can you create new texts in the front end or in the back end? Can you technically make new front-end texts appear instead of an existing back-end texts with a mapping function? If you adapt existing texts in the back end, consider that this might interfere with existing back-end screens and self-contained documents, such as guides. Also, find out how much confusion back-end terms will actually create when they appear on the front end.

### Emoticons and Emojis – Hands Off

**Do not use emoticons or emojis on the user interface.**

**Translation and localization:** Emoticons and emojis are culture specific and therefore hard, if not impossible to translate and localize.

Also, emoticons and emojis do not comply with the tone-of-voice principles on the *SAP Brand* site. For more information, see People-Centric Language and Communication [page 83].

### Related Information

Common User Interface Elements [page 119]
SAP Fiori Design Guidelines

## 4.2 Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level

Software and user interfaces are supposed to be intuitive and self-explanatory. So do not fall for providing stating-the-obvious instructions. Yet sometimes you can't avoid referring to the user interface in one way or another. Here's more about the when and how.

### Basics

**Do not refer to the user interface for its own sake.**

For example, don't just sequentially cram fields, buttons, and other user interface elements of a screen in a procedure. This does not add value. It's simply stating the obvious.

This does not mean that it is forbidden to mention user interface elements or to provide instructions for navigating on the user interface. Just do it consciously and consider the level of detail that's appropriate for the target group and their task.

**If the user interface is not intuitive, do not fix the issue with workaround instructions at click level.**

Instead, try to improve and simplify the user interface. This is the best way to avoid procedural descriptions at all. For more information, see Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111].

**Prefer indirect, device-neutral formulations such as "Confirm the contract." or "Open the `<App Name>`" to direct, click-level instructions.**

Modern applications tend to be multidevice. They are often designed to run on desktops, mobile phones, tablets, and whatever there will be. This implies that the screen layout and user interface elements (including their labels and any text associated with them) may look different. Keep this in mind when referring to the user interface and its elements. Don't get too specific.

Familiarize yourself with the **pros and cons**. The approaches don't necessarily exclude each other. In the same text, there may be mainly indirect formulations and you only resort to click level for tricky aspects. When using click-level formulations, try to be device neutral. For example, use "choose" instead of mouse "click" or mobile "tap". If it is difficult to decide on the formulation approach, consult an editor or a user assistance architect.

## Pros and Cons of Indirect and Direct References

| Criterion | Indirect References to the User Interface as in "Confirm the contract." | Direct References as in "Select the contract and choose/click/tap *Confirm*." |
|---|---|---|
| Pros | It's less text to write, translate, and read.<br><br>Changes on the user interface won't affect texts that contain references to the user interface and their translation. This saves significant time and cost, while ensuring quality.<br><br>Indirect references tend to be device neutral. So they are especially suitable for responsive-design and multidevice applications. | Users can navigate the user interface more easily according to the exact user interface texts that you reference. (But remember: Is this level of detail really needed?) |
| Cons | If the user interface is complicated, your procedural description might be hard to follow. (But remember: This is primarily an indicator that the user interface itself needs to be improved.) | Procedural descriptions might be incorrect and misleading when customers customize their user interfaces and rename field labels or other user interface elements.<br><br>Changing user interface texts means changing and retranslating a large amount of other texts. This is time consuming and expensive. |

| Criterion | Indirect References to the User Interface as in "Confirm the contract." | Direct References as in "Select the contract and choose/click/tap *Confirm*." |
|---|---|---|
| Example | [Note: This example illustrates only indirect references to the user interface. You still have to figure out whether and where this procedural description is needed. For example, does it have to be a topic? Could the steps be transformed into user interface texts and reemerge as titles of steps in a guided procedure?]<br>1. Add products to your shopping cart.<br>2. Go to checkout.<br>3. Enter your address and payment details.<br>4. Place your order.<br>[Note: Here's the most indirect way of referring to the user interface, which you might want to consider if the software is not too complex and the user interface is intuitive. It's a key feature description of an app for tracking a sales pipeline.]<br>**Key Features**<br>• View opportunities by account, employee, or sales organization.<br>• Filter for top opportunities.<br>• Analyze and filter pipeline and target achievement per team.<br>• Display opportunities in weekly, monthly, quarterly, or yearly time periods.<br>• View opportunity details such as account information, primary contact, employee responsible, and their contact information. | [Note: This example illustrates only the click-level writing style. It's not meant to advocate the overwhelming amount of detail.]<br>1. Enter a product name in the *Search* field.<br>2. Choose *Search*.<br>3. Select a product and choose *Add to Cart*.<br>4. Choose *Checkout*.<br>5. Enter your name in the *Name* field.<br>6. Enter your street name in the *Street* field.<br>7. Enter your country/region in the *Country/Region* field.<br>8. Enter your postal code or zip code in the *Postal Code* field.<br>9. Select your payment method using the *Payment Method* radio button. Enter your credit card number in the *Card Number* field.<br>10. Read the terms and conditions and select the *Accept the Terms and Conditions* checkbox.<br>11. To place your order, choose *Buy Now*. |

## Direct, Click-Level References

**If you can't avoid direct, click-level references to the user interface, make sure that the user is oriented.**

Consider mentioning the larger elements on the screen. Tell users what they can do before how they can do it. Refer to texts exactly as they appear on the user interface.

**Translation:** Note that translators do not simply translate direct references to the user interface elements. Rather, translators need to search in a separate translation proposal pool for user interface texts to find the exact match. This is to ensure that users reading the translations won't be confused, for example, by "Shopping Basket" in an instruction while the user interface has "Shopping Cart".

Example

[Note: These examples only illustrate the click-level writing style. They don't advocate this level of detail.]

✔ On the *RFx Response* screen, go to the *Line Items* tab. In the *View* dropdown list, select a view. [Note: From a stating-the-obvious point of view, the second sentence is suspicious. You could at least simplify it to "..., and select a view." The first sentence has a different quality because sometimes you just need to provide this kind of orientation information. However, if your text is full of such instructions, be wary and consider rewriting.]

✔ To remove all scheduled payments, choose *Select All* and then choose *Remove*. [Note: Again, from a stating-the-obvious point of view, this is suspicious. Can you just omit this sentence or at least simplify it to "Select all scheduled payments and remove them."?]

### Incorrect User Interface Texts and How to Refer to Them

| | |
|---|---|
| **If the user interface text has a major defect that massively affects the user experience (for example, incorrect terminology, incomprehensible wording), first try to correct the text on the screen.** | If this can't be done in time for your release (terminology issues are a complicated matter), quote the incorrect text for consistency reasons. Ensure that this issue is added to the backlog of the next release. In the case of incomprehensible wording, however, there's no way out: Fix it now. |
| **If the user interface text has a minor defect (for example, a typo), correct this defect where you quote the user interface text.** | Of course, also correct the text on the screen. To make the meaning of "minor defect" a bit more tangible, consider this: If you correct the defect in your text but not immediately on the user interface, will users still be able to recognize and understand the user interface? If so, then it's a minor defect. |

### Related Information

Common User Interface Elements [page 119]

## 4.3 Common User Interface Elements

Here's a collection of common user interface elements that appear both in desktop and mobile applications. You'll find default standards for formulating user interface texts (field labels, button text, and so on), and for referring to user interface elements in text.

Note

**Out of scope:** This style guide does not cover interaction design, screen design (for example, building blocks or controls), typography (for example, font style, font size, or spacing), localization aspects

(for example, dates, times, or currencies), and technical restrictions (for example, field length). For more information, see the Product Standard for User Experience Consistency and the SAP Fiori Design Guidelines.

## Basics

**Apply the *User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps*.**

These standards are closely connected to the Product Standard for User Experience Consistency. For more information, see the requirement Terminology for Common UI Actions (UXC-015) and the User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*. The corresponding SAPterm component is `SAP-UXC`.

**When referring to user interface elements, set off their labels and titles from body text.**

Example

✔ In the *Delivery Date* field, enter a date that is in the future.

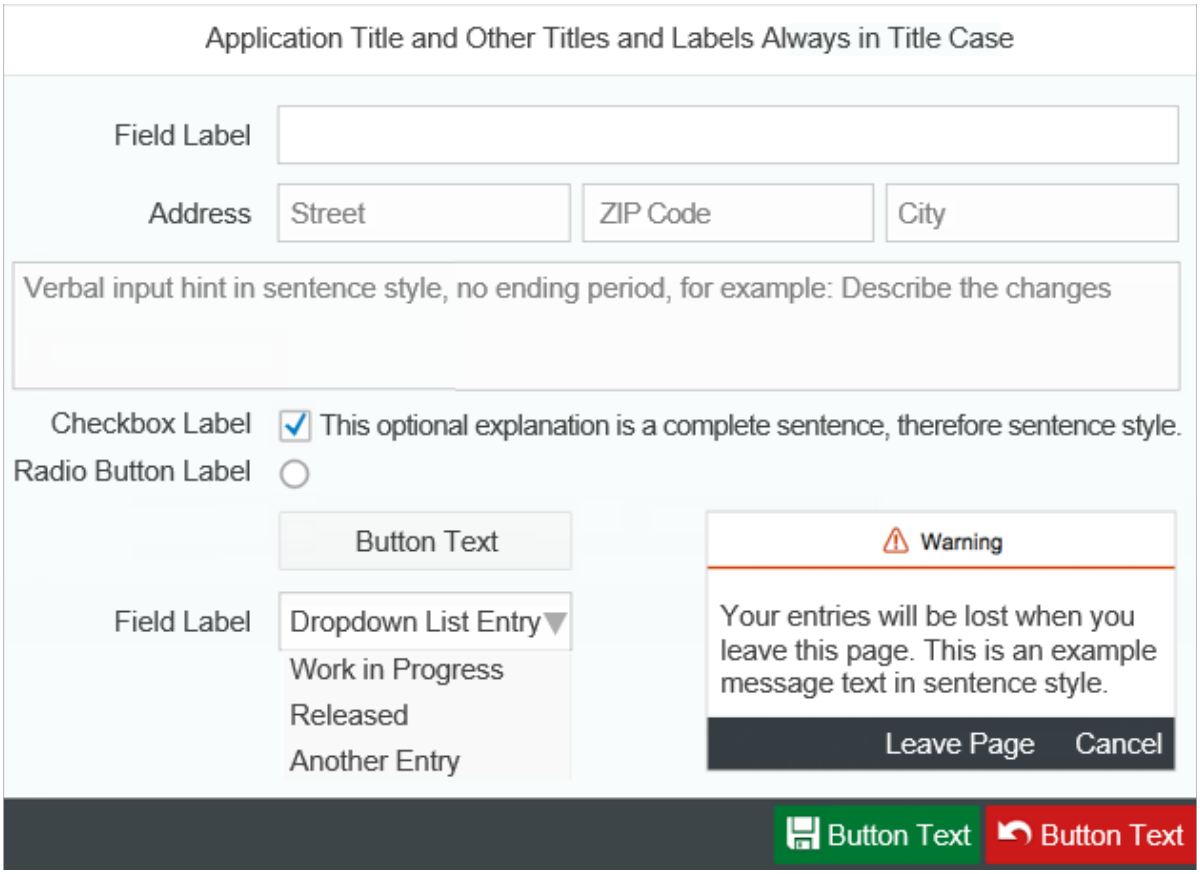
✘ In the delivery date field, enter a date that is in the future.

**Tools:** This style guide is tool agnostic. For information about formatting, see the user guide for your authoring tool. The corresponding formats are typically called `uicontrol`, `menucascade`, and so on.

**Accessibility:** This kind of formatting is a prerequisite for screen readers to detect references to the user interface and pass on this information to people with visual impairments.

Only valid for 'Localization': English

## English: Capitalization on the User Interface




**Use sentence style for any user interface text that consists of one or more complete sentences.**

Texts with one or more sentences are typically used in messages, questions requiring a decision, or if a mere label or title is not sufficient. If the criterion "one or more complete sentences" doesn't work, try the criterion "longer verbal formulation". For example, a tooltip (mouseover) for a field called *Rate Type* might read "Classifies the installation for billing purposes". This is not a complete sentence but it's similar. In other words, the title case version "Classifies the Installation for Billing Purposes" simply looks odd. For more information, see Tooltips (Mouseovers) [page 150].

**Use title case for labels, titles, and similar short texts on the user interface.**

Here are some examples:

- Menu items
- Text on buttons and icons
- Field labels (including checkboxes and radio buttons)
- Predefined entries in dropdown lists and combo boxes (or whatever there might be)
- Titles of screens, tabs, and dialog boxes
- Table titles and their column and row headings

- Any descriptive, translatable name that accompanies a technical name of a software entity (for example, the title of a function module, a report, or a program)

For more information about which parts of speech to capitalize, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199].

**Exception:** Especially with checkboxes, radio buttons, and predefined entries, consider using sentence style if the text is longer. This makes it easier to read. If you decide on sentence style for a certain text type, use it consistently in your context (for example, all subtitles for the cards on an overview page, or all predefined entries in a dropdown list).

End of 'Localization': English

## Screen, Window, Tab, Pane, and Other Grouping Elements

A screen consists of different screen areas. A tab is a navigational pane that groups different sets of information. Tabs are used with other tabs and a user can switch between them. Only one tab can be active at a time. In addition to tabs, there are grouping elements that are set off only by horizontal and vertical bars. They are called “pane”, “panel”, “group box”, or “area”. There are a lot of synonyms with similar meanings for these user interface elements. Therefore, align on the terms to use for your product area or software type. As a general rule, try to use terms that follow the same metaphor. For example, “screen” and “area” go together as do “window” and “pane”.

| Tab, Pane, or Similar on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Tab, Pane, or Similar in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| As short as possible, as long as necessary. Define formulation patterns (for example, nominal or verbal formulation, sequence of words and phrases) for these user interface elements. Test the user interface. | | If you can't avoid a direct, click-level formulation, refer to tabs, panes, and so on by label and descriptor. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]. | |

| Tab, Pane, or Similar on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Tab, Pane, or Similar in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| **English:** title case<br><br>For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199]. | [Note: This is very much product specific.] | **Preposition and descriptor:** See examples, but also consult your style guide or the SAPterm entries for your product area or software type.<br><br>[Note: The nominal and verbal formulations used in the titles are random.]<br><br>on the *Device Management* screen [Note: This is the primary window. Also known as “window”.]<br><br>on the *SAP Easy Access* screen [Note: This applies to the initial application screen of SAP GUI.]<br><br>in the display area, in the search area, in the navigation area [Note: Also known as “... pane” or “... panel”.]<br><br>in the *Meter Reading* group box [Note: Also known as “pane” or “panel”.]<br><br>on the *Meter Reading* tab<br><br>in the *Confirm Meter Reading Results* dialog box [Note: This is a secondary window. Also known as “popup” or “popup window”.]<br><br>You are on the *Meter Reading* tab. [Note: Use sparingly, for example, when it's important to state where a user is.]<br><br>The *Confirm Meter Reading Results* dialog box appears. [Note: Use this interim-step result formulation sparingly, for example, when it's really important to reassure the user.] | |

| Tab, Pane, or Similar on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Tab, Pane, or Similar in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase | [Note: This is very much product specific.] | **Preposition and descriptor:** See examples, but also consult your style guide or the SAPterm entries for your product area or software type.<br>[Note: The nominal and verbal formulations used in the titles are random.]<br>auf dem Bild *Geräteverwaltung* [Note: This is the primary window. Also known as "Fenster".]<br>auf dem Bild *SAP Easy Access* [Note: This applies to the initial application screen of SAP GUI.]<br>im Anzeigebereich, im Suchbereich, im Navigationsbereich<br>im Gruppenrahmen *Ablesung* [Note: Also known as "Bereich".]<br>auf der Registerkarte *Ablesung*<br>im Dialogfenster *Ableseergebnisse bestätigen* [Note: This is a secondary window.]<br>Sie befinden sich auf der Registerkarte *Ablesung*. [Note: Use sparingly, for example, when it's important to state where a user is.]<br>Sie gelangen auf das Dialogfenster *Ableseergebnisse bestätigen*. [Note: Use this interim-step result formulation sparingly, for example, when it's really important to reassure the user.] | |

## Field

A rectangular box in which a user enters data and in which data is displayed.

| Field Label on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Field in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| As short as possible, as long as necessary. Test the user interface. | | If you can't avoid a direct, click-level formulation, refer to the field by label and descriptor. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]. | |

| Field Label on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Field in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| **English:** title case<br><br>For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199]. | Delivery Date<br><br>Meter Reading Type<br><br>Comment | **Preposition:** usually “in”<br><br>**Descriptor:** “field”<br><br>**Verb:** “enter” | In the *Delivery Date* field, enter a date that is in the future. [Note: Consider writing “Enter a future delivery date.”]<br><br>Enter a delivery date. [Note: “In the *Delivery Date* field, enter a delivery date.” is stating the obvious.]<br><br>Enter your user name, password, and the domain **`TEST_40B`**.<br><br>Enter the required data.<br><br>Leave the field empty.<br><br>Enter a comment in the text box. |
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase | Lieferdatum<br><br>Ableseart<br><br>Kommentar | **Preposition:** usually “in”<br><br>**Descriptor:** “Feld”<br><br>**Verb:** “eingeben” | Geben Sie im Feld *Lieferdatum* ein Datum ein, das in der Zukunft liegt. [Note: Consider writing “Geben Sie ein Lieferdatum ein, das in der Zukunft liegt.”]<br><br>Geben Sie ein Lieferdatum ein. [Note: “Geben Sie im Feld *Lieferdatum* ein Lieferdatum ein.” is stating the obvious.]<br><br>Geben Sie Ihren Benutzernamen, das Kennwort und die Domäne **`TEST_40B`** ein.<br><br>Geben Sie die erforderlichen Daten ein.<br><br>Lassen Sie das Feld leer.<br><br>Geben Sie einen Kommentar in das Textfeld ein. |

## Checkbox

A square checkmark element. Checkboxes allow a user to select or deselect one or more options. There are various synonyms for “checkbox”. Therefore, align on the term to use for your product area or software type.

| Checkbox Label on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Checkbox in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| As short as possible, as long as necessary. Test the user interface. | | If you can't avoid a direct, click-level formulation, refer to the checkbox by label and descriptor. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]. | |
| **English:** usually title case<br><br>For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199].<br><br>**Exception:** If a text beside a checkbox consists of one or more complete sentences, use sentence style and appropriate ending punctuation. | Monthly Invoicing<br><br>I accept the SAP License Terms. [Note: This is the exception for complete sentences, that is, sentence style and ending punctuation apply.] | **Descriptor:** "checkbox" (default), but check whether this works for multidevice applications<br><br>**Also known as:** "option", "indicator"<br><br>**Verb:** device neutral "select" and "deselect" | Select the *Monthly Invoicing* checkbox. [Note: Consider writing "Set the contract to monthly invoicing."] |
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase<br><br>**Exception:** If text beside a checkbox consists of one or more complete sentences, use appropriate ending punctuation. | Monatliche Abrechnung<br><br>Ich stimme den SAP-Lizenzbedingungen zu. [Note: This is a complete sentence with ending punctuation.] | **Descriptor:** "Ankreuzfeld" (default), but check whether this works for multidevice applications<br><br>Also known as: "Option", "Kennzeichen"<br><br>**Verb:** device neutral "markieren" and "Markierung aufheben" ("entmarkieren" if space restrictions) | Markieren Sie das Ankreuzfeld *Monatliche Abrechnung*. [Note: Consider writing "Legen Sie für den Vertrag eine monatliche Abrechnung fest." or "Stellen Sie ein, dass der Vertrag monatlich abgerechnet wird."] |

## Radio Button

A round checkmark element. Radio buttons allow a user to select a single option. There are various synonyms for "radio button". Therefore, align on the term to use for your product area or software type.

| Radio Button Label on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Radio Button in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| Use the same default standards as for checkboxes. Only the descriptor is different.<br>Only valid for 'Localization': English<br>**English:** descriptor “radio button” (default), also known as “option” or “option button”<br>End of 'Localization': English<br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br>**German:** descriptor “Auswahlknopf” (default), also known as “Option”<br>End of 'Localization': German | | | |

## Button

A control, usually a small rounded rectangle that a user activates to trigger an action. Common buttons include *Back*, *Cancel*, *Next*, and *Save*.

| Button Text on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Button in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| Verbal formulation. As short as possible, as long as necessary. Align on standard terms for common buttons such as “New” versus “Create”. Test the user interface.<br>**Translation:** Define standard translations for common buttons. | | Do not use an ellipsis (...), an arrow (→), or other characters that indicate that a dialog follows. If you can't avoid a direct, click-level formulation, refer to the button by its label only. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]. | |
| **English:** title case<br>For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199]. | Copy<br>Delete List | **Descriptor:** none, not even “button” or “pushbutton”<br>**Verb:** device neutral “choose” | Choose *Edit*. [Note: Consider writing “Edit `<object>`.”]<br>Choose *Delete List*. [Note: Consider writing “Delete the list”] |
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase | Kopieren<br>Liste löschen | **Descriptor:** none, not even “Drucktaste” or “Schaltfläche”<br>**Verb:** device neutral “wählen” | Wählen Sie *Bearbeiten*. [Note: Consider writing “Bearbeiten Sie `<Objekt>`.”]<br>Wählen Sie *Liste löschen*. [Note: Consider writing “Löschen Sie die Liste”] |

## Menu, Context Menu, and Navigation Path

A list of options from which a user can choose. A menu is either provided in a menu bar at the top of a screen or as a context menu upon user interaction. There are various synonyms with similar meanings for "context menu". Therefore, align on the term to use for your product area or software type.

| Menu Items on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Menu in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| As short as possible, as long as necessary. Align on standard terms for common menu items such as "File" or "Edit". Test the user interface.<br><br>**Translation:** Define standard translations for common menu items. | | Do not use an ellipsis (...), an arrow (→), or other characters that indicate that a dialog follows. If you can't avoid a direct, click-level formulation, refer to a menu by a navigation path. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]. | |
| **English:** title case<br><br>For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199]. | File<br><br>Edit<br><br>Check Plausibility | **Preposition:** usually "in"<br><br>**Descriptor:** none or "menu"; "context menu"<br><br>**Also known as:** "contextual menu", "popup menu", "shortcut menu"<br><br>**Verb:** "choose" | Choose *System* > *User Profile* > *Own Data*.<br><br>In the *System* menu, choose *User Profile* > *Own Data*. [Note: This highlights the name of the menu.]<br><br>In the context menu of the file, choose *Properties*. [Note: Consider writing "Edit the file properties."] |
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase | Datei<br><br>Bearbeiten<br><br>Plausibilität prüfen | **Preposition:** usually "in"<br><br>**Descriptor:** none or "Menü";"Kontextmenü"<br><br>**Also known as:** "Popup-Menü"<br><br>**Verb:** "wählen" | Wählen Sie *System* > *Benutzervorgaben* > *Eigene Daten*.<br><br>Wählen Sie im Menü *System* den Pfad *Benutzervorgaben* > *Eigene Daten*. [Note: This highlights the name of the menu. "den Pfad" is needed to separate menu and menu path.]<br><br>Wählen Sie im Kontextmenü der Datei den Eintrag *Einstellungen*. [Note: "den Eintrag" makes it clear that it's a menu entry and not a file name. Consider writing "Bearbeiten Sie die Dateieigenschaften."] |

## Predefined Entries in a Dropdown List or Combo Box

A dropdown list has predefined entries that a user can select. If it's a combo box, the user can also enter data directly in the field. There are various synonyms with similar meanings for these user interface elements. Therefore, align on the term to use for your product area or software type.

| Dropdown List or Combo Box on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Dropdown List or Combo Box in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| As short as possible, as long as necessary. Test the user interface. | | Try to avoid using descriptors and labels. You can't really predict how predefined entries appear on the user interface, which controls are used, and so on. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116].<br><br>**Preposition, descriptor, and verb:** See examples, but also consult your style guide or the SAPterm entries for your product area or software type. | |
| **English:** title case for labels (field label or any other heading or title associated with the list items) and list items<br><br>For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199].<br><br>If the list items are more sentence-like, consider using sentence style. Do not use title case for abbreviations such as "kg". | [Note: Let's assume the following items are in a dropdown list called *Recurrence Frequency*.]<br><br>Daily<br><br>Weekly<br><br>Monthly<br><br>Yearly | **Descriptor:** If absolutely necessary, use "dropdown list" as a descriptor for dropdown lists. "list" might result in a wrong translation.<br><br>**Also known as:** "combination box", "list box", "dropdown box", "drop-down list box", "list box" | In the *File Name* field, enter a file name, or select a file. [Note: This is a combo box. Consider writing "Specify a file name."]<br><br>On the *Typography* tab, select a font. [Note: It's probably not important to mention that the fonts are in a dropdown list.]<br><br>Select the recurrence frequency. [Note: Consider the more comprehensive "Define the recurrence pattern." There are probably other elements to be defined, such as the week day or start and end time.] |

| Dropdown List or Combo Box on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Dropdown List or Combo Box in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase | [Note: Let's assume the following items are in a dropdown list called *Wiederholungsintervall*. ]<br>Täglich<br>Wöchentlich<br>Monatlich<br>Jährlich | **Descriptor:** If absolutely necessary, use "Auswahlliste" as a descriptor for dropdown lists.<br>**Also known as:** "Aufklappliste" "Dropdown-Box", "Combobox" | Geben Sie im Feld *Dateiname* einen Dateinamen ein, oder wählen Sie eine Datei aus. [Note: This is a combo box. Consider writing "Geben Sie einen Dateinamen ein."]<br>Wählen Sie auf der Registerkarte *Typographie* eine Schrift aus. [Note: It's probably not important to mention that the fonts are in a dropdown list.]<br>Wählen Sie das Wiederholungsintervall aus. [Note: Consider the more comprehensive "Definieren Sie das Wiederholungsmuster." There are probably other elements to be defined, such as the week day or start and end time.] |

## Input Hint

Placeholder text in a field or dropdown list, which tells the user what to do or enter. There are various synonyms for "input hint". The meaning sometimes varies because it can be either the placeholder text in the field or below the field.

| Input Hint on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to an Input Hint in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| If a field or a dropdown list has a **self-descriptive label**, do **not** add an **input hint**. In other words, add an input hint only if there is no label and the input hint is the only cue for the user.<br><br>Use a verbal formulation. Questions or nominal formulations can also be fine. Align on formulation patterns for your product area or software type. Do not use ellipsis (...).<br><br>**Exception:** Do not use an ending period (.) for complete sentences. This is to avoid a mixture of input hints with and without periods on the same screen. A question mark (?) for questions is of course fine. | | Do not quote the input hint in text. Use the input hint itself. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]<br><br>✔ Add notes.<br><br>✘ In the field with the input hint *Add notes*, enter a note. [Note: This is just clumsy.] | |
| **English:** sentence style for verbal formulations, title case for nominal formulations (labels) | Add notes<br><br>Select a status<br><br>What did you change?<br><br>Street \| ZIP Code \| City [Note: The field label is *Address* followed by three fields with these input hints.]<br><br>Full Text Search | **Descriptor:** "input hint"<br><br>**Also known as:** "hint text", "placeholder text", "input prompt" | |
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase | Notizen hinzufügen<br><br>Status auswählen<br><br>Was haben Sie geändert?<br><br>Straße \| Postleitzahl \| Stadt [Note: The field label is *Adresse* followed by three fields with these input hints.]<br><br>Volltextsuche | **Descriptor:** "Eingabehinweis"<br><br>Also known as: "Platzhaltertext", "Eingabeaufforderung" | |

## Slider

An element that lets a user set a value from a continuous range of values.

| Slider on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Slider in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| As short as possible, as long as necessary. Test the user interface. | | If you can't avoid a direct, click-level formulation, refer to the slider by label and descriptor. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]. | |
| **English:** usually title case<br>For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199]. | Color Saturation<br>Volume<br>Speed | **Descriptor:** "slider" (default), but check whether this works for multi-device applications<br>**Verb:** device neutral "move" or "use" | Move the slider back to the original position.<br>To change the color saturation, use the *Percentage* slider. [Note: Consider writing "Change the color saturation."] |
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase | Farbsättigung<br>Lautstärke<br>Geschwindigkeit | **Descriptor:** "Schieberegler" (default), but check whether this works for multidevice applications<br>**Verb:** device neutral "ziehen" and "verwenden" | Ziehen Sie den Schieberegler auf die ursprüngliche Position zurück.<br>Um die Farbsättigung zu ändern, verwenden Sie den Schieberegler *Prozent*. [Note: Consider writing "Ändern Sie die Farbsättigung."] |

## GUI Icon

A graphical element that represents an object, action, or status.

| Icon and Tooltip on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a GUI Icon in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Tools:** This style guide is tool agnostic. For information about GUI icons, see the user guide for your authoring tool and the user interface guidelines for your product area or software type.<br>For more information about tooltips (mouseover), which are mandatory for GUI icons, see Tooltips (Mouseovers) [page 150]. | | If you can't avoid a direct, click-level formulation, use the GUI icon and add the tooltip. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]. | |
| | | **English:**<br>**Descriptor:** usually none<br>**Verb:** device neutral "choose" | Choose (*Send*). [Note: Consider writing "Send the email."] |
| | | **German:**<br>**Descriptor:** usually none<br>**Verb:** device neutral "wählen" | Wählen Sie (*Senden*). [Note: Consider writing "Senden Sie die E-Mail."] |

## Navigation Link (on a Screen, Not in a Topic)

Sometimes navigation links are used instead of buttons, icons, or menus.

| Navigation Link on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Navigation Link in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| As short as possible, as long as necessary. Test the user interface. | | If you can't avoid a direct, click-level formulation, refer to the navigation link by its link text. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]. | |
| **English:** title case<br><br>For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199]. | Edit | **Descriptor:** None. If absolutely necessary, use "link" as a descriptor.<br><br>**Verb:** "choose" | Choose *Edit*. [Note: Consider writing "Edit the address data."] |
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase | Bearbeiten | **Descriptor:** None. If absolutely necessary, use "Link" as a descriptor.<br><br>**Verb:** "wählen" | Wählen Sie *Bearbeiten*. [Note: Consider writing "Bearbeiten Sie die Adressdaten."] |

## Tree, Hierarchy, Structure, and Other Expandable Elements on a Screen

A hierarchical view of items that a user can expand and collapse. There are a lot of synonyms with similar meanings as well as different controls (plus and minus sign, triangles) for these user interface elements. Therefore, align on the terms to use for your product area or software type.

| Tree, Hierarchy, or Similar on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Tree, Hierarchy, or Similar in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| As short as possible, as long as necessary. Test the user interface. | | If you can't avoid a direct, click-level formulation, you can refer to the expandable elements with generic terms such as "hierarchy" and "node" or with specific terms such as "user settings". For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116]. | |

| Tree, Hierarchy, or Similar on the User Interface | ✔ Example on the User Interface | Referring to a Tree, Hierarchy, or Similar in Text | ✔ Example in Text |
|---|---|---|---|
| **English:** title case<br><br>For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199]. | Show More<br><br>Show Less | **Descriptor:** See *Also known as*, but also consult your style guide or the SAPterm entries for your product area or software type.<br><br>**Also known as:** “tree”, “structure”, “hierarchy”, “node”, “element”, you name it<br><br>**Verb:** “expand” and “collapse”, or whatever is used on the user interface | Expand the structure. [Note: Instead of “structure”, you might as well use another term.]<br><br>Expand *User Settings*.<br><br>Collapse *User Settings*.<br><br>Expand *User Settings* and choose *Editor* > *Fonts*. |
| **German:** first letter of first word in uppercase | Mehr anzeigen<br><br>Weniger anzeigen | **Descriptor:** See *Also known as*, but also consult your style guide or the SAPterm entries for your product area or software type.<br><br>**Also known as:** “Baum”, “Struktur”, “Hierarchie”, “Knoten”, “Element”, you name it<br><br>**Verb:** “aufklappen” and “zuklappen”, or whatever is used on the user interface | Klappen Sie die Struktur auf. [Note: Instead of “Struktur”, you might as well use another term.]<br><br>Klappen Sie *Benutzereinstellungen* auf.<br><br>Klappen Sie *Benutzereinstellungen* zu.<br><br>Expandieren Sie *Benutzereinstellungen*, und wählen Sie *Editor* > *Schriften*. |

## Related Information

Formulation Patterns for Message Texts [page 140]

## 4.4 Message Texts and Content Pattern

Messages serve to reassure users or to help them solve errors and other difficult situations. So they must be helpful and easy to understand. Tone of voice is important, too. Don't blame the user. How can you achieve this?

### Basics

**Consider message type and target group. Provide the appropriate level of complexity and detail in a friendly, supportive tone of voice.**

Messages can be success or information messages that reassure users about normal processing, or they can deal with errors and warnings. Information and success messages tend to be brief and self-explanatory. Errors, warnings, and sometimes also confirmation prompts require additional information in terms of diagnosis, cause, and solution. Nontechnical or casual users may need longer explanations than technical or experienced target groups. For more information about the SAP-wide target groups, see Communicating with Your Audience: Who Are Your Target Groups? [page 65].

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ This code has expired. Please enter another code. [Note: You can use "please" but you don't have to. For more information, see Politeness [page 95].]
>
> ✘ !! Error 678!! Invalid data [Note: The exclamation marks scream at the user that something terrible has happened, but the message text doesn't say what it is.]
>
> ✔ Enter a 5-digit ZIP code.
>
> ✘ You entered a ZIP code of the wrong length.

**Recreate the message situation, or ask the developer to do so while you watch.**

This gives you vital information for writing the message. In some cases, the developer may need to provide more messages, which are more specific, instead. Alternatively, it may turn out that the interaction design needs to be changed and another or no message at all is needed. Anyway, it never hurts to consult a user experience designer.

**Translation and globalization: To avoid translation issues later on, keep an eye on variables in messages.**

Remember this example as a **pattern**:

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Add device `<variable 1 (number, ID, ...)>` to group `<variable 2 (name, ID, ...)>`.

> ✖ Add `<variable (translatable word)>` to `<variable (translatable word)>`.

The pattern ensures correct word order and verb/noun/adjective agreement in the target languages:

- The variables are **uniquely addressed**. The conventions depend on the development environment. For example, this could be a number as in `&1` or `{0}` in property files.
- The variables are **placeholders for untranslatable text strings** such as object IDs or names, values, or technical names. They must not contain translatable words (nouns, verbs, adjectives) or sentence fragments.

For more information, see Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160].

## Punctuation

**Use ending periods (.) for complete sentences. Do not join sentences with semicolons (;).**

For more information, see Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157].

**Exception:** If message short texts in ABAP systems (transaction in SE91 and SE61) are displayed **only in SAP GUI**, you can stick to the traditional pattern of joining two sentences with a semicolon (;) and omitting the ending period (.). For more information about front-end and back-end issues, see Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111].

## Content Pattern for Messages

**Familiarize yourself with the message interaction design for your product area or software type.**

This will give you vital background information. Ask a user experience designer how the different types of messages appear in the software.

Here are some **typical questions**: Where do messages appear on the screen? Next to a user interface element, in the status bar, in a dialog box, in a log, and so on? Are the different messages types set off, for example, with icons? How intrusive are the different message types? Which messages disappear on their own? Which messages interrupt the user and how? Are there formulation patterns?

For more information, see Message Handling and Messages in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*. These guidelines are also helpful if your software is not part of SAP Fiori.

**With a user experience designer, align on message**

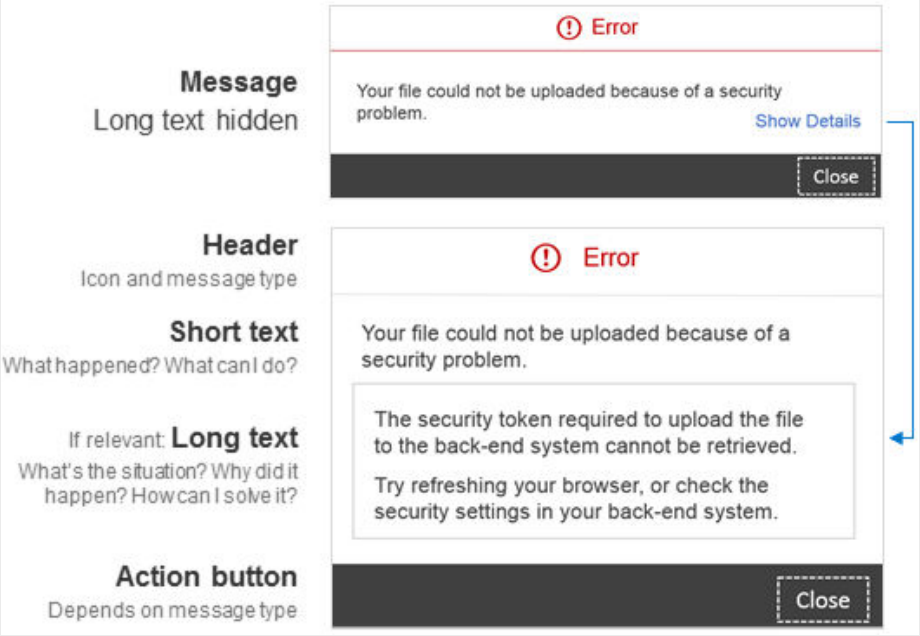
The content pattern for messages outlines the different elements of a message and helps you get started with your own guidelines.

**guidelines for your product area or software type.**

**Tools:** This style guide is tool agnostic. It depends on your development environment, user interface technology, and authoring tools how you create message information and how it is presented to the user later on.

### Example

This is an example of an SAP Fiori message box. It consists of message header (including icon and message type), short text, long text, and action button. By the way, a message box is just one way of displaying messages. Other types are message pages, message popovers for multiple messages, and message toasts for success messages.




**Follow this content pattern for messages.**

| Element | Things to Consider |
|---|---|
| Message header (if relevant) | Are you going to set off your message types with icons and the message type? If so, consider the following pattern:<br>• **Success** message – use a green checkmark icon followed by the word "Success" (of course, without quotation marks).<br>• **Information** message – use a blue information "i" icon followed by "Information".<br>• **Error** message – use a red exclamation point icon followed by "Error".<br>• **Warnings** about unwanted consequences – use a yellow exclamation point icon followed by "Warning".<br>**Exception:** Warnings about data loss and similarly severe consequences get the red exclamation point icon for errors.<br>• **Confirmation prompts** (decision questions) – use a blue question mark icon followed by "`<Action>`" as in "Reject" or "Resume Editing". |

| Element | Things to Consider | |
|---|---|---|
| Message identifier (if relevant) | Mention it in the short or long text when things get very technical.<br><br>The message identifier is a unique alphanumeric ID that is assigned in the development environment. It helps technical target groups such as developers, system administrators, or technical support search for messages in logs, code, error or troubleshooting guides, and elsewhere. | |
| Message short text | **What** happened? What's the problem? Describe it in one or two short sentences. In simple, straightforward cases, it is often sufficient to give direct instructions as in "Enter a future delivery date." instead of "Delivery date is in the past." In other cases such as errors and warnings, the user is in a difficult situation and needs a message long text with additional information and instructions. | |
| Message long text (if relevant) | Diagnosis: **What**'s the situation? Expand on the message short text. Do not copy it.<br><br>Cause: **Why** did this happen? What caused the message to appear? What did the user do? What happened in the software?<br><br>Solution or instructions: **How** can the user solve the problem? How can the user prevent this happening again? What is the effect of a particular choice of action by the user? How can the user cancel or correct an action before the software responds with unwanted consequences such as data loss? | **Multiple target groups of a message:**<br><br>Does a superuser or a technical target group need to take over? If so, instruct the user to seek help. What information does the user need to provide to the technical target group?<br><br>Alternatively, provide information for both target groups in the same message. Make clear what is relevant for whom. For example, you could provide the information for the technical target group under a separate keyblock or heading |

| Element | Things to Consider |
| --- | --- |
| Action buttons (if relevant) | Is the user interrupted by the message and expected to take a decision? If so, consider the following pattern:<br>• **Success** and **information** – use a single *OK* button. All the user can do is to acknowledge the information.<br>• **Errors** – use a single *Close* button. The user has to leave the message and correct the error in the software before proceeding.<br>• **Warnings** and **confirmation prompts** (decision questions) – use one or more `<Action>` buttons (for example, *Leave Page*) followed by a *Cancel* button. The user can decide whether to proceed or to go back and correct things in the software.<br>Note that users often scan messages and rather pay attention to the action buttons. So *Yes* and *No* buttons are not helpful and possibly dangerous because they are not self-descriptive. If the decision isn't critical, or the action is too long to write out on a button, you can use an *OK* and a *Cancel* button. Timeout warnings such as "Auction will close in 30 min." obviously require only an *OK* button. |

## Example

[Note: These are examples of message short texts.]

✔ Purchase order created [Note: This is a self-explanatory information message. It's an incomplete sentence, therefore no ending period (.).]

✘ An error occurred. [or:] Invalid input [Note: Such generic error messages are not helpful. It's stating the obvious. You don't know what happened and how you can get out of this situation.]

✔ Cannot post the document. The status record is incomplete. [Note: This error message probably needs a long text with additional information.

Only valid for 'Localization': English

**English:** [Note: For more information about "cannot", see English: Contractions [page 93].]

End of 'Localization': English

✔ Enter a future delivery date. [Note: This is one of the simple, straightforward cases where it is sufficient to describe the solution. No need to precede it with the redundant diagnosis "You have entered a delivery date in the past."]

✔ Enter alphanumeric characters only.

✘ Don't enter special characters. [Note: Use positive formulations instead. Users need to know what they can do.]

✔ Enter a material. [Note: Make it simple. The front end highlights the area where the user needs to make the entry.]

❌ In the *Material* field, enter a material. [Note: This is stating the obvious.]

✔ Enter the company code. [Note: This is a clear instruction, as opposed to the BUKRS example.]

❌ The BUKRS field is empty. [Note: This is cryptic technical jargon.]

✔ Too many items to be displayed. You can download all items or narrow the list with the advanced search.

❌ Search results exceed max allowed; download all or use adv search

### Related Information

English: No Plurals with “(s)” or “/s” [page 229]
Tone of Voice and Writing Style (SAP Brand) [page 81]
People-Centric Language and Communication [page 83]

## 4.5 Formulation Patterns for Message Texts

The formulation patterns cover common situations that require messages. They help you find formulations that are appropriate for your type of software and target group.

### Basics

**Use or adapt the message example that works best in your case.**

The formulation patterns for message texts are for your inspiration. They are not meant to be absolute standards. The actual formulations depend on the type of software, the target group, the frequency of the message situation (occasional versus frequent task), and in many cases also on space restrictions. Consider deriving your own set of formulations that are suited to your product area or software type.

For even more inspiration: In the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*, there is an extensive section on messaging, which also contains message text examples. For more information, see:

- UI Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori and then *Guidelines for Specific Floorplans and UI Elements* > *Messages* and possibly Situation Handling Framework – UI Text Guidelines
- Explore SAP Fiori and then *UI Elements* > *Messaging*

**Make your messages sound friendly and instructive.**

This starts with little things such as using articles and complete sentences. A **telegraphic style** tends to make messages **sound abrupt**, especially if you're dealing with casual users or if the task and message situation occur rarely or are complex. On

the other hand, telegraphic style can sometimes be efficient for expert target groups, who just need a hint, or if the message appears frequently or simply serves to reassure the user. And admittedly, telegraphic style can be your last resort if there are severe space restrictions and reformulations don't work. One word about the use of “please”: It can help make a message sound friendly but it's not the magic word. For more information, see Politeness [page 95].

> **Example**
>
> ✔ The file cannot be opened. Please check your network settings. [Note: This message is targeted at an end user.]
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> **English:** [Note: For more information about “cannot”, see English: Contractions [page 93].]
>
> End of 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ Error opening the file. See log. [Note: This message could be targeted at savvy developer target group when they need to look up things in a log all the time.]
>
> ✔ Contract created [Note: This message reassures the user. When you create an object in the software and save it, you expect this to work.]

**Check whether the message short text is self-explanatory.**

If so, you're done. If not, provide a message long text with additional information as outlined in the **content pattern for message texts**. For more information, see Message Texts and Content Pattern [page 135].

## Success and Information Messages

You want to reassure the user about normal processing. The user is to acknowledge information that isn't critical and doesn't involve a decision. Such messages are intrinsically self-explanatory. A message short text is usually sufficient. Do not add redundant words such as “successfully”. Add auxiliary verbs such as “was” as appropriate for target group and situation.

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
|---|---|
| **English:** `<Object> <past participle>` or another statement of reassurance | Contract created<br>Your user was created. Please enter your personal data.<br>The project `<variable 1>` was created and assigned to the team `<variable 2>`.<br>Your booking will be reserved for 24 hours. |

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
|---|---|
| **German:** `<Objekt>` `<Partizip Perfekt>` or another statement of reassurance | Vertrag angelegt<br>Ihr Benutzer wurde angelegt. Geben Sie nun Ihre persönlichen Daten ein.<br>Das Projekt `<Variable 1>` ist angelegt und wurde Team `<Variable 2>` zugeordnet.<br>Ihre Buchung wird 24 Stunden reserviert. |

## Required Field

If a value for a required field is missing, use the standard formulation:

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
|---|---|
| **English:** `<Field Label>` is a required field (*). | *Telephone number* is a required field (*). |
| **German:** `<Feldbezeichner>` ist ein Mussfeld (*). | *Telefonnummer* ist ein Mussfeld (*). |

## Technical or Business Errors

Nobody likes errors at the best of times. The user can't continue with their work and has to correct things in the software. So do not just describe the problem. Help the user solve it, and make the message sound friendly. For more information, see Politeness [page 95]. Error messages usually require a long text with additional information. Technical information, such as message identifiers (also called “error codes”) or logs, is also helpful.

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
|---|---|
| `<Error diagnosis>`. `<Instruction or solution>`. | Error during initialization. See log.[Note: Remember that this may sound abrupt.]<br>Your file could not be uploaded because of a security problem. [Note: Here starts the long text.] The security token required to upload the file to the back-end system can't be retrieved. Try refreshing your browser, or ask technical support to check the security settings in your back-end system. |

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
|---|---|
| **English:** A technical error occurred (`<preferably with message identifier>`). Create a support case.<br>[Or:] ..., contact `<technical target group>`. | A technical error occurred (`XY123`). Create a support case.<br>A technical error occurred (`XY123`). Create a support case in component `XX-YY-ZZ`. [Note: You don't need to mention the component because there's an automated matching. But if you want it to be a specific component, mention it.]<br>A technical error occurred (`XY123`). Contact technical support. [Note: "technical support" is just an example of a technical target group.]<br>We're sorry. A technical error occurred (`XY123`). Please contact technical support for assistance. |
| **German:** Ein technischer Fehler ist aufgetreten (`<möglichst mit Meldungs-ID>`). Legen Sie eine Supportmeldung an.<br>[Or:] ..., wenden Sie sich an `<technische Zielgruppe>`. | Ein technischer Fehler ist aufgetreten (`XY123`). Legen Sie eine Supportmeldung an.<br>Ein technischer Fehler ist aufgetreten (`XY123`). Legen Sie eine Supportmeldung in der Komponente `XX-YY-ZZ` an. [Note: Note: You don't need to mention the component because there's an automated matching. But if you want it to be a specific component, mention it.]<br>Ein technischer Fehler ist aufgetreten (`XY123`). Wenden Sie sich an den technischen Support. [Note: "technischer Support" is just an example of a technical target group.]<br>Leider ist ein technischer Fehler aufgetreten (`XY123`). Bitte wenden Sie sich an den technischen Support. |

## Technical Target Group Needs to Take Over

Sometimes the user can take initial steps to resolve an issue. If this does not help, a technical target group or even SAP needs to take over.

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
|---|---|
| **English:** Contact `<technical target group>`. | Contact your super user.<br>Contact your system administrator. [Note: Provided there is one. Depends on the software type.]<br>Contact your company's internal support team. [Note: Use if you don't know who the user is supposed to contact in the company.]<br>Contact technical support. [Note: Very neutral. Use if you can't predict who exactly can help.]<br>Contact the help desk. [Note: Very neutral. Use if you can't predict who exactly can help. Sounds friendlier than "technical support".]<br>Contact SAP. [Note: Use if only SAP can take over.] |

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| **German:** Wenden Sie sich an `<technische Zielgruppe>`. | Wenden Sie sich an Ihren Superuser.<br>Wenden Sie sich an Ihre Systemadministration. [Note: Provided there is one. Depends on the software type.]<br>Wenden Sie sich an den internen Support Ihrer Firma. [Note: Use if you don't know who the user is supposed to contact in the company.]<br>Wenden Sie sich an den technischen Support. [Note: Very neutral. Use if you can't predict who exactly can help.]<br>Wenden Sie sich an den Helpdesk. [Note: Very neutral. Use if you can't predict who exactly can help. Sounds friendlier than "technischer Support".]<br>Wenden Sie sich an SAP. [Note: Use if only SAP can take over.] |

## Decisions in Confirmation Prompts and Warnings

Decisions are complemented with action buttons that indicate the decision options. Make sure that the buttons clearly indicate what will happen. Users often scan the message and focus only on the action buttons.

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| **English:** "do you want to?", "are you sure that", or a similar formulation | Unsaved data will be lost. Do you want to save? [Note: The action buttons could be *Save*, *Don't Save*, and *Cancel*.]<br>Your entries will be lost when you leave this page. [Note: The actions buttons could be *Leave Page* and *Cancel*.]<br>Are you sure that you want to delete the purchase order `<variable 1>`? [Note: The action buttons could be *Delete* and *Cancel*.]<br>Approve leave request? [Note: This formulation pattern is especially suited to messages that appear frequently because it's easy to scan. The action buttons could be *Approve*, *Reject*, and *Cancel*.]<br>The quantity that you have reported exceeds the quantity planned. [Note: If the decision isn't critical, formulate the message as a statement and use the action buttons *OK* and *Cancel*.] |

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| **German:** “möchten Sie?”, “möchten Sie wirklich?”, or a similar formulation | Ungesicherte Daten gehen verloren. Möchten Sie sichern? [Note: The action buttons could be *Sichern*, *Nicht sichern*, and *Abbrechen*.]<br><br>Ihre Eingaben gehen verloren, wenn Sie die Seite verlassen. [Note: The actions buttons could be *Seite verlassen* and *Abbrechen*.]<br><br>Möchten Sie die Bestellung `<variable 1>` wirklich löschen? [Note: The action buttons could be *Löschen* and *Abbrechen*.]<br><br>Urlaubsantrag genehmigen? [Note: This formulation pattern is especially suited to messages that appear frequently because it's easy to scan. The action buttons could be *Genehmigen*, *Ablehnen*, and *Abbrechen*.]<br><br>Die zurückgemeldete Menge übersteigt die geplante Menge. [Note: If the decision isn't critical, formulate the message as a statement and use the action buttons are *OK* and *Abbrechen*.] |

## Busy Dialogs or Progress Bars

The busy dialog and an animated graphic, such as a progress bar, inform the user about an ongoing operation. During the operation the screen is blocked.

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| `<Something is happening in the software>` | Loading...<br><br>Processing...<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br><br>**German:** The “ing” form has no default equivalent. You can try the passive voice “Daten werden geladen...” or a paraphrase “Verarbeitung läuft...”. If there are space restrictions, resort to the infinitive as in “Laden...”.<br><br>End of 'Localization': German<br><br>Updates are being installed. Please wait until the data is loaded. |

## Inability to Perform Action

Nominal formulations such as “deletion not possible” sound clumsy or stilted. Prefer verbal “could not be deleted” or “You cannot delete” instead.

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| `<Action not possible>`. `<Cause or solution>`. | You cannot create a new step. Release the source process first.<br>You cannot reset the meter. Meter `<variable 1>` is in sample lot `<variable 2>`.<br>[Note: In the following examples, "You cannot" would sound odd because the focus is more on what the software cannot accomplish.]<br>The email could not be sent. Enter a password for outgoing emails.<br>Cannot display revision status. The period is already completed.<br>Only valid for 'Localization': English<br>**English:** [Note: For more information about "cannot", see English: Contractions [page 93].]<br>End of 'Localization': English<br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br>**German:** "cannot display" has the default equivalent "kann nicht angezeigt werden."<br>End of 'Localization': German |

## Authorization Problems

This is similar to the type *Inability to Perform Action*. The action is not possible because it is not permitted due to missing authorizations or incompatible status issues. "authorization/authorized" versus "permitted/permission" or similar – find out which terminology is used for your product area or software type.

> ⓘ Note
>
> Familiarize yourself with the requirement *Secure Authorization Concept* (SEC-248) of the Product Standard for Security. The relevant sections for formulating message texts are *What to Tell the User* and *What Not to Tell the User*. This requirement is motivated by regulatory compliance for access control (for example, SOX, GAAP, FDA, data protection) and is based on the principles of segregation of duties and least privilege. For more information, see Secure Authorization Concept (SEC-248).
>
> The gist of SEC-248 is:
>
> - Message texts are integral elements of a secure authorization concept. But text can't make up for weaknesses in the authorization concept implemented by developers, for example, if there should rather be two different messages instead of one.
> - Let's distinguish between the following scenarios:
>   - The **user has already accessed an object** and knows that it exists and what it contains. However, as per authorization check, a certain action is not allowed. The recommended message to be displayed to the user is "Not authorized" or "Access denied". Keep it short. Do **not** disclose information that could be used by an attacker, such as "wrong path" or "`<role>` role required". If the same message appears in a dump message, a log, or other contexts that can only be accessed by administrators or other users with wide-ranging technical authorizations, it often makes sense to provide such information.
>   - The **user does not know that an object exists** and searches for it. But sometimes the user must not know that this object exists because this is **business-critical or sensitive information**. By

playing around with search criteria, the user could find out by interpreting the message text that there's an important new customer contract or a credit card number. So it's better to provide a neutral message along the lines of "No item matches your search" instead of "You're not authorized to open `<object>`."

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
|---|---|
| `<Action not permitted>`. `<Cause or solution>`. | Not authorized<br><br>Access denied<br><br>No change authorization. Contact `<technical target group>`.<br><br>You are not authorized to change contracts. Contact `<technical target group>`.<br><br>You cannot change the contract because you do not have permission. Contact `<technical target group>`.<br><br>You cannot change the document. Documents with more than `<variable 1 (number of pages)>` pages can only be changed by the editor in chief. [Note: This invented message text is harmless. But if you replace "document" and "editor in chief" with "contract" and "primary account owner", things are different. This is very likely business-critical information.]<br><br>The contract cannot be changed. The bidder `<variable 1>` does not have the `<variable 2>` role. [Note: This kind of authorization message can be ok in a log or a dump message. Verify with a security expert.]<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': English<br><br>**English:** [Note: For more information about "cannot", see English: Contractions [page 93].]<br><br>End of 'Localization': English<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br><br>**German:** "not authorized to" has the default equivalent "keine Berechtigung haben".<br><br>End of 'Localization': German |

## Existence and Availability of Objects

Note the difference between objects that don't exist (at all) and objects that are not available for a particular reason. If appropriate, give the reason or provide instructions.

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| `<Already exists>` | You cannot create a new customer quote. The customer quote `<variable 1>` already exists for the buyer `<variable 2>`.<br><br>For the period `<variable 1>`, the customer quote `<variable 2>` already exists. You cannot create a new one.<br><br>You cannot create a new customer quote for the period `<variable 1>`, as one already exists.<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': English<br><br>**English:** [Note: For more information about "cannot", see English: Contractions [page 93].]<br><br>End of 'Localization': English<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br><br>**German:** "already exists" has the default equivalent "ist bereits vorhanden".<br><br>End of 'Localization': German |
| `<Exists more than once>` | The party `<variable 1>` exists more than once.<br><br>There's a duplicate for the party `<variable 1>`. Compare them and remove the one you do not need.<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br><br>**German:** "exists more than once" has the default equivalent "ist mehrfach vorhanden".<br><br>End of 'Localization': German |
| `<Does not exist>` | The business partner does not exist. It may have been removed or deleted. [Note: Consider the more helpful "Select an existing business partner." instead.]<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br><br>**German:** "does not exist" has the default equivalent "ist nicht vorhanden".<br><br>End of 'Localization': German |
| `<Is not available>` | The seller `<variable 1>` is not available for purchasing unit `<variable 2>`. Select another seller, or assign and activate the seller for the purchasing unit.<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br><br>**German:** "is not available" has the default equivalent "ist nicht verfügbar".<br><br>End of 'Localization': German |

## Invalid or Missing User Entries

Instead of stating what is "not valid" or "not permitted", consider putting it the other way round and using a positive formulation. Focus on what the user can do.

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| `<Invalid user entries>` | Enter a number that is within the external interval `<variable 2>`. [instead of:] Number `<variable 1>` not valid for external interval `<variable 2>`.<br><br>Enter an item value that is less than the limit `<variable 1>` for the purchase order `<variable 2>`. [instead of:] Item value is greater than limit `<variable 1>` of purchase order `<variable 2>`.<br><br>You can add only one buyer. [or:] Remove the other buyers. [instead of:] Only one buyer permitted |
| `<Mandatory entry missing>` | Enter a currency. [or:] Currency is a mandatory field. Enter a currency and resubmit the form.<br><br>[Note: If the empty fields are highlighted on the screen, you can use the following generic formulation.]<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': English<br><br>**English:** Provide the missing information. [or:] Provide the missing information where indicated.<br><br>End of 'Localization': English<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br><br>**German:** Ergänzen Sie die fehlenden Eingaben. [or:] Ergänzen Sie die fehlenden Eingaben an entsprechender Stelle.<br><br>End of 'Localization': German |
| `<Date A needs to be before/after date B>` | Enter a start date that is before the end date. [instead of:] The start date must be before the end date. [or:] Invalid start date<br><br>Enter a publication deadline that is after the draft date. [instead of:] The publication deadline must be after the draft date. [or:] Invalid publication date |

## Search Results

Such messages are intrinsically self-explanatory. A message short text is usually sufficient.

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| `<Too many search results>` | Your search results exceed the maximum number. Narrow down your search.<br><br>Narrow down your search. Try with more or different search terms, or change the filter settings.<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br><br>**German:** “narrow down your search” has the default equivalent “die Suche weiter einschränken”.<br><br>End of 'Localization': German |

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| `<No search results>` | No search results found. Try with fewer or different search terms, or change the filter settings.<br>No item matches your search. Try with different search terms, or include archived contracts.<br>No open documents found for the user `<variable 1>`<br>Only valid for 'Localization': German<br>**German:** “no ... found” has the default equivalent “kein ... gefunden”.<br>End of 'Localization': German |

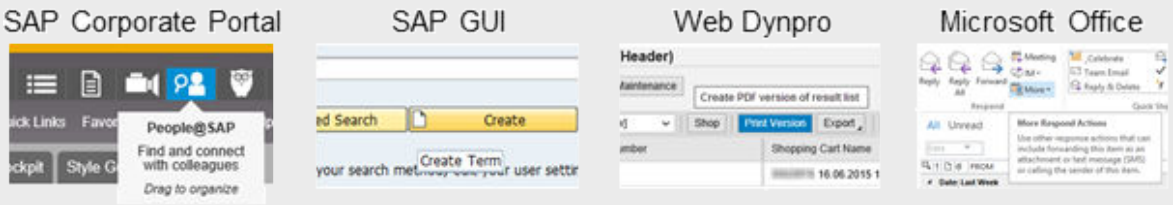
## Related Information

English: No Plurals with “(s)” or “/s” [page 229]
Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157]
Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160]

# 4.6 Tooltips (Mouseovers)

Tooltips appear on mouseover in desktop applications. They **briefly** explain fields, buttons, GUI icons, and other user interface elements. Tooltips also help make screens more accessible because, as text strings, they can be processed by assistive technologies such as screen readers.

> ⓘ Note
>
> **Terminology and usage:** There is no universal terminology or usage, not even a universal technology. Tooltips are also known as “mouseover”, “rollover”, “quick info text”, “quick help”, “balloon help”, or other. Here are some examples:



## Basics

**Tools and user experience: Find out what kind of tooltip is technically used for your type of user interface.**

This style guide is tool agnostic. It depends on your **development environment and user interface technology** how you create tooltips, how they are displayed, what and how much text they contain, and how they relate to other types of embedded help. Familiarize yourself with the concept for embedded help that applies to your type of software. For example, consult the user interface guidelines for your user interface technology. In particular, find out whether your user interface is for desktop only or for multidevice applications. Tooltips only show up on the desktop and are not available to mobile users working on touch devices.

> Example
>
> **Multi device:** SAPUI5 and SAP Fiori mainly rely on SAP Companion as a help viewer (carousel, hot spots, and so on). They consider tooltips as a last resort and advise to use tooltips **only** to show the labels of elements that have no text, such as icons.
>
> **Desktop only:** Web Dynpro has tooltips (for the full form of abbreviations) but there's also quick help (for brief explanations, also as mouseover) and detailed field help (back-end information linked from quick help). SAP GUI has tooltips, field help (F1, technically a data element), and a separate text object for accessibility information.

**Check whether a tooltip is required at all. Have a look at the whole screen.**

You don't have to add tooltips for the sake of doing so. If the label of a user interface element describes the use sufficiently, no tooltip is needed. Alternatively, adapt the label or – especially if a longer explanation is required – provide the information in another type of embedded help.

For example, if the field label *Delivery Date* actually means "Promised Delivery Date", you can either put this information in a tooltip or adapt the field label. This, however, depends on the space restrictions on the screen and whether the field label is reused on other screens. Similarly, think about whether the information that you're about to provide in a tooltip might make sense as permanent text on the screen, for example, in the form of one or two explanatory sentences before a group of fields.

**Formulate the tooltip as short as possible. Do not overload tooltips with information.**

As a general rule, let's say 5–10 words, maybe even 15. Long texts don't look attractive and can be hard to read. The longer the tooltip, the more likely that you need to provide the information elsewhere, especially if the text just continues on to the right creating very long boxes. Again, this depends on the user interface technology and embedded-help concept. Similarly, sometimes tooltips have a delay setting, they disappear after a few seconds of mouseover. So the text needs to be short to give the user a chance to read it.

**Do not manually copy the label of the user interface element as-is to the tooltip.**

This is redundant. Also, the copied text won't change when the label changes. In some environments, the label of the user interface element is automatically generated into the tooltip or the tooltip is used to display the full text of a label that is manually abbreviated. Still redundant, but at least no double maintenance.

## Punctuation and Capitalization

**As a general rule, use an ending period (.) for complete sentences.**

For more information, see Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157].

**English: Use title case if the tooltip is like a label or title.**

Use **sentence style** if the tooltip is a complete sentence or a longer verbal formulation. For more information, see Common User Interface Elements [page 119].

## Content and Formulation Pattern

**Align on a set of tooltip formulations and examples that are suited to your product area or software type.**

You can't really tie this to the type of user interface element. For example, sometimes it will be sufficient to extend the nominal formulation of a field label with another nominal phrase in the tooltip. In other cases, you will think that it's better to use a complete sentence.

Here's a **checklist** of what to decide on:

- Recommended number of words?
- Nominal versus verbal formulations – when does what make sense?
- Complete versus incomplete sentences?
- Use a verb in the imperative (or in some languages: infinitive) versus third-person singular?
- Add keyboard shortcuts in parentheses ( ), as in “Print (CTRL + P)”?

**Accessibility:** Keyboard shortcuts in parentheses ( ) are an accessibility requirement for buttons, GUI icons, and expandable elements such as trees or hierarchies. Similarly, a tooltip that displays a link URL is not helpful. Enter meaningful text instead.

### ✤ Example

✔ Current Start Date [Note: This tooltip explains the *Start Date* field. The tooltip is the longer form of the field label, therefore title case.]

✔ Confirm the classification of the talents [Note: This tooltip explains an *Approve* button. The tooltip text is a longer verbal formulation, therefore sentence style.]

✔ Specifies why a shipment or a shipment item is invalid [Note: This tooltip explains the *Shipping Status* field. It's a longer verbal formulation but not a complete sentence, therefore no ending period. The delivery status is always determined by the software, the user can't enter it. Therefore, a verb in the third person singular (“Specifies”) is more appropriate than an instruction (“Specify”). If the different shipment statuses are self-explanatory, no tooltip is needed at all. A tooltip such as “Status of the Shipment” has no added value.]

✔ Print (Ctrl + P) [Note: This tooltip explains a *Print* button.]

✔ Time compensation if you worked overtime or on a bank holiday [Note: This tooltip explains the predefined entry `Time Off in Lieu` in the *Type of Leave* field.]

✔ Required for the final billing at move-out. If not provided by the customer, the meter reading result is extrapolated from the previous consumption history. [Note: This tooltip explains the *Move-Out Meter Reading* field on a screen for the billing clerk. The incomplete sentence gets an ending period because another sentence follows. Sentence style goes without saying. This tooltip is very long. If this is your only option for providing the information, such a tooltip is fine. If there are other types of embedded help available, rather provide the information in one of these.]

### Related Information

Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157]
Keyboard Keys and Key Combinations (Hotkeys) [page 153]
Common User Interface Elements [page 119]
SAP Fiori Design Guidelines

## 4.7 Keyboard Keys and Key Combinations (Hotkeys)

Keyboard keys and key combinations are click-level formulations used for desktop applications. As such, they have their pros and cons. But they do have their place in accessibility information. They can be interesting for target groups with a need for fast data entry.

### Basics

**As a general rule, do not mention keyboard keys and key combinations.**

This is click-level information and is usually unnecessary. It suffices to say “Scroll down.” instead of “Use the `Page down` key.” or “Press `Page down`.” Similarly, key combinations such as `Ctrl` + `C` or `Ctrl` + `S` are standardized and therefore well known. Also, remember that keyboard keys and key combinations come from the world of desktop applications. They don't go well together with texts for multidevice applications. For more information, see Referring to the User Interface – Beware of Click Level [page 116].

If necessary for clarity, mention the descriptors “key” and “key combination”.

**Exception: When providing accessibility information, however, mention keyboard keys and key combinations.**

For users of keyboard-only navigation, it's important to get a complete picture of the keyboard navigation alternatives. For more information, see Tooltips (Mouseovers) [page 150] and Guidelines for the Documentation of Keyboard Shortcuts.

**Exception: Consider mentioning time-saving keyboard keys and key combinations to target groups with a need for fast data entry.**

Fast data entry is important for technical target groups and professional users. Align on a common approach for your product area or software type. For example, you could mention the keyboard information only at first occurrence in a topic. Another approach could be that you provide a dedicated topic or that you put the keyboard information in a getting-started deliverable. Don't go for completeness. Concentrate on shortcuts for frequent actions that save time.

## Logical Sequence

**Action first, (key) combination after: Describe what before how.**

To make it easier for users to understand what action is performed by a key combination, always describe the action first (what) before listing the key combination (how). For more information on logical sequence, see Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles [page 176].

> Example
>
> ✔ To move the object to the left, press the left arrow key.

## Formatting and Punctuation

**Format the keyboard keys. Use the appropriate separators for key combinations.**

**Tools:** This style guide is tool agnostic. For information about formatting, see the user guide for your authoring tool. The plus sign separator (+) is often inserted automatically for tagged text. If you have to type the plus sign (same applies to the other separator), insert a space before and after the separator.

| Separator | ✔ Correct Example | ✘ Incorrect Example |
|---|---|---|
| A **plus sign (+)** indicates that the keys are pressed simultaneously. | **English:** Press `Ctrl` + `Alt` + `Del`.<br>**German:** Drücken Sie `Strg` + `Alt` + `Entf`. | `Ctrl+ALT+Del` |
| A **comma (,)** indicates that the keys are pressed one after another. | **English:** Press and keep `Ctrl` + `Alt` and then `F`, `O`.<br>**German:**Halten Sie `Strg` + `Alt` gedrückt, und drücken Sie dann `F`, `O`. | `STRG,ALT,F,O` |

## Key Names

| English: Key Name | German: Key Name | What It Does |
|---|---|---|
| `Esc` | `Esc` | Cancels functions |
| `F1` through `F12` | `F1` through `F12` | Carries out various functions |
| `Tab` | `Tab` | Indents paragraphs or jumps from one field to the next |
| `Caps lock` | `Feststelltaste` | Keeps `Shift` on |
| `Shift` | `Umschalt` | Switches to uppercase letters and special symbols |
| `Ctrl` | `Strg` | Gives other keys a new function |
| `Alt` | `Alt` | Gives other keys a new function |
| `Alt Gr` | `Alt Gr` | Used for typing special characters |
| `Spacebar` | `Leertaste` | Inserts a space |
| `Backspace` | `Rücktaste` | Deletes the character or space to the left of the cursor |
| `Enter` | `Enter` | Triggers an entered command or creates a new paragraph in the text. Do **not** refer to this key with "Return". |
| `Ins` | `Einfg` | Controls whether new characters are inserted or existing characters are overwritten at the cursor position |
| `Del` | `Entf` | Deletes the character or space to the right of the cursor |
| `Home` | `Pos1` | Places the cursor at the start of the line |
| `End` | `Ende` | Places the cursor at the end of the line |
| `Page up` | `Bild aufwärts` | Scrolls up |
| `Page down` | `Bild abwärts` | Scrolls down |
| `Up arrow` | `Pfeil nach oben` | Moves the cursor upward |
| `Down arrow` | `Pfeil nach unten` | Moves the cursor downward |
| `Left arrow` | `Pfeil nach links` | Moves the cursor to the left |
| `Right arrow` | `Pfeil nach rechts` | Moves the cursor to the right |
| `Num lock` | `Num lock` | Activates the number lock |
| Apple keyboard | | |

| English: Key Name | German: Key Name | What It Does |
|---|---|---|
| `Command` | `Command` | Gives other keys a new function |
| `Option` | `Option` | Gives other keys a new function |
| `Control` | `Control` | Gives other keys a new function |
| `Return` | `Return` | Triggers an entered command or creates a new paragraph in the text. It's Windows equivalent is `Enter`. |

## Hotkeys – Key Combinations Created at Design Time

**At design time, hotkeys look like this: "Save as &Template" or "_Save Document"**

**Translation: Choose the same letter for the hotkey as in the source.**

A hotkey is a key combination that users press at runtime to trigger an action. One of the keys is always a modifier key, such as the `Alt` or `Ctrl` key. Developers typically place an ampersand (&) in front of the hotkey letter. Sometimes they use an underscore (_). For more information, see Hotkeys.

If the letter with the hotkey is not present in the translation, place the hotkey before a different letter. But do not pick a narrow letter, such as "l", because the hotkey will be hard to detect at runtime. Also, do not place the hotkey before a special character. You do not need to validate whether a letter has already been used for a hotkey unless being told.

Example

| ✔ English Source | ✔ German Translation |
|---|---|
| &Save | &Sichern |
| &Contract | &Vertrag |
| Save as &Template | Als &Vorlage sichern |
| Save as Tem&plate<br>[Note: Let's assume that the developer has already used "T" as a hotkey elsewhere.] | Als &Vorlage sichern [Note: There's no "T" in the translation. So just use a different letter. Lowercase "l" is not a good choice because the hotkey would be hard to detect.] |
| Align _Left | _Links ausrichten |

In rare cases, you'll come across hotkeys that consist of a single character, such as `file.mnemonic=F` (for `file.label=File`). If so, ask for product-specific guidelines.

# 4.8 Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface

There are different development environments, user interface technologies, and screen designs. For punctuation marks and special characters, you may have to consider consistency rules, technical restrictions, plus language and localization aspects. For example, did you know that Chinese has two different commas?

## Basics

**Make sure that punctuation marks and special characters (symbols) are used consistently on the user interface.**

If not, follow up with a developer or a user experience designer: What can each of you do to ensure consistency? Remember that the text on the user interface can come from different sources. There are also user experience decisions, such as currency symbol versus the ISO 3-letter code (for example, euro sign "€" versus "EUR"). Therefore, familiarize yourself with the user interface development environment and get involved in product-specific or tool-specific guidelines.

## Punctuation Marks

For more information, see User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*.

| Punctuation Mark | Standard | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|
| Period (.) | Use a period **at the end of a complete sentence** or after an incomplete sentence if a complete one follows.<br><br>**Exception:** Do not use an ending period (.) for input hints. For more information, see Common User Interface Elements [page 119]. | You don't have authorization to view this page.<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': English<br><br>**English:** Enter your user ID. [Note: When the verb is the imperative, the subject "you" is hidden in the verb. But it's still a complete sentence.]<br><br>End of 'Localization': English<br><br>No matching items found. Try with different search criteria. [Note: This is an incomplete sentence followed by a complete sentence.]<br><br>Leave request created [Note: This is an incomplete sentence, therefore no period.] |

| Punctuation Mark | Standard | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|
| Semicolon (;) | Do **not** connect sentences or phrases with a semicolon. Instead use two separate sentences ending with periods.<br><br>Semicolons are not incorrect. They're just a bit old-fashioned on modern user interfaces. | The file cannot be opened. Please check your network settings.<br><br>✘ File cannot be opened; check check network settings<br><br>Only valid for 'Localization': English<br><br>**English:** [Note: For more information about "cannot", see English: Contractions [page 93].]<br><br>End of 'Localization': English |
| Exclamation point (!) | Do **not** use exclamation points on the user interface, especially not at the end of messages. Exclamation points are likely to be perceived as alarming or offensive. This depends on culture and context.<br><br>**Exception:** If you're using a very casual tone of voice for your target group, exclamation points can fit in as expressions of enthusiasm once in a while. But remember less is more. | Enter a future delivery date. [Note: A simple period (.) is sufficient.]<br><br>✘ Incorrect entry! Enter a valid delivery date! [Note: This is just patronizing.]<br><br>Welcome! [Note: This could be a text on a welcome screen or in a welcome email.] |
| Ellipsis (...) | Use ellipsis with text indicating a **busy dialog** and with **menu items** that lead to further selection options. No space between ellipsis and last character.<br><br>Do **not** add ellipsis to input prompt text in empty fields. | Loading... [Note: A busy dialog is also visualized by a rotating busy symbol.]<br><br>Open In... |
| Colon (:) | Align with a user experience designer on the use of colons with **field labels**: Always or never?<br><br>**Just in case:** It may have been decided for your type of user interface to end field labels with colons as in *Delivery Date:*. Ideally, the colon is part of the text string. However, if the colon is added by a user interface control at runtime, ask the user experience designer to ensure for the double-byte languages that the double-byte colon is available. Note that this applies only to natural language text strings. It does not apply to colons used in code or URLs because they are not translated. It doesn't hurt to involve a localization expert. | |
| | As an emergency solution for unavoidable **concatenated or generated texts**, use a colon to separate the phrases syntactically. However, in the first place, get rid of concatenated texts. | Search In: Sales Orders [Note: This ensures that the verb comes at the beginning in all languages and will not be truncated in case of a longer string. Test the screens. This solution may not always work.] |

| Punctuation Mark | Standard | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|
| Slash (/) | If a slash is used as a separator, put a space before and after the slash. Here are typical cases:<br>• A field label precedes two adjacent fields.<br>• A table column header has two labels (because space restrictions don't allow two columns).<br>Note that these cases are different from phrases such as "plan/actual comparison". Here the words "plan/actual" form a unit to modify "comparison". | ZIP Code / City [Note: Imagine this field label to precede the empty fields in an address form.]<br>✘ ZIP Code/City [Note: This suggests that "ZIP" refers to "Code" and "City". But there is no such thing as a "ZIP City".]<br>Customer / Plant [Note: Imagine this to be a table column header.] |

**Translation and localization: Make sure that punctuation marks and special characters are translatable text strings and not hard-coded.**

This enables translators to adapt the complete text string. Punctuation rules and punctuation marks can be surprisingly language-specific with regard to use, typography, and word order. For example, Chinese has two different types of commas, and Chinese speakers are very conscious of this difference. For more information, see Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages [page 160].

## Special Characters or Symbols

**Verify whether the target group is familiar with the special character or symbol.**

On the user interface you always have to deal with space restrictions. So a special character or symbol can be a handy abbreviation. As a general rule, you can use common symbols such as the percentage sign (%). Be careful with technical or mathematical symbols such as the sigma sign (∑), greater and less than signs (> and <), or the equal sign (=). Use them only if they are a widely accepted standard in the business domain.

**Translation and localization:** Symbols can be hard to translate. There may not necessarily be language-specific equivalents in the target languages, especially in the double-byte languages. For example, the number sign (#) is a widely used convention in the United States and Canada but not necessarily elsewhere. Translators need to resort to a text equivalent such as "Number", which will result in space issues on the user interface.

**Be careful with special characters, such as ampersand (&), dollar sign ($), or even quotation marks ("...").**

Some special characters may have a special function in the programming language or environment where the software or the user interface is developed. For example, in ABAP ampersands (&1 or &v1&) are used as variables in messages. So it wouldn't be a good idea to use "&" as shorthand for "and". This is sloppy writing anyway.

**Translation and localization: Remember that the ISO 3-letter code for**

However, this is also partially a user experience decision. For more information, see Currencies [page 216].

currencies is the stable alternative to currency symbols.

### Related Information

Keyboard Keys and Key Combinations (Hotkeys) [page 153]
Periods [page 304]
Colons [page 305]
Semicolons [page 311]
Slashes [page 317]

## 4.9 Developer Checklist: Translatable and Meaningful Screens in All Languages

The user interface is translated into up to 50 target languages. So here are the **dos and don'ts for developers**. User assistance developers and translators can use this checklist as a basis for reviews, product-specific checklists, or developer workshops. **Short link:** `https://url.sap/uadevchecklist`

**What is user interface text?** It ranges from all kinds of labels and titles (for fields, buttons, menus, columns, screens, you name it) and messages (short and long text) to embedded help (such as tooltips or permanent on-screen explanations).

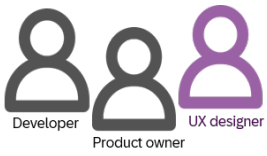
> → Tip
>
> Want to improve your **English writing skills**? Try this: English Writing Program
>
> **How to collaborate with user assistance developers and translators?** Interested in the user assistance portfolio? Try Introduction to User Assistance for Everybody and English Writing Program.

### Involve the User Assistance Colleagues from the Start

**From the planning phase onwards, involve user assistance developers and translators.**

You can rely on their expertise for terminology and comprehensibility. They rely on your subject matter expertise and willingness to ensure translatability. This is especially important for user interface texts (translated into up to 50 target languages).

Here's what user assistance developers and translators do and how they work together with product owners, developers, and user experience designers:




- Involve UA developers early on
- Explain/demo features and screens
- Provide input and feedback
- Invite UA developers to reviews
- Tell them about feature flags



User assistance developer

- Participate in scrum meetings, reviews, customer activities, ...
- Terminology
- UI: create/edit UI texts (UX writing), review mockups, test UIs,
- Embedded help: field help, guided tours, what's new
- Documentation on SAP Help Portal: user/admin/... guides, product pages
- Digital assistants: design dialog flows
- Multimedia: create how-to videos, interactive graphics, ...

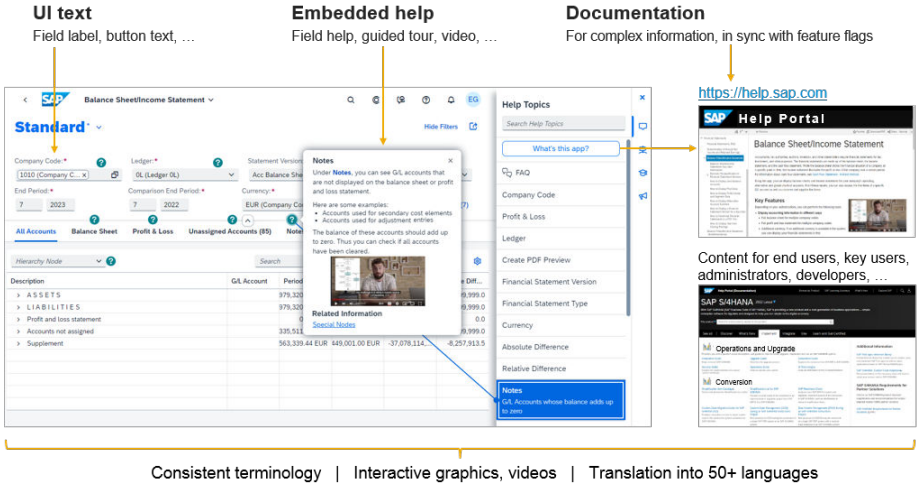


English/German Translator (in-house)

- Participate in scrum meetings, reviews, ...
- Translate terminology and user assistance
- UI: review mockups, test translated UIs
- Language editing (English), translation editing
- Answer translation queries

Translation (50+ languages) is out-sourced. For English/German, some products have in-house translation.

And here's where user assistance developers and translators contribute to the product:




## Technical Translatability

**Ensure that user interface text is technically translatable.**

Here are the **translatability requirements** from the Product Standard for Globalization (see also Translatability Overview):

- Translatability (GLOB-187): For example, no hard-coded text included, context information such as text type available, etc.
- Development Language (GLOB-127): U.S. English
- Fallback Language (GLOB-57): Fallback mechanisms if text is not available in the user's language

## User Interface Text – Basic Dos and Don'ts

| | |
|---|---|
| **Externalize text strings. Do not use hard-coded text.** | Hard-coded text is directly embedded in the source code. Such text won't be translated because it is not detected by translation tools. |
| **Sign in with source language English. Write your text in U.S. English.** | Otherwise, customers will get screens with text in the wrong language, which they find annoying. And you'll have to correct your cases of wrong language usage, which you'll find annoying and time consuming. Translation tools and memories work only if a text with source language English really contains English text.<br><br>**Exception:** A few product teams still use German as a source language. That's fine because they also have translators with target language English. |
| **Use agreed terminology and product names from SAPterm. No synonyms – they cause confusion.** | If you plan to change terminology or formulations for common user interface texts, please contact your user assistance developers and translators upfront.<br><br>**SAPterm:** Open the STM system and call up transaction STERM. Alternatively, try https://url.sap/sapterm-internal or https://www.sapterm.com (public).<br><br>**Product and other approved names:** Go to the Naming Center on the *SAP Brand* site. You can also look them up in SAPterm in the `BV-BRAND-VOICE` component. |
| **For common user actions, use the SAP-wide terminology defined in the Product Standard for User Experience Consistency.** | There's a handy list of verbs for common actions, such as “New” versus “Add” or “Delete” versus “Remove” versus “Discard”. For more information (especially which terms to use), see the requirement Terminology for Common UI Actions (UXC-015) and the related User Interface Text Guidelines for SAP Fiori Apps in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*. |
| **Before mass translation, remove test and dummy text.** | This helps reduce translation costs and time. Also, fewer translation queries for you! |

## User Interface Text – Reviews and Language Editing

> **Note**
>
> User interface text reviews and language editing are crucial for the user experience and the translation process. In other words: It's about time, money, nerves!

| | |
|---|---|
| **When creating or changing user interface text, involve user assistance developers.** | Create user interface text (incl. messages) together, or ask them to review these texts. Invite them to mockup sessions and user interface reviews.<br><br>This way the English source will have a good quality right from the start. Remember there's translation into up to 50 target languages. Advantages for you: You'll get fewer translation queries and customer tickets, and also fewer questions from the user assistance developers when they write the documentation. |

**Ask for language editing.**

If you work together with your user assistance developers on user interface text , there won't be much to do in terms of language editing. Or let's put it like this: User interface text reviews and language editing coincide. Mere language editing focuses on grammar, spelling, typos, and so on – but the text won't necessarily make sense on the screen. So you'd need an additional review step.

Here's how it works:

- **ABAP:** Usual procedure with the system text editor (STE). Keep user assistance developers and translators in the loop.
- **Non-ABAP (property files):** The user assistance developers edit the property files in the source, which is GitHub in most cases. For more information, see Language Editing (Outside the ABAP Environment) community and the Translation Enablement Workbench community.

## Truncated Text, Length Restrictions, and Abbreviations

> **Note**
>
> Truncated and cryptically abbreviated text makes screens unusable, not just in English. Did you know that most target languages need more space than English? So it's important to know how to deal with text length restrictions and space on the user interface. Here's an example of a screen with truncated field labels even though there's lots of white space. Doesn't look inviting.




**Do not set text length restrictions of 1–3 characters.**

They cannot be translated well into double-byte languages, such as Chinese or Japanese.

**Exception:** There can be exceptions. For example, the 1-letter or 2-letter abbreviations of weekdays in the calendar can be translated into double-byte languages because these languages have equivalent short forms.

**Get rid of cryptic, manual abbreviations.**

Abbreviations are difficult or even impossible to understand and translate. Try removing or increasing text length restrictions, adapting the screen areas, or rewording the text.

> Example
>
> ✔ Project Forecast [or:] Forecast
>
> ✘ Proj. Fcst.
>
> ✔ Payment Currency [or:] Currency
>
> ✘ PyC

**Exception:** You can of course use common or industry-standard abbreviations, such as “ID”, “CPU”, “ABAP”, or “VPN”. They are more common than their full forms. This may depend on the target group, though.

**Do something proactive against truncated text, cryptic abbreviations, and hard-coded text.**

Contact Language Experience Lab (LX Lab). They have great tools for you and offer info sessions and onboarding services for all times zones.

Here are some of those helpful tools:

- **User Interface Text Space Calculator**
  This small app helps you prevent truncation issues already at design time. The app calculates the longest translation and tells you the length (in characters, pixels, and “em”s) that works for all 50 target languages. Here's a link to the app: User Interface Text Space Calculator. For more information, see User Interface Text Space Calculator in the *SAP Design Guidelines* or the User Interface Text Space Calculator documentation.
  **Want to see a demo of this tool?** Here's a short video:

- **Pseudotranslation** into the technical language 2Q
  This technique mimicks your target languages on the user interface and highlights problematic areas even before translation starts. It helps you verify that screens will be consumable in all languages. For more information, see the Pseudotranslation documentation.
- **Translation Object Detective** in the technical language 1Q
  You're on a screen and notice that a text needs to be corrected or retranslated. To get this done, you need technical information about this text. By displaying the screen in language 1Q, you'll get the technical name and object type of this text. For more information, see the Translation Object Detective documentation.

**Text string length versus space on the user interface – these are two different things!**

They both cause truncation or force you to use manual abbreviations. Here's what to do:

- **Do you need to restrict the length at all?** If not, don't do so. This applies, for example, to SAPUI5 or Java. By not restricting the length, you save translators from introducing manual abbreviations in the target languages.
  **Exception:** Restrict the length manually **only if** space on the screen is absolutely critical or there is no automatic mechanism for handling longer text.

- If the **string length is restricted** (you have to define it or it is predefined in the system), allow the maximum number of characters for the text type. To determine the recommended length, use this app: User Interface Text Space Calculator
- **Truncated text in other languages?** Even if the text string length is not restricted, the user interface will not automatically look great in every language. You may still need to assign more space to certain screen areas. With pseudotranslation you can find out which screen areas are affected.

## Variables in Messages and Other User Interface Text

**Start with this 2 min video about variables.**

The video visualizes why **not** to use variables for translatable words.

**Do not use variables to represent translatable words (nouns, verbs, adjectives, ...).**

Why? Because this makes text untranslatable. There'll be issues such as incomprehensible sentences with confusing word order or incorrect verb/noun/adjective agreement in the target languages. And for you as a developer, this means lots of translation queries asking you to get rid of these variables-for-translatable-words sentences.

Therefore, stick to this:

- Use variables **only for untranslatable items** such as object IDs, values, or technical names. Again: No variables for translatable words!
- Address the variables uniquely with self-descriptive names or by numbering. This way translators can move each variable to the correct position in the sentence.
  Some programming languages allow developers to define self-descriptive variables like {sender} and {recipient}. The string “from {0} to {1}” is not translatable because {0} and {1} could be people, places, or dates - and each of these might need a different translation for “from” and “to”. The string '“from {sender} to {recipient}” is translatable. If self-descriptive variables are not possible, explain in a comment for translators what's behind the variable.

> ⓘ Note
>
> `<variable>` is a neutral placeholder for notations such as {sender} in I18N property files or `&1` in ABAP.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✖ Do you want to `<variable>` the `<variable>`? [Note: **Untranslatable!** No clue what the variables contain. Also, the English word order and grammatical structure will not work in other languages. For example, many languages rely on inflectional endings. Now to get these endings right, a translator needs to know the complete sentence and its words – which is impossible because the

sentence and the variables are translated independently of each other. Also, in many languages, the translation of the article “the” is likely to result in a messy mix of slashes, such as German “den/die/das” or French “l'/la/le/les”.]

✔ Add device `<variable 1 (here: an ID)>` to group `<variable 2 (here: an ID)>`. [Note: Good! The variables refer to untranslatable items (in this case: IDs) instead of translatable words. The variables are part of the text string and they are preceded by descriptive words.]

✔ Do you want to approve shopping cart `<variable 1 (here: an ID)>`? [Note: Everything fine. Compare it to the incorrect examples.]

✘ Do you want to approve shopping cart ? [Note: The variable is invisible. Looks like it's generated into the text at runtime. Translators can't move it to the right position in the target language.]

**Exception:** In rare cases, you might not be able to avoid a variable with translatable text – for example, if you want to point the user to a Web site. In such a case, separate the variable from all the other words in the sentence. This is the only way to make the sentence translatable for all types of target languages.

#### Example

[Note: `<variable 1>` is the version number. `<variable 2>` is the text “SAP Store” with an underlying URL.]

✔ Download SAP Lumira `<variable 1>` from this site: `<variable 2>`

✘ Download SAP Lumira `<variable 1>` from `<variable 2>`. [Note: Won't work with languages that rely on inflectional endings.]

### Do not concatenate words to form sentences even if it is tempting.

Different languages have a different word order and grammar. In the target languages, concatenated text results in incorrect, incomprehensible, or even nonsensical sentences. The translator doesn't stand a chance of providing a good translation. Users are likely to be annoyed.

#### Example

[Note: Write down complete sentences, without variables.]

✔ Do you want to create the order?

✔ Do you want to change the order?

✔ Do you want to create the contract?

✔ Do you want to change the contract? [and so on]

✘ Do you want to `<variable 1>` `<variable 2>`? [Note: Concatenations with translatable words won't work in the target languages. Remember the thing with different word order and grammar?]

✔ Use method `<variable 1>` to call the document.

✘ Use method `<variable 1 (here: a technical name)>` `<variable 2>` `<variable 3>`. [Note: `<variable 2>` contains "to" and `<variable 3>` "call the document".]

✘ **German translation on the screen:** Verwenden Sie Methode Xyz zu Rufen Sie das Dokument auf. [Correct German: Verwenden Sie Methode Xyz, um das Dokument aufzurufen.]

✘ Use `<variable 1>` `<variable 2>`.

| ✘ Design Time with Concatenations | English at Runtime (Looks Fine But ...) | ✘ Incorrect Czech at Runtime |
|---|---|---|
| ✘ Use `<variable 1>` `<variable 2>`. | Use the preferred airline. | ✘ Použijte preferován**o** letecká link**a**. [Note: Variables are translated without sentence context. Inflectional endings are not correct, that is, the sentence is not correct.]<br><br>✔ Použijte preferovan**ou** leteck**ou** link**u**. [Note: You'll only get this correct Czech sentence if it's translated from a complete English sentence, one without variables for translatable words.] |
| | Use the preferred hotel. | ✘ Použijte preferován**o** hotel.<br><br>✔ Použijte preferovan**ý** hotel. |
| | Use the preferred vendor. | ✘ Použijte preferován**o** dodavatel.<br><br>✔ Použijte preferovan**ého** dodavatel**e**. |

**Be careful with variable in number-noun combinations. Separate number and noun.**

Constructions such as "`<variable>` days" do **not** work in other languages. Plural formation is not as regular as in English, numbers often require specific inflectional endings. For example, English has "1 day, 2 days, 5 days" versus Czech "1 den, 2 dny, 5 dní").

### ✤ Example

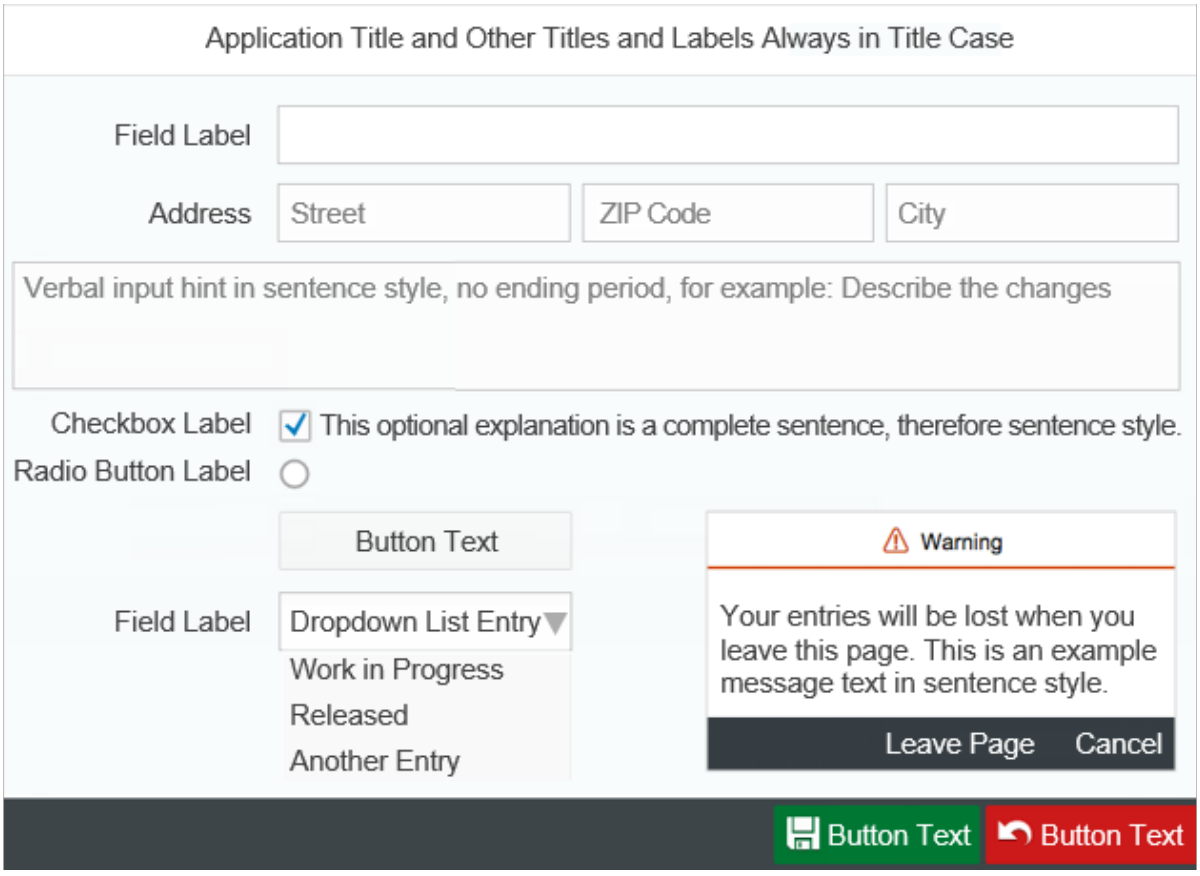
✔ Password expiration in days: `<variable (here: a number)>` [Note: This is the simplest solution to separate number and noun. But sometimes it might not fit in the overall text flow. Consult a localization expert from Language Experience Lab (LX Lab).]

❌ This password expires in `<variable (here: a number)> <variable (here: hours, days, months)>`. [Note: Again, this is untranslatable.]

❌ Password expiration in day(s): `<variable (here: a number)>` [Note: “day(s)” – there won't be an equivalent in other languages. Plural formation is less regular. It's not just adding an “s” as in English.]

Only valid for 'Localization': English

## English: Capitalization on the User Interface




**Use sentence style for messages and all other sentence-like text on the user interface.**

Sentence style is your normal, everyday capitalization style. It is equivalent to using lowercase for all words, except for proper nouns and the first letter in a new sentence.

> Example
>
> ✔ Your booking will be reserved for 24 hours. [Note: This could be a confirmation message.]

✔ A draft of your last invoice was saved. Do you want to resume editing or discard the invoice? [Note: This is a user decision.]

✔ Classifies the installation for billing purposes [Note: This is a tooltip with sentence-like text. It briefly explains the *Rate Type* field. If your tooltip just gives the full form of an abbreviated field label such as *Rt. Tp.* (or whatever other user interface element), then the tootip would be *Rate Type* in title case.]

**Use title case for all types of titles and labels on the user interface.**

**Title case applies to:** field labels, checkboxes, radio buttons; buttons, menu items; predefined entries in a dropdown list; titles of screens, tabs, and dialog boxes; table titles and their column and row headings; and so on

**How does title case work?**

Example

✔ **First and Last Words** Get Title Case

✔ All **Major Words** (Nouns, Verbs, Adjectives, and Adverbs) Get Title Case

✔ I, My, You, Your, and Other **Personal Pronouns** Get Title Case

✔ This, That, These, Those, All, Any, Some, Every, Each, What, Where, Who, and Other **Determiners** Get Title Case

✔ Am, Is, Are, Was, Were, Be, Been, Has, Had, Do, Doing, Did, Create, Creating, Created, and Other **Verbs** Get Title Case

✔ About, After, Before, Between, During, Through, Under, Within, Without, and Other **Prepositions with 5 or More Letters** Get Title Case

✔ Signing In to the System and Other Cases Where **Prepositions Form Part of the Verb Phrase** Get Title Case

✔ Save File As, Approve Leave Request, My Documents, Purchase Order Overview, Frequently Bought Together, Work in Progress, Sold-to Party, Up-to-Date Information, About Us, Facts About the Product, Seen Through the Eyes of Our Customers, Tune In in March for the Conclusion

End of 'Localization': English

## Context Information for Translators

**Help translators by providing notes (brief explanations), the**

Translators don't get to see the application screens in the translation tool (ask them for a demo). Their worklist contains only text strings. To find the correct translation, they rely on your context information.

**text type (for example, field or message), or self-descriptive text keys.**

**ABAP:** In ABAP systems, the text type is automatically known to translators because it's the object type (for example, data element short text or message long text), which appears in their worklist.

> Example
>
> [Note: Without context information, the English source text is impossible to translate. But if the translator knows that, for example, “Order” is a button text, then they know how to translate this text.]
>
> **English:** Order
>
> **German translation?** Bestellen [verb if it's a button] Auftrag [noun if it's a title or a label]
>
> **English:** Delete document
>
> **German translation?** ?Dokument | Beleg? löschen [verb if it's a button] Löschen Sie ?das Dokument | den Beleg?. [complete sentence if it's a message]

**Non-ABAP: Embed the context information in a comment.**

You can use comments to set text types, text length restrictions (if absolutely necessary), and a note intended for the translator. Place the comment immediately before the key/value pair.

Use the following **pattern**: `# text type: note for translator`

> Example
>
> ```
> # XBUT: button text on the final Shopping Cart screen
> view.SCADetail.Order=Place Order
> ```
>
> ```
> # XTOL: welcome appears in the upper right corner of the
> screen, is followed by first and last name
> view.Shop.welcome=Welcome {0}
> ```
>
> ```
> # XFLD: This is the start date.
> view.LeaveRequest.StartDate=Start
> ```
>
> [Note: If you **can't avoid restricting the text length**, use the pattern `# text type, length restriction: note for translator` and provide a buffer for the other languages by applying the text length recommendations.]
>
> ```
> # XFLD, 20: This is the start date.
> view.LeaveRequest.StartDate=Start
> ```

**Non-ABAP: Classify each user interface text with the correct text type in the property file.**

If you need help, ask your translator or contact Language Experience Lab (LX Lab). Here are the recommended text types:

| Text Type | When to Use and Comments | Capitalization |
|---|---|---|
| `XMSG` | Message text<br>Obsolete: `YMSG` (message text) and `XLOG` (log entry) → use `XMSG` | **Sentence style** applies:<br>✔ This is a text in sentence style. |
| `YINS` | Instruction for a user, for example, a permanent text on a screen that introduces a group of fields | |
| `XLNK` | Hyperlink | |
| `XACT` | Accessibility text<br>Text in the `alt` attribute is translated. | |
| `XTIT` | Title (or heading) of a nonactionable user interface element, for example, a column heading, wizard title, or screen area title<br>Obsolete: `XCOL` (column heading), `XGRP` (group title), and `XTBS` (tab title) → use `XTIT` | **Title case** applies (see also the *English: Capitalization* section):<br>✔ Titles and Labels in Title Case<br>✔ Rate Type<br>✔ Clean All Views<br>✔ Import Localized Content |
| `XFLD` | Field label | |
| `XBUT` | Button | |
| `XMIT` | Menu header or menu item | |
| `XSEL` | Values in a dropdown list<br>Obsolete: `XLST` (list item) → use `XSEL` | Title case and sentence style as appropriate for text length:<br>• **Title case for short, label-like text**, such as a status<br>✔ In Process<br>• **Sentence style for longer, sentence-like text**<br>✔ Workspaces closed in the last six months<br>✔ Check spelling as you type |
| `XCKL` | Checkbox label | |
| `XRBL` | Radio button label | |
| `XTOL` | Explanatory text for a user interface element that does not have a label (for example, an icon). For more information, see Using Tooltips in the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*.<br>Only if you can't provide embedded help with SAP Companion: Brief explanation (tooltip) of a user interface element | |

| Text Type | When to Use and Comments | Capitalization |
|---|---|---|
| `NOTR` | No translation – the text won't even appear in the translation worklist. So think twice before using it. If in doubt, ask your translation coordinator.<br><br>**⚠ Caution**<br>Do **not** use `NOTR` when you're tempted by some gut feeling "oh well, I don't think this text needs to be translated." Not even if your product is available only in English.<br><br>Use `NOTR` only for text strings that are **inherently untranslatable**. One guiding question is: Will the software still work as expected if the string is modified? If not, it is `NOTR`.<br><br>Here are some examples:<br>• Technical strings, such as `http GET` or concatenated `MaterialInspectionResults`<br>• Cryptic strings, such as `E029S6MMckcNCO2iv4bomEAVlD8=`<br>• Formatting, such as `'---OETY----------`<br>• Programming language keywords, such as `SELECT`, `FROM`, or `WHERE`<br>• Registry keys, folder names, IDs of stored procedures, and so on | Not applicable |

## Geopolitical Implications of the Term "Country" and Country/Region Names

**Do not use the term "country". Instead, use "country/region" or "country or region", or rephrase completely.**

This is because of geopolitics. By doing this, you protect SAP from legal or other consequences, such as product bans or the shutdown of Web sites. For more information, see Country/Region-Specific Guidance in the Product Standard for Globalization and the related requirement Country and Region Handling (GLOB-192).

### Example

✔ Country/Region [Note: This is a field label., therefore title case.]

✔ Country/Region Code [Note: This is a field label example with a compound.]

✔ Local Version [Note: This is a field label. This example shows that “country” can also be replaced with something else.]

✔ Country/Region | Region | City [or:] Country/Region | Subdivision | City [Note: These are column titles. “Country/Region” used to be “Country”. The question now is what to do with “region”: Keep, change to “subdivision”, or to something else? The term “subdivision” is used in the ISO standard *Codes for the Representation of Names of Countries and Their Subdivisions* (ISO 3166). Your decision depends on the context. Align with the Product Standard for Globalization.]

✘ Country Version

✔ Specify your country/region. [or:] Select a country/region and language. [or:] Select the relevant countries/regions. [Note: These appear in message texts and refer to the *Country/Region* field.]

✔ ... in compliance with all applicable laws, including local laws of the country or region in which you reside ...

## Wording and Formulations

**Write from the user's point of view.**

Use active voice and “you”. Use positive formulations (“do”, rather than “do not”). Give clear instructions instead of describing the problem. Beware of long noun strings. Split a series of nouns into smaller, more manageable units. This is easier to understand and to translate.

### Example

✔ Enter the company code.

✘ Company code was not entered. [or:] BUKRS field is empty.

✔ You can create a worklist. [or:] Create a worklist.

✘ It is possible to create a worklist. [or:] A worklist can be created.

✔ After downloading the software, follow the instructions in the installation wizard.

✘ After the download an installer is available.

✔ Check the port signals from the device adapter card.

❌ Check the device adapter card port signals.

**Do not use "(s)" or "/s" plurals.**

Such constructions are hard to translate and will lead to awkward or unacceptable formulations in the target languages. Noun plurals are not always as simple and regular as in English. Some languages have no plural form. Other languages require multiple plural forms depending on the number preceding the noun. In many languages, noun plurals require verb and adjective agreement. Translators have to resort to a messy mix of parentheses and slashes.

Example

❌ **English:** Change the new contract(s).

❌ **German:** Ändern Sie den/die neuen Vertrag/Verträge.

❌ **French:** Modifiez le/les nouveau(x) contrat(s).

Here's how you can avoid this:

Example

✔ Select the regions for the sales revenue report. [Note: Often the plural form is sufficient.]

❌ Select the region(s) for the sales revenue report.

✔ Drag each file to the relevant folder.

❌ Drag the file(s) to the relevant folder(s).

✔ Number of documents deleted: `<number>` [Note: This works in all languages.]

❌ `<Number>` documents deleted [Note: This doesn't work in some target languages because they require multiple plural forms depending on the number preceding the noun.]

## Typography and Punctuation Marks

**Use a font size of 10 or higher.**

In many Asian languages, characters with a font size smaller than 9 will become difficult to read.

**Use CamelCase or ALL CAPS only for technical names.**

CamelCase and ALL CAPS are not easy to read. They also indicate to translators that this text must not be translated.

**Make sure that punctuation marks, spaces, and special**

Do not hard code them. Do not add them at runtime. This enables translators to adapt the complete text. If you need help, consult a localization expert.

**characters are part of a translatable text.**

Why is this important? Punctuation rules, punctuation marks, and special characters (symbols) can be **surprisingly language-specific** with regard to use, typography, and word order. This is especially true for the **double-byte languages**, such as Chinese or Japanese. They do not use spaces as separators. Single-byte punctuation marks and special characters (symbols) have double-byte equivalents, which are typographically different. Sometimes there are even two double-byte equivalents, such as the two different Chinese commas. Sometimes there is no equivalent at all. For example, the number sign (#) is a widely used convention in the United States and Canada but not necessarily elsewhere. Translators need to resort to a text equivalent such as “Number”, which will result in space issues on the user interface.

### Example

The correct Chinese double-byte colon is typographically different from the single-byte colon used in Western languages. The Chinese comma is actually two different commas, a normal one and a special one that's used as a separator in a list of items. Chinese speakers are very conscious of the difference. Incorrect use can lead to nonacceptance. Have a look at this example:




## Related Information

Product Standard for User Assistance
Product Standard for User Experience Consistency
Product Standard for Globalization
Product Standard for Accessibility
Non-ABAP Translation
User Assistance in English and Relevant Languages (Continuous Delivery)

# 5 Style and Wording: Practical Issues and Principles

Good writing follows basic principles such as simplicity, precision, conciseness, active voice ("you"), and logical sequence. The principles explained here are at word and sentence level. (For topics and documents, consult an editor.)

## Simple and Easy to Understand

**Use simple, common words and phrases.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ agree [instead of: concur], although [instead of: albeit], before [instead of: prior to], harmful [instead of: deleterious], start/begin [instead of: commence], try [instead of: endeavor], up to now [instead of: heretofore], use [instead of: utilize]
>
> ✔ decide [instead of: take a decision], upgrade [instead of: perform an upgrade], explain [instead of: provide an explanation], can [instead of: be able to, it is possible to], is transparent [instead of: is characterized by transparency]
>
> ✔ outcome [instead of: final outcome], perfect [instead of: absolutely perfect]

**Use simple syntax. Limit sentence length to 20 words.**

Do not put too much information and complexity in a sentence. There are no absolute numbers for sentence length. Around 20 words is a good average. If a sentence is longer, split it into shorter sentences, or possibly into a list or a table. Similarly, complicated syntax is hard to understand. If your sentence has two or more subordinate clauses (especially if they're embedded into each other), try to split up the sentence.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The ISO 4217 code list is the international standard for naming currencies in banking and commerce. The codes are used in place of translated currency names or ambiguous currency symbols. The codes for common currencies are often better known than the currency names or symbols.
>
> ✘ The ISO 4217 code list, which is internationally the established norm in banking and commerce for defining different currencies, so that, in many parts of the world, the codes for the more common currencies are better known to the general public than translated currency names or ambiguous currency symbols with the result that these codes are used for exchange rates, for example, when they are published in newspapers or posted in banks.

**Preferably use the present tense, not the future tense.**

As a general rule, consider these aspects: If your sentence expresses something generic or habitual, the present tense is usually fine because simpler. The future tense is for actions that will happen sometime in the future, not just in a few seconds. Note that the future tense can also be used to make things sound a bit more conversational.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The account assignment category determines [instead of: will determine] how the system assigns accounts. [Note: This is a generic statement (“this always happens if/when”).]
>
> ✔ Your settings are applied [instead of: will be applied] when you restart. [Note: This is a generic statement (“this always happens if/when”). It's not something that happens only to you sometime in the future. It happens to everybody.]
>
> ✔ Extract the archive and make a note of the location. You'll use the extracted files in a later step. [Note: You're telling a user to make a note because they will need the information sometime in the future.]

**Use positive formulations. Rephrase double negatives.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ If the `tools.zip` file is not found, the installer stops.
>
> ✘ The installer will not continue if the `tools.zip` file is not provided.
>
> ✔ If you can connect to the application machine from the server machine, you can configure the application machine remotely.
>
> ✘ If the application machine is not reachable from the server machine, remote configuration will not be possible.

**Split a series of nouns or prepositional phrases into smaller, more manageable units.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Check the port signals from the device adapter card.
>
> ✘ Check the device adapter card port signals.
>
> ✔ In the process hierarchy, copy an object with roles and tasks. [or:] Copy an object with roles and tasks that are used in the process hierarchy.
>
> ✘ Copy an object with roles and tasks in the process hierarchy. [Note: It's not clear whether “in the process hierarchy” modifies “roles and tasks” or whether it indicates where to copy the roles and tasks.]

**Use clipped words such as “sync” with care.**

People without first-language proficiency in English may not understand the clipped form because it's not (yet) part of everyday speech. Ask a language editor or a native speaker whether they consider the clipped form as jargon or slang. Find out what sounds natural to your target group.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ phone, memo, typo, exam [Note: These are actually clipped forms but they've become more common than their full forms.]
>
> ✔ sync, synchronize [Note: Both forms are fine. Your final word choice depends on target group and context.]
>
> ✔ morph
>
> ✘ metamorphose [Note: The clipped form “morph” is more common.]
>
> ✔ collaboration
>
> ✘ collab [Note: The full form “collaboration” is more common. But “collab”, “obvi”, and similar clipped forms appear on Twitter and other social media. Some day they might make their way into the standard language.]
>
> ✔ obvious, obviously
>
> ✘ obvi

## Precise and Concise

**Use clear and consistent terminology.**

For more information, see Terminology and SAPterm [page 74].

**Make every word count: Eliminate wordy formulations. Do not state the obvious. Use intensifiers sparingly.**

Writing concisely is not about eliminating as many words as possible. Writing concisely is about eliminating words and information that are superfluous or confusing.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The software collects and analyzes data automatically. For example, if the introduction of hybrid vehicles reduces the impact of fuel costs on transportation costs, this change is immediately reflected in the application.
>
> ✘ The software performs sophisticated automated data collection and analysis; for example, if the considerable impact of fuel costs on transportation costs declines with the introduction of hybrid vehicles, the application will immediately reflect those changes.
>
> ✔ For security reasons, do not tell your password to anyone else. Change it at least every six months in your user settings.

❌ It is vital for security reasons to choose a password that is only known to you, and this password needs to be changed from time to time (in the user settings where you will get instructions that provide sufficient information and guidance).

✔ The `Pages out` value is important for assessing system performance.

❌ The `Pages out` value is very [or: basically, really, rather, fairly, absolutely, extremely] important for assessing system performance.

> **Green Tip**
>
> Conciseness also saves time and money. Every word that you delete won't need to be translated into multiple languages. This may not seem like a big deal at the sentence level, but this impact on resources adds up over time.

**Be clear. Do not be vague or abstract.**

Use precise verbs. For example, instead of the SAP jargon “maintain” use “edit”, “specify”, “create”, “change”, or “manage”, as appropriate for the context (user interface element, user interface technology). For more information, see the SAPterm components listed in Terminology and SAPterm [page 74].

Use verbal formulations. Do not turn verbs into nouns. Be careful with gerunds. Use impersonal verb constructions with care. Try to replace them with the active voice, an imperative, or “you”.

**Example**

✔ The project team upgrades the system.

❌ The project team performs the upgrade of the system.

❌ The project team has the responsibility for handling the upgrade of the system.

✔ If you limit the search to the *Financials* area, the search results won't contain telecommunication contracts.

❌ Limiting the search to the *Financials* area won't return telecommunication contracts.

❌ It is possible to generate a task list. [Note: This sentence is fuzzy.]

✔ The employee generates a task list. [Note: This could be part of a process description (who does what)]

✔ To generate a task list, enter a due date or other search criteria. [or:] Generate a task list. [Note: This could be an instruction in a procedure.]

✔ After downloading the software, follow the instructions in the installer.

❌ After you have downloaded the software, an installer is available.

✔ When you use fuzzy search, the terms most identical to the search string are listed first.

✘ If fuzzy search is active, the terms most identical to the search string are listed first.

✔ Do not use group passwords. [or:] Do not share passwords.

✘ Group passwords should not be used.

**Do not generalize (“generally”, “usually”, “sometimes”). Mention exceptions or rare cases.**

If you can't make a statement that is generally applicable because there are exceptions, list the cases in which the exceptions apply.

Example

✔ You can delete only layouts that you have created. Only the system administrator can delete layouts that were created by other users.

✘ You can generally delete only a layout that you have created.

✘ apparently, to all intents and purposes, for the most part, generally, in general, in some respects, in some ways, (most) often, occasionally, probably, to a certain extent, usually, primarily

## Active/Passive Voice and Addressing the User

**Preferably use the active voice. Address the user directly with “you”.**

The passive voice often makes it difficult to determine who is doing what to whom or what.

**Make a conscious decision to use the active or passive voice.**

It depends on how you want to present a statement. In most cases, this is about who is doing what to whom. As a general rule, aim for at least at 80% active voice. The main differences between active and passive are outlined in the following table:

| Active Voice | Passive Voice |
| --- | --- |
| Use the active voice to emphasize the person or thing performing the action. Make clear whether the user or the software (system) performs the action. | Use the passive voice in the following cases:<br>• The agent of the action is not known, not important, or not mentioned for the sake of politeness.<br>• The context provides sufficient information about who is doing what to whom. This can improve the overall text flow. |

| Active Voice | Passive Voice |
| --- | --- |
| Active voice and addressing the user is not exactly the same:<br>• Preferably address the user directly. Use “you” or an imperative. This holds the user's attention.<br>• Otherwise use the third person and name the agent, for example, “the user”, “the vendor”, “the system”, or “the Web service”. | |

### Example

✘ The objects to be deleted are selected. [Note: It is not clear what this sentence means.]

✔ You can select the objects to be deleted. [or:] Select the objects to be deleted. [or:] The system administrator selects the objects to be deleted. [or:] The system selects the objects to be deleted.

✔ In the course of a fiscal year, a budget that was approved at an earlier point in time may sometimes need to be adjusted. [Note: The focus is on the fact that a budget may need to be adjusted. It is not important here to know who approved the budget or who will adjust it.]

✔ This function is designed for business executives. [Note: The passive voice is fine because it is not important who designed the function.]

✘ The product team designed the function for business executives.

## Logical Sequence

**Describe what before how.**

This ensures that users understand the consequences of an action before they perform the action.

### Example

✔ To avoid performance problems during working hours, schedule the route generation as a batch job.

✘ Schedule the route generation as a batch job. This avoids performance problems during working hours.

✔ To remove the item permanently, choose *Delete*. [Note: This is not the best of examples because it's stating the obvious at click level. But it illustrates well that sometimes what before how makes a big difference.]

❌ Choose *Delete* to remove the item permanently.

**Describe actions that occur in a chronological sequence in this sequence.**

Example

✔ Create an account. Confirm the account by entering the authentication code.

✔ After creating the account, confirm the account by entering the authentication code.

❌ Enter the authentication code after creating the account.

**In conditional sentences, place the condition "if" before the statement "`<this happens>`".**

No need to introduce the statement with "then". In most cases, the sentence works fine without it.

**Exception:** If the conditional clause is too long (for example, it contains more than one condition), place the shorter statement before the condition. Consider presenting the conditions as a list.

**German:** Introduce the conditional clause with "wenn". Do not use inverted syntax. That is, do not front the verb because this might be mistaken for an imperative.

Example

✔ If you purchase goods from another state, the vendor charges tax on the invoice.

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** Wenn Sie diese Datei löschen, funktioniert die Software nicht mehr.

End of 'Localization': German

❌ **German:** Löschen Sie diese Datei, funktioniert die Software nicht mehr. [Note: The user will first interpret "Löschen" as an imperative before reanalyzing it in a second step as a conditional clause with inverted syntax. But this might be too late. File has gone.]

## Related Information

People-Centric Language and Communication [page 83]
Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98]
Accessibility [page 103]

# 5.1 SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names

The official naming source for SAP offerings is the *Approved Names* repository on the *SAP Brand* site. It covers names of products, services, events, organizations, programs, and other special names, as well as qualifiers (options, editions, or versions), abbreviations, descriptors, and usage notes.

## Basics

**Look up the official, approved names of SAP offerings on the SAP Brand site at https://brand.sap.com.**

Because names evolve, check the *Approved Names* repository often. For more information, see Approved Names. For information about third-party software or company names, see Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62].

If you can't find a name, it may be in the pipeline or currently in review. If you are unsure about the correct use of a name, send an email to the following email address: naming@sap.com

The approved names are replicated to SAPterm. You can look them up in the `BV-BRAND-VOICE` component. For information about SAPterm, see Terminology and SAPterm [page 74].

**Use approved names and their descriptors exactly as given in the usage notes.**

In other words: exact spelling and wording, no abbreviations unless there's an approved one, correct descriptor when needed, and no plurals or possessives.

**Exception:** As opposed to marketing materials, do **not** add a trademark symbol to approved names in user assistance (including user interface texts), not even on title pages. The trademarks are covered by a central legal text instead. For more information, see Copyright, Trademarks, and Other Legal Notices [page 60].

> Example
>
> ✔ SAP HANA, SAP Business ByDesign, SAP for Defense & Security [Note: These are the mere names, **without** a trademark symbol when mentioned in user assistance.]
>
> ✘ SAP Hana, HANA, SAP ByDesign, SAP BYD, SAP for Defense & Public Security, Defense & Public Security [Note: No random spelling, no random abbreviations]
>
> ✘ SAP HANA®, SAP® Business ByDesign®, SAP® for Defense & Public Security [Note: No trademark symbols]
>
> ✔ The SAP Business One solution helps small businesses streamline their operations. [Note: A descriptor is required at first occurrence.]
>
> ✘ SAP Business One (B1) helps small businesses streamline their operations.

✔ SAP CRM systems, SAP HANA benefits

✖ SAP CRMs, SAP HANA's benefits [Note: No plurals, no possessives]

**Do not set off approved names with italics or quotation marks ("...").**

**Tools:** If your authoring tool supports purely semantic tagging (no visual rendering in the final output), apply it. This will help you when searching for outdated names.

**Translation: As a general rule, do not translate approved names.**

Approved names may have translatable elements, though. As a general rule, words in lowercase are translatable. Approved names are defined in the Approved Names repository on the SAP Brand site (English only). They are replicated to SAPterm, where they are translated. For more information, see Brand Translation Guidelines.

If your audience is not likely to understand an approved name (in U.S. English), you can add a local language translation in parentheses ( ), but do not add the prefix "SAP". If needs be (for example, if an approved name such as "SAP Business One" is not semantically transparent), you can also briefly explain the approved name. Then, however, use only the approved name for the SAP offering. It is perfectly okay to use the local language term when you mean the general concept and not the SAP offering.

✤ Example

✔ **German:** Die Anwendung SAP Travel Management (Reisemanagement) ermöglicht Ihnen ... [Note: The descriptor "Anwendung" (German for "application") is used because it's the first occurrence of the approved name. The German equivalent "Reisemanagement" is optional.]

✖ **German:** Die Anwendung SAP-Reisemanagement ermöglicht Ihnen ...

**Do not use the former product names "SAP R/3" and "SAP R/3 Enterprise".**

These and related products are no longer actively sold or marketed. In most cases, the SAP ERP application has replaced the former SAP R/3 product line. Only use "SAP R/3" and "SAP R/3 Enterprise" for historical reference or referring to a customer's legacy systems.

Only valid for 'Localization': English

## English: When to Use Title Case for Approved Names That Contain Lowercase

**In titles, headings, and anywhere else title case is required, use title case.**

For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199].

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Installing and Configuring the SAP HANA Cloud Connector [Note: This is a **topic title**. Therefore, title case applies even if the approved name for body text is actually “SAP HANA cloud connector”.]
>
> ✔ The SAP HANA cloud connector runs as an on-premise agent to serve as a link between ... . [Note: This is **body text**.]

End of 'Localization': English

## Descriptors and Articles

**At first occurrence of an SAP offering, use the approved descriptor.**

“First occurrence” refers to the first occurrence in a reusable text unit. Assume this to be a topic. But it can also be a text fragment below topic level.

A descriptor is used to specify the offering: solution, service, application, platform, program, portfolio, package, environment, initiative, and a host of others. All official SAP offerings are listed in the *Approved Names* repository with one or more approved descriptors. Don't invent your own. If several descriptors are available, use the one that applies to your context, not just the first in the list.

**Translation:** As opposed to approved names, descriptors are translated. See SAPterm.

**After the first occurrence, use the approved name stand-alone. No descriptor. No article (“the”).**

Alternatively, you can use the descriptor with a demonstrative pronoun (“this”, “these”). You can always use “software”, “offering”, or “technology” as a generic alternative to many descriptors after first occurrence. “System” may also be appropriate if comparing SAP software to third-party software systems.

**Exception:** The usage notes in the *Approved Names* repository stipulate that the descriptor is always required.

Only valid for 'Localization': German

**Exception for German:** It is ok to use an article if the formulation would sound ungrammatical or odd otherwise.

End of 'Localization': German

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The SAP Business One solution helps small businesses streamline their operations. This solution [or:] SAP Business One ... .
>
> ✘ SAP Business One (B1) helps small businesses streamline their operations. SAP B1 [or:] The SAP B1 ... . [Note: There are no approved abbreviations for SAP Business One. “SAP B1” and “B1” are not allowed according to the usage notes.]
>
> ✘ The SAP Business One (B1) helps small businesses streamline their operations. The SAP Business One ... .

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** Die Lösung SAP Sports One umfasst ... . Mit SAP Sports One [or:] Mit dieser Lösung können Sie ... .

End of 'Localization': German

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** Mit dem SAP Support Portal können Sie ... . [Note: Without the article "der" the German sentence would sound ungrammatical. A typical constellation seems to be that the last word in the approved name is a noun that is similar to a German word. Plus, this last word is actually a descriptor that happens to be part of the approved name. Similar examples are "SAP HANA Marketplace" or "SAP Mobile App Framework".]

End of 'Localization': German

## Abbreviations and Space Restrictions

**Use only approved abbreviations or acronyms from the *Approved Names* repository.**

Abbreviations and acronyms of approved names are rare. They are listed only if there is an industry standard such as "ERP". Do not invent your own short forms. In some cases, there may be trademark infringements or conflicting meanings of an abbreviation or acronym.

**At first occurrence, use the full name and the abbreviation in parentheses ( ), followed by the descriptor.**

Example

✔ the SAP Customer Relationship Management (SAP CRM) application [Note: "SAP CRM" is an approved abbreviation, which you can find in the usage notes.]

✔ the connection package for collaborative health networks (connection package for CHNs)

✘ the SAP Business One (B1) solution [Note: There are no approved abbreviations for SAP Business One. "SAP B1" and "B1" are not allowed according to the usage notes.]

**If space restrictions do not permit the full name and descriptor in the allowed space at first occurrence, you may use the approved abbreviation or acronym and omit the descriptor.**

These special circumstances may include an ad, sign, title or heading, Microsoft PowerPoint slide, figure, chart, diagram, or Web text with fixed space or character-count limits. Provide the full name and descriptor as soon as space allows.

## The Prefix “SAP”

**Use the prefix “SAP” with care.**

As the masterbrand, the prefix “SAP” is a typical element of SAP offerings and other terms in the *Approved Names* repository. In this context, it is safe to use the prefix.

**Do not unintentionally create phrases with the prefix “SAP” that may be misunderstood as SAP offerings.**

If so, rephrase. For example, check whether you can leave out “SAP” without changing the meaning. However, sometimes you need to use the prefix “SAP”, for example, if you need to differentiate between SAP and third-party entities or if you want to emphasize the fact that something is SAP-specific without explicitly contrasting it with something that is from a third party.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ You can carry out planning and forecasting with the SAP Cloud for Sales solution.
>
> ✘ You can use SAP Cloud for Sales for Planning and Forecasting.
>
> ✔ Establishing effective application lifecycle management (ALM) is high on the priority list of many CEOs.
>
> ✘ Establishing effective SAP application lifecycle management (SAP ALM) is high on the priority list of many CEOs.

## Compounds with Approved Names

**Avoid compounds with approved names. Rephrase, for example, with a preposition.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ the settings in SAP Extended Warehouse Management [Note: Prefer the prepositional formulation to “the SAP Extended Warehouse Management settings”. However, “the SAP Extended Warehouse Management application” is fine because “application” is the official descriptor. And a prepositional formulation wouldn't work anyway.]

**German: If you can't avoid a compound, apply German hyphenation for compounds (“durchkoppeln”).**

German hyphenation rules apply irrespective of whether the complete approved name is branded or trademarked (for example, “SAP Fiori” or “SAP HANA”) or not. For more information, see German: Komposita mit englischen Wörtern (nicht im Rechtschreibduden) [page 297] and Copyright, Trademarks, and Other Legal Notices [page 60].

> **Example**
>
> [Note: The assumption is that you can't avoid the compound. Remember that trademark symbols are not used in user assistance (including user interface texts).]
>
> ✔ die SAP-Extended-Warehouse-Management-Einstellungen
>
> ✔ SAP-Fiori-Apps, SAP-HANA-Datenbank [Note: Actually, both product names are trademarked. Nevertheless, German hyphenation rules apply to compounds.]

**Tool exception:** If your authoring tool has a tag for product names and you're supposed to use variables instead of typing the approved name, then obviously you can't apply German hyphenation rules, neither in a German source text nor in a translation into German. This situation is not ideal but that's how it is. The benefit of the tag is that approved names are automatically replaced when they change. But this only works because the approved names are not translated. They are always in English. So do not apply this type of term replacement with variables to translatable terms.

## Third-Party Companies and Their Offerings

**If an SAP offering includes the name of a third-party company, make sure you use the third-party name exactly as found in the *Approved Names* repository.**

> **Example**
>
> ✔ The SAP-MICROSOFT Unite Partner Connection program helps partners explore and gain insight into new opportunities. Partners benefit from field collaboration, training programs, demos, and more. [Note: According to the usage notes, the descriptor "program" is optional with this approved name.]
>
> ✘ The SAP – Microsoft Unite Partner Connection program ...
>
> ✔ The SAP Interactive Forms software by Adobe ...
>
> ✘ The SAP IForms by Adobe

**Before mentioning third-party companies or their offerings elsewhere, make sure that you comply with legal requirements.**

For more information, see Copyright, Trademarks, and Other Legal Notices [page 60] and Third-Party Software – How To Refer to It [page 62].

### Granular or Technical References to SAP Software

**Be aware that sometimes approved names are not granular or technical enough.**

The *Approved Names* repository does not include the name of every function, feature, tool, engine, and the like. For more information, see Software Objects and Entities [page 193].

If you need to refer to technical components, go to the Product and Production Management System (PPMS) or the Product Availability Matrix (PAM). For more information, see the PPMS Content wiki and PAM. Alternatively, look up things in the *Technical System Landscape* sections of installation or master guides. If you're writing SAP Library or Customizing documentation for on-premise ABAP systems, you may need to refer to the components of the application component hierarchy (transaction HIER).

**Before using the generic term "system", check whether there is a more precise descriptor to describe the software.**

In technical contexts, though, the term "system" is often appropriate.

> Example
>
> ✔ From an SAP CRM system, you can replicate the data to an external ERP system. If the ERP system is an SAP system, you can connect the systems by implementing standard interfaces.

### Related Information

Releases, Support Packages, and Other Versioning Information [page 189]

## 5.2 Releases, Support Packages, and Other Versioning Information

No need to mention versioning information everywhere. However, in specific, often technical contexts, you need to mention version numbers, support packages, or whatever versioning methodology there is. Now the question is when exactly and how.

### Basics

**As a general rule, do not mention or repeat versioning information if you can avoid it.**

In most cases, versioning information is not required. Usually you are describing the latest state of the software, and the versioning information has already been established elsewhere (for example, on a title page). So why write something like

"In the 4.1 version, you can build widgets." if a simple "You can build widgets." is sufficient? Also, you'll be saving yourself a lot of annoying maintenance by doing so.

**Mention versioning information when it's distinctive (for example, on a title page).**

In some, often technical contexts, you have to be exact for reasons of clarity. Here are some typical contexts for versioning information:

- On the title page of a document
- In a cross-release document (for example, your administration guide has title information such as "`<version>` or higher")
- In delta information, such as what's new or release notes
- In very rare cases on version-specific product pages on SAP Help Portal
  This is, for example, the case with the SAP NetWeaver product pages. There's one for SAP NetWeaver 7.5, SAP NetWeaver Application Server for ABAP 7.52, and so on. This is because of legacy constraints in release management. Normal product pages do not have version information in the page title. They have a version selector.

**Use the versioning information as defined by the central release management group.**

The release management group defines the SAP-wide types of software versioning and ensures that the data is centrally stored. This covers releases, support packages and support package stacks, feature packages and feature package stacks, enhancement packages, and whatever else there is. For more information, go to the Product Availability Matrix (PAM). See also Software Product Naming and Versioning Guidelines and the Product and Production Management System (PPMS) wiki (especially PPMS and Naming Conventions).

**Do not use the terms "support package (stack)" and "feature package (stack)" interchangeably.**

If in doubt, ask your product owner or look it up in PPMS. A feature package stack is a dedicated shipment vehicle for non-disruptive delivery of fast innovation for generally available software versions. It uses support package technology to deliver new features, and also bundles software corrections and legal changes. Support package stacks contain only corrections and legal changes.

When to use the suffix "stack"? It applies to product level as in "SAP Invented Product 1.2 SPS 3". Do not use "stack" at the lower level of software components.

## Formulation Patterns for Body Text

**As a general rule for body text, remember the formulation pattern "SAP Invented Product 1.2 SPS 3".**

In direct combination with approved names and version numbers, terms such as "support package stack" are usually abbreviated (in this case to "SPS"). The reason is that they are used for and by expert target groups in technical contexts. You can assume that the target groups IT consultant/implementer, IT administrator, and developer understand these acronyms. But it doesn't hurt to verify this assumption.

**Exception:** Check whether there are additional standards for the term and the acronym that you're going to use. For example, for enhancement packages (according to the Approved Names repository), the default is "enhancement package". "EHP" is reserved for space restrictions.

| English: Formulation Pattern | German: Formulation Pattern | Comment |
|---|---|---|
| `<Approved Name> <version number> <SPS, FPS, and so on, and number>` | `<Approved Name> <Versionsnummer> <SPS, FPS usw. und Nummer>` | Use in body text. No leading zero (0) for single-digit numbers. Space between acronym and number. |
| ✔ SAP Solution Manager 7.1 SPS 9 | ✔ SAP Solution Manager 7.1 SPS 9 | Remember that there are specific standards for enhancement packages. |
| ✔ SAP enhancement package 4 SPS 2 for SAP ERP 6.0 SPS 11 | ✔ SAP-Erweiterungspaket 4 SPS 2 für SAP ERP 6.0 SPS 11 | |
| ✔ SAP provides enhancement package 4 for SAP ERP 5.0, which includes support package stack 2 (SPS 2). SPS 2 is required because ... | ✔ SAP liefert das Erweiterungspaket 4 für SAP ERP 5.0, das Support Package Stack 2 (SPS 2) beinhaltet. SPS 2 ist die Voraussetzung, um ... | At first occurrence, you can always use the full form but you don't have to.<br>If you can assume the target group to be familiar with the acronym, use it straightaway. |
| ✔ SAP provides enhancement package 8 for SAP ERP 6.0 SPS 2. | ✔ SAP liefert das Erweiterungspaket 4 für SAP ERP 5.0 SPS 2. | |
| ✔ Mainstream maintenance for the SAP Classified Advertising Management 1.0 application was available through March 2022. The 2.0 version of the application has been available since January 2021. | ✔ Die Mainstream-Wartung der Anwendung SAP Classified Advertising Management 1.0 dauerte bis März 2022. Die Version 2.0 der Anwendung ist seit Januar 2021 verfügbar. | If you need to write about versions. |
| ... and higher, up to ... | ... und höher, bis zu ... | To refer to **multiple versions**, support packages, or other, use these phrases. |
| ✔ SAP Solution Manager 7.1 and higher | ✔ SAP Solution Manager 7.1 und höher | |

## When to Use a Leading Zero (0)

| | |
|---|---|
| **In PPMS, enter data for all types of packages and stacks with a leading zero (as defined in the versioning conventions).** | If you're the person who makes the PPMS entries, remember the leading zero. This will avoid sorting issues. For more information, see Software Product Naming and Versioning Guidelines and PPMS and Naming Conventions. |
| **Avoid sorting issues.** | Check whether a leading zero is required for technical reasons. In sorting contexts (folders, directories, fields, HTML page titles, and the like), a missing zero may lead to data sequenced in the wrong way. |
| **In instructions where exact user input is required, use a leading zero.** | Sometimes the leading zero is required for technical reasons, and the user has to type it (instead of selecting it from a dropdown list). Omitting it would lead to wrong search results or other incorrect processing. Note that this is actually a data-entry usability issue. |

### Example

✔ Enter the support package stack number with a leading zero, for example, **03**. [Note: This could be an instruction for entering PPMS data.]

## Acronym Versus Full Form

| | |
|---|---|
| Remember: Acronym in combination with numbers as in “SPS 3”. Full form stand-alone. | **Exception:** If there are space restrictions, use the acronym but try to provide the full form nearby (for example, as a mouseover or in the body text). Also, it never hurts to check the wider context on the user interface or in a topic before deciding. |

## Example

✔ As of SAP Solution Manager 7.1 SPS 9 you can … . Further support packages are available on a monthly basis.

✘ As of SAP Solution Manager 7.1 SPS 9 you can … . Further SPS are available on a monthly basis.

✔ Support Package Overview [Note: This is a topic title or a heading.]

✘ SP Overview

✔ SAP ERP 6.0 EHP 7, SAP ERP 6.0 EHP 6, …, SAP ERP 6.0 EHP 2

[Note: These are navigation entries for SAP ERP on SAP Help Portal at https://help.sap.com/erp. Navigation entries with the full form “Enhancement Package” (title case!) would be too long. The navigation entries are created manually, there is no automated sorting. Therefore no leading zero.]

✔ SAP ERP 6.0 [and below] SAP Enhancement Package 7

[Note: These are title and subtitle of a version-specific product page for SAP ERP on SAP Help Portal. No space restrictions. Therefore the full form “Enhancement Package” (title case!) instead of the acronym “EHP” is used. For more information about the acronym “ERP”, see the Approved Names repository, and search for **SAP ERP**.]

## Related Information

Release, Upgrade and Maintenance Info (in SAP Support Portal)
SAP Release Strategy and Management
Global Release Strategy community
Abbreviations [page 205]

# 5.3 Software Objects and Entities

The *Approved Names* repository on the *SAP Brand* site does not cover the name of every function, feature, tool, engine, and the like. So how do you refer to such software objects and entities? Lowercase or uppercase? English only or translate? Formatting? Mention the technical name? Here are some formulation patterns.

## Basics

**Take a step back. Ask yourself: What am I really referring to?**

This will help you find a formulation pattern. Here are some **guiding questions**:

| Guiding Question | How to Proceed | Formatting |
|---|---|---|
| Is it an SAP offering with an approved name? | Search in the *Approved Names* repository. Use the approved name according to the naming guidelines. For more information, see SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183] and Approved Names on the *SAP Brand* site. | No. Do not set off approved names from body text. No italics and the like. |
| Is it something from real life? | Follow the standards in the *Real-Life Entities* section. | No. |
| Is it a software object such as a role or an API? | Follow the standards in the *Software Objects* section. | Yes. Set off title (name) and technical name from body text. |
| Is it a software entity such as a tool or an engine? | Follow the standards in the *Software Entities* section. | No. |

### Example

✔ As a strategic purchaser, you need the *Strategic Purchaser* (`SRM_PCT_PURCHASER_STRATEGIC`) role in the system. [Note: You may be wondering why "strategic purchaser" has both lowercase and uppercase. The first mention refers to real life ("What's your job?" – "I'm a strategic purchaser/developer/system administrator/... .") The second mention refers to a software object with the title *Strategic Purchaser*.]

✘ As a Strategic Purchaser, you need the *Strategic Purchaser* (`SRM_PCT_PURCHASER_STRATEGIC`) role in the system.

✘ As a *Strategic Purchaser*, you need the *Strategic Purchaser* (`SRM_PCT_PURCHASER_STRATEGIC`) role in the system.

**Familiarize yourself with the following text elements: title, technical name, and descriptor**

These elements are relevant for determining word order and setting off titles and technical names from body text.

| Text Element | Use |
|---|---|
| Title | Translatable label of an entity. Example: *Strategic Purchaser* (title of a role) |
| Technical name | Nontranslatable label of an entity. Example: `SRM_PCT_PURCHASER_STRATEGIC` |
| Descriptor | Label that indicates the type of entity. Examples: role, component, business process, status, function module, method, interface. A descriptor is a useful complement to title and technical name, especially at first occurrence in a text. Titles and technical names do not necessarily indicate the type of entity, but the descriptor does. |

## Real-Life Entities or Similar

**If the entity corresponds to something from real life or if the aspect "this is software" is not relevant, write the word for the entity like any other word.**

Do not set off the word. Neither with formatting nor with unconventional capitalization (uppercase, lowercase). Do not fall into the trap of signaling "corresponds to a system object" by using title case. Less is more.

> Example
>
> ✔ A strategic purchaser typically creates a purchasing contract as soon as it becomes clear that the relationship with a supplier will be long-term. [Note: Here "strategic purchaser" is a role from real life in the sense that it exemplifies what real persons acting in this role typically do as part of their normal job. No need to introduce and format the strategic purchaser as a software entity.]
>
> ✔ By confirming the purchase order, the seller is obliged to deliver a specified quantity of goods at a specified price within a specified time. In the system, the status of the purchase order automatically changes to *Confirmed*. This status triggers additional workflow steps. To configure these workflows steps, ... [Note: Assume this text to be targeted at consultants or the implementation team. They need to know how the real life is matched in the software. Note the switch of perspectives. The first sentence mirrors the real-life perspective. The focus is on the business process itself, not on how to accomplish it in the software. But in the next sentence there is a switch to the software perspective, which is often indicated by formulations such as "in the software" or "in the system".]
>
> ✘ When the purchase order has the *Confirmed* status, the seller is obliged to deliver a specified quantity of goods at a specified price within

a specified time. [Note: Something is wrong here. Software perspective in the first half of the sentence and real-life perspective in the other half don't go together. It's not the software that obliges the seller to deliver the goods. It was the seller's decision to confirm the purchase order. The confirmation just happened to be in the software.]

✔ The default aggregation of the contract data is replicated to a migration object. [Note: Even though all the nouns correspond to objects in the software, this aspect is not in focus. The sentence is a general statement. It simply conveys how aggregated contract and the migration object are related.]

✘ The *Default Aggregation* of the Contract Data is replicated to a Migration Object. [Note: Too much title case minimizes readability. Overusing title case makes it meaningless.]

## Software Objects

> ⓘ Note
>
> **Terminology:** "Software object" refers to technical entities such as APIs, function modules, scenarios, process steps, roles, authorization objects, and so on. They have a title (a name) and in many cases a technical name. There are various instances of each object type. For example, in ABAP systems there are lots of function modules, each with a title and a technical name.

**If the entity corresponds to a software object, set off title and technical name at first occurrence.**

"First occurrence" refers to the first occurrence in a reusable text unit. Assume this to be a topic. But it can also be a text fragment below topic level. Write the technical name in lowercase, uppercase, or even CamelCase, as appropriate for the conventions of the development environment.

Use the formulation pattern that applies to your language:

| English: Formulation Pattern | German: Formulation Pattern |
|---|---|
| *Title in Title Case* (`technical name`) `<descriptor>`<br><br>✔ the *Strategic Purchaser* (`SRM_PCT_PURCHASER_STRATEGIC`) role<br><br>✔ the *Date Plausibility Check* (`DATE_PLAUSIBILITY_CHECK`) function module<br><br>✔ the *Sales and Profit Planning* (`CO-PA-SPP`) component [Context: application component hierarchy in ABAP systems] | `<Kategorie>` *Titel* (`technischer Name`)<br><br>✔ die Rolle *Strategischer Einkäufer* (`SRM_PCT_PURCHASER_STRATEGIC`)<br><br>✔ der Funktionsbaustein *Plausibilitätsprüfung für Datum* (`DATE_PLAUSIBILITY_CHECK`)<br><br>✔ die Komponente *Absatz- und Ergebnisplanung* (`CO-PA-SPP`) [Context: application component hierarchy in ABAP systems] |

**Example**

✔ You need the *Strategic Purchaser* (`SRM_PCT_PURCHASER_STRATEGIC`) role in the system. [Note: The technical name is written according to the ABAP spelling convention, that is, in all caps. This can be different in other development environments.]

**Tools:** This style guide is tool agnostic. For information about formatting, see the user guide for your authoring tool.

**In all further occurrences, you do not need to repeat the 3-element formulation pattern.**

As long as it's clear what you are referring to, you can use the title on its own or the descriptor preceded by a demonstrative pronoun. In technical contexts, it's also fine to use the technical name instead of the title. Don't forget to format the title or the technical name, though.

**Example**

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **English:** The user is assigned to the *Strategic Purchaser* (`SRM_PCT_PURCHASER_STRATEGIC`) role. ... When implementing this role, you ...

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** Der Benutzer benötigt die Rolle *Strategischer Einkäufer* (`SRM_PCT_PURCHASER_STRATEGIC`). ... Um diese Rolle zu implementieren, ...

End of 'Localization': German

**Do not mistake the formulation pattern for an absolute standard.**

There may be cases where it makes sense to omit one of the elements used in the pattern. For example, if there is no technical name or the technical name is not relevant.

Only valid for 'Localization': English

**English:** If the overall phrase sounds unnatural (for example, if title and technical name are very long), feel free to reverse the word order of the formulation pattern to this: `<descriptor>` *Title in Title Case* (`technical name`)

End of 'Localization': English

## Software Entities Such as Tools or Engines

> **Note**
>
> There's always a gray area. Software entities such as "A/administration C/cockpit" or "UI C/component W/workbench" are difficult to refer to. There's often no approved name. But the 3-element formulation pattern (title, technical name, descriptor) doesn't really fit either.

**Verify that the entity name is like a proper noun.**

First, rule out that there's an approved name on the *SAP Brand* site (because if so, those rules would apply). Then check whether the name of the software entity is like a proper noun. Proper nouns do not have a plural. They only refer to one thing. For example, there is only one BAdI Builder (a tool) in an ABAP system but there are many BAdIs in the system, each with a title and a technical name.

**Apply pragmatic formulation patterns, as appropriate for proper nouns.**

Here they are:

- Only valid for 'Localization': English
  **English:** Use title case.
  End of 'Localization': English
- Do **not** format the name. It's a name, not a title. You wouldn't format names of people either.
- Use an article.
- Do not precede these phrases with "SAP" because this is reserved for approved names.
- Only valid for 'Localization': German
  **German:** Consider translating the name. If you decide on the English name, apply German hyphenation rules. For more information, see German: Komposita mit englischen Wörtern (nicht im Rechtschreibduden) [page 297].
  End of 'Localization': German
- Enter the name in SAPterm.

> **Example**
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **English:** The BAdI Builder ...
>
> End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** Der BAdI-Builder ...

End of 'Localization': German

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **English:** The UI Component Workbench ...

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** Die UI-Komponenten-Workbench ...

End of 'Localization': German

## Software and AI

> ⓘ Note
>
> **Terminology**: Artifical intelligence (AI) is defined as the simulation of human intelligence processes by machines and computer systems. There are different types of AI systems, but what they have in common is that they're considered as part of software.

**Make it obvious that users are interacting with AI.**

When talking about AI, use the name of the AI you're referring to.

> ✤ Example
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **Joule** offers conversational interactions between humans and computers to simplify access to information and automate business processes.
>
> End of 'Localization': English

Avoid using pronouns, if possible. If your text becomes repetitive, you can use the pronoun *it* or stay with approved qualifiers. Keep in mind that AI is part of software, and that pronouns can vary in different languages.

**Specify the type of AI, if possible.**

Add qualifiers that are approved, for example, by *SAP Brand*.

> ✤ Example
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ The **Joule capability** will be embedded in products across the portfolio.
>
> End of 'Localization': English

For more information on AI brand guidelines, see https://url.sap/brand-ai.

# 5.4 English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case)

English has different styles of capitalization: sentence style and title case (also known as “initial caps” or “headline style”). What's the difference? When to use which capitalization style?

## Basics: Sentence Style, Title Case, and All Uppercase

**Use sentence style and title case as outlined in the table.**

| Type | Where | How |
|---|---|---|
| **Sentence style:**<br>✔ This example sentence is written in sentence style. | Body text | **Lowercase for all words**. First letter of the first word in a sentence of course in uppercase. That's the normal style in English.<br>**Exception:** Uppercase for the first letters of proper nouns and names (each element) |
| **Title case:**<br>✔ Example Title or Heading or Caption in Title Case | Titles, headings, captions, and names<br>This includes: document titles, topic titles, section or keyblock titles in a topic, captions for graphics and table, column headings, product names and other approved names, as well as titles (names) of software objects and user interface elements | **Uppercase for the first letter of major words**. Simplified summary:<br>• Always the first and last word<br>• Nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs<br>• Prepositions with 5 or more letters, for example, “About”<br>• Determiners and pronouns, for example, “This” or “Your” |

**Do not use all caps.**

**Never**. Neither in topics nor on the user interface. It decreases readability.

## Title Case in Detail

| Criterion | First Letter in Uppercase | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|
| Positioning of words | The first and the last word, no matter what part of speech they are | Changes in the System Landscape<br>An Idea to Start With<br>Created By |

| Criterion | First Letter in Uppercase | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|
| Words carrying meaning | • Nouns and gerunds<br>• Verbs, including all forms of "Be"<br>• Participles<br>• Adjectives<br>• Adverbs, including "Than" after comparatives and "Not" | Installing Updates<br>To Be or Not to Be<br>How to Implement Mandatory Changes Quickly<br>More Options Than Expected<br>The Secrets of Business Add-Ins (BAdIs) [Note: "in" is not used as a preposition but as an adverb, therefore "Add-In", not "Add-in".] |
| Determiners and pronouns | • "This", "That", "These", "Those" [Note: The articles "the", "a", and "an" are lowercase.]<br>• "All", "Any", "Some", "Every", and so on<br>• "What", "Which", "Who", "Whose", "Where", and so on<br>• "You", "They", "Hers", "Its", "Them", and so on | What to Do When Every Option Has Some Surprises<br>All About Your Decisions from Our Perspective |
| Prepositions | Prepositions of 5 or more letters, for example, "About", "Between", "During", "Through", or "Without" | All About the Current Situation<br>Just Between You and Me<br>Seen Through the Eyes of Our Customers<br>News from the CEO<br>Places to Go<br>Based on Experience<br>Based in London |
| Prepositions used as adverbs | All prepositions that form part of a verb phrase (for example, "sign in") | Sold-to Party [Note: "to" is not part of the verb phrase "to sell something \| to someone".]<br>Signing In to the System [Note: "In" is part of the verb phrase "to sign in \| to something".]<br>Tune In in March for the Conclusion [Note: "In" is part of the verb phrase "to tune in \| to something". The second "in" is a preposition with less than 5 letters.] |
| Conjunctions | All subordinating conjunctions, for example, "Because", "If", "That", or "When"<br>[Note: The coordinating conjunctions "and", "but", or "or" are lowercase.] | What to Do If Everything Goes Wrong<br>Updates and Changes |

| Criterion | First Letter in Uppercase | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- | --- |
| In combination with punctuation marks | • Capitalize **hyphenated** words as if they were separate words.<br>• Capitalize words in **parentheses ( )** as if they did not appear in parentheses.<br>• Any word after a **colon (:)** in a title counts as a first word, and is therefore in upper-case. | Sold-to Party [Note: See also rules for prepositions.]<br>Self-Service Material<br>Self-Service Material (in Public APIs)<br>Self-Service Material: An Idea to Start With |

## When Not to Use Title Case

**Do not use title case for normal, everyday words in body text.**

This will result in overuse of title case, which doesn't make texts more readable. In most cases, title case is not necessary anyway. Remember: In English, title case is reserved for titles, headings, names, and proper nouns. Here's also a helpful rule of thumb for proper nouns: If there can be more than one of something, it's probably not a proper noun and does not merit title case. For more information, see the Wikipedia article on proper nouns.

Ok, you may be tempted to use title case for normal, everyday words because these words are somehow special. For example, they refer to something new or important, or to a software object or concept. Now if you apply these criteria, there will be more and more title case in body text. But specialness and newness will fade away over time. Also, users will wonder why some words are written in title case and others in lowercase or why the same word is sometimes written in title case and sometimes not.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ business process, intellectual property, source code review, server room, application server, meter reading result, situation handling, error handling, user assistance [Note: These are just some random examples without any need for title case.]
>
> ✔ the World Wide Web Consortium (W3C), the White House, the Great Lakes [Note: These are proper nouns.]
>
> ✔ After setting the task to done, you won't be able to work on it any longer. Do you want to continue?
>
> ✘ After setting the Task to Done, you won't be able to work on it any longer. Do you want to Continue? [Note: For all words in title case, there are equivalents in the software (say an object, dropdown list, and a button). But this fact is neither decisive nor important. Users will just think “odd spelling”.]
>
> ✔ You can help users focus on specific circumstances if you bring important issues to their attention. For example, they get a heads-up for an upcoming deadline or are informed about an event across work streams. Power users can use the *Manage Situation Types* app to adapt messages and notification recipients.

❌ You can help Users focus on specific circumstances if you bring important Issues to their attention. For example, they get a heads-up for an upcoming Deadline or are informed about an Event across Work Streams. Power Users can use the *Manage Situation Types* app to adapt Messages and Notification Recipients. [Note: "the *Manage Situation Types* app" is the only phrase where title case is correct. "Manage Situation Types" is the title (name) of an app.]

### Related Information

Common User Interface Elements [page 119]
SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183]
Software Objects and Entities [page 193]

## 5.5 Titles and Headings

Titles and headings make content easy to scan, not only for the reader but also for search engines. Therefore, make sure that titles and headings are informative signposts of the content to follow. Important aspects are keywords, nominal or verbal formulation, and singular or plural nouns.

> ⓘ Note
>
> **Terminology:** "Title" primarily refers to document titles and topic titles, but also to titles (names) of software objects. "Heading" primarily refers to section or keyblock titles in a topic, graphic titles (captions), table titles (captions), and column headings. For the sake of simplicity, the umbrella term "title" is used.

### Basics

**Formulate titles as short as possible and as long (informative) as necessary. Consider the context.**

The challenge is to find a good balance. There are no absolute standards for this. A good title is determined by context: Does it relate to and contrast with other titles at the same level and around it? Is it an informative signpost of the content to follow? Does it contain the relevant keywords? Does it meet the expectations of the target group?

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Meter Data Unification and Synchronization
>
> ❌ MDUS

✔ Retrieving Archived Contracts

✘ Calling Up the ES21 Transaction for Archived Documents

✔ Approving a Leave Request [Note: This smells of stating the obvious. Is such a topic required at all? The user interface needs to be self-explanatory.]

✘ Setting the *Confirmed* Flag in Leave Requests

**Use plural or singular nouns in titles as appropriate.**

Sometimes users act on one thing, sometimes on more than one.

✤ Example

✔ Setting Up the System Landscape

✔ Setting Up Authorizations

**Formulate titles so that they indicate whether it is procedural or conceptual information. Be consistent in this.**

To indicate the type of information, use the following **formulation patterns**:

- For procedural information, use a verbal formulation.
- For conceptual information, use a nominal formulation.

## Formulation Patterns in Detail

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
|---|---|
| Procedural information (tasks, procedures, how to) | |
| **English:** Gerund<br><br>Use a preferred verb from the controlled vocabulary. For more information, see Controlled Vocabulary (= list of verbs) on the *Ask the Editors* community.<br><br>In certain contexts, there may be reasons (for example, contrasting related concepts and tasks) to use the imperative or "How to `<Verb Phrase>`" instead. That's fine as long as the use case is well researched and clearly defined. **Nevertheless, the standard formulation pattern is and remains the gerund.** | Setting Up Authorizations<br><br>✘ Set Up Authorizations [Note: The imperative pattern is sometimes said to work for more fine-grained tasks. But then, what exactly is a fine-grained task?]<br><br>✘ How to Set Up Authorizations [Note: "How to" is redundant. Also, imagine a sequence of topic titles that all start with "How to" – rather hard to scan because the meaningful words are not fronted. However, in a set of conceptual topics, a "How to" topic title makes the procedural information easy to find. But if this topic is reused, the title will clash with gerund titles.] |

| Formulation Pattern | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- |
| **German:** Verbal formulation with infinitive | Berechtigungen einstellen<br>✘ Einstellen der Berechtigungen |
| Conceptual information (concepts, reference, what is) | |
| **English:** Nominal formulation | Authorizations<br>Authorization Concept |
| **German:** Nominal formulation | Berechtigungen<br>Berechtigungskonzept |

## Punctuation and Capitalization

| | |
| --- | --- |
| **English: Use title case.** | For more information and exceptions, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199]. |
| **Use colons (:), parentheses ( ), and questions marks (?) with care. Don't overdo it.** | The same applies to exclamation points (!), which are even less recommended in titles because they can have an offensive connotation. As for periods (.), do not use them in titles. |

## Formatting

| | |
| --- | --- |
| **Do not use additional formatting in titles.** | Titles are already set off from body text by typographic means, such as font and font size. If a title might be misunderstood because of missing formatting, try rephrasing. If rephrasing doesn't work, use quotation marks ("...") as a last resort.<br>**Exception:** If technically possible, format technical names such as parameter names with the appropriate tag. |

## Related Information

Structuring: Topics, Links, Lists, Tables, and More [page 237]

# 5.6 Abbreviations

Abbreviations have their pros and cons. They save space and can be an efficient means of communication between experts. But if abbreviations are not familiar to the target group, they cause confusion. So how can you best deal with abbreviations?

> ⓘ Note
>
> The following abbreviation standards do **not** apply to the approved names on the *SAP Brand* site or to third-party software or companies. For more information, see SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183].

## Basics

**Less is more. But no abbreviation is best, especially on the user interface.**

Abbreviations (including acronyms) negatively affect readability and comprehensibility. They increase the cognitive load because you have to remember what they stand for. Now imagine there are lots of abbreviations, maybe you're not familiar with the subject matter. This will simply put you off. Therefore, use abbreviations only in exceptional cases.

Also, sometimes people tend to use abbreviations (typically acronyms) just because they are too lazy to spell the full form. That's human, but not user-friendly. Similarly, if you introduce an abbreviation and then only use it once or twice, why do you use it at all? And then there are texts that alternate between the full form and the abbreviation. That isn't a good approach either.

**Translation:** Abbreviations are difficult for translation. If translators don't know what the abbreviation stands for (especially on-the-fly abbreviations due to space restrictions), they can't translate it. This is also a good indicator that the text or the user interface is not as self-explanatory as assumed.

**Exception:**

- In text and on the user interface, you can use an abbreviation (mostly an acronym) if it is **more common than the full form** or if it is a standard or industry abbreviation. To be on the safe side, verify this with the target group and consult the relevant standard reference works, for example, *Merriam-Websters' Collegiate Dictionary*.
- On the **user interface**, the main reason for using an abbreviation is space restrictions. Try rephrasing first. Also, modern user interface technologies often provide other means of avoiding abbreviations. For example, even if text is truncated, the user can resize a screen area or get a tooltip (mouseover) to display the full text. For more information, see Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111].

> Example
>
> ✔ ID, PC, a.m., PhD, CET [Note: These abbreviations are more common than the full forms.]
>
> ✔ ABAP [Note: For developers, “ABAP” is more common than “Advanced Business Application Programming”.]
>
> ✘ PyC [Note: The abbreviation “PyC” (for “payment currency”) was defined for SAP-GUI screens (ages ago), because of space restrictions on this type of user interface. It's not meant to be used in text and on other types of user interfaces, though.]

**If you can't avoid using an abbreviation, enter it in SAPterm.**

You may need the abbreviation for translation reasons or you want the abbreviation (most likely an acronym) to be the common form to be used. However, the fact that an abbreviation is in SAPterm does not mean that you're supposed to use it. Again: No abbreviation is best.

**Do not use CamelCase in abbreviations.**

On-the-fly CamelCase abbreviations of normal, translatable words are unnecessary jargon and negatively affect the readability of the source text. Such CamelCase abbreviations are confusing for translators and may lead to incorrect or incomprehensible text in the target languages.

**Translation:** CamelCase is actually an indicator for translators that the word in CamelCase is not to be translated.

**Exception:** CamelCase is fine in technical names because they are not translated. However, use CamelCase in technical names only if required by the programming language or other naming conventions.

## First Occurrence in Body Text or in a Title (Heading, Caption)

**Prerequisite:** You've tried everything but you can't avoid using the abbreviation.

**At first occurrence, use the full form followed by the abbreviation in parentheses ( ). After this, use the abbreviation.**

“First occurrence” refers to the first occurrence of the abbreviation in a reusable text unit. Assume this to be a topic. But it can also be a text fragment below topic level.

Do not give both the full form and the abbreviation many times in the same topic. This defeats the purpose of introducing the abbreviation.

**Exception:**

- If an abbreviation is more common than the full form, use the abbreviation straightaway without introducing the full form first. If in doubt, check with the target group.
- In print-only documents, you can alternatively provide an abbreviation list and use the abbreviations straightaway.

Do not use abbreviations in titles (headings, captions). If there are space restrictions, try rephrasing.

**Exception:** If rephrasing doesn't work, use the abbreviation in the title. In the body text after the title, provide the full form with the abbreviation in parentheses ( ).

## Acronyms

When having to create an acronym, make sure that there are no unwanted surprises.

Acronyms need to meet the following criteria:

- No established use with a different meaning in the area of business or industry, especially outside of SAP
- No undesirable connotation, such as “WC”, “PMS”, or “SS”

Form the plural of acronyms without an apostrophe (').

Example

✔ BAPIs, PCs, IDs

English: Use indefinite articles before acronyms as you would in speech.

Some letters of the alphabet are pronounced with an initial vowel, such as “s”. This requires the indefinite article “an”.

Example

✔ a BAPI, an SAP solution

Only valid for 'Localization': English

## English: No Latin Abbreviations

Do not use Latin abbreviations. Instead, use the full English equivalent.

Example

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ✔ Full form | for example, such as, like | that is | and so on | note | and others | opposed to, versus | compare |
| ✘ Latin abbreviation | e.g. | i.e. | etc. | n.b. | et al. | vs. | cf. |

**Exception:** In case of space restrictions (for example, on the user interface), it's ok to use common Latin abbreviations such as "e.g." This is even advocated by the *Chicago Manual of Style*: i.e., e.g., etc.. Alternatively, try to rephrase.

End of 'Localization': English

### Miscellaneous

| | |
|---|---|
| **Use "and" instead of ampersand (&), plus sign (+), or similar special characters.** | Basically, "&", "+", and the like are considered unnecessary abbreviations – why abbreviate if you can write it out? Also, in some development or user interface environments (for example, ABAP), ampersands are used to introduce variables. So there might be technical implications.<br><br>**Exception:** "&", "+", and the like are part of an approved name or any third-party software or companies. Also, these special characters can be a last resort in case of space restrictions. But don't forget that there might be unwanted technical implications. |
| **In abbreviations with periods, such as "a.m.", do not use a space.** | For more information, see Spaces [page 302]. |

### Related Information

Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157]

## 5.7 Numbers

Numbers help communicate valuable information and impact the user's comprehension of your content. And the most basic question is when to spell out numbers and when to use numerals.

### Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| **As a general rule, spell out numbers one through nine, but use numerals for 10 and higher.** | This also applies to ordinal numbers, such as "first" and "10th". Note that this general rule has many exceptions or special cases. |

#### Example

✔ There are two optional steps in the installation procedure.

✔ A tweet contains 140 characters.

**Exception: Use only numerals when you want to draw the attention to the number.**

Here are some typical cases when to use only numerals:

- A sentence or paragraph contains many numbers. They form a series. By using only numerals you can avoid a mixture of numerals and spelled-out numbers.
- The number refers to figures, ages, times, dates, years, units of measurement, dimensions, currencies, page numbers, percentages, telephone numbers, or similar.
- The number is used in formulations such as "`<number>` or more", "up to `<number>`", or "`<number>` of the following `<noun>`".

#### Example

✔ The software was developed with 4 customers. It was launched in 2022 after 3 months development time.

✔ The company has 27 subsidiaries worldwide – 7 in North America, 11 in Europe, and 9 in Asia.

✔ If there are 5 or more errors, the transport is stopped. [Note: You could also write "more than 4 errors". There's no semantic difference. But it's easier to remember formulations such as "5 or more" because the numeral indicates where the number range starts.]

**Use only the spelled-out number in fixed phrases such as "third party".**

#### Example

✔ first name, third-party company, third person [grammar], first-language proficiency, first [adverb], the twenty-first century

**Exception :** If there are space restrictions, use the numeral. What else can you do? However, do not use superscript.

**For negative numbers, write the minus sign (-) directly before the number.**

For more information, see also Currencies [page 216].

#### Example

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **English:** USD –100

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** –100 EUR

End of 'Localization': German

## Number Ranges

**Use an en dash (–) for number ranges.**

Do not leave a space on either side of the en dash.

**Exception:** For the sake of parallel formulations, use “from ... to ...” instead of “from ... – ...”. Similarly this applies to “between ... and ...”.

Example

✔ Only use the numerals 0–9 and the letters A–Z in your password.

✔ The conference will take place on April 2–4, 2022.

✔ From 2020 to 2022, the sales revenue increased considerably.

**Make clear where the number range exactly begins.**

Ranges such as “50–150,000 views” are ambiguous. It is not clear whether the initial value is 50 or 50,000. Use “to” in cases of ambiguity.

Example

✔ The page has 50,000–150,000 views per day. [Note: The number range is between the number 50,000 and the number 150,000.]

✔ The page has 50 to 150,000 views per day. [Note: The number range is between the number 50 and the number 150,000.]

## Related Information

Formatting Data Overview (SAP Fiori Design Guidelines)

## 5.7.1 Decimal and Thousand Separators

Decimal and thousand separators are language-specific. And then there's the question how to refer to millions and billions. Let's have a look.

### Basics

**Use the language-specific decimal separator.**

For example, English uses the decimal point (.) but German uses the decimal comma (,). If the fraction is smaller than 1, use a leading zero (0).

> ✤ Example
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **English:** You will need 2.5 days for this but consider the 0.5 days to be a buffer.
>
> End of 'Localization': English
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': German
>
> ✔ **German:** Sie benötigen hierfür 2,5 Tage, aber darin enthalten sind 0,5 Tage Puffer.
>
> End of 'Localization': German

**For numbers with 4 or more digits before the decimal separator, use the language-specific thousand separator.**

For example, English uses a comma (,) but German uses a point (.). Start left of the decimal separator and separate the amount into groups of 3 digits. Don't group the decimals. Use this grouping method always in tables, in financial contexts such as business reports, in texts that contain many numbers, and for numbers that are combined with units of measurement or currencies.

Admittedly, there are cases when a thousand separator may look odd, especially if the number is not high (say 1500), there's no unit of measurement or currency attached and it's possibly the only number in the text. In such a case, it's ok to omit the thousand separator. You might even avoid confusion by doing so.

**Exception:** For telephone numbers, area codes, zip codes, bank account numbers, or other types of numbers, different grouping conventions may apply. For example, the separator could be a space and the digits may be separated into groups of two. The conventions may also be specific to industry, language, country, or region. On the user interface, different conventions may apply, as appropriate for localization and user experience.

> ✤ Example
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **English:** 7,654,321 hits, 25,500 kg, USD 5,000 [but if stand-alone:] 1500 persons
>
> End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** 7.654.321 Treffer, 25.500 kg, 5.000 EUR [but if stand-alone:] 1500 Personen

End of 'Localization': German

## Millions and Billions

To make large numbers easier to read, consider using words instead of thousand separators.

**Exception:** On the user interface, different conventions may apply, as appropriate for localization and user experience.

### Example

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **English:** 10 million hits, 10 billion apples

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** 10 Millionen Treffer, 10 Milliarden Äpfel

End of 'Localization': German

If there are space restrictions, consider using abbreviations.

Align for your product area or software type when to use which abbreviation. Here are some suggestions:

- In **table cells or column headings**, consider using the following abbreviations:

  Only valid for 'Localization': English

  **English:** “thsd”, “mil”, and “bil” (according to *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary*)

  End of 'Localization': English

  Only valid for 'Localization': German

  **German:** “Tsd.”, “Mio.”, and “Mrd.” (according to the Rechtschreibduden)

  End of 'Localization': German

- On the **user interface**, especially if it's mobile, there are often severe space restrictions. Consider using “K” for thousands, “M” for millions, and “B” for billions. Consult the *SAP Fiori Design Guidelines*.

## Related Information

Formatting Data Overview (SAP Fiori Design Guidelines)

## 5.7.2 Units of Measurement and Scientific Symbols

The International System of Units (SI – from French "Système International d'Unités") is the most used system of measurement worldwide. Here are some things that are good to know.

### Basics

**Use metric units of measurement.**

For example, specify distances in kilometers, not in miles. Use the language-neutral standard abbreviation or symbol. Note that these never get a plural "s".

You can find the units of measurement and their abbreviations on the Internet. For example, see Metric System (Merriam-Webster), or Common Conversion Factors (National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST), U.S. Department of Commerce).

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Palo Alto lies 33 km south of San Francisco International Airport.
>
> ✔ The area is 10 $km^2$.

**If you refer to the unit of measurement without a quantity, use the language-specific term for the unit of measurement.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ In the United States, distances are measured in miles instead of kilometers.

**In combinations or ranges, use the unit of measurement for each occurrence of a value.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ 10 mm × 17 mm

**English: If a nonmetric unit is more common in North America, add it in parentheses ( ).**

In scientific and academic circles, Americans are definitely switching over to metric. But sometimes they stick to the nonmetric ways. For example, paper measurements are almost always described in inches. Similarly, height and weight are still more commonly described in feet and pounds. Here are some equivalents: 1 mm = 0.04 in, 1 cm = 0.39 in, 1 m = 3.28 ft or 1.09 yd, 1 km = 0.62 mi, 1 ml = 0.03 fl oz, 1 l = 2.11 pt or 0.26 gal, 1 g = 0.035 oz, 1 kg = 2.21 lb

**Translation:** In all other languages, omit the nonmetric equivalent.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The required paper size is 21 cm × 29.7 cm (8.19 in × 11.58 in).

✔ Palo Alto lies 33 km (21 mi) south of San Francisco International Airport. [Note: There are several abbreviations for “mile”. The abbreviation “mi” is used by the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST). It's not ambiguous as opposed to “m”. However, in combinations such as “mph” for miles per hour, it's “m” instead of “mi”.]

## Common Units of Measurements

| English: Unit of Measurement | German: Unit of Measurement | Abbreviation |
|---|---|---|
| **Time** | | |
| millisecond | Millisekunde | ms |
| second | Sekunde | s |
| minute | Minute | min |
| hour | Stunde | h |
| day | Tag | d |
| week | Woche | wk |
| month | Monat | mo |
| year | Jahr | yr |
| **Length** | | |
| millimeter | Millimeter | mm |
| centimeter | Zentimeter | cm |
| meter | Meter | m |
| kilometer | Kilometer | km |
| **Volume** | | |
| milliliter | Milliliter | ml |
| liter | Liter | l |
| **Mass or Weight** | | |
| milligram | Milligramm | mg |

| English: Unit of Measurement | German: Unit of Measurement | Abbreviation |
|---|---|---|
| gram | Gramm | g |
| kilogram | Kilogramm | kg |
| ton | Tonne | t |
| **Temperature** | | |
| degree Celsius | Grad Celsius | °C |
| degree Fahrenheit | Grad Fahrenheit | °F |

## Percentages

**English:** Do not use a space between the numeral and the percentage symbol.

For information about verb agreement with percentages, see English: Singular Versus Plural Constructions [page 280].

> Example
>
> ✔ 5% of the participants

**German:** Use a space between the numeral and the percentage symbol.

> Example
>
> ✔ 5 % der Teilnehmer

## Standard Prefixes

**In compound units of measurement, use standard prefixes.**

The following table contains common prefixes. You can find more prefixes for units of measurement on the Internet. Search for **`SI units of measurement prefixes`**.

| Prefix | Full Form | ✔Correct Example |
|---|---|---|
| k | kilo | 1 kg [Note: But it's "1 KB".] |
| M | mega | 1 MB |
| G | giga | 1 GB |

| Prefix | Full Form | ✔Correct Example |
|---|---|---|
| T | tera | 1 TB |
| P | peta | 1 PB |
| c | centi | 1 cm |
| m | milli | 1 ml |

> **Note**
>
> You may need to make clear whether kilobyte (and the other "byte" compounds) is used with a binary or metric meaning. For customers, the difference between metric (1024 bytes) and binary (1000 bytes) can result in an expensive surprise.

### Related Information

Formatting Data Overview (SAP Fiori Design Guidelines)
SI Brochure: The International System of Units (SI)
Die gesetzlichen Einheiten in Deutschland

## 5.7.3 Currencies

The ISO 3-letter codes for currencies are used worldwide in banking and business. They are stable and unique. Yet there are some things to know, for example, the sequence of amount and currency code.

### Basics

**Use the ISO 3-letter code for currencies.**

You can find the ISO currency codes on the Internet. For example, see Codes for Trade, which are published by the United Nations Economic Commission for Europe (UNECE). The currency codes are defined in the ISO standard *Currency Codes* (ISO 4217). The ISO currency codes are portable, stable, and unique as opposed to currency symbols, such as the dollar ($) or pound (£ or £) symbols. You won't need to think about special characters, Unicode code points, or ALT codes.

**Exception:** On the user interface, different conventions may apply, as appropriate for localization and user experience.

Example

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **English:** The price is EUR 100. [Note: The sequence is currency before amount.]

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** Der Preis ist 100 EUR. [Note: The sequence is amount before currency.]

End of 'Localization': German

If you refer to a currency without an amount, use the language-specific term for the currency (for example, “euros”).

Example

✔ You can pay in euros or dollars.

As a general rule, use dollars for texts written in English and euros for texts written in German.

**Translation:** It depends on audience, subject matter, and other context criteria whether you localize the currency, that is, whether you use a currency that's typical for the target language. In the case of example data, clarify whether the data is available in the relevant target languages.

**Exception:** In country/region-specific texts, such as localized versions for payroll, use the relevant national currency.

## Punctuation

If a sum of money has no digits after the decimal mark (point or comma), omit the decimal mark and the double zero (00).

**Exception:** A different sum of money in the same sentence or paragraph has digits after the decimal mark. On the user interface, different conventions may apply, as appropriate for localization and user experience.

Example

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **English:** Each piece costs USD 70.

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** Das Einzelstück kostet 70 EUR.

End of 'Localization': German

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **Exception for English:** Each piece costs USD 70.00 net or USD 74.45 gross.

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **Exception for German:** Das Einzelstück kostet 70,00 EUR netto und 74,45 EUR brutto.

End of 'Localization': German

**For sums of money with 4 or more digits, use separators.**

Note that separators are language specific.

**Exception:** On the user interface, different conventions may apply, as appropriate for localization and user experience.

Example

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **English:** USD 1,234,567.89

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** 1.234.567,89 EUR

End of 'Localization': German

**In negative sums of money, write the minus sign (–) immediately before the amount.**

Do not leave a space between minus sign and amount.

Example

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **English:** USD –100

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** –100 EUR

End of 'Localization': German

## Related Information

Formatting Data Overview (SAP Fiori Design Guidelines)

## 5.7.4 Dates and Times

For dates and times there are many conventions, depending on country and language. So it's important to agree on a date and time format that can't be misinterpreted. For example, “May 1, 2022” is clear whereas “01/05/2022” is ambiguous.

### Basics

**Write months as words and years as 4 digits.**

This avoids misinterpretation.

**Exception:** On the user interface, different conventions may apply, as appropriate for localization and user experience.

> Example
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **English:** On August 5, 2024, the project was started. [Note: The pattern is Month DD, YYYY.]
>
> End of 'Localization': English
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **English:** On Monday, August 5, 2024, the project was started. [Note: This is just in case you want to mention the weekday.]
>
> End of 'Localization': English
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✘ **English:** On 08/05/2022, the project was started. [Note: This is ambiguous for a global audience. There are different conventions in different countries, regions, and languages. Some people might interpret it as MM/DD/YYYY, others as DD/MM/YYYY.]
>
> End of 'Localization': English
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': German
>
> ✔ **German:** Am 5. August 2022 begann das Projekt. [Note: The pattern is DD. Month YYYY.]
>
> End of 'Localization': German
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': German
>
> ✔ **German:** Am Montag, dem 5. August 2024 begann das Projekt. [Note: This is just in case you want to mention the weekday. For more information, see Verbindungen aus Wochentag und Kalendertag (D32) im Rechtschreibduden.]
>
> End of 'Localization': German

**Make clear whether the time is a.m. or p.m.**

This avoids misinterpretation.

**Exception:** On the user interface, different conventions may apply, as appropriate for localization and user experience.

> **Example**
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **English:** 8:00 a.m., 6:15 p.m.
>
> End of 'Localization': English
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': German
>
> ✔ **German:** 8:00 Uhr, 18:15 Uhr
>
> End of 'Localization': German

**If you need to mention the time zone, use the abbreviated form in parentheses ( ).**

You can find the time zone abbreviations on the Internet. For some time zones, the same abbreviation is used. For example, “IST” can refer to “Israel Standard Time” or to “India Standard Time”. If needs be, disambiguate.

> **Example**
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **English:** 3:00 a.m. (CST), 10:00 a.m. (UTC), 11:00 a.m. (CET), 12:00 a.m. (IST Israel), 3:30 p.m. (IST India)
>
> End of 'Localization': English
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': German
>
> ✔ **German:** 3:00 Uhr (CST), 10:00 Uhr (UTC), 11:00 Uhr (MEZ), 12:00 Uhr (IST Israel), 15:30 Uhr (IST Indien)
>
> End of 'Localization': German

> **Note**
>
> YYYY-MM-DD hh:mm:ss is the **machine-readable** date and time format used for data exchange between systems. It's defined in an ISO standard called *Data elements and interchange formats – Information interchange – Representation of dates and times* (ISO 8601). This date and time format is not relevant for body text and the user interface. In the software it typically appears in log files. So you might need to use it in technical texts. If so, use hyphens (-) as separators.

## Related Information

Formatting Data Overview (SAP Fiori Design Guidelines)

## 5.7.5 Telephone Numbers

Follow these guidelines when you deal with telephone numbers in text (but don't necessarily extend these rules to the user interface).

### Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| **Separate the groups of digits using the conventions for the country or region (for example, hyphens or spaces).** | Do not use an en dash (–) in place of the hyphen (-). Do not place any groups of digits in parentheses. |
| **When writing international telephone numbers, include the country/region code, preceded immediately by a plus sign (+).** | The plus sign indicates that additional numbers are required, which may vary according to where the call is being made from. And: Don't forget to omit the zero (0) before the area code. |

Example

✔ **Germany:** +49 6227 7-12345

✔ **United States:** +1 610-661-1000

### Related Information

Formatting Data Overview (SAP Fiori Design Guidelines)
Text on the User Interface – The Basics [page 111]

## 5.8 Geographic Names

Geographic names (countries, regions, cities, mountains, and so on) are proper names. They sometimes have equivalents (translated forms) in other languages and sometimes not. How can you deal with this in the source text and in translation?

### Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| **If a geographic name has a language-** | Otherwise use the geographic name as spelled in its original language. This includes accents and language-specific characters (authoring/translation tools permitting). |

**specific form in the language in which you are writing, use it.**

In terms of mindset, imagine being an end user, you'd certainly like to see the geographic name in your language. For example on the user interface, assuming you're a German-speaking end user, you'd expect “Sachsen” instead of “Saxony” on the German user interface and in the German documentation. Likewise, English-speaking users expect “Saxony” and Russian-speaking users “Саксония”.

**Translation:** This applies analogously to translators and their target languages (geographic name in the target language, otherwise in the original language of the geographic name).

## Geopolitical Dimension

**Be aware of the geopolitical dimension of geographic names.**

For more information, see Country/Region-Specific Guidance in the Product Standard for Globalization and the related requirement Country and Region Handling (GLOB-192).

## How to Research the Language-Specific Form

**Research the geographic name in your language.**

You'll need to weigh your findings against each other.There is no one-solution-fits-all approach to this. If things get too complicated (for example, other writing systems), contact a localization expert from Language Experience Lab (LX Lab).

Here are some general recommendations:

- Look up the geographic name in the relevant dictionary for your language. For example, in English it's *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary* and in German the Rechtschreibduden.
- Try Wikipedia. Wikipedia lists the original name and the English form if available.
- Another good resource is the standard *Codes for the Representation of Names of Countries and Their Subdivisions – Part 2: Country Subdivision Code* (ISO 3166-2), as published on Wikipedia.
  From the country code (column 1), you can drill down in English (and lots of other Wikipedia languages) to the names of the different subdivisions of each country. The names are listed in their original language and if available, in the language in which you are writing. For example, see ISO_3166-2:DE, the Wikipedia language being English.

> ✤ Example
>
> [Note: These examples are for English.]
>
> ✔ Vienna [Note: In German, it's “Wien”. In *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary*, you get hits for both forms but “Vienna” is clearly classified as the English form.]

✔ Cádiz, Málaga [Note: Accented vowels preserved in *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary*.]

✔ Indre-et-Loire [Note: Not listed in *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary*. Only on Wikipedia, which only gives the French form.]

✘ Indre-and-Loire

✔ Ciudad Real [Note: Listed in *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary*. Also on Wikipedia, which provides an English form in quotation marks. This seems to indicate that this is a literal translation, not intended for use as a geograpic name. See also the "Côte-d'Or" example.]

✔ Côte-d'Or [Note: Listed in *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary*. Also on Wikipedia, which provides an English form in quotation marks and preceded with "literally".]

## 5.9 Examples – Names, Other Data, and How to Introduce Them

When describing examples, you will need names of people and companies and probably some address data or telephone numbers. The tricky thing is where to get such data and what to observe from a legal perspective. Also, how can you introduce and set off examples?

### Basics

**Describe bias-free examples.**

Exemplify diversity in society (culture, gender, age, ethnicity, and so on). For more information, see Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98].

**Use names and other data that are already available for your product area or software type.**

Ask your product team or the colleagues responsible for setting up demos.

**Make sure that the names and any other data in your examples do not infringe on the rights of others or security regulations.**

Here are the things you need to check:

- People and company names are **not humorous or negative**. The names are **not branded** either, which is often the case with famous or fictional names.
- People and company names and any related data (for example, addresses, telephone, email, passwords, or URLs) do **not** correspond to existing people and companies.

Why? For example, you wouldn't want your own telephone number published in a user guide, a video, or elsewhere. In addition, SAP might be held liable for improper use of names and data. For security reasons, do not mention internal or confidential information (for example, real users, their passwords, or internal telephone numbers) in user assistance or elsewhere.

## Generic First and Last Names

**If there are no example names for your product area or software type, use the generic people names in your examples.**

These names are common in the countries, regions, and languages from which they are taken. For example, "Peter" is a common first name in many parts of the world and "Patel" is a common last name in India. The names do not correspond to existing or famous persons. Admittedly, the names do correspond to existing persons but there are so many "Julie Armstrongs" that the name can't be related to a particular "Julie Armstrong". Here are the generic names:

| Language | Female Names | | Male Names | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| English | Julie | Armstrong | Michael | Adams |
| | Donna | Moore | John | Miller |
| | Denise | Smith | Peter | Wilson |
| German | Katrin | Bauer | Gerd | Becker |
| | Michaela | Schneider | Stefan | Bosch |
| | Sabine | Mayer | Thomas | Schmidt |
| French | Isabelle | Dupont | Alain | Chevalier |
| | Monique | Legrand | Laurent | Dubois |
| | Nathalie | Perrin | Michel | Leclerq |
| Spanish | Carmen | Fernandez | Francisco | Gomez |
| | Cristina | Lopez | Miguel | Rodriguez |
| | Teresa | Ruiz | Jose | Vega |
| Portuguese | Maria | Fontes | João | Pereira |
| | Rita | Machado | Pedro | da Silva |
| | Joana | Oliveira | Tiago | Santos |

| Language | Female Names | | Male Names | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Italian | Alessandra | Bertolini | Antonio | Ferrari |
| | Francesca | De Angelis | Giovanni | Ricci |
| | Roberta | Esposito | Marco | Rossi |
| Russian | Elena | Petrova | Mikhail | Komarov |
| | Marina | Sokolova | Oleg | Semenov |
| | Svetlana | Volkova | Vladimir | Zhukov |
| India (many languages) | Aneesha | Mishra | Karan | Agarwal |
| | Nandita | Patel | Rahul | Ghosh |
| | Veena | Singh | Ravi | Pandey |
| Chinese | Kathy | Liu | John | Li |
| | Jenny | Ma | Matthew | Zhao |
| | Xiaoli | Wang | Xiaoming | Zhou |
| Japanese | Aiko | Abe | Hiroshi | Akiyama |
| | Tomoko | Sato | Kenji | Kawashima |
| | Yoko | Ishida | Takahiro | Suzuki |

## Fake Links

If you need to fake links for whatever reason, use https://www.example.com as underlying URL.

You can use this domain in examples without prior coordination or asking for permission. For more information, see IANA-Managed Reserved Domains.

## How to Introduce and Set Off Examples

**Make it clear where the example starts and ends.**

The basic criterion is the size of your example. But also consider how the example relates to the surrounding text and topics. It gets a bit disproportionate if there's more example text than body text. Here's a general rule:

| Size of Example | How to Set Off |
|---|---|
| About a page or more | Topic with the title formulation pattern "Example: `<Example Title>`" |
| About half a page | Section or keyblock with the title "Example" |
| About 3–5 sentences and you want them to be set off from body text | Block element with example icon and signal word "Example", for example, like this:<br>**Example**<br>This is an example that I want to be set off from body text. It has an icon and a signal word. And this is the third sentence but there may be more sentences. 3–5 sentences are a rough guideline. |
| Word or sentence level | Formulations such as "for example" or "such as" – don't forget to get the commas right |

**Tools:** This style guide is tool agnostic. For information about formatting, see the user guide for your authoring tool.

## Related Information

English: Commas [page 306]

# 5.10 Prepositions to Be Used with Common Computer Terms

Prepositions are a tricky thing. Here's a list of preposition-noun combinations for common computer terms.

## Basics

**Before using the preposition-noun combinations, check whether the noun itself is appropriate in your context.**

For example, find out whether a piece of software needs to be referred to with the descriptor “application” or “solution”. Especially for user interface elements, there is often front-end-specific terminology. For more information, see Common User Interface Elements [page 119].

**Be aware that you might need to use a different preposition (as appropriate for the verb).**

Different verbs require different prepositions. For example, the term “PC” is to be used with the preposition “on” as in “the file on the PC”. But when you use a verb that denotes a change of direction, such as “move”, the preposition changes as in “move the file from the server to the PC”.

## System and Software

| English Term | Preposition | German Term | Preposition |
|---|---|---|---|
| screen | on the ... | Bild ... | auf dem ... |
| user interface | on the ... | Benutzungsoberfläche | auf der ... |
| application | in the ... | Anwendung | in der ... |
| solution | in the ... | Lösung | in der ... |
| program | in the ... | Programm | im ... |
| platform | on the ... | Plattform | auf der ... |
| software | in the ... | Software | in der ... |
| hardware | in the ... | Hardware | in der ... |
| system | in the ... | System | im ... |
| session | in the ... | Modus | im ... |
| front end | install on the ... | Frontend | auf dem ... installieren |
| back end | in the ... | Backend | im ... |

| English Term | Preposition | German Term | Preposition |
|---|---|---|---|
| database | in the ... | Datenbank | in der ... |
| server | on the ... | Server | auf dem ... |
| toolkit | in the ... | Toolkit | im Toolkit |
| workbench | in the ... | Workbench | in der ... |

## Computer

| English Term | Preposition | German Term | Preposition |
|---|---|---|---|
| PC | on the ... | PC | auf dem ... |
| disk | on the ... | Laufwerk | auf dem ... |
| hard drive | on the ... | Festplatte | auf der ... |
| path | under `<path>` | Pfad | unter `<Pfad>` |
| directory | in the ... | Verzeichnis | im ... |

## Web

| English Term | Preposition | German Term | Preposition |
|---|---|---|---|
| Internet, intranet | on the ... | Internet, Intranet | im ... |
| Web | on the ... | Web | im ... |
| Web site | on the ... | Webseite | auf der ... |
| home page | on the ... | Homepage | auf der ... |
| marketplace | on the ... | Marktplatz | auf dem ... |
| portal | on the ... | Portal | im ... |
| launchpad | on the ... | Launchpad | im ... |
| hub | on the ... | Hub | im ... |
| URL | at `<URL>` | URL | unter `<URL>` |

| English Term | Preposition | German Term | Preposition |
|---|---|---|---|
| community | in the ... | Community | in der ... |
| wiki | in the ...<br>[Note: But it's "on Wikipedia".] | Wiki | im ... |

> **Note**
>
> Terms such as "portal" or "marketplace" are sometimes part of an approved name. In this case, do not use an article; for example: "on SAP Help Portal". However, in other languages, an article might be required for grammatical reasons. For example, in German it's "im SAP Help Portal". "in SAP Help Portal" is simply not grammatical.

### Related Information

Common User Interface Elements [page 119]

## 5.11 English: No Plurals with "(s)" or "/s"

Even if it is tempting in English to use plural forms such as "contract(s)" or "order/s", this doesn't work in other languages. So how can you avoid the tempting "(s)" and "/s" and make life easier for translators?

### Basics

**Do not use plural forms such as "contract(s)" or "order/s".**

Neither in text (topics) nor on the user interface (for example, in labels or messages). Why not? "(s)" or "/s" plurals are hard to translate and will lead to awkward or unacceptable formulations in the target languages. In other words, this has a negative effect on the user experience, especially if such constructions appear on the user interface.

**Translation:** Noun plurals are not always as simple and regular as in English. Some languages have no plural form. Other languages require multiple plural forms depending on the number preceding the noun. For example, in Russian it makes a difference whether the number is 0, 1, 2–4, or 5 and more. Many languages have irregular plurals. In Russian, French, Italian, and many other languages, noun plurals also require verb and adjective agreement.

> Example
>
> ✘ **English:** Change the new contract(s).
>
> ✘ **German:** Ändern Sie den/die neuen Vertrag/Verträge.
>
> ✘ **French:** Modifiez le/les nouveau(x) contrat(s).

## Reformulation Patterns

**Get rid of "(s)" and "/s".**

Here are some suggestions:

| Reformulation Pattern | ✘ Before | ✔ After |
|---|---|---|
| **Plural only** – this is often sufficient | Change the contract(s).<br>Variant(s) [Note: Imagine this to be the title of a tab.] | Change the contracts.<br>Variants [Note: There are usually a couple of variants, not a single one.] |
| **"one or more"** – if you want to highlight that there can also be a single instance | Create backup file(s) for your content. | Create one or more backup files, as appropriate for your content. [Note: Check whether the plural form is sufficient.] |
| "`<singular>` or `<plural>`" – if you want to highlight that there can also be a single instance | Select the region(s) for the sales revenue report. | Select the region or regions for the sales revenue report. [Note: Check whether the plural form is sufficient.] |
| **"each", "every", or "any of"** – these pronouns cover singular and plural meanings | Drag the file(s) to the relevant folder(s).<br>Cloud(s) have a silver lining.<br>If the data set(s) is/are broken, it/they will be automatically updated. | Drag each file to the relevant folder.<br>Every cloud has a silver lining.<br>If any of the data sets is broken, it will be automatically updated. |
| **Disconnect number from noun** – this is a good strategy for dealing with variables, especially on the user interface | `<n>` document(s) were deleted.<br>`<n>` host(s) | Number of deleted documents: `<n>`<br>Number of hosts: `<n>` |

| Reformulation Pattern | ✗ Before | ✓ After |
|---|---|---|
| **Separate texts for singular and plural case** – however, if you mention a number, disconnect it from the noun | Contract(s) created | Contract created [Note: This is singular.]<br>Contracts created [Note: This is plural.]<br>Number of contracts created: <n> [Note: This is plural and a number.] |

## 5.12 Files and Folders – How to Refer to Them

Sometimes you need to refer to files or file types. But how exactly: TXT file, .txt file, or text file? And then, what's the difference between folders and directories? Slash (/) or back slash (\)? What about case sensitivity?

> ⓘ Note
>
> **Terminology:** "File type" specifies the type of file, for example, a text file or a spreadsheet. "File name extension" is the part of the file name that is preceded by the dot, for example, ".docx" in `Newsletter.docx`. The term "directory" is used at operating-system level (developer perspective), whereas "folder" is used on graphical user interfaces (user perspective). In other words, your choice of terminology depends on the operating system.

### Basics

**When referring to files and folders (directories), use uppercase and lowercase as well as slash (/) and back slash (\) according to the conventions of the environment, such as operating system or product-specific conventions.**

For example, Unix and Linux are case sensitive and use a slash (/) whereas Microsoft Windows is not case-sensitive and uses a back slash (\). If you quote file names, folders (directories), or paths from the development environment, do so exactly as found in the source. If something is wrong with the source (typos and so on), make sure that the source is corrected.

For information about naming conventions for files and folders (directories) that are released for the public or that are connected to user interface controls, see Naming Conventions in the Product Standard for Accessibility. For example, they recommend using short file names with natural-language words separated by blanks for the *Type Ahead* navigation pattern.

**Especially with longer paths, consider**

Use a complete introductory sentence, ended with a colon (:). Do not spread a single sentence over multiple paragraphs.

separating the path information syntactically from the sentence.

**Translation**: Clear-cut sentence segmentation is especially important for efficient translation.

> Example
>
> ✔ Copy the template to the following folder:
>
> `\\dwdf1234\Newsletter\templates\Microsoft Word\Work in progress` [Note: This is a long path.]
>
> ✔ Copy the template to `\\dwdf1234\Newsletter\templates\Microsoft Word\Work in progress`. [Note: This is also correct, but the preceding example is easier to read.]
>
> ✘ Copy the template to the
>
> `\\dwdf1234\Invented Share\Newsletter\templates\Microsoft Word\Work in progress`
>
> folder. [Note: The sentence consists of three paragraphs.]
>
> ✔ Copy the file to the `Draft` folder. [Note: This is a short path, where only the folder name is given.]

**Tools:** For information about formatting file names, folder names, or paths, see the user guide for your authoring tool.

This style guide is tool agnostic.

## File Names, File Types, and File Name Extensions

When referring to a specific file, write the file name extension in lowercase.

> Example
>
> ✔ Copy `NewsletterTemplate.docx` to the `Templates` folder.
>
> ✔ Download `NewsletterTemplate.docx`. [Note: Consider writing "Download the newsletter template." Maybe you don't have to be specific about the file name.]

When referring to a file type, distinguish between using a descriptive term and the file name extension.

Descriptive terms for file types usually have a broader meaning than related file name extensions. For example, "text file" and "TXT file" are not equivalent. "Text file" comprises the file types TXT, DOC, RTF, and so on whereas "TXT file" is simply a plain text file. If you decide on using the file name extension, write it in uppercase (makes the text easier to scan) and accompany it with a descriptor such as "file".

Example

✔ Text files contain either plain text or formatted text. [Note: That's very general information.]

✔ Executable files, such as EXE or BAT files, are used to ... [Note: By using examples, you can make generic terms more tangible. Note that the descriptor “file” is used.]

✔ Download the ZIP file.

✘ Download the ZIP.

✔ You can download the document as a PDF file. [or:] You can download the document as a PDF. [Note: In some cases such as “PDF”, the file name extension has evolved into a descriptive term. In such cases, you can omit the descriptor.]

✔ Since Microsoft Word 2007, Microsoft Word files have the `.docx` file name extension. [Note: Here's an example when to refer to a file name extension. Instead of “DOC files” or “DOCX files”, the descriptive term “Microsoft Word files” is used.]

**If the file type extension is not familiar to the target group, provide the full form with the acronym in parentheses ( ) at first occurrence.**

Example

✔ Save the file as an *Open Document Text* (ODT) file.

## 5.13 Special Characters – How to Refer to Them

Instead of using special characters and punctuation marks, you sometimes need to refer to them. For example, you are explaining the elements of a good password. What is the formulation pattern to use? What are the names of the special characters and punctuation marks?

### Basics

**Use this formulation pattern: `<name>` (`<symbol>`)**

Example

✔ Make sure that your password contains special characters, such as an ampersand (&) or an asterisk (*).

**In certain specific contexts, you may have to refer to a few symbols with a different term.**

Therefore, check whether the term in question is appropriate for the context. For example, the at sign (@) is pronounced "at" in email addresses. In a commercial context, however, the same symbol is referred to as "commercial at". For example, "tomatoes @ EUR 1", which is pronounced "tomatoes at one euro each". Similar examples could be given for the number sign (#) and the tilde (~).

## Single Characters

| Symbol | English Term | German Term |
|---|---|---|
| & | ampersand | kaufmännisches Und |
| @ | at sign | At-Zeichen |
| * | asterisk | Asterisk |
| # | number sign | Raute |
| § | section symbol | Paragrafenzeichen |
| ~ | tilde | Tilde |
| _ | underscore | Unterstrich |
| / | slash, forward slash | Schrägstrich |
| \ | backslash | inverser Schrägstrich |
| \| | vertical slash | vertikaler Strich |
| > | greater than sign | Größer-als-Zeichen |
| < | less than sign | Kleiner-als-Zeichen |
| = | equal sign | Gleichheitszeichen |
| - | hyphen | Bindestrich |
| – | en dash | Gedankenstrich |
| — | em dash | Spiegelstrich |
| + | plus sign | Pluszeichen |
| − | minus sign | Minuszeichen |
| ± | plus or minus sign | Plusminuszeichen |

| Symbol | English Term | German Term |
|---|---|---|
| × | multiplication sign | Multiplikationszeichen |
| ÷ | division sign | Divisionszeichen |
| ° | degree symbol | Gradzeichen |
| % | percent sign | Prozentzeichen |
| . | period | Punkt |
| ! | exclamation point | Ausrufezeichen |
| ? | question mark | Fragezeichen |
| , | comma | Komma |
| : | colon | Doppelpunkt |
| ; | semicolon | Semikolon |
| ... | ellipsis points | Auslassungspunkte |
| ’ | apostrophe | Apostroph |

## Pairs of Opening and Closing Characters

| Symbol | English Term | German Term |
|---|---|---|
| | To refer to the opening or closing character individually, use: opening, closing | To refer to the opening or closing character individually, use: öffnend, schließend |
| “ ” | double quotation marks, double English quotation marks | doppelte Anführungszeichen, doppelte englische Anführungszeichen |
| „ “ | double quotation marks, double German quotation marks | doppelte Anführungszeichen, doppelte deutsche Anführungszeichen |
| ‘ ’ | single quotation marks, single English quotation marks | einfache Anführungszeichen, einfache englische Anführungszeichen |
| , ‘ | single quotation marks, single German quotation marks | einfache Anführungszeichen, einfache deutsche Anführungszeichen |
| ( ) | parentheses | Klammern, runde Klammern |
| { } | curly brackets | geschweifte Klammern |

| Symbol | English Term | German Term |
|---|---|---|
| [ ] | square brackets | eckige Klammern |
| < > | angle brackets | spitze Klammern |

# 6 Structuring: Topics, Links, Lists, Tables, and More

Information is easier to scan and understand when it is structured. Within a topic you can use lists, tables, subheadings, notes, cautions, cross-references (with hyperlinks), and so on. Above topic level, your challenge is to design meaningful navigation structures.

## Basics

**Find out whether there are standards for structuring and for topic types.**

For example, there may be predefined templates or structuring guidelines for your product area or software type. For more information about the DITA topic types (task, concept, reference), see the UA Infrastructure User Guide and search for **`The Darwin Information Typing Architecture (DITA)`** and **`Working with Content in DITA Topics`**.

**Draft the high-level navigation structure before deciding where to put the nitty-gritty specifics.**

Start by considering which topic titles would help your target audience navigate through the content. Draft the content of your planned topics. For example, this could be a list of keywords or content notes. Review this draft structure and the content with your product team and others as often as you think necessary. From review to review, you can get more specific. It will get easier to decide where to put the specifics. And at a certain stage, you'll automatically start formulating. If you need help with this iterative process, consult an editor (see User Assistance Services) or a user assistance architect from your product area.

**DITA:** The high-level structure roughly corresponds to a buildable map.

**Make sure that a topic is a meaningful, self-contained unit of information.**

You don't know how your target group has found the topic (searching, browsing, or by mere chance). So the topic has to immediately relate to them as an intuitive unit of information such as a task, a process, or a concept. Meaningfulness starts with an informative topic title. For more information, see Titles and Headings [page 202].

**Use links to avoid redundancies.**

Do not repeat or copy and paste the same information everywhere. This is redundant and will result in inconsistencies. Provide information with the appropriate level of detail for context and target group. If required in a topic, cross-refer and link to more information. For more information, see Cross-References and Hyperlinks [page 240].

## Navigation Structures

**Create navigation structures that are intuitive and meaningful for the target group.**

A navigation structure is, for example, a table of contents in a book-like document or a navigation structure in a Web browser. It could also correspond to steps in a wizard. Here's a checklist with potential issues:

| Criterion | Revise If You Find This Issue |
|---|---|
| ✔ **Neat and clean**<br>The first, formal impression is good. The structure looks well organized in terms of length and depth, balance, and topics. | ✘ Structure is too long or too deep. Important information is hidden deep down.<br>✘ Too many or too few subtopics under some nodes.<br>✘ Topic titles are too long or meaningless. There are similar or identical titles in the same structure.<br>✘ The topic length is not balanced. Some topics are very long, others are very short. |
| ✔ **Relevant for the target group**<br>The structure relates to the target group's work situation and tasks. It does not simply mirror the software or user interface perspective. | ✘ Many topic titles contain or merely consist of tool names, abbreviations, or user interface terminology.<br>✘ There are many suspiciously stating-the-obvious topic titles such as “Creating ...”, “Editing ...”, “Displaying ...”, “Entering ...”, or “Deleting ...” |
| ✔ **Intuitive**<br>The structuring principle is obvious and helps you find the information quickly. For example, there is an natural logical sequence, or it's big picture and details, or basic and advanced. | ✘ Topic sequence and organization are unclear or random. |

## Topics

**Use a structured-writing approach with predefined topic types.**

For example, DITA distinguishes between tasks, concepts, and reference. Predefined topic types contain predefined block elements such as sections (subheadings) or lists that guide you.

Structured-writing approaches are not restricted to self-contained documents, such as guides. There is also information that is stored in the software itself (for example,

Javadoc) or that is embedded in the user interface (for example, field help or step descriptions). So if appropriate for the amount of information to be conveyed, also apply structured writing. You may need to define your own topic types or templates in the development environment.

**Make sure that a topic is neither too long nor too short.**

As a general rule, 1–2 pages are a good compromise. Even 3 pages can be fine, for example, if the topic contains syntax elements and their descriptions. If a topic is longer than 1 screen page, the user needs to scroll. If the information is spread over multiple topics, the user needs more clicks and printing can be less convenient.

**Make sure that the topic is intuitive and meaningful for the target group.**

Here's a checklist with potential issues:

| Criterion | Revise If You Find This Issue |
|---|---|
| ✔ **Neat and clean**<br><br>The first, formal impression is good. The topic structure looks well organized and is balanced. The layout supports scanning the text quickly. There is a good balance between plain text and block elements.<br><br>Block elements: subheadings, lists, tables, notes, cautions, warnings, examples, and so on. | ✘ It's plain text only. Often the paragraphs are very long.<br><br>✘ Too many different block elements, for example, more notes than steps.<br><br>✘ Lists have 4 or more levels plus interwoven notes and tables. |
| ✔ **Self-contained and meaningful**<br><br>The topic relates to the target group. | ✘ You don't know what the topic is about and why it's there.<br><br>✘ The topic is very long or very short.<br><br>✘ You can make sense of the topic only after reading all linked topics.<br><br>✘ The topic contains information for target groups that have different information needs. For example, technical information for developers and click-level information for end users. |
| ✔ **Big picture first**<br><br>The target group quickly knows what the topic is about and whether it is worth reading. | ✘ The topic title and the first paragraph don't reveal what the topic is about. So you don't know whether it's relevant for you. You're thinking "aha, hmhm?".<br><br>✘ The first paragraph just repeats the title or explains a minor, often technical detail.<br><br>✘ The first paragraph is not related to the title at all. |

| Criterion | Revise If You Find This Issue |
| --- | --- |
| ✔ **1 paragraph = 1 idea**<br>Each paragraph has a clear focus. The paragraphs have an intuitive text flow. | ✘ The paragraphs are very long and contain many ideas.<br>✘ You need to skip back and forth. Information on the same aspect is split over multiple paragraphs.<br>✘ You need to read the topic more than once to get the meaning.<br>✘ Lists are actually tables.<br>✘ Bulleted lists are actually numbered lists and vice versa. |

### Related Information

Communicating with Your Audience: Who Are Your Target Groups? [page 65]

## 6.1 Cross-References and Hyperlinks

With or without hyperlinks, cross-references are a tricky thing. You have to consider different aspects, such as legal issues, formulation patterns, technical feasibility, and location in the topic (inline or end of topic).

> ⓘ Note
>
> **Terminology:** “Cross-reference” is the mere formulation. “Hyperlink” is the technical element that connects the two texts. It is an optional element in a cross-reference because hyperlinks are not always desirable or technically possible.
>
> **Tools and technical feasibility:** This style guide is tool agnostic. For technical information about generated links, relationship tables, and so on, see the user guide for your authoring tool.

### Basics

| | |
| --- | --- |
| **Familiarize yourself with the legal perspective on cross-references and hyperlinks.** | For more information, see Cross-References and Hyperlinks from a Legal Perspective [page 58]. |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Familiarize yourself with the cross-reference and hyperlink strategy for your product area or software type.** | This style guide provides you with generic standards for manual cross-references and hyperlinks. As information landscapes become more complex, there is a trend towards generating links automatically (tag clouds, best bets, meta data, and so on). When you are developing a new information architecture, make sure that you have a strategy and standards for this. |
| **Use meaningful link texts, which help users decide whether the hyperlink is relevant for them.** | Ideally, the link text is identical to the title of the link target, or at least close to it. This reassures users because their expectations are met. Do **not** hide the hyperlink under **meaningless phrases** such as "here", "details" or "read more".<br><br>**Accessibility:** Meaningful link texts help users with screen readers work faster when they use the link list feature. The link list contains only the link texts, from which users can navigate to the link target. Imagine you had a list of five links that all read "Read More". Definitely not helpful. |
| **As a general rule, do not use more than 7 cross-references per page or topic.** | Too many cross-references (hyperlinks) are distracting. If there are too many cross-references in a topic, consider rewriting and restructuring. When deciding on a cross-reference, think about the purpose. What is the **added value for the audience**? What if it is omitted? |
| **Be aware that manual hyperlinks from one topic to another restrict the reuse of a topic.** | It doesn't matter whether the manual link is in the body text or in a separate link section at the end of a topic. All manual links between topics result in output dependencies because the target topics need to be part of the final output. |

## Hyperlinks in Normal Descriptive Sentences – Yes or No?

| | |
|---|---|
| **As a general rule, do not insert hyperlinks in normal descriptive sentences.** | Keep them syntactically separate. One benefit is that you consciously insert cross-references and hyperlinks (less is more). Another benefit is that you won't run into problems with word order, consistency, or (if it's topic-based writing) outdated link texts.<br><br>For example, in English, titles are written in title case and use the gerund. If you incorporated the hyperlink into a sentence, you would have to decide whether to spell the link text in title case (like the title of the target document) or to use sentence style (which applies to body text) and what to do with the gerund (without "ing" it's probably easier).<br><br>Here's where to insert hyperlinks:<br><br>• In a cross-reference formulation ("For more information, see `<target>`.") Strictly speaking, this is not 100% syntactically separate. But it's a formulation pattern at least. All languages have their specific means to express the meta meaning "look things up here" followed by a target (for example, a topic title or document title).<br>• After a colon (:) |

Sometimes it's redundant or simply boring to add “For more information, see `<target>`.” everywhere in a paragraph, or you have space restrictions. So you precede the hyperlink with an introductory sentence ended by a colon.

- In a separate link section at the end of a topic

**Translation:** Different languages can have a different word order. By keeping hyperlinks and normal descriptive sentences syntactically separate, you are making things easier for translators and translation software.

**Exception:** If there are space restrictions, you can incorporate hyperlinks in normal descriptive sentences. But also try to rephrase the text with a colon. Another exception is glossary links. They are always inserted directly into the sentence.

### Example

[Note: Let's assume that the title of the target is “Defining the Superordinate Billing Rule” and that it's a topic in a content management system.]

✔ Billing models are central to the price structure. For more information, see Defining the Superordinate Billing Rule.

✔ Interested in billing models? Start here in our user guide: Defining the Superordinate Billing Rule [Note: Adding “For more information, see `<target>`.” would be correct but also redundant. It makes the text just longer. The important thing is that hyperlink and normal descriptive text are syntactically separate.]

✘ Interested in billing models? Start here in our user guide to Defining the Superordinate Billing Rule. [Note: This is incorrect English. What happened? The link text is automatically inserted from the topic title but is syntactically connected to the sentence. Likewise the translation will be incorrect because translators won't be able to adapt the text. Also, title case looks odd in a normal descriptive sentence.]

[Note: **Adapting the link text** can be tempting from a text flow perspective. But this usage is **discouraged**. In some cases, it can be a **last-ditch resort**. For example, there are space restrictions, or the text would be crowded with “For more information” but then you're also back to the question “why so many inline links?”]

✘ Interested in billing models? Start here in our user guide to define the superordinate billing rule. [Note: The link text was manually changed. This way translators can adapt the translation to meet the grammar needs of the target language. But this also means extra translation. The English link text is one text string. In other languages, parts of this text string might need to be moved to another position in the sentence, the question being where to meaningfully insert the hyperlink? Also, the link text might outdate over time. Users might be confused if they follow the hyperlink and get to a target with the updated title “Create the Main Billing Schema”.]

✘ Interested in billing models? Start here in our user guide to define the superordinate billing rule. [Note: This is similar to the preceding example. Here, the link text was shortened. But now it is less clear what to expect. Is it information about billing rules in general or only about defining them?]

> ✔ **Related Information** [Note: Imagine this to be the separate link section at the end of a topic.]
>
> Defining the Superordinate Billing Rule

## Inline or End of Topic – Where to Place Cross-References

**Place cross-references (hyperlinks) preferably at the end of a topic.**

There are separate sections that are usually called "More Information" or "Related Information".

Now what's the benefit of doing this? Inline links can be distracting. Providing cross-references (hyperlinks) in a separate section is a strategy to spare the user from deciding whether to follow the link. The primary strategy is, of course, to have as few links as possible.

**Use inline links consciously. Define use cases for your product area or software type.**

Admittedly, sometimes you need inline links. If in doubt, ask yourself: Are text flow and comprehensibility negatively affected if the inline link is omitted or moved to the end of the topic? There are no absolute standards for this. Typical use cases are inline links to prerequisite and postrequisite information or inline links from a superordinate task or process to subordinate tasks or processes.

## Formulation Patterns for Inline Cross-References

**Remember the generic pattern "For more information, see `<target>`."**

If you're wondering whether the verb "see" is discriminatory, the answer is no. It's ok to use it. This was discussed with the colleagues from the Product Standard for Accessibility. For more information, see Accessibility [page 103].

Here are some variants of the formulation pattern:

| English: Formulation Pattern | German: Formulation Pattern | Comment |
|---|---|---|
| For more information, see `<target>`. | Weitere Informationen finden Sie unter `<Ziel>`. | It's clear from the preceding sentence what "more information" refers to. |
| For more information about `<subject>`, see `<target>`. | Weitere Informationen über `<Thema>` finden Sie unter `<Ziel>`. | It's not clear what "more information" refers to. So you're introducing the missing information with "about". |

| English: Formulation Pattern | German: Formulation Pattern | Comment |
|---|---|---|
| For information about `<subject>`, see `<target>`. | Informationen über `<Thema>` finden Sie unter `<Ziel>`. | You want to make the user aware of a related subject that hasn't been mentioned so far. But watch out, this might be nice-to-know information. Consider rewriting. |
| ... `<target>` ... | ... `<Ziel>` ... | At its best, the target is a single link. If this is not possible (technical restrictions, legacy content, URL not stable, and so on), link as directly as possible and then give the user some cues. |
| ..., see `<target>` and search for `<text>`. | ... finden Sie unter/in `<Ziel>`, indem Sie nach `<Text>` suchen. | Sometimes a search formulation can be helpful. Prefer this to a navigation path, which tends to outdate. |
| ...on SAP Help Portal ... | ... im SAP Help Portal ... | Rare, but you may want to stress that some stuff is on SAP Help Portal or even mention an easy-to-remember URL. |
| ... on SAP Help Portal at `<URL with alias>` ... | ... im SAP Help Portal unter `<URL mit Alias>` ... | |
| For more information, see SAP Note `<number>`. | Weitere Informationen finden Sie im SAP-Hinweis `<Nummer>`. | SAP Notes may contain information that's relevant for user assistance, typically for documentation. SAP Notes (category *Consulting* or *FAQ*) are often created as a response to customer requests "We need to know how `<this>` works, it's not in the documentation." Therefore, before cross-referring to SAP Notes, check whether you need to fill gaps in the user assistance or describe some typical cases. |

The following examples are not exhaustive. Your exact formulation depends very much on the context and overall text flow. In any case, check whether your cross-reference formulation works as intended. For example, ask a colleague to try it out.

Example

✔ Each device has a master record, which contains data that remains unchanged over a long period of time. For more information, see Master Records.

✘ Each device has a master record, which contains data that remains unchanged over a long period of time. Read more.

✔ For more information, see the installation guide.

✔ For more information, see the installation guide for SAP Invented Product.

✔ For more information, see the installation guide for SAP Invented Product 7.1 SPS 9.

✔ For more information, see the installation guide and search for **`Creating a Back-End User`**.

✔ For more information, see the installation guide, select the version, and search for **`Creating a Back-End User`**.

✔ For more information, see SAP Invented Product on SAP Help Portal at https://help.sap.com/docs/invprod.

✔ For more information, see SAP Note 1234567. [Note: In some authoring tools, you can make the note number directly link to the note by formatting it. For example, the IXIA CCMS has a special tag for SAP Notes.]

## ABAP Back End: Cross-References to Customizing Documentation and Settings

| | |
|---|---|
| **Do not use the term "Implementation Guide (IMG)". Instead, refer to "Customizing" only.** | This is to avoid confusion with other guides that are book-like documents (for example, master guides). The term "Implementation Guide (IMG)" still occurs in the SAP system, but consultants and system administrators, who form the target group for the IMG, mostly use the term "Customizing". |

When referring to Customizing documentation and settings, use the following formulation pattern:

| English: Formulation Pattern | German: Formulation Pattern |
| --- | --- |
| ... Customizing for `<Title of IMG Node>` under `<path>` | ... Customizing für `<Titel des IMG-Knotens>` unter `<Pfad>` |
| ✔ For more information about budget categories, see Customizing for *Investment Management* under *Investment Programs* > *Budgeting in Program*. | ✔ Weitere Informationen über Budgetkategorien finden Sie im Customizing für *Investitionsmanagement* unter *Investitionsprogramm* > *Budgetierung im Programm*. |
| ✔ You have defined the budget categories in Customizing for *Investment Management*. | ✔ Sie haben die Einstellungen für Budgetkategorien im Customizing für *Investment Management* definiert. |

### Related Information

UA Infrastructure User Guide

## 6.2 Lists

Lists make information easy to consume. The main ingredients are: introductory sentence, appropriate type of list (for example, an ordered list), parallel formulations. Here's more about the main and fine-tuning ingredients.

### Basics

**Use a complete introductory sentence, ended by a colon (:). Do not embed list items.**

A complete introductory sentence makes the purpose of the list immediately clear. The information is easier to consume and translate. Helpful formulations are, for example, “the following `<noun>`:” or “as follows:”.

**Translation:** Clear-cut sentence segmentation is especially important for efficient translation because the sentence structure in the source is different from the target languages. So by keeping introductory sentence and list items syntactically separate, you are making things easier for translators and translation software.

**Use the appropriate type of list (numbered or**

If the sequence is important, use a numbered (ordered) list or steps in a task. If not, use a bulleted (unordered) list.

| | |
|---|---|
| bulleted). Main question: Is the sequence of list items important? | **DITA:** There are also other list types such as definition list, parameter list, or simple list. Also, using a numbered (ordered) list or the steps in a *Task* topic does not automatically mean that you're describing a meaningful task for your audience. For more information about list types and tasks, see the UA Infrastructure User Guide and the DITA specification on the Internet.<br><br>**Tools:** This style guide is tool agnostic. For information about list formatting, see the user guide for your authoring tool. |
| Use parallel formulations for the list items. Do not mix noun or verb phrases with complete sentences. | Parallel formulations support readability because they make the information easier to consume. |

### Example

[Note: The following example illustrates a chronological sequence. However, from a content point of view, it is not a good example. It is stating the obvious on the user interface, which is simply superfluous.]

✔ Proceed as follows:

1. Enter your personal data.
2. Enter the component and release.
3. Describe the technical problem.

[Note: In the following example, the sequence of list items is not important.]

✔ Use a password that contains all of the following elements:

- Characters in uppercase and lowercase
- Numbers
- Special characters

[Note: In the following example, **everything is incorrect**: The list items are embedded in the introductory sentence. It's the incorrect list type, should be a bulleted list instead. There are no parallel formulations. Punctuation and capitalization are inconsistent.]

✘ Before you can create

1. Purchase requisitions,
2. purchase orders and ...
3. Don't forget scheduling agreements.

you must have the relevant authorizations.

## List Introductions

| | |
|---|---|
| Do not mention the number of list items. | The number might change over time. Formulations such as “the following <noun>” or “as follows” are the easy way out. |

**Avoid redundancy: introductory sentence versus title (heading)**

The most common introduction is an introductory sentence. However, sometimes you have to weigh using an introductory sentence against using a title (heading). For example, the section title *Steps* is followed by "Proceed as follows:" Can you hear the redundancy bells ringing? Do you really need both list introductions? Admittedly, if you're using a template or the text is generated, you may not be able to completely avoid redundancy.

Here are some decision criteria:

- If you want to visually set off the introduction from the body text, use only the title (heading). If not, use only the introductory sentence.
- Alternatively, consider using a short title (heading) followed by a longer introductory sentence that conveys additional information. Additional information means information that can't be included in the title (heading), for example, an if-clause or formulations such as "2 of the following <noun>".
- If it is difficult to decide on the type of introduction, check what is required for accessibility reasons. This may be a decision that is specific to your authoring tool and output format.

## List Items

**Make list items easy to scan. Set off important information.**

Put important information first. Maybe even set it off in bold font. Consider splitting up long list items, for example, by introducing each list item with a word or a phrase that summarizes the item. Add the details in a separate paragraph below or precede the details with an en dash (–) or a colon (:) in the same paragraph.

Alternatively, consider using a table instead of a list. Header row and columns make the information easy to scan.

**Use at least 2 items. Do not use a list for a single item.**

**Exception:** Generated lists sometimes contain a single item. Also, in other fill-in-the-gap situations, it can be the lesser evil to predefine a list structure than adding instructions on how to manually deal with a single item.

**If a list contains 8 or more items on the same level, check whether you can structure the list differently.**

"8 or more" is simply a general rule. It's not an absolute number. Consider grouping or merging related items.

**Preferably use no more than 2 list levels.**

If you are considering using a 3rd level, check whether you really need it. In rare cases, you might need it, for example, when describing a complicated installation procedure. However, if the list has 4 or more levels, restructure the text. For example, consider splitting up the topic into multiple topics or using subheadings in place of the 1st-level list items.

**Be cautious with using tables in lists.**

A table is yet another list level, especially if the list already has 2 levels. So you have to weigh complexity against readability. Also, lists are indented, which means

there is less space for the table columns. A two-column table (for example, with choices on the user interface) won't hurt, though.

**Set off optional and conditional list items (typically steps).**

The easiest way to label a step as optional is to start with "Optional:". However, watch out for conditional steps. Optional (you can do it or leave it, no difference) is not the same as conditional (mandatory step if a certain condition is met). You can introduce a conditional step with an if-clause as in "If ..., do this." or – to make it more prominent – with the condition stated as in "Migrated objects only: Do this."

If the list contains too many optional or conditional items, the description is likely to be rather confusing. Consider rewriting or splitting up the topic.

**Tools:** In the IXIA CCMS, you can tag list items as optional, and they're automatically preceded with "Optional:" in the final output.

## Punctuation and Capitalization

**If the list item is an incomplete sentence, do not use punctuation marks at the end.**

This certainly applies to periods (.) and commas (,). Just in case even if this is something rare: If you have list items that are abbreviated questions (for example, "Text created?", "Text reviewed?", "Text translated?"), you can of course end the list item with a question mark (?).

**If you have list items with a mix of complete and incomplete sentences, try to get rid of the mix and streamline the items (parallel formulations!).**

This may sometimes be difficult, for example, if all items are words and some of them are accompanied by a meaningful explanatory sentence. In such cases, consider separating the word and explanation with an en dash (–) or moving the explanations to a separate paragraph in the list item. In any case, use a consistent punctuation approach for the list.

**English: Begin the first word of each list item with an uppercase letter.**

This is irrespective of whether the list item is a complete or incomplete sentence.

**German: If the list item is an incomplete sentence, begin the first word with a lowercase or uppercase letter as appropriate for the part of speech.**

Complete sentences always begin with an uppercase letter.

## Example

[Note: The following example shows how you can make a list easy to scan.]

✔ You can perform the following tasks:

- **Manage facility hierarchies**

You can mirror your company's structure by creating facility hierarchies and organizing them into organizational hierarchies. You can assign a material to each facility in the hierarchy. To enable facility-based analysis, you can upload master data for facility hierarchies and for materials to the analysis database.

- **Collect consumption and emissions data for materials**
  You can automatically collect and aggregate consumption and emissions data for each material in your facility hierarchy.
- **Calculate emissions**
  You can calculate emissions for different parts of the facility hierarchy based on your measurement data.
- **Display usage statistics**
  You can display usage statistics for the analysis database, per user or per user group.

✘ [Note: Here's the same example but it's **not** easy to scan. Your eyes focus on "You can" instead of the meaningful parts.]

You can perform the following tasks:

- You can mirror your company's structure by creating facility hierarchies and organizing them into organizational hierarchies. You can assign a material to each facility in the hierarchy. To enable facility-based analysis, you can upload master data for facility hierarchies and for materials to the analysis database.
- You can automatically collect and aggregate consumption and emissions data for each material in your facility hierarchy.
- You can calculate emissions for different parts of the facility hierarchy based on your measurement data.
- You can display usage statistics for the analysis database, per user or per user group.

[Note: In the following example, a table would be more appropriate. In the list, the most important information (what can be configured) is hidden.]

✘ You have the following configuration options:

- Personalize basic settings on the user interface, such as language, date, and time
  For more information, see Configuring Individual User Interface Settings.
- Configure global user interface settings, such as the default size of user interface tables, refresh intervals, thresholds for displaying messages, or the path to the online help
  For more information, see Configuring Global User Interface Settings.
- Configure notifications when a specific event occurs
  For more information, see Configuring Notification Settings.
- Configure engine settings, such as security, landscape scanner, archive log, operations, or timer
  For more information, see Configuring Engine Settings.

✔ [Note: Now the same information is presented in a table instead of a list.]

You have the following configuration options:

| Configuration Option | Examples | More Information |
|---|---|---|
| Personalized user interface | Language, date, and time | Configuring Individual User Interface Settings |

| Configuration Option | Examples | More Information |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Global user interface | Default size of user interface tables, refresh intervals, thresholds for displaying messages, or the path to the online help | Configuring Global User Interface Settings |
| Notifications | Notifications that indicate when a specific event occurs | Configuring Notification Settings |
| Engine | Security, landscape scanner, archive log, operations, or timer settings | Configuring Engine Settings |

### Related Information

Tables [page 251]
UA Infrastructure User Guide

## 6.3 Tables

Tables are great for providing a structured overview of facts and information. They are easy to scan. But how can you best present the connection between related items of information? Find out how to deal with rows and columns.

### Basics

| | |
| --- | --- |
| **Use a complete introductory sentence, ended by a colon (:).** | A complete introductory sentence makes the purpose of the table immediately clear. The information is easier to consume. Helpful formulations are, for example, “the following <noun>:” or “as follows:”. |
| **Use the appropriate type of table.** | **DITA:** There are also other table types such as choice table or properties table. For more information, see the UA Infrastructure User Guide and the DITA specification on the Internet. |
| **Do not overload a table. General rule: max. 5 columns** | The consumption situation is the decisive aspect, especially with responsive-design user interfaces. Imagine you are the user: Is the table too complex (too many columns and rows with too much text)? What are the output types? Will text be cut off? How much scrolling is needed (to the right, to the left, back to the header row)?<br><br>If the table is not appropriate for the consumption situation, restructure the table and maybe even the topic. |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Use a header row. Use meaningful titles for the header cells.** | Header cells are the most common way of structuring a table.<br><br>**Tools:** This style guide is tool agnostic. For information about table formatting, see the user guide for your authoring tool. |
| **To avoid unnecessary white space, use proportional column widths.** | Fixed columns widths do not scale properly.<br><br>**Tools:** In some authoring tools you can enter a ratio between the columns. |
| **Use parallel formulations for the table cells in a column. Do not mix noun or verb phrases with complete sentences.** | Parallel formulations support readability because they make the information easier to consume. |

### Example

✔ Different types of requests are delegated to different components, as follows:

| Type of Request | Delegated To |
|---|---|
| Data definition statement | Metadata manager |
| Transaction control statement | Transaction manager |
| Planning command | Planning engine |
| Procedure callObject invocation | Stored procedure processor |
| Repository operation | Object store |
| Application-specific stored procedure, incoming MDX requests | RepositoryCalc engine |

✘ [Note: This is the plain-text version of the preceding example. It's not easy to scan.]

Different types of requests are delegated to different components. Data definition statements are dispatched to the metadata manager, transaction control statements are forwarded to the transaction manager, planning commands are routed to the planning engine and procedure calls are forwarded to the stored procedure processor. Object invocations are forwarded to object store and calls of repository operations are forwarded to the repository. Calls of application-specific stored procedures are forwarded to the calc engine for execution. Incoming MDX requests are forwarded to the calc engine.

## Table Introductions (Including Titles)

| | |
|---|---|
| **Do not mention the number of rows or columns.** | The number might change over time. For example, if the first column has 5 configuration options (each in a single cell), an introductory sentence with “5 configuration options” is not a future-proof formulation. Formulations such as “the following <noun>” or “as follows” are the easy way out. |

**Avoid redundancy: introductory sentence versus title (heading, caption)**

The most common introduction is an introductory sentence. Sometimes you may have to weigh using an introductory sentence against a title (heading, caption). For example, the section title *Device Types* is followed by "The device types are explained in the following table:" and a similar table caption. That's redundant. In this case you could get around it by omitting the table caption. The section title is already easy to the eye when you scan the text. Admittedly, if you're using a template or the text is generated, you may not be able to avoid redundancy.

Here are some decision criteria:

- If you want to visually set off the introduction from the body text, use only the title (heading). If not, use only the introductory sentence.
- Alternatively, consider using a short title (heading) followed by a longer introductory sentence that conveys additional information. Additional information means information that can't be included in the title (heading), for example, an if-clause or formulations such as "2 of the following <noun>".
- If you need to refer to the tables by number and title (for example, a topic contains multiple tables), use table captions.
- If it is difficult to decide on the types of introduction or their combination, check what is required for accessibility reasons. This may be a decision that is specific to your authoring tool and output type.

**If you use table captions, do so consistently.**

That is:

- Use captions for **all** tables in your document, not only for some.
- Do not use the word "table" or similar words in the caption.
- Use nominal formulations. Do not use complete sentences.
- Position the caption above the table.
  **Tools:** In the IXIA CCMS, the caption is positioned as predefined for the output type.
- Do not number the tables. There's no added value in this.
  Numbering tables is a relic from print times when tables where stored in an appendix and numbers were the only way of referring to them.
  **Tools:** If needs be, the IXIA CCMS has a parameter for automatic numbering.

## Cells, Columns, and Rows

**In all cells, make it short, simple, and specific. Do not overload the table with text or white space.**

Here are some simplification tips:

- Move words that apply to all cells of a column to the header cell. This, of course, implies removing the words from the other cells.
- Split tables with many columns into sets of smaller tables, especially if the first column contains merged cells that span multiple rows. Each merged cell can often be converted to a title (section, heading, caption).
- Combine long, nonbreaking text strings, such as technical names or URLs, with their descriptions in the same cell.

Keep column headings and cell text syntactically separate. Do not use ellipsis points (...).

**Translation:** Clear-cut sentence segmentation is especially important for efficient translation because the sentence structure in the source is different from the target languages. So by keeping the cells syntactically separate, you are making things easier for translators and translation software.

Leave cells empty if there's no information.

**Accessibility:** Screen readers know how to interpret empty cells.

However, if it's more important to make clear that the information is not missing by mistake, add a meaningful formulation such as "Not applicable".

Do not use an X or an x mark in table columns. Use descriptive words such as "Yes" or "Correct".

**Translation and localization:** The x mark can be a confusing symbol. For example, in some parts of the world, people use it in checklists when they mean "correct". But in other parts, the x mark means exactly the opposite (and people use a check mark for "correct").

For some 2-column tables, consider using a header column instead of a header row.

Sometimes it is more appropriate to use a header column. For example, you need to provide a technical data overview for a software entity (component, release, technical name, and so on). Such information is often generated text.

**Tools:** In some authoring tools, you need to create these 2-column tables as a list (for example, parameter list) instead.

## Punctuation and Capitalization

In header cells and table captions, keep the use of punctuation marks to a minimum.

For example, you do not need a period (.) after a nominal formulation in a header cell. In some cases, questions marks (?), parentheses ( ) and the like may be helpful, though. For text in non-header cells, standard punctuation applies: Complete sentences end with a period (.), incomplete sentences do not. In some cases, you may need to make an inner judgement call for consistency reasons.

If you have a column that has table cells with a mix of complete and incomplete sentences, try to get rid of the mix and streamline the items (parallel formulations!).

This may sometimes be difficult, for example, if all items are words and some of them are accompanied by a meaningful explanatory sentence. In such cases, consider separating the word and explanation with an en dash (–) or moving the explanations to a separate paragraph in the table cell. Alternatively, add a separate column for the explanations. In any case, use a consistent punctuation approach in the table.

Apply the following standards for capitalization.

| Text Element | English: Capitalization | German: Capitalization |
|---|---|---|
| Table caption | Use title case.<br><br>✔ Table Caption in Title Case | Begin the first word with an uppercase letter, irrespective of the part of speech.<br><br>✔ Beispielhafte Tabellenüberschrift |
| Header cell | Use title case.<br><br>✔ Header Cell in Title Case | Begin the first word with an uppercase letter, irrespective of the part of speech.<br><br>✔ Beispielhafte Zellenüberschrift in Kopfzeile |
| Table cell | Sentence style: Begin the first word with an uppercase letter.<br><br>✔ Table cell in sentence style | As appropriate for the part of speech and whether it's a complete or incomplete sentence.<br><br>✔ unvollständiger Satz in einer Tabellenzelle<br><br>✔ Dies ist ein vollständiger Satz in einer Tabellenzelle. |

### Related Information

UA Infrastructure User Guide

## 6.4 Notes, Tips, Cautions, and the Like

Advisory information may range from helpful tips or recommendations to warnings about unwanted or serious consequences, such as data loss or system failure. Such information is typically set off with graphical symbols and signal words, such as “note” or “caution”. Find out how to distinguish different types of advisory information.

> ⓘ Note
>
> The standards for advisory, safety-related information in the software and manufacturing industries are not aligned. Industry 4.0 and the Internet of things, however, mean that the two worlds will move closer together. If the software controls machines, the manufacturing standards for product safety will become relevant, simply because it can be about life and death. For more information about the main international standards, see Cautions and Warnings in ISO and Other International Standards [page 320].

## Basics

**Alert users to information of particular interest (advisory information).**

Suggest actions that may help them recover from error situations. Bring their attention to actions that may cause system failure or data loss. Set off advisory information from body text.

**Use all types of advisory information in moderation.**

Overusing notes, tips, and so on diminishes their importance. As a general rule, do not use more than 2 items of advisory information per topic. Also, do not put them directly after one another. Remember that with notes and tips you don't always have to set off the information from body text. Sometimes it is sufficient to introduce such information with a simple “Note that” sentence.

**If you find yourself copying the same advisory information everywhere, consider providing it centrally.**

For example, provide it in a separate topic. Give the topic a meaningful title, and position it before those topics to which it relates.

## The Different Types

**Consider the guidelines for notes, tips, or one of the other types as a general rule.**

The distinction between the different types can be blurry.

**Tools**: This style guide is tool agnostic. For information about formatting, see the user guide for your authoring tool.

| Type | When to Use | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|
| Note | Point out important or unusual information to the user. Something that they need to understand or that is not obvious. No direct action involved. | ⓘ Note<br>The pricing-relevant data needs to correspond to the data specified for the Web shop in the shop management tool. |
| Tip | Advise the user to take an action (or refrain from it) to solve or avoid unwanted, minor issues. No risk of harm. The issues are relatively easy to repair.<br>Tips are usually optional. The user can successfully use the software without the tip. The tip is just a handy time-saving advice. So check whether the tip is really required. | → Tip<br>If your system is running slowly, verify that memory configuration parameters are set to the recommended values. |

| Type | When to Use | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Recommendation | Point out settings, procedures, or methods that are advantageous for the customer or have proven to be successful. | You can now perform a test connection between a portal tenant system and the ABAP user store to which it is assigned.<br><br>**→ Recommendation**<br><br>Perform this test before you create the portal tenant. You can also use the test connection capability as a troubleshooting mechanism for existing tenants. |
| Caution | Caution the user to avoid severe or dangerous hazards. Potential harm may range from damaged files over data loss and data inconsistency to system failure. The issues are not easy to repair.<br><br>The user may need help from a super user or create a support ticket. Other users or the whole system may also be affected. | **⚠ Caution**<br><br>Do not manually alter localization files. Doing so may cause unpredictable results, including data loss.<br><br>[Note: This is a new example.]<br><br>The report selects all sales documents whose delivery date is within the authorization horizon and triggers an authorization in the clearing house.<br><br>**⚠ Caution**<br><br>To **avoid data inconsistency**, schedule the report only in the leading system. This ensures that replicated sales documents are not authorized in dependent systems. |
| Remember | Point out fundamental information that you want users to remember because they'll need it later on.<br><br>You can also use the remember note to summarize a long, complex explanation thread. Again, these are things that you want the user to remember. | [Note: This could also be a caution.]<br><br>**→ Remember**<br><br>Never push project maps from DEV to SHIP. This will break the dependency between project and project map in SHIP, and no output is generated.<br><br>[Note: This is a new example.]<br><br>**→ Remember**<br><br>Continuous delivery is not just about software. So as a user assistance developer, make sure that user assistance and translation aspects are part of the definition of done in your project. |

| Type | When to Use | ✔ Example |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Restriction | Be careful. If in doubt, do **not** use it. You will easily get into describing limitations of the software, which is likely to negatively affect revenue recognition. There is a separate limitations process. Ask your product owner. For more information, see Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50]. | [Note: Impossible to find good examples.] |

## Related Information

UA Infrastructure User Guide

# 7 Multimedia and Graphics: Overview

Interactive content, videos, graphics, and screenshots – what is there to know and where can you find the guidelines? Likewise, there are layout standards for colors, fonts, indents, and so on. All this is important for an SAP-wide look and feel, but it's more than this style guide can cover.

## Basics

Follow the links in the table.

| Topic | In This Style Guide | More Information Elsewhere |
|---|---|---|
| Graphics in user assistance | Graphics [page 260] | Media Board tab in the User Assistance Dashboard |
| Screenshots in user assistance | Screenshots [page 262] | |
| Videos in user assistance | Videos [page 264] | Media Board tab in the User Assistance Dashboard |
| User experience and design, and user interface | User Interface: User Assistance Meets User Experience [page 108] | SAP Design System Guidelines |
| SAP-wide standards for color, typography, logo, graphics, photos, and so on | Not applicable | Identity Overview on the *SAP Brand* site |
| SAP-wide media library (audio, icons, illustrations, photos, pictograms, videos) | Not applicable | SAP Media Library on the *SAP Brand* site |

# 7.1 Graphics

Here's basic guidance on how to connect graphics with text and where to find more information about tools, templates, colors, fonts, pictograms, Technical Architecture Modeling (TAM), interactive graphics, and so on.

## Basics

**Follow the guidelines provided in the UA Dashboard and in the *UA Infrastructure User Guide*.**

You'll find extensive information about graphic size, grid alignment, colors, lines, fonts, pictograms, photographs, and screenshots. You'll also find templates, style guides, and contacts for the simple graphics, TAM graphics, info graphics, and interactive graphics. You can also book trainings or create a production request. For more information, see Media Board tab in the User Assistance Dashboard and search for **`Working with Graphics`** in the UA Infrastructure User Guide.

**Not in scope:** Neither the multimedia community nor this style guide cover the use of graphics on the user interface, such as GUI icons, or the visual appearance of the user interface and its elements. This is in the area of user experience (UX). For more information, see SAP Fiori Design Guidelines.

**Tools: Create graphics with Microsoft PowerPoint or Microsoft Visio. Upload them to the IXIA CCMS.**

By doing so, you ensure that the graphics can be reused by others and that they can be translated with standard translation tools.

**Make sure that the graphic is appropriately introduced and explained.**

A good question to ask yourself or others is: Would a user think “why on earth is this graphic here?”? If the answer is yes, do something about it.

Don't just dump the graphic in the text. The purpose of the graphic in the text and what it depicts need to be clear. You don't have to explain the graphic at pixel level in terms of “and in the upper left, there's a green square”. This is stating the obvious. Think of text and graphic as complementing each other. For example, you describe something complex and then proceed with something like “and here's a graphic:” or the other way round.

**Accessibility:** The graphic also needs to be explained for accessibility reasons, that is, for users who rely on a screen reader. First, they know that the thing that can't be read out to them is a graphic, and they don't have to guess whether it's broken text or whatever. Second, they know what the graphic is about. Now to the `alt` text. If you have explained the graphic in the (body) text, no need to copy this explanation to an `alt` text. But what you could do is to fill the `alt` text with something like “The graphic is explained in the accompanying text.” You can also add text to explain a special detail of the graphic that would be odd to explain in the (body) text but is helpful for users who rely on a screen reader. For more information, see the UA Infrastructure User Guide and search for **`Making Content Usable for Everyone (Accessibility To Dos)`**.

## Graphic Introductions (Including Titles)

**Use a complete introductory sentence, ended by a colon (:).**

This is the most common type of introduction. Helpful formulations are, for example, “the following graphic:” or “let's take a look:”.

**Avoid redundancy: introductory sentence versus title (heading, caption)**

Sometimes you have to weigh using an introductory sentence against a title (heading, caption). Try to keep the redundancy between these text elements as minimal as possible. You may know this kind of redundancy from table introductions. For more information about avoiding this, see Tables [page 251] (section on table introductions).

**If you use graphic captions, do so consistently.**

That is:

- Use captions for **all** graphics in your document, not only for some.
- Use nominal formulations. Do not use complete sentences.
- Only valid for 'Localization': English
  **English:** Use title case. For more information, see English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199].
  End of 'Localization': English
- Do not use the word “figure” or similar words in the caption.
- Position the caption below the graphic.
  **Tools:** In the IXIA CCMS, the caption is positioned as predefined for the output type.
- Do not number the graphics. There's no added value in this.
  Numbering graphics is a relic from print times when graphics where stored in an appendix and numbers were the only way of referring to them.
  **Tools:** If need be, the IXIA CCMS has a parameter for automatic numbering.

## How to Connect Graphic and Text

**Decide on the sequence of graphic, introductory sentence, and subject matter explanation.**

This depends on the logical flow. Sometimes it makes sense to start with the graphic and then explain it. And sometimes it's the other way round.

**Use an introductory sentence.**

It connects graphic and subject matter explanation.

**Make the introductory sentence sound natural, as appropriate for the text flow and type of graphic.**

You can use the generic term “graphic” or more specific terms such as “diagram” or “chart”. By the way, you don't even have to use these terms at all. Have a look at the examples.

> Example
>
> ✔ The following graphic illustrates the process:
>
> ✔ This pie chart provides an overview of expenses by company unit:
>
> ✔ Let's start with a process diagram that shows the different steps:
>
> ✔ And here's a graphic that illustrates the main aspects:
>
> ✔ Let's look at this overview:
>
> ✔ Here's how it works:

### Related Information

Photography – Diversity and Inclusion (on the SAP Brand site)

## 7.2 Screenshots

Screenshots are a controversial thing. Loved by customers, feared by translation. Here's a summary of things to consider upfront.

### Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| **Use screenshots consciously because they have their pros and cons.** | Customers like screenshots very much because they can be a useful complement to text. However, screenshots can't be translated and they do not meet accessibility requirements.<br><br>The decisive questions are: What's the added value of the screenshot? Does the added value merit the efforts with maintenance and translation? Apart from this, remember that screenshots are graphics, and so the relevant standards, such as introductory sentence, apply. For more information, see Graphics [page 260]. |
| **Align on a screenshot process for your product area or software type. Involve translation.** | As a user assistance developer, you are responsible for ensuring that the screenshots are available in the required target languages, in time, and in the IXIASOFT CCMS. |

## Things to Consider

| Aspect | Things to Consider |
|---|---|
| Screenshot updates in all languages | Every little change to the user interface makes your screenshots inaccurate. For example, there can be new fields or buttons, layout or theme may change. So you'll have to update the screenshots frequently – in the source and the relevant target languages. |
| User interface already translated? | The user interface and possibly example data also need to be available in the relevant target languages. |
| New target languages | There may be new target languages. This means all screenshots need to be recreated in these new languages.<br><br>For some target languages, such as Chinese or Turkish, you will need someone with sufficient language competency in these languages to navigate to the required screen and create the screenshot. |
| English only screenshots versus user experience | You may now think let's go for English only screenshots. Not necessarily a good idea from a user experience perspective. This slows down the speed of reading. Users are forced to translate on the fly what they read in their languages and match things to the English UI texts in the English screenshot. |
| Confidential or personal information | The screenshot must **not** contain any confidential or personal information (for example, personal files on the desktop, running programs in the task bar, SAP-internal URLs or ports).<br><br>Blurring out information is not sufficient as technologies and AI tools can be used to decipher blurred content. Make sure to fully cover information or crop the screenshot to exclude any confidential or personal information. |
| Accessibility | Screenshots do not meet accessibility criteria. The information conveyed in the screenshot needs to be conveyed in another, accessible format, for example, a textual description. How you provide this information depends on your development environment and authoring tools.<br><br>For more information, see Accessibility [page 103] and Graphics [page 260]. |
| Configurable user interface | The software and its user interface can be highly configurable. So screens at the customer's site may look completely different. |
| Screenshot storage | Screenshots require proper versioning, translation integration, and localization support. You get all this, for example, in the IXIA CCMS. |

### Added-Value Checklist

**If a screenshot does not add value, omit it.**

Here's a checklist:

| Added Value of Screenshot | No Added Value |
|---|---|
| ✔ Reassures the user in a difficult situation ("Am I on the right track?"), for example, in tutorial-style content | ✘ Used for decoration purposes (the more, the better) |
| ✔ Exemplifies the graphical representation of data or the user interface (for example, in a *Getting Started* section) | ✘ Fancy replacement of ordinary text elements such as tables or lists |
| ✔ Has an appropriate size, text and screenshot are balanced, the user is not distracted by the screenshot | ✘ Stating the obvious, such as a progress bar screenshot |
| ✔ Has the appropriate level of detail and sufficient orientation context, the user can match the detail screenshot to the real screen | ✘ Screenshot of a complete screen when the focus is actually on a particular detail or part of the screen |

### Related Information

UA Infrastructure User Guide

## 7.3 Videos

Here's basic guidance on videos in the area of user assistance. Videos can make it much easier for your audience to grasp the information. However, this very benefit is a drawback for users with vision or auditory disabilities. So make sure to cover accessibility aspects.

### Basics

**Follow the guidelines provided in the UA Dashboard and in the *UA Infrastructure User Guide*.**

You'll find templates, style guides, and contacts for how-to, what's new, and other types of videos. You can also book trainings or create a production request. For more information, see Media Board tab in the User Assistance Dashboard and search for **`Working with Videos`** in the UA Infrastructure User Guide.

**Keep it short.**

If the content is too complex or long, consider producing several shorter videos instead of just one. The attention span of an average video viewer drops considerably after 60 seconds. If watched on a mobile device, the attention span for a video is even less. Recommendation for promotional and what's new videos is 60-90 seconds. How-to videos can be longer, depending on the content.

## Legal Aspects

**If you have questions about the use of videos in your product area or software type, contact your representative in the Legal Network for User Assistance.**

For more information, see the Legal Network for User Assistance community.

**Note that videos that are published on SAP-branded accounts on third-party social media platforms can only serve as an addition to the core user assistance, which is provided with the software.**

In particular, do **not** communicate information about new functions and features in videos **before** the software (including the core user assistance) has been officially released to the public. For more information, see Legal Aspects: User Assistance [page 50].

## Accessibility Aspects

**Cover the needs of users who rely on assistive technologies, such as screen readers or hearing aids.**

Video is a medium that is **not per se accessible** for everybody. For the audio part, provide synchronized subtitles (captions). For the visual part, provide audio descriptions. Alternatively, provide a full text alternative (a transcript). By the way, everybody can benefit from subtitles, for example, if a speaker talks with a strong accent. In addition, provide full control of animation, audio, and video content to users. For more information, see Accessibility Guidelines for Video Content and search for **`Making Content Usable for Everyone (Accessibility To Dos)`** in the UA Infrastructure User Guide.

**If you need consulting, contact a colleague from the Product Standard for Accessibility.**

For more information, see the Product Standard for Accessibility.

**Remember the most obvious requirements from the Product Standard for Accessibility.**

Here they are:

- Text alternative for non-text content (see ACC-255)
- Animation, Audio and Video Control (see ACC-279)
- No flickering or flashing content (see ACC-280)

For even more information, see the *Web Content Accessibility Guidelines* (Overview and How to Make Presentations Accessible to All).

## Related Information

Accessibility [page 103]
Photography – Diversity and Inclusion (on the SAP Brand site)

# 8 The Mechanics: Language, Grammar, and Punctuation

Here's a collection of basic standards that you are likely to look up frequently or that have SAP-specific implications.

Only valid for 'Localization': English

**English:** The standards for English are based on *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary* (latest print version or online version at https://www.merriam-webster.com) and *The Chicago Manual of Style* (latest print version or free online FAQ at https://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org).

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

**German:** The standards for German are based on *Die deutsche Rechtschreibung* (Duden, Band 1; short: Rechtschreibduden, latest print version or free online version at https://www.duden.de).

End of 'Localization': German

## 8.1 Corporate Language (U.S. English) and Source Languages (English, German)

U.S. English is the corporate language at SAP. How does this relate to English and German, the source languages for software and user assistance?

### Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| **English: Look up spelling in *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary*.** | *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary* is SAP's language reference work for English. Online access: https://www.merriam-webster.com |
| **German: Look up spelling in the Rechtschreibduden.** | The Rechtschreibduden is SAP's language reference work for German. Online access: https://www.duden.de |

## Corporate Language for Global Communication

**U.S. English is the corporate standard and official business language at SAP.**

SAP offerings are named and branded in U.S. English. For more information, see SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183]. For any materials that are intended for a global audience, always use U.S. English.

**Exception:** If you are communicating in or for specific English-speaking countries or regions, such as South Africa, Ireland, or Australia, you may determine that it is more appropriate to use the local English language standards in country/region-specific texts.

## Source Languages in Software Development and User Assistance

**U.S. English is the default source language.**

German is the minor source language. It is used only in a few product areas.

**Exception:** In service-oriented architecture (SOA), use British English spelling for entity names (model and technical names) according to *Naming and Identification Principles for Data Elements* (ISO IEC 11179-5).

## Related Information

Language (on the SAP Brand site)
Terminology and SAPterm [page 74]
English: U.S. English, Global English, and Some Grammar [page 269]
German: Deutsche Rechtschreibung und Wortwahl [page 286]

# 8.2 English: U.S. English, Global English, and Some Grammar

U.S. English is the corporate language at SAP. It is also the main source language for software and user assistance. So let's have a look at selected language and grammar aspects, especially since not everybody (neither audience nor authors) has first-language proficiency in English in a globalized world.

## Basics: U.S. English

| | |
|---|---|
| **U.S. English is the corporate standard and official business language at SAP for all global communication.** | This includes all types of user assistance. |
| **The official reference works for English are *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary* and *The Chicago Manual of Style*.** | If one of these works offers multiple conventions, choose the first alternative. If these works and the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication* contradict each other, the standards in the SAP style guide take priority. |

## Global Authors Writing for a Global Audience

| | |
|---|---|
| **If you do not have first-language proficiency in English, ask for language editing.** | SAP's user assistance developers are located all over the world. So your first language may not be English. To ensure that your texts are linguistically correct, language editing is required. Your user assistance manager will help you find a language editor.<br><br>**Translation:** Language editing helps reduce translation costs and time. |
| **Consider the needs of a global audience already at the level of language and grammar.** | Not everybody in a global audience has first-language proficiency in English. Some grammatical constructions in English are difficult for speakers of other languages. For more information, see English: How to Write Clear, Translatable Texts for a Global Audience [page 270]. |
| **Improve your writing skills with the English Writing Program.** | The English Writing Program provides lessons about grammar, style, and writing skills. Each lesson takes around 15 minutes to complete. Many lessons contain exercises, so you can check straight away whether you have understood the content. Even if your first language is English, you might find certain modules helpful. For more information, see. English Writing Program. |

## Related Information

Corporate Language (U.S. English) and Source Languages (English, German) [page 267]
Terminology and SAPterm [page 74]

## 8.2.1 English: How to Write Clear, Translatable Texts for a Global Audience

You can help improve comprehensibility and reduce translation costs. When writing for a global audience, remember that in this audience there are many people without first-language proficiency in English. By keeping your language clear and easy to understand, you are also optimizing the texts for translation.

### What Is Global English?

The overall goal of global English is to **improve comprehensibility for a global audience**. By the way, this also improves translation quality. In his book *The Global English Style Guide: Writing Clear, Translatable Documentation for a Global Market*, John R. Kohl presents an extensive set of guidelines and examples, based on work experience, research, and specialist literature. The guidelines focus on how to avoid formulation patterns and grammatical constructions that are difficult for translation and for people without first-language proficiency.

The following guidelines are considered to be most relevant and easy to implement in SAP texts. All examples are from SAP texts. For more information, read the book.

### Basics

**Make sure that your sentences sound natural.**

This might even require completely rephrasing the sentences. If you're stuck, consult colleagues. If you do not have first-language proficiency in English, ask a language editor or a native speaker.

**Remember the main principles of global English.**

Here they are:

- Common words and phrases
- Simple sentences, transparent sentence structure
- No syntactic ambiguities
- No complicated or unusual grammatical constructions

## Common Words

**Use common, everyday words and phrases.**

People who do not have first-language proficiency in English may not always be familiar with less common words and phrases.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ agree [instead of: concur], although [instead of: albeit], before [instead of: prior to], harmful [instead of: deleterious], start/begin [instead of: commence], try [instead of: endeavor], up to now [instead of: heretofore], use [instead of: utilize]

## Syntactic Cues Instead of Telegraphic Style

**Make the sentence structure explicit. Do not omit syntactic cues for the sake of conciseness.**

Syntactic cues are language elements such as conjunctions, articles, prepositions, or punctuation. They indicate the syntax of a sentence and show how the different words in the sentence are related. If you omit syntactic cues because you want to make the text concise, the text can actually get more difficult to understand (and translate).

Conciseness is not about omitting as many words as possible. Conciseness is about omitting only those words that do not affect meaning and comprehensibility.

**Use articles.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✘ Editing Contracts [Note: The heading is ambiguous. Does it mean “how to edit contracts” or “contracts used for editing”?]
>
> ✔ Editing the Contracts [alternative without article: How to Edit Contracts], Editing a Contract [if it's a single contract], Contracts with Editors [no article, but “with” is also a syntactic cue]
>
> ✘ Send a copy of your degree certificate and résumé. [Note: Does “a copy of” refer only to “degree certificate” or to both “degree certificate” and “résumé”? Does “degree” modify only “certificate” or both “certificate” and “résumé”?]
>
> ✔ Send a copy of your degree certificate and a résumé. [Note: The indefinite article “a” before “résumé” makes clear that the units of meaning are “a copy of your degree certificate” and “résumé”.]

**Use “that” to introduce an object clause with verbs such as “make sure” or “indicate”.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The *Shared* status indicates that the counter is shared by several contract items.

❌ The *Shared* status indicates the counter is shared by several contract items.

✔ As part of the handshake procedure, the client verifies that the common name of the public certificate exactly matches the hostname.

❌ As part of the handshake procedure, the client verifies the common name of the public certificate exactly matches the hostname. [Note: At first reading, the reader may think that the client merely verifies the name. There is no syntactic cue that a complete sentence is to follow after "verifies".]

**Use "that" in restrictive relative clauses.**

In restrictive relative clauses, you can omit "that" without making the sentence ungrammatical. However, the sentence structure is less explicit.

Example

✔ Define the customer information that you require for the tax transaction.

❌ Define the customer information you require for the tax transaction.

**Clarify which parts of a sentence are being joined by the conjunctions "and" and "or".**

Example

❌ Check the power supply and switch on your computer. [Note: At first reading, you might think that you have to check the power supply and the switch.]

✔ Check the power supply. Switch on your computer.

✔ After you have checked that your computer is plugged in, you can switch it on.

**Keep phrasal verbs together.**

A phrasal verb is a group of words that functions as a verb and consists of a verb and a preposition, an adverb, or both. If you keep the parts of a phrasal verb together, sentences are clearer.

Example

✔ Fill out this application form.

❌ Fill this application form out.

## Grammatical Constructions

**Consider using a relative clause instead of a participle construction.**

You can often replace a participle that follows and modifies a noun with a relative clause.

Example

✔ The template that was used for the course description was outdated.

✘ The template used for the course description was outdated.

✔ Add comments to the done criteria that are being defined. [Or: ... that your scrum team is defining]

✘ Add comments to the done criteria being defined.

**Do not use “have” and “get” to mean “to have someone do something” or “to cause something to happen”.**

Example

✔ A technical consultant installs the software.

✘ Customers have the software installed by a technical consultant.

✔ To request a new portal page, contact the portal administrator.

✘ To get a new portal page created, contact the portal administrator.

### Related Information

English Writing Program

## 8.2.2 English: American (U.S.) and British English Spelling Conventions

This overview of spelling conventions is not intended to be exhaustive. It lists the main differences.

### Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| **Use the American English spelling conventions.** | For more information, see *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary* or consult grammar books. |

| Difference | ✔American English Spelling | ✔Example | British English Spelling |
|---|---|---|---|
| Suffix | -ense | defense, license | -ence |
| | -er | center, meter | -re |
| | -ize or -yze | organize, analyze<br>Exception: advertise | -ise or -yse |
| | -ization | organization | -isation |
| | -og | catalog, dialog | -ogue |
| | -or | color, favor | -our |
| Final “l” plus “ed” or “ing” | Doubled only in stressed syllables | excelled, controlling<br>[Note: But only one “l” in “canceled”, “modeling”, and so on.] | Always doubled |
| Individual words | check [context: bank]; forward, backward, toward; fulfill, fulfilling, fulfillment; program | | cheque; forwards, backwards, towards; fulfil, fulfilling, fulfilment; programme |

## Related Information

Corporate Language (U.S. English) and Source Languages (English, German) [page 267]
Terminology and SAPterm [page 74]
English Writing Program

## 8.2.3 English: American (U.S.) and British English Terms

This vocabulary overview is not intended to be exhaustive or binding. It simply serves to illustrate common word differences between American and British English.

### Basics

**If a word or phrase is not the same in American English as in British English, use the American English word or phrase.**

If in doubt, refer to *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary* or SAPterm. Often terms are not strictly American or British, they are rather alternatives or tendencies. Because specialist terms are defined in collaboration with subject-matter experts and entered in SAPterm, the vocabulary aspect is less of a problem at SAP. In other words: SAPterm entries take priority.

**Exception: Do not extend the use of American English vocabulary to legal, financial, human resources or other localization contexts, where country/region-specific terms are needed.**

For example, "social security" and "ZIP code" are correct for the United States whereas "national insurance" and "postal code" are correct for the United Kingdom.

| Subject | ✔American English Term | British English Term |
|---|---|---|
| Money | bill | bank note |
| | check [in a bank] | cheque |
| | check [in a restaurant] | bill |
| | checking account | current account |
| | fiscal year | accounting year |
| | sales | turnover |
| | savings account | deposit account |
| Telephone | busy | engaged |
| | to call collect | to reverse the charges |
| | pound sign [Note: SAP uses "number sign" for # in other contexts.] | hash mark |
| Prepositions | as of [date] | as at [date] |
| | fill out [a form] | fill in [a form] |
| | for more information about | for more information on |

| Subject | ✔American English Term | British English Term |
|---|---|---|
| | on the weekend | at the weekend |
| Conjunctions | because | as [can be used to mean "because"] |
| | since [meaning "because"]<br>[Note: "since" is sometimes ambiguous as in "Since the server has been overloaded, your application may shut down." Does it mean "because" or "since the time"? Watch out for this ambiguity and rephrase the sentence.] | because |
| Punctuation marks | ( ) = parentheses | brackets |
| | { } = curly brackets, braces<br>[Note: To be on the safe side, use "curly brackets".] | curly brackets |
| | [ ] = square brackets, brackets<br>[Note: To be on the safe side, use "square brackets".] | square brackets |
| | check mark | tick |
| | exclamation point | exclamation mark |
| | quotation marks | inverted commas |
| | period | full stop |
| Work environment | expiration date | expiry date |
| | first floor | ground floor |
| | public holiday | bank holiday |
| | résumé | curriculum vitae, CV |
| | vacation | holiday, leave |
| Other | counterclockwise | anti-clockwise |
| | retroactive | retrospective |

## Some Examples

### Related Information

Corporate Language (U.S. English) and Source Languages (English, German) [page 267]
Terminology and SAPterm [page 74]
English Writing Program

## 8.2.4 English: Hyphenation

The main purpose of hyphens is to prevent misinterpretation. This hyphenation overview is not intended to be exhaustive. It focuses on common prefixes, noun compounds, and phrasal adjectives.

### Basics

**Hyphenate words according to American English (U.S.) conventions.**

**To find out how to hyphenate a particular word, refer to *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary*.**

American English hyphenates words less frequently than British English.

If you can't find the word there, refer to *The Chicago Manual of Style* for general hyphenation standards. And to make things a bit more complicated, also check SAPterm whether your product decided ages ago on a particular spelling.

### Common Prefixes

| With a Hyphen | ✔ Example | Without a Hyphen | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|---|
| all- | all-inclusive | anti | antismoking |
| cross- | cross-application | auto | autogenerated |
| ex- | ex-president | bio | biodegradable |
| full- | full-scale | co | cooperate |
| high- | high-level | counter | counterclockwise |
| self- | self-service | extra | extrafine |
| well- | well-known | multi | multimedia |
| | | non | nonnegotiable |

| With a Hyphen | ✔ Example | Without a Hyphen | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | post | postmodern |
| | | pre | preassembled |
| | | over | overqualified |
| | | re | readjust |
| | | semi | semiconductor |
| | | sub | subterranean |
| | | super | superterranean |
| | | under | underqualified |

**Be careful when hyphenating adjectives.**

> Example
>
> ✔ A well-known actor [Note: Hyphen required. The adjective is used before a noun and modifies it.]
>
> ✔ This actor is well known. [Note: No hyphen. The adjective is used stand-alone. It does not modify a noun.]
>
> ✘ This actor is well-known.

## Adjectives

**If a phrasal adjective is used before a noun (as in "copy-protected folders"), hyphenate the phrasal adjective.**

Do **not** use a hyphen if the phrasal adjective does not modify a noun or if the adjective is modified by an adverb.

> Example
>
> ✔ The Web-enabled tools sold well. [Note: Hyphen required. The adjective is used before a noun and modifies it.]
>
> ✔ The tools are Web enabled. [Note: No hyphen. The adjective is used stand-alone. It does not modify a noun.]
>
> ✘ The Web enabled tools [Note: This could be misinterpreted as something the Web has done.]
>
> ✔ This is a time-consuming exercise.

✔ This exercise is time consuming.

✔ The cash-flow-at-risk calculation

✔ The sales-order-related production

✔ SAP offers highly configurable applications. [Note: “highly” is an adverb that modifies the adjective “configurable”. You could replace it with “very”.]

✘ SAP offers highly-configurable applications.

**Use suspended hyphens to avoid redundancy in a series.**

When the second element of a hyphenated adjective is omitted, replace it with a hyphen (-). Do not use this pattern when the first element is omitted. This is likely to confuse readers.

### Example

✔ short- and long-term memory

✔ first- and second-generation computers

✔ over- and underworked participants

✔ water-based and water-soluble paint [Note: No suspended hyphen. “water-” appears in both adjectives as the first element. This way it's easier to read.]

✘ water-based and -soluble paint [Note: This is likely to confuse readers.]

✔ country/region-specific reports [Note: Here “country/region” forms a unit. It replaces the term “country” because of gepolitical considerations. See Terminology and SAPterm [page 74].]

**Hyphenate between a numeral and a unit of measurement if the unit of measurement is spelled out.**

If the unit of measurement is abbreviated, do not use a hyphen.

### Example

✔ A 2 kg weight

✔ 200 GB hard drive

✔ The 18-mile highway

### Nouns

**In noun compounds, do not use hyphens unnecessarily. Use hyphens to prevent misinterpretation.**

If a noun compound consists of 4 or more nouns, you might want to argue that it would be best to use hyphens. In a way, you're right, but primarily such compounds indicate that you need to rephrase the wording. Consider using a relative clause or a prepositional phrase.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The user interface element, the real estate manager, the user assistance process, the tax law change [Note: No hyphen necessary because no danger of misinterpretation. For example, nobody would understand "user interface element" as "interface element for users".]
>
> ✔ The operating-system file [Note: This is not ambiguous. This is the "file for the operating system".]
>
> ✘ The operating system file [Note: This is ambiguous. Is it a "system file that is operating" or is it the "file for the operating system"?]
>
> ✔ The owner of the user assistance process [Note: This is easier to understand than the "user assistance process owner".]

### Related Information

English: Capitalization (Sentence Style and Title Case) [page 199]
Hyphens and Dashes [page 309]
English Writing Program

## 8.2.5 English: Singular Versus Plural Constructions

This overview of singular and plural constructions is not intended to be exhaustive. It covers collectives and percentages.

### Collective Nouns

**Use a singular verb with collective nouns.**

American English generally uses a singular verb with collective nouns, such as "data", "company", "team", "government", or "SAP". In British English the use of a singular or plural verb depends on whether the collective is viewed as a group of individuals or as a unit.

> ✤ Example
>
> [Note: In the following examples, “correct” reflects American English usage, which is the standard at SAP.]
>
> ✔ SAP is launching a new product.
>
> ✘ ... are launching ...
>
> ✔ The data is saved according to your profile settings.
>
> ✘ ... are saved ...
>
> ✔ The company plans to present the half-year figures at the press conference today.
>
> ✘ ... plan ...

## Percentages

**Make sure that the verb agrees in number with the noun or pronoun that it refers to.**

A percentage takes a singular verb when it refers to a word in the singular. A percentage takes a plural verb when it refers to a word in the plural. If the percentage stands alone, use the context to determine what the percentage refers to.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Nearly 80% of the building was renovated.
>
> ✔ Almost 75% of the project team was present. [Note: “team” is a collective noun, which requires a singular verb in American English.]
>
> ✔ Almost 75% of the course participants were present.

## Related Information

English Writing Program

## 8.2.6 English: Relative Clauses with “That”, “Which”, and “Who”

In English, there are restrictive and nonrestrictive relative clauses. Restrictive relative clauses are not set off with commas, because the relative clause is essential to the meaning of the sentence. Let's have a look at some examples. Note: This overview is not intended to be exhaustive.

### Basics: Restrictive or Nonrestrictive?

Consider how the relative clause is semantically related to the main clause. What is the overall meaning?

A **restrictive relative clause** contains information that is essential. If you remove a restrictive relative clause from a sentence, the overall meaning of the sentence changes. To signal this close connection, restrictive relative clauses are **not** set off with commas.

With a **nonrestrictive relative clause** it's the other way round. The relative clause is not essential and therefore it is set off with commas.

**Terminology:** Restrictive relative clauses are sometimes called **defining relative clauses**. Nonrestrictive relative clauses are sometimes called **nondefining relative clauses**.

### Relative Pronouns

Here's an overview of relative pronouns and the use of commas.

In all examples, the relative pronouns “that”, “which”, and “who” are the subject of verbs in relative clauses. For more information about their use as objects in relative clauses (especially when accompanied by prepositions), see English: Grammar Issues of Frequent Debate [page 283].

| Relative Pronoun | Type of Relative Clause (Commas) | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|
| that | Restrictive (no commas) | The data backups that are scheduled to run weekly are done by external backup tools. [Note: This example implies that only the **weekly** data backups are done by external backup tools. All other data backups are done by internal backup tools.] |

| Relative Pronoun | Type of Relative Clause (Commas) | ✔ Example |
|---|---|---|
| which | Nonrestrictive (with commas) | The data backups, which are scheduled to run weekly, are performed with the help of external backup tools. [Note: This example implies that **all** data backups are scheduled to run weekly and are done by external backup tools.]<br><br>SAP SE, which is based in Walldorf, has subsidiaries around the world. [Note: The relative clause is not essential to the meaning because there is only one SAP SE. In effect, you can read the sentence as: SAP SE has subsidiaries around the world.] |
| who [for persons] | Restrictive (no commas) | My cousin who lives in London ... [Note: I have at least two cousins.] |
| | Nonrestrictive (with commas) | My cousin, who lives in London, ...[Note: I have only one cousin.] |

## Related Information

English Writing Program

# 8.2.7 English: Grammar Issues of Frequent Debate

This is a collection of miscellaneous grammatical phenomena such as dangling modifiers, split infinitives, or the position of prepositions in relative clauses. Neither the collection nor the explanations are intended to be exhaustive. For more information, consult grammar books or your language editor.

## Dangling Modifiers

**Make sure that your text does not contain dangling modifiers.**

A dangling modifier is a phrase that, from a grammatical point of view, refers to the subject of a sentence but is actually intended to refer to a different noun.

> Example
>
> ✘ After recharging the battery, the camera is ready for use. [Note: The incorrect example implies that it is the camera that recharges the battery.]
>
> ✔ After you have recharged the battery, the camera is ready for use.

✔ After recharging the battery, you can use the camera.

## Relative Clauses: Where to Position the Preposition?

**In restrictive relative clauses where the relative pronoun is the object of a preposition, you can often put the preposition at the end of the relative clause.**

The basic rules are illustrated in the following examples. The decisive aspect is "Does it sound like natural language?"

### Example

[Note: This is about "that ... about" as opposed to "about which ...".]

✔ The document that the product owner was talking about was published. [Note: This is natural language. It supports a friendly, conversational tone. It doesn't sound formal or stilted.]

[Note: From a grammatical point of view, the following examples are of course correct.]

✔ ✘ The document the product owner was talking about was published. [Note: This is a bit too informal. This type of grammatical construction is also difficult for people without first-language proficiency. The relative clause is introduced without a syntactic cue (relative pronoun).]

✔ ✘ The document about which the product owner was talking was published. [Note: This is very formal.]

## Singular "They" (and "Their")

**Be careful with singular "they" (and "their").**

The construction has been gaining in use, especially in spoken language. The *SAP Brand* site promotes it (see Writing Style Overview), as did the *Chicago Manual of Style*. Nevertheless, singular "they" ("their", "them") can be unclear for translation and for people without first-language proficiency. Consider rewriting in such cases. For more information, see Bias-Free Language and Communication [page 98] and Chicago Style for the Singular "They".

### Example

✔ Each participant contributed in their preferred language.

✔ When the chairperson published the report, they immediately got feedback.

✔ The user must enter a password. They need to remember the password for the next page. [Note: This might be difficult for people without first-language proficiency.So you

could rewrite the second sentence to “The password is also required on the next page.” or merge both sentences to “Enter a password and remember it.”]

✔ We can trace the last number that called – unless the caller withheld the number. [Note: This is the easy way out. Instead of “his/her/their number” it's just “the number”.]

✔ We can trace the last number that called – unless the caller withheld their number. [Note: This might work for people without first-language proficiency. It's a bit difficult to explain exactly why, possibly because of the semantic and grammatical context.]

## Split Infinitives

**Use split infinitives if you want to contrast different ways of doing things.**

A split infinitive is an infinitive that has an adverb between “to” and the verb. Split infinitives disrupt natural word order, but they can be useful for highlighting certain aspects.

### ✤ Example

✔ This setting allows you to enter data quickly. [Note: This is normal, unmarked word order.]

✔ To quickly enter the most important data, use the business partner template for the target group. To completely enter the data in one session, create the business partner without entering a template. [Note: The split infinitive highlights the different ways of doing things.]

## Related Information

English: How to Write Clear, Translatable Texts for a Global Audience [page 270]
English Writing Program

# 8.3 German: Deutsche Rechtschreibung und Wortwahl

Als Ergänzung zum Rechtschreibduden hat SAP spezifische Standards festgelegt. Diese regeln den Umgang mit Varianten im Duden (z.B. Schreibung) oder softwaretypische Spezialfälle (z.B. Komposita mit englischen Wörtern).

## Allgemeine Standards

**Verwenden Sie die deutsche Rechtschreibung und Zeichensetzung sowie deutsche und fremdsprachliche Wörter so, wie sie im aktuellen Rechtschreibduden vorgegeben sind.**

Andere Werke, z.B. Wortlisten der deutschen Nachrichtenagenturen, sind für das Schreiben bei SAP **nicht** relevant.

**Passen Sie die Rechtschreibung in bestehenden Texten nur an, wenn Sie den Text inhaltlich aktualisieren müssen.**

Weitere Informationen finden Sie im Hinweis 500518.

**Wenn der Rechtschreibduden mehrere Möglichkeiten zulässt, folgen Sie bei SAP folgenden Standards:**

| Thema | SAP-Standard | ✔ Beispiel | ✘ Beispiel |
|---|---|---|---|
| verschiedene Schreibweisen | Dudenempfehlung (gelb unterlegt) | Potenzial [Anmerkung: Das ist die Dudenempfehlung.] | Potential |
| Genitiv | Bildung auf "-s" | des Objekts | des Objektes |
| | **kein** Apostroph (') bei Substantiven und Akronymen | des Herstellers, des Computers, des APIs | des Hersteller's, des Computer's, des API's |
| | **kein** Apostroph (') bei Namen | Peters Liste<br>Ausnahme: Andreas' Liste (m), Andrea's Liste (w) [Anmerkung: Apostroph zur Verdeutlichung des Genus bei Namen] | Peter's Liste |
| Plural | **kein** Apostroph (') bei Abkürzungen (Akronymen) | die APIs | die API's |

| Thema | SAP-Standard | ✔ Beispiel | ✘ Beispiel |
|---|---|---|---|
| mehrere Genus-angaben | das im Duden erst-genannte Genus | der Tachometer | das Tachometer |

### Related Information

Corporate Language (U.S. English) and Source Languages (English, German) [page 267]
SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183]
Punctuation [page 301]
German: Komma [page 309]
SAP Translation Style Guide (German)

## 8.3.1 German: Englische Wörter im Deutschen

Entlehnungen aus dem Englischen sind im Deutschen häufig, insbesondere in der Softwarebranche. Wie geht man damit um? Im Folgenden finden Sie die grundlegenden Standards.

### Allgemeine Standards

| | |
|---|---|
| **Vermeiden Sie unnötige englische Wörter im Deutschen.** | Viele englische Wörter erschweren dem Leser das Textverständnis und stellen Sie als Autor vor schwierige Fragen der Schreibung, Deklination und Konjugation. |
| **Prüfen Sie, ob Sie statt des englischen Worts ein gebräuchliches deutsches Wort (oder eine Wortgruppe) verwenden können.** | Berücksichtigen Sie auch, dass ein englisches Wort im Deutschen je nach Kontext anders wiedergegeben werden muss. |

Example

[Anmerkung: Obwohl die englischen Wörter laut Rechtschreibduden nicht falsch sind, finden sich gute und oft auch zu bevorzugende deutsche Entsprechungen.]

| Englisches Wort | Vom Englischen beeinflusstes Wort | ✔ Deutsche Entsprechung |
|---|---|---|
| to download, to upload | downloaden, uploaden | herunterladen, hochladen |
| | downgeloaded, upgeloaded | heruntergeladen, hochgeladen |

| Englisches Wort | Vom Englischen beeinflusstes Wort | ✔ Deutsche Entsprechung |
|---|---|---|
| proactive | proaktiv | initiativ, vorausschauend, vorbeugend, präventiv, im Vorfeld, weitsichtig, klug, ... |
| performance | Performance [Anmerkung: richtig, wenn in der technischen Bedeutung in Bezug auf Software verwendet] | Leistung(sbilanz), Ergebnis, Aufgabenerfüllung, Unternehmensleistung, Unternehmenserfolg, ... |
| ecosystem | Ökosystem [Anmerkung: richtig in Bezug auf Umwelt oder wenn der Kontext klar und eine Variation zur deutschen Entsprechung notwendig ist] | Kunden- und Partnernetz, Partner, Kunden, Investoren und andere Anspruchsgruppen, ... |

### Related Information

SAP Translation Style Guide (German)

## 8.3.2 German: Genus englischer Substantive im Deutschen

Das Genus englischer Substantive im Deutschen zu bestimmen ist nicht immer leicht. Der einfachste Fall ist, wenn das Substantiv im Rechtschreibduden steht. Wenn dies nicht der Fall ist, finden Sie hier einige Prinzipien, die Ihnen helfen, das Genus zu bestimmen.

### Allgemeine Standards

**Wenn das englische Substantiv nicht im Rechtschreibduden enthalten ist, ziehen Sie zur Bestimmung des Genus die im Folgenden beschriebenen Prinzipien heran.**

In manchen Fällen treffen mehrere, sich widersprechende Prinzipien zu. Wägen Sie die Prinzipien ab, und wählen Sie das für Ihren Kontext Passende. Wenn das englische Wort im Rechtschreibduden steht, gilt wie bei deutschen Wörtern das im Duden angegebene (erstgenannte) Genus.

## Deutsches Wort mit ähnlicher Bedeutung

Das Genus der deutschen Übersetzung des Substantivs wird übernommen.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ das Internet [Anmerkung: analog zu “das Netz”]
>
> ✔ die Workbench [Anmerkung: analog zu “die Werkbank”]

## Oberbegriff

Das Genus des deutschen Oberbegriffs wird übernommen.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ der Sherry, der Cocktail, der Brandy [Anmerkung: analog zu “der Alkohol”]

## Suffix

Das Genus richtet sich nach dem Suffix des englischen Substantivs.

| Englisches Suffix | Im Deutschen assoziiertes Genus | ✔Beispiel |
|---|---|---|
| -er | maskulin | der Computer |
| -or | | der Editor |
| -ist | | der Lobbyist |
| -ster | | der Cluster |
| -ness | feminin | die Fitness |
| -ty | | die Publicity |
| -ion | | die Bodylotion |
| -ment | neutrum | das Management |
| -ing | | das Controlling |

### Silbenanzahl

**Einsilbige englische Substantive erhalten meist das maskuline Genus.**

> Example
>
> ✔ der Job, der Host, der Hub, der Pool
>
> ✔ das Byte, das Team

### Related Information

SAP Translation Style Guide (German)

## 8.3.3 German: Deklination englischer Substantive im Deutschen

Wie werden englische Substantive im Deutschen dekliniert? Im Folgenden finden Sie die wichtigsten Standards im Überblick.

### Allgemeine Standards

**Deklinieren Sie englische Substantive wie im Deutschen.**

Maßgebliche und umfassende Informationen finden Sie in *Die deutsche Grammatik* (Duden, Band 4) im Abschnitt *Die Deklination der Fremdwörter*.

### Genitiv Singular

**Fügen Sie an englische Maskulina und Neutra im Genitiv Singular ein “s” an. Feminina erhalten kein “s”.**

Dies gilt auch für softwarenahe Eigennamen. Die Grundregel mit Genitiv-“s” funktioniert jedoch nicht immer, z.B. bei Feminina oder bei bestimmten Wortausgängen wie z.B. “ist”. Schlagen Sie Details in der Grammatik nach.

> Example
>
> ✔ das Datum des Upgrades, die Änderung des Customizings, der Besitzer des Computers

✔ die Vertreter der Lobby, die Verwendung der Query [Anmerkung: Genitiv von Feminina]

✔ die Beschreibung des Service, die Verwendung des Interface, die Meinung des Lobbyisten [Anmerkung: kein “s” im Genitiv]

**Ausnahme: Bilden Sie bei SAP-Produktnamen und anderen Approved Names keinen Genitiv mit “s”. Verwenden Sie eine umschreibende Formulierung.**

Example

✔ die Implementierung von SAP Business Warehouse (SAP BW)

✘ die Implementierung eines SAP Business Warehouses (SAP BWs)

✔ das umfassende Funktionsspektrum von SAP ERP

✘ SAP ERPs umfassendes Funktionsspektrum

## Plural

**Fügen Sie an englische Substantive die Pluralendung “s” an, selbst wenn das Substantiv auf “y” endet.**

Dies gilt auch für softwarenahe Eigennamen. Die Grundregel mit Plural-“s” funktioniert jedoch nicht immer. Schlagen Sie Details in der Grammatik nach.

Example

✔ die Reports, die Bytes, die Teams, die Querys

✘ die Queries

**Aber:**

✔ die Computer, die Controller, die Adapter [Anmerkung: Substantive mit der Endung “er” haben keine Pluralendung. Sie bleiben im Plural gleich.]

✔ die Sponsoren, die Lobbyisten [Anmerkung: Substantive mit der Endung “or” oder “ist” erhalten die Pluralendung “en”.]

**Ausnahme: Bilden Sie bei SAP-Produktnamen und anderen Approved Names keinen Plural mit “s”. Verwenden Sie eine umschreibende Formulierung.**

Example

✔ Das Unternehmen implementierte SAP ERP an mehreren Standorten.

✘ Das Unternehmen hatte mehrere SAP ERPs.

✔ Die Implementierung von SAP-BW-Anwendungen

✘ die Implementierung von SAP BWs

### Related Information

SAP Translation Style Guide (German)

## 8.3.4 German: Englische Verben im Deutschen

Ist ein englisches Verb angebracht im Deutschen? Wie werden englische Verben konjugiert? Im Folgenden finden Sie die wichtigsten Standards im Überblick.

### Allgemeine Standards

**Vermeiden Sie unnötige englische Verben im Deutschen.**

Dies gilt auch, wenn das englische Verb im aktuellen Rechtschreibduden enthalten ist.

**Prüfen Sie, ob Sie statt des englischen Verbs ein gebräuchliches deutsches Verb (oder eine Wortgruppe) verwenden können.**

Berücksichtigen Sie auch, dass ein englisches Wort im Deutschen je nach Kontext anders wiedergegeben werden muss.

Example

| Englisches Verb | Vom Englischen beeinflusstes Verb | ✔ Empfohlene deutsche Entsprechung |
|---|---|---|
| to cancel | canceln | abbrechen, stornieren, kündigen, absagen |
| to deploy | deployen | verteilen, implementieren, ein Deployment durchführen, einsetzen |
| to download, to upload | downloaden, uploaden | herunterladen, hochladen |
| to manage | managen | verwalten, steuern, koordinieren, leiten, organisieren |
| to map | mappen | ein Mapping durchführen, zuordnen, abgleichen |
| to outsource | outsourcen | auslagern |
| to scroll | scrollen | blättern |

| Englisches Verb | Vom Englischen beeinflusstes Verb | ✔ Empfohlene deutsche Entsprechung |
|---|---|---|
| to update | updaten | aktualisieren |
| to upgrade | upgraden | ein Upgrade durchführen, aktualisieren |

### Konjugation

**Wenn Sie ein englisches Verb verwenden, konjugieren Sie es wie ein regelmäßiges deutsches Verb.**

Example

✔ scannen [Infinitiv mit "en"], er scannt [3. Person Singular Präsens], er hat gescannt [3. Person Singular Perfekt]

✔ downloaden, er hat downgeloadet [Anmerkung: Dieses Beispiel illustriert grammatische Aspekte. Das bessere, weil gebräuchliche Verb ist natürlich "herunterladen".]

### Related Information

SAP Translation Style Guide (German)

## 8.3.5 German: Komposita mit deutschen Wörtern (im Rechtschreibduden)

Im Deutschen gilt für Komposita vorrangig Zusammenschreibung ohne Bindestrich. In manchen Fällen ist jedoch ein Bindestrich angebracht. Nur wann genau? Und was ist mit englischen Wörtern? Im Folgenden einige Standards.

### Allgemeine Standards

**Als deutsche Wörter gelten alle Wörter, die im Rechtschreibduden enthalten sind.**

Fremdsprachliche Wörter werden wie deutsche Wörter behandelt, wenn sie mit der entsprechenden Bedeutung im Rechtschreibduden enthalten sind.

**Wenn ein englisches Wort nicht oder nicht mit der entsprechenden Bedeutung im Rechtschreibduden enthalten ist, bestimmen Sie die Schreibung des Wortes anhand der Standards für Komposita mit englischen Wörtern.**

Weitere Informationen finden Sie unter German: Komposita mit englischen Wörtern (nicht im Rechtschreibduden) [page 297].

## 3 oder weniger Substantive

**Wenn ein Kompositum aus 3 oder weniger Substantiven besteht, schreiben Sie das Wort zusammen, d.h. ohne Bindestrich (-).**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Konsumgüterindustrie, Produktpreisliste, Cashflowdiagramm

**Ausnahme: Um Missverständnisse zu vermeiden oder unübersichtliche Zusammensetzungen zu gliedern, setzen Sie einen Bindestrich an der semantisch richtigen Stelle.**

Diese Fälle sind selten.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Druck-Erzeugnis, Drucker-Zeugnis, Break-even-Analyse

**Ausnahme: Wenn im Kompositum 3 identische Vokale aufeinander treffen, setzen Sie einen Bindestrich.**

Diese Fälle sind selten.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Kaffee-Ecke

## 4 oder mehr Substantive

**Wenn ein Kompositum aus 4 oder mehr Substantiven besteht, setzen Sie einen Bindestrich an der semantisch richtigen Stelle.**

Komposita mit 4 und mehr Substantiven wirken sperrig, egal ob mit oder ohne Bindestrich. Prüfen Sie, ob Sie im Kompositum ein Wort streichen oder ersetzen oder statt des Kompositums eine Wortgruppe mit Präpositionen verwenden können.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Verrechnungswert-Prüffunktion [Anmerkung: Der Bindestrich stimmt, und das Wort ist lesbar. Jedoch ist das Kompositum ingesamt sperrig.]
>
> ✔ Verrechnungswertprüfungen [Anmerkung: “Prüffunktion” wurde durch “Prüfungen” ersetzt. “Funktion” ist ein verzichtbares Füllwort.]

✔ Prüfung des Verrechnungswerts, Prüffunktion für den Verrechnungswert

## Fugen-“s”

Setzen Sie keinen Bindestrich nach einem Fugen-“s”.

Example

✔ Lösungsvorschlag, Hochleistungscomputer

Ausnahme: Wenn das Wort, das dem Fugen-“s” folgt, eine Abkürzung ist oder ein englisches Wort, das nicht im Rechtschreibduden enthalten ist, setzen Sie einen Bindestrich.

Example

✔ Bankverbindungs-ID, Berechnungs-Workbench

✘ BankverbindungsID

## Abkürzungen und Kurzwörter

Setzen Sie bei Komposita mit Abkürzungen einen Bindestrich. Behalten Sie die Groß- und Kleinschreibung der Abkürzung bei.

Example

✔ ABAP-Programmierung, km-Zahl, US-amerikanisch

Hinterfragen Sie Komposita mit Kurzwörtern wie z.B. “Infostruktur”.

Die Schreibung selbst ist einfach: Schreiben Sie Komposita mit Kurzwörtern zusammen, d.h. ohne Bindestrich. Also z.B. “Infostruktur” für vollständig “Informationsstruktur”. Die grundlegende Frage ist allerdings: Warum überhaupt die Kurzform? Manchmal ist Platzmangel ein Grund. Grundsätzlich ist aber ein ständiger Wechsel zwischen Kurzwort und vollständiger Wortform dem Textverständnis abträglich (auch auf Softwareoberflächen). Verwenden Sie, wenn möglich, die vollständige Wortform.

## “Nicht”

Schreiben Sie die Wortfolge “nicht” und Adjektiv oder Partizip getrennt, d.h. ohne Bindestrich.

Example

✔ eine nicht zutreffende Regel, eine nicht abzugsfähige Vorsteuer

Schreiben Sie Komposita aus “nicht” und Substantiv zusammen, d.h. ohne Bindestrich. Prüfen Sie, ob Sie das Kompositum mit „nicht“ verbal auflösen können.

Example

✔ Nichtlagermaterial

✔ bei Nichtbefolgung einer Regel [Anmerkung: Dies klingt nach Amtsdeutsch. Leichter verständlich ist eine verbale Umschreibung, wie z.B. “Wenn Sie die Regel nicht befolgen”.]

✔ Nicht-SAP-Software [Anmerkung: Hier muss ein Bindestrich gesetzt werden, da “SAP” ein Akronym ist.]

## “Soll”, “Ist”, “Muss” und “Kann”

Schreiben Sie Komposita mit “Soll”, “Ist”, “Muss” und “Kann” zusammen, d.h. ohne Bindestrich.

Example

✔ Sollkapazität, Istwerte, Mussfeld, Kannfeld

## Mehrere Bestimmungswörter vor dem Grundwort

Wenn mehrere Wörter als Bestimmung vor dem Grundwort stehen, setzen Sie Bindestriche zwischen alle Wörter.

Example

✔ Soll-Ist-Vergleich, Preis-Mengen-Staffel

### Zahlen und Ziffern

**Setzen Sie bei Komposita mit Ziffern einen Bindestrich.**

Vor allem in technischen Texten werden Zahlen als Ziffern geschrieben, da sie die Aufmerksamkeit auf sich lenken.Weitere Informationen zur Schreibung von Zahlen und Ziffern finden Sie unter Numbers [page 208].

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ 200-GB-Festplatte, 12-fach

### Related Information

Hyphens and Dashes [page 309]
SAP Translation Style Guide (German)

## 8.3.6 German: Komposita mit englischen Wörtern (nicht im Rechtschreibduden)

Bei Komposita mit englischen Wörtern stellen sich im Deutschen Fragen zu Groß-, Klein- und Zusammenschreibung, und nicht zu vergessen zum Bindestrich. Im Folgenden einige Standards.

### Allgemeine Standards

**Wenden Sie die im Folgenden beschriebenen Standards für die Schreibung eines Kompositums an, dessen englische Bestandteile nicht oder nicht mit der entsprechenden Bedeutung im Rechtschreibduden enthalten sind.**

Hierbei spielt auch die Schreibung im Englischen eine Rolle. Verbindlich für die Schreibung im Englischen ist das aktuelle *Merriam-Webster's Collegiate Dictionary*. Informationen über Komposita mit Produktnamen und anderen Approved Names finden Sie unter SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183].

**Wenn ein englisches Wort mit der entsprechenden Bedeutung im Rechtschreibduden enthalten ist, gelten für Komposita dieser Wörter die Standards für deutsche Komposita.**

Für die Schreibung des englischen Worts gilt die Dudenempfehlung. Weitere Informationen finden Sie unter German: Komposita mit deutschen Wörtern (im Rechtschreibduden) [page 293].

## Groß- und Kleinschreibung

**Wenn das Kompositum ein Substantiv ist, schreiben Sie den Anfangsbuchstaben sowie den ersten Buchstaben aller substantivischen Einzelwörter als Großbuchstaben.**

Der Anfangsbuchstabe ist immer ein Großbuchstabe (Majuskel), auch wenn das erste Einzelwort kein Substantiv ist. Achten Sie darauf, dass keine Binnenmajuskeln (Großbuchstabe mitten im Wort ohne vorhergehenden Bindestrich) entstehen.

> Example
>
> ✔ Just-in-Time-Lieferung, Workplace-Architektur
>
> ✘ WorkPlace-Architektur [Anmerkung: keine Binnenmajuskel!]

**Ausnahme:** SAP-Produktnamen und andere Approved Names, die Binnenmajuskeln enthalten, wie z.B. SAP MaxDB, SAP Business ByDesign

**Wenn das Kompositum zu einer anderen Wortart gehört, schreiben Sie den Anfangsbuchstaben sowie den ersten Buchstaben aller substantivischen Einzelwörter als Kleinbuchstaben.**

Prüfen Sie, ob Sie das Kompositum verbal auflösen können.

> Example
>
> ✔ clientseitig

## Ausschließlich englische Substantive

**Schreiben Sie das Kompositum zusammen, d.h. ohne Bindestrich, wenn es im Englischen zusammengeschrieben wird.**

> Example
>
> ✔ Showcase [Englisch: showcase]

**Schreiben Sie das Kompositum getrennt, wenn es im Englischen getrennt geschrieben wird und wenn Sie es als softwarenahen Eigennamen für eine Funktion, ein Tool o.ä. im Deutschen verwenden.**

Als Indiz hierfür kann ein entsprechender Eintrag in SAPterm gelten. Sie können für diesen Namen in SAPterm das Kennzeichen *Nicht zu übersetzen/ Term in Zielsprache replizieren* setzen.

> Example
>
> ✔ Data Aging [Englisch: Data Aging]
>
> ✔ Accounting Engine [Englisch: Accounting Engine]

Setzen Sie einen Bindestrich (-), wenn das Kompositum im Englischen getrennt oder mit Bindestrich geschrieben wird oder wenn Sie den Bindestrich im Deutschen zur besseren Lesbarkeit einfügen wollen.

Example

✔ Release-Management [Englisch: release management. Anmerkung: “Management” bezeichnet hierbei eine technische Funktion.]

## Englisches Adjektiv und englisches Substantiv

Schreiben Sie die Wörter getrennt.

Example

✔ Developmental Editor [Englisch: developmental editor]

## Englisches Substantiv und englische Präposition oder englisches Adverb

Setzen Sie einen Bindestrich, wenn das Kompositum im Englischen getrennt oder mit Bindestrich geschrieben wird.

Example

✔ Trade-off [Englisch: trade-off]

Schreiben Sie das Kompositum zusammen, d.h. ohne Bindestrich, wenn das Kompositum im Englischen zusammengeschrieben wird.

Example

✔ Shutdown [Englisch: shutdown]

## Englisches und deutsches Substantiv

Setzen Sie einen Bindestrich.

Example

✔ Developmental-Editing-Prozess, Repository-Vergleich

✘ Developmental Editing-Prozess [Anmerkung: Das Substantiv “Developmental Editing” wird zwar ohne Bindestrich geschrieben, aber in einem Kompositum mit einem deutschenWort ist zwischen allen Bestandteilen ein Bindestrich erforderlich.]

## Englisches Adjektiv und deutsches Substantiv

**Setzen Sie einen Bindestrich.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Top-down-Planung, End-to-End-Szenario [Anmerkung: Das englische Wort “end” ist zwar ein Substantiv, aber die Kombination “end-to-end” ist ein Adjektiv.]

## Englisches Substantiv und deutsches Adjektiv

**Schreiben Sie das Kompositum zusammen, d.h. ohne Bindestrich, wenn das englische Substantiv ein eingliedriges Substantiv ist oder ein Kompositum, das im Deutschen ohne Bindestrich geschrieben wird.**

Die Zusammenschreibung mit deutschen Adjektiven folgt den Regeln des Rechtschreibdudens zur Getrennt- und Zusammenschreibung (K57–62). Zur besseren Lesbarkeit können Sie in Einzelfällen einen Bindestrich setzen.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ bootfähig, hashbasiert, clientseitig

## Elemente aus Programmiersprachen

**Setzen Sie einen Bindestrich bei Komposita mit Elementen aus Programmiersprachen.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ IF-Schleife, DEFINE-Anweisung

**Um den Programmierbefehl nicht zu verfälschen, bilden Sie bei Programmierbefehlen mit 2 oder mehr Bestandteilen kein Kompositum. Setzen Sie einen Bezeichner vor den Befehl. Wenn möglich, formatieren Sie den Befehl.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ der Befehl `DELETE FROM` [Anmerkung: Hier mit dem DITA-Tag `cmdname` formattiert.]
>
> ✘ DELETE-FROM-Befehl

## Related Information

Hyphens and Dashes [page 309]
SAP Translation Style Guide (German)

# 8.4 Punctuation

This overview is not intended to be exhaustive. It focuses on punctuation aspects that are of particular relevance for writing texts at SAP or that are frequent sources of error.

## Basics

**For punctuation in general, refer to the latest version of the standard work for your language.**

Only valid for 'Localization': English

**English:** *The Chicago Manual of Style*

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

**German:** Rechtschreibduden

End of 'Localization': German

Punctuation rules and punctuation marks are language-specific. You can apply them from one language to another only to a limited extent.

**Never rely on punctuation alone to convey what you have to say.**

The aim of punctuation is to **make texts easier to read** and understand. There will always be cases of doubt or personal style. In some cases, for example on the user interface, you might even have to break punctuation conventions in order to comply with other standards. To come to a decision, it often helps to keep in mind that many punctuation conventions come from the printing age. This does not, however, mean that you're free to punctuate at random.

**Do not enclose punctuation marks that follow the last word of a phrase in formatting.**

**Translation:** Translation software works more efficiently if punctuation marks and formatted words are kept separate. The software mostly uses periods (.) and colons (:) to detect translation segments. If punctuation marks are part of formatted text, translators have to manually expand the translation segment because the target languages have different punctuation rules and word order.

**Exception:** If the phrase and the punctuation mark closely belong together and form a stable translation segment, you can of course enclose the punctuation mark in formatting. For example, in this style guide that's the reason why independent introductory phrases such as "**Translation:**" or "**Tools:**" have the colon inside the formatting. Also, if abbreviations contain periods, you can't avoid enclosing the period in formatting. On the other hand, the best solution is to avoid the abbreviation.

> Example
>
> ✔ You have the following **configuration options**: [Note: You can't assume that "configuration options" is also the last word in the target languages. Therefore, the colon is **not** part of the formatting.]

✔ You can use this software to plan, **optimize**, and execute your transportation process. [Note: You cannot assume that “optimize” is also followed by a comma in the target languages. Therefore, the comma is **not** part of the formatting.]

✔ On the *Dev. Type* screen, you can ... [Note: The period is part of the abbreviation, the assumption being that the abbreviation couldn't be avoided on the user interface.]

### Related Information

Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157]

## 8.4.1 Spaces

When to use spaces in text? Spaces separate words as we all know. But then there are nonbreaking spaces, and sometimes spaces can even do harm, for example, in URLs. So there seems to be more to find out about spaces.

### Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| Remember: The function of spaces is to separate words. | From a typographic point of view, each space is also a potential line break, that is, a breaking space. |
| Use only 1 space as a separator between individual words and after a punctuation mark. | Do not use multiple spaces. Even after a period (.) at the end of a sentence, it's really just 1 space instead of 2 spaces. |
| In longer phrases such as navigation paths or keyboard combinations, use 1 space as a potential line break before and after the individual elements. | Without spaces, the authoring tool interprets the whole phrase as a unit and, if there are space restrictions, shifts it to the next line. The result is an unwanted line break in the middle of the line.<br>**Tools:** Check whether you need to manually insert the space. Most authoring tools automatically add spaces. |

## Nonbreaking Spaces

**Use nonbreaking spaces to prevent words that belong very closely together from being split by a line break.**

For example, use a nonbreaking space for short phrases such as “5 kg”.

**Tools:** In many authoring tools, you can create a nonbreaking space by pressing `Ctrl` + `Shift` + `Spacebar`.

**Be careful with nonbreaking spaces. Don't overdo it.**

Connecting longer phrases with nonbreaking spaces can result in unwanted line breaks.

## When Not to Use Spaces

**Do not use spaces in abbreviations with periods (.).**

This is to keep the elements together.

Example

Only valid for 'Localization': English

✔ **English:** a.m., p.m.

End of 'Localization': English

Only valid for 'Localization': German

✔ **German:** z.B., d.h.

End of 'Localization': German

**Tools:** Typographically, a thin space would be correct, but not a full space. However, few authoring tools support thin spaces.

**Do not insert a space as a potential line break in directory paths, URLs, technical names, and so on.**

Inserting a space means changing the phrase itself and results, for example, in broken hyperlinks.

## 8.4.2 Periods

Periods are used at the end of a sentence. But there are a few things to know, for example, how periods affect translation software.

### Basics

**Use a period (.) at the end of a complete sentence.**

In some cases, you may need to make an inner judgement call for consistency reasons. For example, you have list items or table cells (in a column) with a mix of complete and incomplete sentences.

Now just in case – what is a complete sentence? Roughly speaking, it has at least a subject and a verb and can be followed by complements such as objects or prepositional phrases. Sometimes the subject can also be hidden in the verb.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The administrator [subject] checks [verb] the user authorizations during the test phase.
>
> ✔ The authorization screen [subject] appears [verb]. [Note: This is an example with a nonagentive subject and a verb without any complements. But it's still a complete sentence. However, before writing such a sentence, do check whether you can omit this sentence because you're stating the obvious.]
>
> ✔ Enter your user ID. [Note: This is an English example where the subject is hidden in the verb (imperative form). In other languages, the subject may be overt as in German "Geben Sie [subject] Ihre Benutzer-ID ein."]

**Do not enclose a period that ends a sentence in formatting.**

**Translation:** This has to do with translation segments used by translation software. For more information, see Punctuation [page 301].

**If the last word in a sentence is an abbreviation that ends with a period, do not add a second period at the end of the sentence.**

Double periods would indeed look odd.

### Related Information

Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157]

## 8.4.3 Colons

Not much to say about colons, just this: They are helpful for introducing information.

### Basics

| | |
|---|---|
| **Use a colon (:) to introduce information.** | A colon is typically used at the end of an introductory sentence for a list, a table, or a graphic. |
| **Do not enclose a colon in formatting.** | **Translation:** This has to do with translation segments used by translation software. For more information, see Punctuation [page 301]. |
| **If the colon is followed by a complete sentence, begin the first word with an uppercase letter.** | This is customary at the start of a sentence anyway. |
| **If the colon is followed by an incomplete sentence (a word or a phrase), begin the first word with a lowercase letter.** | **Exception:** There are language-specific reasons for doing so, for example, proper nouns or other spelling conventions.<br>Only valid for 'Localization': English<br>**English exception:** In titles (headings, captions), begin the first word with an uppercase letter, irrespective of the part of speech.<br>End of 'Localization': English |

Example

✔ You have the following **configuration options**: [Note: The colon is not enclosed in formatting.]

✔ The course covers some of the most important quality activities: developmental editing, copy editing, and documentation testing.

✔ System administrators have a choice: They can run the reports manually, or they can schedule them to run at regular intervals.

### Related Information

Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157]

## 8.4.4 English: Commas

Together with periods, commas are the most common punctuation marks. Here's a collection of their main uses.

### "and", "or", and Other Coordinating Conjunctions

**Use the serial comma.**

When the coordinating conjunctions "and" or "or" precede the last item in a series, use a comma before the conjunction. Serial commas help avoid confusion in cases where the last item in a series is a pair. By the way, series means a list of at least three items.

**Exception:** Do not use a comma in a series whose elements are all joined by conjunctions.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ You use this business process to plan, optimize, and execute the complete transportation.
>
> ✘ You use this business process to plan, and optimize the complete transportation. [Note: No comma after "plan" because there are only two items.]
>
> ✔ The guide covers topics such as system monitoring, report scheduling, and database backup and recovery. [Note: The last item "database backup and recovery" is a pair and must not be separated by a comma. A comma is, however, required after "scheduling".]
>
> ✔ The conference is in Paris or Rome or maybe in Brussels. [Note: This is the exception.]

**Use a comma before the coordinating conjunctions "and", "but", "or", "so", and "yet" if they introduce an independent clause.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The printer in this office is new, but the one in the next corridor offers more functions.

### Nonrestrictive Relative Clauses

**Use a comma to set off a nonrestrictive relative clause.**

A nonrestrictive relative clause contains information that is not essential to the overall meaning of the sentence.

> **Example**
>
> ✔ SAP SE, which is based in Walldorf, has subsidiaries around the world.

## Adverbial Clauses and Phrases

**If an adverbial clause (introduced by “if”, “when”, “before”, and so on) precedes the main clause, end the adverbial clause with a comma.**

Do not use a comma if the adverbial clause follows the main clause.

> **Example**
>
> ✔ If you can sign in, the license key has been correctly installed.
>
> ✔ You can release the order even if you did not create it yourself.

**After an introductory prepositional phrase of 5 or more words, use a comma.**

If the introductory phrase consists of 4 or fewer words, use a comma if it is necessary to indicate a slight pause or to prevent misinterpretation.

> **Example**
>
> ✔ After careful planning and preparation, the project was started.
>
> ✔ After receiving the copy-editing findings, the authors make the necessary corrections to their documents.
>
> ✔ Before leaving, employees make sure that they have switched off their computers.

**After an introductory adverb that refers to the whole sentence (for example, “therefore” or “however”), use a comma.**

Such adverbs often express consequence or contrast.

> **Example**
>
> ✔ The payment was received too late. Therefore, the customer had to pay a fee.

## Explanatory Expressions with “that is”, “for example”, or “such as”

Use a comma with “that is”.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ You can run the deletion program to test it, that is, without physically deleting the data.

Use a comma with “for example”.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ For example, you can pay the sum in dollars.
>
> ✔ You can pay the sum, for example, in dollars.

Use a comma with “such as” if “such as” is not essential (non-restrictive meaning).

And unsurprisingly there's no comma if the meaning is restrictive. It's the same principle as with relative clauses.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Citrus fruits, such as oranges and grapefruits, are high in vitamin C. [Note: If you remove the “such as” expression, the meaning doesn't change. Therefore a comma is required.]
>
> ✔ Currencies such as the dollar and the euro are stable. [Note: Not all currencies are stable, that is, restrictive meaning. And therefore no comma.]

## No Comma Between Subject and Verb

Do not use a comma between subject and verb.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Planning and conducting a successful developmental editing project is one of the most challenging tasks for an experienced user assistance developer.
>
> ✘ Planning and conducting a successful developmental editing project, is one of the most challenging tasks for an experienced user assistance developer.

## Related Information

English: Relative Clauses with “That”, “Which”, and “Who” [page 282]

## 8.4.5 German: Komma

Kommasetzung im Deutschen wird ausführlich im Rechtschreibduden beschrieben. Die hier behandelten Fälle haben im Duden keine Empfehlung.

### SAP-Standard (fehlende Empfehlung im Rechtschreibduden)

**Setzen Sie ein Komma (,) vor erweitertem Infinitiv.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Der Benutzer wagte es nicht, den Auftrag zu löschen.
>
> ✔ Sie trafen sich, um die wichtigsten Punkte abzustimmen.

**Setzen Sie ein Komma vor "und" und "oder", wenn sie vollständige Hauptsätze einleiten.**

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Der Systemadministrator hatte die Berechtigung erteilt, und der Benutzer konnte den Auftrag freigeben.

**Setzen Sie ein Komma vor Ausdrücke wie "d.h." und "z.B.".**

**Danach** nur ein Komma, wenn ein vollständiger Haupt- oder Nebensatz folgt.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ Im Juni, d.h. nach Entwicklungsschluss, müssen Sie eine explizite Änderungsgenehmigung beantragen.
>
> ✔ Im Juni, d.h., wenn der Entwicklungsschluss vorbei ist, müssen Sie eine explizite Änderungsgenehmigung beantragen.

## 8.4.6 Hyphens and Dashes

Hyphens are used at word level. Dashes are used at sentence level. Typographically, they are different punctuation marks.

### Typography

**Note that hyphens and dashes are typographically different punctuation marks.**

Hyphens are used at word level, dashes at sentence level. Compare: Hyphen (-) versus en dash (–) versus em dash (—)

## Hyphen

**Use a hyphen (-) to form compounds if grammatically required.**

Compound formation and hyphenation are language specific.

> Example
>
> ✔ This is a time-consuming exercise.

## En Dash

**Use en dashes (–) instead of em dashes (—). Use en dashes with care.**

Dashes increase the complexity of a sentence. They form a stronger break than commas (,) but a less strong break than parentheses ( ).

Consider this:

- If the information to be added is important, write a separate sentence.
- If the information is not important enough to merit a separate sentence, consider whether it is really necessary.

**Use en dashes to set off explanatory information or, at the end of a sentence, to introduce something unexpected.**

> Example
>
> ✔ The bidding functions – more extensive than those provided by many auction tools – are available to any authorized bidder.
>
> ✔ You can of course save time by omitting the final quality checks – although this usually does not pay off.
>
> ✔ Incident Management – Web-Enabled Enhancements [Note: This is a topic title. Therefore title case applies. Note the difference between en dash (sentence level) and hyphen (word level).]

**Use a space before and after the en dash.**

**Exception:** No spaces in number ranges. Example: 1–3 weeks

## Never an Em Dash

**Do not use em dashes (—).**

There's nothing wrong with em dashes. It's more a question of consistency.

The thing is: Different languages use different typographic means. American English often uses em dashes but en dashes are equally fine. But em dashes are not necessarily used in other languages, for example, in German or other varieties of English.

### Related Information

English: Hyphenation [page 277]
German: Komposita mit deutschen Wörtern (im Rechtschreibduden) [page 293]
German: Komposita mit englischen Wörtern (nicht im Rechtschreibduden) [page 297]

## 8.4.7 Semicolons

More than a comma, not yet a period. Use semicolons sparingly.

### Basics

**Use semicolons (;) sparingly with main clauses. Preferably create separate sentences instead.**

A semicolon is a stronger division than a comma (,), but a weaker division than a period (.). You can use it to join closely related sentences, for example, if you want to contrast the statements. But do so sparingly. Separate sentences are shorter and therefore easier to read. Alternatively, consider rephrasing or using a conjunction (“and”, “but”, “though”, “because”, and so on).

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The new version of the app allows patients to manage their own health data; the one that is in use is available only to health professionals.
>
> **Better:** ✔ The new version of the software allows patients to manage their own health data. Up to now, the software was only used by health professionals.
>
> ✔ Search results exceed maximum to be displayed; narrow down the list, using the advanced search.
>
> **Better:** ✔ Search results exceed maximum to be displayed. To narrow down the list, use the advanced search.

**Use a semicolon to separate items in a series of items when the items are long and complex or contain commas or other internal punctuation.**

On the other hand, consider rewriting this series of long items. Can you shorten the items? Can you present the items in a list?

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The following cities hosted recent SAP conferences: Atlanta, Georgia; Las Vegas, Nevada; Orlando, Florida.

### Related Information

Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157]

## 8.4.8 Parentheses and Brackets

Parentheses and brackets are similar but not interchangeable. Their common purpose is to set off information in a sentence.

### Parentheses

**Use parentheses ( ) to set off explanatory information.**

Explanatory information digresses from the main idea of the sentence but helps make a sentence or paragraph more understandable. As a general rule, the more words there are in parentheses, the better it is to rephrase the whole sentence. In specific contexts, however, parentheses are required, for example, when introducing abbreviations or technical names.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ The system administrator (or equivalent user) has to create user roles with relevant authorizations.
>
> ✔ The activities of the archiving programs (writing archives, deleting archives, and reloading archives) are protected by authorization objects.
>
> ✔ Many workflow scenarios are integrated in the International Demonstration and Education System (IDES).

**If a sentence is followed by explanatory information in parentheses that forms a complete sentence, place the period within the parentheses.**

If the explanatory information in parentheses is an incomplete sentence (a word or a phrase), place the period after the closing parentheses.

> ✤ Example
>
> ✔ In an annual physical inventory, you record all stocks on a certain day. (A physical inventory usually takes place at the end of the fiscal year.)
>
> ✔ In an annual physical inventory, you record all stocks on a certain day (usually at the end of the fiscal year).

## Square Brackets

**Use square brackets [ ] to add explanatory information to a quotation.**

The explanation is not part of the quotation itself.

> Example
>
> ✔ "The standardized layout of the AIFTE [Abbreviation Invented For This Example] guides helps consultants find information quickly", says Denise Moore, system administrator.

**Use brackets with enclosed ellipsis points [...] to indicate words that have been omitted in a quotation.**

> Example
>
> ✔ "The standardized layout of the [...] guides helps consultants find information quickly", says Denise Moore, system administrator.

## Angle Brackets

**Use angle brackets `<text>` to indicate placeholders.**

**Tools:** If your authoring tool provides a placeholder tag, use the tag instead of inserting the angle brackets manually. The corresponding tags are typically called *variable*, *placeholder*, or *varname*. This style guide is tool agnostic. For information about formatting, see the user guide for your authoring tool.

> Example
>
> ✔ The installation directory of the target system is located in the following directory:
> `installation\<database>\system\<system variant>`

# 8.4.9 Quotation Marks

Quotation marks are language specific. They are typically used for direct speech. But this use is rare in user assistance (including user interface texts). So when would you use quotation marks? Basically, their main use is in metalanguage discussions about the use and meaning of words.

## Basics

**Use language-specific quotation marks.**

For example, English has "..." (remember it with 6699) and German has „... " (remember it with 9966). These are the typographically correct quotation marks. Unfortunately, they are not necessarily available in all authoring tools.

**If it is a complete quoted sentence, enclose ending punctuation marks (mostly periods and commas) in quotation marks. Otherwise put them outside.**

This partially contradicts what *The Chicago Manual of Style* says. But when you provide technical information, it is more important to be exact. From a logical point of view, punctuation marks do not belong in quotation marks. The precedence of exact formulations over punctuation conventions is also accepted by *The Chicago Manual of Style*.

> Example
>
> ✔ The comma after "en dashes" in the phrase "hyphens, en dashes, and em dashes" is a serial comma.
>
> ✔ Common descriptors are terms such as "component", "application", or "business scenario".
>
> ✘ Common descriptors are terms such as "component," "application," or "business scenario."
>
> ✔ "Our new order service has been a real hit with our customers," says Matthew Armstrong, project leader. [Note: This is a complete quoted sentence. Therefore, the comma is inside the quotation marks.]

## When and How to Use

**If you are discussing the use or meaning of a particular word or phrase, place the word or phrase in quotation marks.**

In such metalanguage discussions, the word or phrase in question is often introduced with descriptors such as "the word", "the term", or "means". The quotation marks clearly set off the word or phrase from the surrounding text.

> Example
>
> ✔ The term "purchase contract" is an invalid synonym of the correct term "purchasing contract".

✔ In certain contexts, the modal verb “can” means “to be able to”.

**Use quotation marks for quotations or direct speech.**

This use is, of course, rare in user assistance.

Example

✔ “Our new order service has been a real hit with our customers,” says Matthew Armstrong, project leader. [Note: This is a complete quoted sentence. Therefore, the comma is inside the quotation marks.]

**If your authoring tool does not provide formatting means, you can use quotation marks as surrogate formatting for user interface elements.**

For example, message short texts in the ABAP environment can't be formatted. They are just plain text. Now what to do if you need to refer to a field? You could write: Enter data in the “Material” field. However, you can easily avoid this by writing “Enter a material.” Therefore, consider quotation marks as a last-ditch means of formatting.

## When Not to Use

**Do not use quotation marks to indicate that a word or phrase is being used in an unexpected or ironic way.**

In many cases, you can omit the quotation marks without changing the meaning. If that doesn't work, change the wording or indicate the connotation of “unexpected or ironic” with lexical means. For example, precede a phrase with the modifier “so-called”.

**Do not use quotation marks to refer to titles, headings, or captions. Use formatting instead.**

**Exception:** Do not format approved names. For more information, see SAP Product Names and Other Approved Names [page 183] and Software Objects and Entities [page 193].

Example

✘ In the “Quotation and Order Management” scenario, the first process step is about ... [Note: Quotation marks are not correct because this sentence is not a metalanguage discussion about the scenario title. What you are doing is introducing a scenario by its name and then providing information about it.]

✔ In the *Quotation and Order Management* scenario, the first process step is about ... [Note: This title is not an approved name. Therefore it is formatted.]

### Tools and Typography

**If your authoring tool provides a quotation mark tag, find out whether the quotation marks are also rendered correctly in translated text.**

For example, in the IXIA CCMS there is a tag for quotes (<q>). When the text is translated, the quotation marks defined for target languages are automatically applied. But this is not necessarily the case with every authoring tool.

**If there is no quotation mark tag (for example, in Microsoft Word), try to get the quotation marks for your language by using the autoreplace function.**

The autoreplace function ensures that the typographically incorrect quotation marks ("...") are automatically replaced with the language-specific ones while you're typing (English “...”, German „...“). However, if there's no way to get the typographically correct quotation marks, it's ok to resort to the incorrect ones "...".

## 8.4.10 Apostrophes

Although the use of apostrophes is language-specific, there is the typographic question of whether it's a true or false apostrophe.

### Grammar

**English: Do not use an apostrophe (') for the plural of nouns and acronyms.**

It's unsurprisingly simple. For example, the plural of “computer” is “computers” and the plural of “BAdI” is “BAdIs”.

**German: Do not use an apostrophe (') for the possessive case (Genitiv) of nouns and acronyms.**

It's unsurprisingly simple. For example, the possessive case of “Computer” is “der Hersteller des Computers” and the possessive case of “BAdI” is “die Verwendung des BAdIs”.

### Tools and Typography

**If technically possible, use the typographically correct apostrophe (’).**

It is identical to a closing single quotation mark (’).

**If you find the apostrophe you are using is not typographically correct, check whether your authoring tool provides an autoreplace function.**

If so, use this function to have the false apostrophes automatically replaced with the true apostrophe (’) while you are typing. If not, use the false apostrophe ('). Do not use accent acute (´) or accent grave (`) as a surrogate apostrophe.

# 8.4.11 Slashes

Slashes are not state-of-the-art punctuation in sentences. They are best used as separators in URLs and the like.

## Basics

**Do not use a forward slash (/) as a shorthand for "or" or similar meanings.**

In most cases, you can replace the slash with formulations such as "or" or "..., ..., or both". If this sounds clumsy or if there are space restrictions, "and/or" can be a permissible alternative.

> Example
>
> ✔ You can change or delete a bill of material at any time.
>
> ✘ You can change/delete a bill of material at any time.
>
> ✔ Start and end dates are displayed.
>
> ✘ Start/end dates are displayed.
>
> ✔ The plan/actual comparison is very important. [Note: This is one of the rare cases where a slash makes sense. "plan/actual" forms a unit to modify "comparison". The slash does not mean "and/or". It's rather an established short form for "the comparison of the planned and actual numbers" or whatever it is that is being compared.]
>
> Only valid for 'Localization': English
>
> ✔ **English:** Plan/actual comparisons are great. [Note: This is just in case you were wondering whether "actual" gets lowercase or uppercase.]
>
> End of 'Localization': English

**Exception:** The slash is part of an approved name or a proper noun.

> Example
>
> ✔ SAP S/4HANA

**Use slashes as separators in URLs, directory paths, or similar.**

Forward slash (/) or a backslash (\)? You may need to consider additional aspects, such as the operating system.

> Example
>
> ✔ https://www.example.org

✔ `C:\Documents and Settings\Administrator\My Documents` [Note: This is from a Microsoft Windows operating system.]

✔ `/db/programs/files/picture.jpg` [Note: This is from a Unix operating system.]

## Related Information

Punctuation Marks and Special Characters on the User Interface [page 157]

# 9 Appendix

Here's supplementary information to various topics in the *SAP Style Guide for Technical Communication*.

The supplementary information in the appendix is too specific to be included in the main body of the style guide.

## 9.1 Accessibility Aspects for Output Formats and Tools

HTML, PDF, video, graphics, Web pages – there are many different output formats. As a person who is responsible for an output format or tool, ensure that the final output in whatever format has maximum accessibility. So what can you do?

### Basics

**Ensure that tools and development environments support accessibility of the final output as much as possible.**

Do not make user assistance developers and translators ensure accessibility manually. For example, user assistance developers shouldn't have to manually enable text resizing, ensure color contrast, or check start and end tags of elements.

**Test your output formats and tools against the requirements of the Product Standard for Accessibility.**

The requirements cover information and text, visual perception, user interface elements, orientation and navigation, user interaction, and time-dependent content. For more information, see the Product Standard for Accessibility.

> ✤ Example
>
> Text alternative for non-text content (ACC-255), text resizing up to 200% (ACC-260), color and contrast (at least 4.5:1, preferably 7:1, ACC-261 and 262), interoperability with assistive technologies (ACC-264), consistent navigation (ACC-267), full keyboard support (ACC-270), animation, audio and video control (ACC-279), no flickering or flashing content (ACC-280)

### Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.0

**Consider consulting the *Web Content Accessibility Guidelines* (WCAG).**

You will find a wealth of information (requirements, explanations, how to technically meet requirements for different output formats). Start with the 12 brief common-sense principles, which go along the lines of "Provide alternatives for time-based media" or "Provide ways to help users navigate". For more information, see https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG20 (scroll down to the table of contents).

### Related Information

Accessibility [page 103]

## 9.2 Cautions and Warnings in ISO and Other International Standards

The standards for advisory, safety-related information in the software and manufacturing industries are different. Industry 4.0 and Internet of things, however, mean that the two worlds will move closer together. But how do they differ? What does this mean for user assistance?

### Basic Comparison Software Only Versus Machine and Software

**If your Internet-of-things application has safety-related aspects, familiarize with the main international standards.**

The standards for safety-related information are likely to affect your user assistance deliverables. The following table provides you with a basic comparison between software only and machines controlled by software. This is, however, just scratching the surface. You will need to consult the standards themselves.

| Software Only | Manufacturing (Machines Controlled by Software) |
|---|---|
| The standards are **less strict**, less detailed, and considerably less enforced than the manufacturing industry (machinery, medicine, chemistry, and so on).<br><br>The main standards are as follows:<br><br>• DITA with the `note` tag with the type attributes `note`, `tip`, `caution` (rendered as "warning"), and others<br>• *Systems and Software Engineering – Requirements for Designers and Developers of User Documentation* (ISO IEC IEEE 26514) with note, caution, and warning | Advisory information is known as **safety-related information that warns about hazards and prevents harm** to people, property, and environment.<br><br>The main standards are as follows:<br><br>• *Safety Alerting Standards* (ANSI Z535, especially Z535.6 for product safety information in product manuals)<br>• *Graphical Symbols – Safety Colours and Safety Signs* (ISO 3864)<br>• *Preparation of iIstructions for Use – Structuring, Content and Presentation – Part 1: General Principles and Detailed Requirements* (IEC 82079-1) |
| **ISO 26514** has the following **requirements**:<br><br>• Notes, cautions, and warnings to be set off consistently from body text<br>• Signal words to precede text<br>• Warnings and cautions to be identified by different graphical symbols, for example, an exclamation point or lightning bolt in a triangle<br><br>**DITA** briefly explains the `note` tag as "information, differentiated from the main text, which expands on or calls attention to a particular point" and states that there are different types of notes. That's it. | **ANSI Z535.6, ISO 3864-2, and ISO 82079-1** have the following **requirements**:<br><br>• Documents or chapters with fundamental safety-related information as ("grouped safety messages", "safety notes") opposed to specific safety-related information that appears in body text ("section and embedded safety messages", "warning messages")<br>• Specific signal words to be used for specific types of hazards (according to risk level, injury or death, and property damage)<br>• Strict standards for how to set off the safety-related information (predefined safety alert symbol, font colors, background colors, signal words in all caps)<br>• Standard for formulating the safety-related information (type and source of the hazard, consequences, how to avoid hazard and harm) |

| Software Only | Manufacturing (Machines Controlled by Software) |
| --- | --- |
| **ISO 26514** defines the **types** of advisory information as follows:<br>• **Note** refers to "helpful hint or other information that might assist the user by emphasizing or supplementing important points of the main text".<br>• **Caution** refers to "performing some action might lead to consequences that are unwanted or undefined, such as loss of data or an equipment problem".<br>• **Warning** refers to "performing some action might lead to serious or dangerous consequences". | **ISO 3864-2 and ISO 82079-1** define the **types** of advisory (= safety-related) information in body text as follows and require them to be used with the predefined safety alert symbol (triangle with exclamation point) and a specific background color:<br>• **CAUTION** (yellow background) is the signal word for "a hazard with a low level of risk which, if not avoided, could result in minor or moderate injury".<br>• **WARNING** (orange background) is the signal word for "a hazard with a medium level of risk which, if not avoided, could result in death or serious injury".<br>• **DANGER** (red background) is the signal word for "a hazard with a high level of risk which, if not avoided, will result in death or serious injury".<br>**ANSI Z535.6** has similar definitions and in addition a signal word for property damages (to be used without the safety alert symbol):<br>• **NOTICE** is the signal word for "information considered important, but not hazard-related (for example, messages relating to property damage)". |

**As appropriate for industry, country, or region, be prepared to search for additional standards.**

You can search for additional standards on Web sites of international or country/region-specific standard organizations, such as *International Standardization Organisation* (ISO), *International Electrotechnical Commission* (IEC), *Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers* (IEEE), or *Deutsches Institut für Normung* (DIN).

## Related Information

Notes, Tips, Cautions, and the Like [page 255]

# Important Disclaimers and Legal Information

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About the icons:

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